

Fate's Edge: Player's Guide

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Fate's Edge: Player's Guide

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Chapter 1

Welcome to Fate's Edge

A world where every choice carries weight, every spell risks backlash, and every legend is written in the shadow of consequence.

Welcome to **Fate's Edge**, a tabletop roleplaying game where narrative drives mechanics, and every decision shapes not only your character's path—but the world around them. This is not a game of perfect successes or clean victories. It is a game of risk, drama, and legacy.

What Is This Game?

Fate's Edge is a narrative-first RPG where:

- Every roll introduces potential for triumph *and* complication.
- Magic is powerful—but dangerous.
- Choices ripple outward, shaping character arcs and the setting.
- Growth is meaningful, earned through experience spent on skills, talents, and assets.

This guide helps you build a character, understand the setting, and step into a world where your actions matter.

Core Principles

The game is built on four key ideas:

Narrative First Mechanics serve the story. Rules reward descriptive play and creative problem-solving.

Risk Creates Drama Every roll carries tension. Even success may come at a cost.

Meaningful Growth Experience is a currency of choice. Invest in yourself or in your influence on the world.

Consequences Matter No action is free. Every choice changes the fiction.

Style of Play

Expect cinematic, collaborative storytelling:

- Stories driven by character choices.
- A world that reacts to your decisions.

- Themes of legacy, sacrifice, and moral complexity.

Whether you are a lone duelist, a scheming mastermind, or a spirit-touched outlander, your path is yours to forge.

Guide Structure

This Player's Guide contains:

- **Core Mechanics** — Action resolution, experience spending, consequences.
- **Character Creation** — Attributes, skills, magical paths, and archetypes.
- **Magic and Talents** — Dangerous arts and unique abilities.
- **World and Lore** — Lands, peoples, and cultures.
- **Assets and Allies** — Building influence beyond yourself.
- **Appendices** — Quick references, generators, and player tools.

How to Use This Book

Read cover to cover or jump to relevant sections. Each chapter stands alone while connecting to broader themes.

Use the *System Reference Document* for full mechanical support and additional rules.

Getting Started

This is a game of bold choices and lasting consequences. Your story is written in decisions—not dice rolls.

Welcome to the Edge. The world is watching.

What will you risk to reshape the world?

1.1 The Philosophy of Narrative First

In Fate's Edge, the story is not a byproduct of the rules—it is the reason the rules exist. When you sit down to play, you are not rolling dice to see what happens; you are telling a story together, with dice as your co-authors. This is the *narrative first* philosophy, and it changes everything about how you approach the game.

1.1.1 Why Narrative First?

Imagine this scene:

Your character, a wounded duelist, faces the baron's champion in the royal arena. Your legs ache from the earlier fight, and the crowd's roar has become a physical pressure. You know one strike will end it—but you also know you are one misstep from death.

Now consider two ways this might play out:

- **Mechanics-First Approach:** "I roll Body 3 + Melee 2 to attack. I get 3 successes. The baron's champion has 2 Harm. I win."
- **Narrative-First Approach:** "I lunge forward, my blade a silver arc against the red of the arena sand. But my injured leg buckles—I spend 1 Boon to re-roll the die that came up 1—and

I twist to drive my shoulder into his chest instead. The crowd roars as we both fall to the sand, my blade at his throat.” *GM*: “*You have the advantage, but your wound has reopened. What do you do?*”

The first version tells you who won. The second tells you *how* you won and what it cost you. This is the heart of narrative first: your choices matter not because of numbers on a sheet, but because of the story they create.

1.1.2 Your Role in the Story

In Fate’s Edge, you are:

- **A storyteller** — Your descriptions shape the world around you.
- **An active participant** — Your choices drive the narrative forward.
- **A co-creator** — You and the GM build the story together.

This means:

- **Flavor is free:** Describe how you fight, what your character looks like, or what the world feels like—no mechanical cost, only story enrichment.
Example: “I parry with the grace of a dancer, my movements a memory of my mother’s training, even as blood drips from my brow.”
- **Describe your action before rolling:** Do not just say “I attack”—show us how you do it. This informs the GM’s response and often determines the Position (Dominant, Controlled, Desperate).
Example: “I use the crowd’s noise as cover to slip behind him and strike his exposed back.” (This would likely be *Dominant Position* for a stealthy approach.)
- **Embrace failure as opportunity:** When you miss a roll, it is not “you fail to hit.” It is “the blade glances off his armor, and you see the baron’s hand reach for the hilt of his dagger.” Failures should always move the story forward.

Playing Safely: X-Card

Fate's Edge explores mature themes—conflict, loss, horror, betrayal, and difficult choices. The table should always feel safe. Use these three simple tools to keep the game enjoyable for everyone.

X-Card (by John Stavropoulos). Any player (including the GM) can draw an “X” on a card or simply say “X” when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is **removed from the fiction**—no questions, no explanations, no judgments. You do not need to justify using the X-Card. The scene is retconned or redirected.

Lines. A **Line** is a hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: “No sexual violence,” “No harm to children,” “No body horror.” Before the campaign or a session, players name their Lines. The GM and group honor them completely.

Veils. A **Veil** is a soft boundary: content that can happen “off screen” or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described in detail. Example: “A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit.” Veils allow the story to acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

How to Use These Tools at Your Table.

- Establish Lines and Veils during **Session Zero** (or before your first game). Write them down where everyone can see them.
- Keep an X-Card visible on the table (a printed card, a drawn X, or a digital symbol). Remind players they can use it at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player who used it.
- The GM is also a player. The GM may use the X-Card for their own comfort.
- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust that they had a good reason and support them.

These tools are not about censorship—they are about consent. They allow the group to tell darker, more intense stories together *because* everyone knows they can tap out at any time. A game that feels safe is a game that can go to the edge.

For more detail, search online for “TTRPG X-Card” or “Lines and Veils RPG”. Many free resources are available.

1.1.3 The Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. If you find yourself asking “What’s the optimal move?” try reframing it as “What would be most interesting for the story?”

Remember

In Fate's Edge, the dice do not determine your success or failure. *You* determine the story. The dice just help decide which path you take to get there.

This philosophy is not just about storytelling—it is about creating a shared experience where every player feels their choices matter, every moment has weight, and the story grows richer with every roll. Welcome to a game where the world responds to your choices, not the other way around.

Your story begins now. What will you risk to reshape the world?

Flavor is Free

Players: Remember that **flavor is free!**

Add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or requiring rolls. Want to parry with a traditional technique? Go ahead. Want to describe seasonal festivals during a social roll? Perfect.

Flavor enriches the narrative without changing mechanical outcomes. Describe your character's background, customs, or scene details. The Game Master should encourage this and reciprocate. Mechanics determine success or failure, but flavor determines the story we tell.

Narrative-Heavy Gameplay Options

For groups that prefer strong narrative focus, consider these optional approaches:

Collaborative Scene Framing: Players may suggest scene elements (weather, NPC reactions, environmental details) that fit the established fiction, with GM approval.

Intent-Driven Resolution: For non-combat actions where success is reasonably assured, the GM may ask players to describe *how* they accomplish their goal rather than rolling dice.

Flashback Declarations: Players can declare a flashback scene to establish that something happened in the past (acquiring an item, making a connection, learning information) by spending 1 Boon and describing the scene.

Descriptive Assistance: Players can assist each other by providing vivid, helpful descriptions of the action, granting a +1 die bonus to the primary actor's roll.

Narrative Control Points: Each player starts each session with 1 Narrative Control Point. They can spend it to:

- Introduce a minor NPC who provides useful information or assistance.
- Establish that they have a useful item on hand (within reason).
- Create a favorable environmental detail.

These points refresh each session and encourage proactive storytelling.

Chapter 2

Core Mechanics

The 90-Second Play Loop

At the heart of every scene is a simple, fast loop that keeps the story moving:

1. **GM sets the stage** – Describe the situation and ask “What do you do?”
2. **Player declares intent and approach** – State what you want to achieve and how (Attribute + Skill).
3. **GM sets Position and Difficulty Value (DV)** – Choose Dominant/Controlled/Desperate and a DV (2–5+).
4. **Player rolls dice** – Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).
5. **Apply outcome** – Compare Successes to DV (Clean Success / Success with Cost / Partial / Miss).
6. **GM spends Story Beats (SB)** – Introduce complications, advance clocks, or escalate the scene.
7. **Player marks resources** – Gain Boons (1 on Partial, 2 on Miss), track Fatigue/Harm, update Obligation, etc.
8. **Pass the spotlight** – Next player acts, or GM frames a new beat.

This loop should take about 90 seconds per player action. If it drags, simplify: focus on intent, one roll, and a clear consequence.

2.1 Player-Managed Modules

In Fate’s Edge, you are the primary manager of your character’s mechanical state. This isn’t just about convenience—it is a core design principle that reduces GM overhead and keeps you engaged.

You Track Your Own Story

What You Manage:

- Obligation tracks (one per Patron or Symbol)
- Corruption clocks (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers)
- Leash clocks (summoned spirits)
- Asset states (Maintained, Neglected, Compromised)
- Follower conditions (Exposure, Harm)
- Progression clocks (Repertoire, Spirit Bond)
- Boons, Favor, Leverage

Your Responsibilities:

1. **Mark immediately** when a rule says “mark +X”.
2. **Declare thresholds** (“My Obligation is full!”).
3. **Keep it visible** (use trackers everyone can see).
4. **Maintain ownership** – you know your state best.

GM Support: The GM spot-checks and provides consequences, but you drive your character’s mechanical narrative.

2.2 Basic Dice Mechanics

When you attempt a significant action, roll a pool of ten-sided dice (d10s). The size of your pool is:

$$DicePool = Attribute + Skill$$

Attribute (1–5) Broad traits like Strength, Wit, or Charm.

Skill (0–5) Training in a specific area (e.g., Melee, Stealth, Arcana).

Reading the Dice

Each die that rolls **6 or higher** counts as a **Success**. Each die that rolls a **1** generates a **Story Beat (SB)**.

Die Result	Effect
6–10	+1 Success
1	+1 Story Beat (SB)
2–5	Nothing

2.2.0.0.1 Example: Lyra (Agility 3 + Stealth 2 = 5 dice) rolls: 6, 4, 3, 1, 6 → 2 Successes, 1 SB. The DV is 2 – she succeeds, but the GM has 1 SB to spend (perhaps a guard stirs).

2.3 Difficulty Value (DV)

The Game Master sets a **Difficulty Value** – the target number of Successes needed.

Difficulty Value (DV) Ladder

DV	Situation
2	Routine, no pressure
3	Pressured, mild opposition
4	Difficult, active resistance
5+	Extreme, high stakes

2.3.0.0.1 Note: DV 3 is most common. If the GM calls for a roll, something is at stake.

2.4 The Outcome Matrix

Compare your Successes to the DV to determine the outcome.

Outcome Matrix

Outcome	What It Means
Clean Success ($S \geq DV$)	You achieve your goal without complication.
Success with Cost ($S \geq DV, SB > 0$)	You succeed, but the GM spends SB to add a twist.
Partial ($0 < S < DV$)	You make progress, but the situation remains unresolved.
Miss ($S = 0$)	You fail, and the situation escalates.

2.4.0.0.1 What a Partial Means. A Partial is not failure – it moves the story forward. Examples:

- Improve your Position for the next attempt.
- Reduce the effective DV of the next roll.
- Succeed at reduced scale or duration.
- Reveal information or open a new path.

2.4.1 Critical Successes

A roll of **10** counts as **two Successes**. If the roll succeeds, each 10 adds narrative weight.

10s	Effect
1	Strong success – improved Position, minor advantage.
2	Exceptional success – choose two benefits.
3	Legendary success – decisive victory, clear 1 clock segment.
4+	Mythic success – reshape the scene, clear 1–2 clock segments.

Important: 10s are never re-rolled by Position effects. Critical effects apply only if the roll succeeds.

2.5 Boons

Boons represent momentum and narrative leverage. You may hold up to **5 Boons**.

2.5.1 Earning Boons

- **Partial Success:** Gain 1 Boon
- **Miss:** Gain 2 Boons
- **Bond-Driven Action:** Once per bond per session, gain 1 Boon when an action meaningfully engages that bond.
- **GM Award:** For creativity, sacrifice, or strong narrative play.

When not awarded: Safe rehearsal, null-risk probes, or repeated identical attempts in the same scene do not generate Boons.

2.5.2 Spending Boons

- Re-roll a single die (after seeing the result)
- Activate an on-screen Asset (1 Boon)
- Improve Position by 1 step before a roll
- Power certain Rites or abilities
- Convert to XP (2 Boons = 1 XP, once per session during downtime, max 2 XP per session)

2.5.3 Carryover Limit

At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of **2**. Excess are lost – spend them or lose them.

2.6 Position

Every action takes place from a **Position** that reflects the character’s advantage.

Position	Narrative Frame	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	You press your advantage	Re-roll one <i>failure</i>
Controlled	Balanced norm	No re-rolls
Desperate	You act under duress	Re-roll one <i>success</i>

2.6.0.0.1 Boon Interaction with Fatigue: When Fatigue forces a success re-roll, spending 1 Boon negates *one* such re-roll. You may spend Boons after seeing the result of a Fatigue re-roll.

2.7 Story Beats (SB)

Story Beats are narrative tools the GM spends to introduce twists. They keep the story alive with complications.

2.7.1 SB Spend Examples

- **1 SB:** Minor complication – noise, trace, +1 Supply segment.
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback – alarm raised, lose cover, lesser foe appears.
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble – reinforcements, key gear breaks.
- **4+ SB:** Major turn – trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts.

2.7.1.0.1 Player Advice: Don’t fear Story Beats – they are fuel for drama, not punishment.

2.8 Harm and Fatigue

2.8.1 Fatigue Track

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to **Body**. Mark Fatigue for exertion, magical strain, or stress.

- Each Fatigue step worsens your Position: Dominant → Controlled → Desperate.
- If already Desperate, apply −1 die per Fatigue instead.
- **Overflow:** When the track fills, increase Harm by 1 step and clear all Fatigue.
- **Recovery:** Short rest clears 1–2 Fatigue; full night’s rest clears all.

2.8.2 Harm Levels

Harm Level	Effect
Harm 1	−1 die on related actions
Harm 2	−1 die on most actions until treated
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying

2.8.3 Recovery

- **Fatigue:** Short rest (food/water) removes 2 Fatigue; full night removes all.
- **Harm:** Requires medical care and time – minor treatment downgrades Harm, proper care removes it.

2.9 Initiative and Turn Order

Fate’s Edge does not use fixed initiative. Turn order follows the fiction:

- **Narrative Fiat:** The GM frames spotlight order based on circumstances.
- **Player Input:** Players may suggest acting when it makes sense.
- **Surprise:** Ambushers act first; targets respond after.
- **Flexibility:** Spotlight may shift mid-scene if fictionally appropriate.

2.9.1 Turn Economy (Quick Rules)

Each character takes **1 Action and 1 Move** on their turn. Actions and Moves may be taken in any order; repeating the same Action is not allowed unless noted.

2.9.1.0.1 Move: Traverse up to normal movement.

- **Disengage:** Move without provoking; your next offensive action is Controlled.
- **Dash:** Move again this turn; your next defense is Desperate.
- **Stand:** Use your move to stand from prone.

2.9.1.0.2 Attack: Make melee or ranged attack versus DV set by the GM. Teamwork/Assist costs 1 Boon.

2.9.1.0.3 Observe / Change Position: Take a beat to read the field; gain +1 Position for one action this turn (e.g., Controlled → Dominant). Once per turn, cannot exceed Dominant.

2.9.1.0.4 Activate an Asset: Use gear, symbol, or feature per its text. Items with [Action] consume an Action; [Free] do not.

2.9.1.0.5 Setup (Teamwork): Create advantage for an ally. On success, grant their next action +1 Position or step up Effect.

2.9.1.0.6 Assist (Teamwork): Spend 1 Boon to give an ally +1 die on their current roll; you share appropriate risk.

2.9.1.0.7 Defend / Protect: Adopt a guarding stance. Choose a nearby ally; until your next turn you may intercept one hit on them and roll to resist it. On success, reduce/negate Harm; you take any fallout.

2.9.1.0.8 Channel / Weave: Runekeeper/ritual flow – Channel (prime power) then Weave (shape/release). Interruption may worsen Position or cause failure.

2.9.1.0.9 Cast Rite / Song: Perform a Rite/Song per its write-up. You may Push to accelerate at the cost of Fatigue/Corruption.

2.9.1.0.10 Interact: Lift, pull, flip lever, shove foe, break object, apply poultice, reload, draw/stow, etc. GM sets DV/Effect.

2.9.1.0.11 Free Items: Short shouts, dropping an item, quick glance. Longer actions require Observe or Interact.

2.9.1.0.12 Reactions (Out of Turn): Protection may trigger when an ally is hit. Class/Asset reactions fire as written.

2.9.1.0.13 Position Caps: Bonuses cannot raise Position above Dominant; penalties cannot drop below Desperate. Beyond these caps, adjust DV or Effect instead.

2.10 Assistance

Characters can help each other. One helper per action may provide assistance by spending 1 Boon, adding +1 die to the primary actor's roll. Maximum +3 dice from all assists.

2.10.1 Defend Action (Optional Core Rule)

Characters may explicitly **Defend** against incoming attacks.

2.10.1.0.1 Declare Defense: On your turn, spend a Move or Standard action to enter a defensive stance. Until your next turn, you count as Defending.

2.10.1.0.2 Mechanical Effect: When targeted by a harmful action, roll an appropriate Attribute + Skill pool (e.g., Body+Athletics to dodge, Spirit+Resolve to resist). Your Position improves by one step for this roll (if already Dominant, gain +1 die instead).

2.10.1.0.3 Resolution:

- **Success:** Avoid or fully negate the harm.
- **Partial:** Reduce severity by one tier (e.g., Harm 2 $\rightarrow$ 1).
- **Miss:** Full effect occurs, but your next Position against that attacker improves by one step.

2.11 Weapons & Armor**2.11.1 Weapons by Weight Class**

- **Light (4 XP)** – fast, concealable.
- **Medium (8 XP)** – balanced, battlefield standard.
- **Heavy (12 XP)** – punishing, slow.

2.11.2 Melee Modifiers

Weight	Close	Near	Notes
Light	+2d	+1d	Quick in tight quarters
Medium	+1d	+2d	Set once/scene or -1d first attack
Heavy	-1d	+3d	Set once/scene or -2d first attack

2.11.3 Ranged & Tempo

Weight	Tempo	Close	Near	Far
Light (4 XP)	Fast	Controlled	+1d	—
Medium (8 XP)	Standard	Desperate	+2d	+1d
Heavy (12 XP)	Slow	Desperate	+1d	+3d

2.11.3.0.1 Tempo: **Fast** = Move+Shoot. **Standard** = Move or Shoot, Aim for +1d/+1 Effect. **Slow** = Set/Brace, full reload, cannot Move+Shoot.

2.11.4 Weapon Tags (Optional, +4 XP each, max 2)

Reach, Close, Accurate, Brutal, Hook, Concealable, Quickdraw, Two-Handed, Off-Hand.

2.11.5 Shields (Optional)

Shield	XP	Benefit	Tradeoff
Buckler	4	+1d Defend vs melee or +1 DV once	Off-hand occupied
Heater	8	+1d Defend; convert 1 Harm $\rightarrow$ 1 Fatigue	-1d Ranged
Pavise	12	Plant: heavy cover cone	Slow to move; bulky

2.11.6 Armor

Armor	XP	Conversion	Penalty
Light	4	1 Harm $\rightarrow$ 1 Fatigue	—
Medium	8	2 Harm $\rightarrow$ 1 Fatigue	-1d physical skills
Heavy	12	3 Harm $\rightarrow$ 2 Fatigue	-2d physical, no sprint in rough

2.11.6.0.1 Notes: Conversion applies per Harm instance before marking Fatigue. You may still Resist first.

2.11.7 Condition & Upkeep

Neglected Weapons: -1d; **Armor:** conversion worsened by one step.

Compromised Weapons: -1d first attack each round; **Armor:** no conversion.

Fix: Short rest with tools removes Neglected. A scene of work or a smith removes Compromised.

2.12 Ranged Options

- **Aim:** +1 die or +1 Effect next shot (lost if you Move or are disrupted).
- **Volley:** Spend extra ammo for +1 die (max +2).
- **Suppress:** Zone under fire; foes there act at -1 die or Limited Effect until they shift cover.
- **Overwatch:** Ready a Controlled shot on a clear trigger crossing your line.

2.13 Followers and Assets

2.13.1 Followers

Followers are named NPCs with a personal relationship to your character. They:

- Assist during scenes via Bonds and Assists.
- Act offscreen to gather information or manage tasks.
- Have motives and vulnerabilities – the GM may place them at risk.

Followers are not disposable tools. They can grow, change, or be lost.

2.13.2 Assets

Assets are durable resources or positions under your control – safehouses, networks, political offices, relics. They:

- Create advantages that persist beyond a single scene.
- Resolve problems that dice alone cannot.
- Cost Boons to activate (the GM determines the impact).

Assets can be threatened, degraded, or lost. Overuse attracts attention.

2.13.3 Followers vs. Assets

	Followers	Assets
Nature	People	Resources/Structures
Primary Role	Personal support	Strategic leverage
Activation	Assists, Bonds	Boon expenditure
Risk	Emotional, narrative	Structural, political
Growth	Can become PCs	Can expand or collapse

2.13.3.0.1 Design Principle: Followers create *depth*. Assets create *reach*. High-tier play depends on managing both.

2.14 Game Structure

2.14.1 Time Scales

Moment A heartbeat, a single action.

Some Time A few minutes, a short activity.

Significant Time Hours, extended effort.

Days Large-scale endeavors.

2.14.2 Game Units

Scene Basic narrative unit, covers a specific conflict.

Session One game session (3–6 hours).

Campaign Entire story arc.

2.15 Action Resolution Steps

1. Describe your intent and method.
2. Build dice pool: Attribute + Skill (+ gear, assists).
3. Roll d10s; count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).
4. Compare Successes to DV.
5. Apply outcome from the Outcome Matrix.
6. GM spends SB if applicable.
7. Earn Boons for Partial or Miss.

Quick Reference

Dice Pool: Attribute + Skill d10s

Success: 6+ on each die

Story Beat: 1 on any die gives SB to GM

DV: 2 (easy) to 5+ (extreme)

Harm: 3-level system with penalties

Boons: 2 on miss, 1 on partial

2.16 Narrative Suggestions

- **Collaborative Scene Framing:** Players may suggest scene elements (weather, NPC reactions) with GM approval.
- **Intent-Driven Resolution:** If success is reasonably assured, the GM may ask players to describe *how* rather than roll.
- **Flashback Declarations:** Spend 1 Boon to declare a flashback establishing past preparation, and describe the scene.
- **Descriptive Assistance:** Players can assist by providing vivid descriptions, granting a +1 die to the primary actor.
- **Proactive Storytelling:** Players may suggest minor favorable details (a helpful NPC, a useful item on hand) subject to GM approval.

2.16.1 Small Folk of the Threshold

The Aelaerem (halflings) and Aelinnel (gnomes) are diminutive peoples attuned to liminal spaces—doorways, hedge-gaps, tide-cut stairs, and the quiet places between hearth and hollow. While they share a small stature and a knack for slipping through cracks, their cultural instincts differ.

- **Restriction:** Cannot use Heavy Armor. May use any one-handed or two-handed weapon, but Heavy Weapons impose **−1 Position** on all actions while wielding them.
- **Bonus:** When wielding a **spear, quarterstaff, or light polearm** (any Medium or Light weapon with the **Reach** tag), treat the weapon as **one weight class lighter** for the purpose of attack modifiers. Additionally, once per scene when you make a melee attack with such a weapon, you may spend **1 Boon** to convert a *Partial* success into a *Clean Success* (representing a clever thrust that uses the enemy’s momentum against them).

Aelaerem — The Hearth’s Luck

Aelaerem are survivors, homebodies, and masters of sudden fortune.

Bonus — Once per scene, you may improve your ****Position** by one step** (e.g., Desperate → Controlled, Controlled → Dominant) as a free action ****before**** rolling an action. This represents a flash of luck, a well-timed sidestep, or an unexpected opening.

Aelinnel — The Bright Trick

Aelinnel are fae-touched, mathematically clever, and never without a tool for the moment. Choose ****one**** of the following abilities to represent their tricky nature.

Option A: Short Step (Teleport)

Bonus — Once per scene, as a ****Move action****, you may instantly teleport to any unobserved location you can see within ****Near**** range. You cannot pass through solid barriers. This is a fey-like blink, not a physical jump.

Option B: Knack for the Right Thing (Handy Item)

Bonus — Once per scene, you may declare that you have a ****small, mundane item**** on your person that is useful in the current situation (e.g., a coil of rope, a lockpick, a candle, a chalk stick). This costs no Boon and requires no roll. The item must be plausible for your character to carry. (This is a free, once-per-scene version of the ****Flashback Declaration**** mechanic described in §??.)

Both peoples are often underestimated—a mistake that has left many a larger foe stumbling through a door that was never really shut.

Chapter 3

Magic and Special Abilities

Magic in this game is powerful but dangerous—a negotiation with reality itself that always carries risks. This chapter covers the core magical systems and the distinct paths a character may follow.

Sidebar: [TAGS] & Magic

What are [TAGS]? Effects in *Fate's Edge* are communicated via [TAGS]. Each [TAG] is a discrete effect gated behind a Talent, Rite, spell, or asset—it *cannot be invoked spontaneously* unless a rule grants access.

How they're used. [TAGS] provide a common language for describing effects, especially when players invent spells via *Free Casting*. Many prewritten spells and abilities also list their [TAGS] for clarity.

3.1 The Nature of Magic

Magic is not a safe tool but a dangerous force:

- **Powerful:** Can reshape battles, stories, or even the world.
- **Controlled:** Every use generates **Story Beats (SB)** that manifest as backlash.
- **Thematic:** Effects and consequences align with the type of magic used.
- **Volatile:** Never fully predictable or controllable.
- **Narrative:** Casting is always a significant story moment.

3.1.0.0.1 Table Vignette: “*I can hold the avalanche,*” says Mira, *fingers trembling.* “*But something will answer.*” The party nods—risk accepted, stakes clear.

3.2 Paths of Magic

Magic in *Fate's Edge* is not a single system. Characters may follow one of several distinct paths, each with its own mechanics, costs, and narrative flavor. The five primary paths are:

Free Caster Improvisational magic using [TAGS]. Flexible but risky.

Runekeeper Structured rites granted by a Patron. Reliable but accrues Obligation.

Invoker Ritual magic using Patron symbols. Safe but slow.

Cantor Songs that mimic Low Rites. Accessible but corrupting.

Summoner Binding and commanding spirits. Powerful but requires control.

A character may dabble in multiple paths, but specialization is more effective.

3.2.1 Free Caster (Spellcraft)

Free casters shape raw magic through will and knowledge. They do not rely on Patrons or rote rites.

Requirements

- Talent: **Spellcraft** (6 XP)
- Appropriate magical skill (Arcana, Elemental Magic, etc.)

Casting Procedure

1. **Declare Intent:** Describe the desired effect using [TAGS].
2. **Choose Approach:** Attribute + magical skill.
3. **Set Position & DV:** $DV = 1 + \text{number of [TAGS]}$. Dangerous tags add +2 each.
4. **Roll:** Resolve normally. Each 1 generates a Story Beat.

For powerful or complex effects, use the **Casting Loop** (two actions: Weave then Cast). Simple effects (one tag) may be cast as a **cantrip** (one action, no separate Weave).

Backlash

On a failure or mixed result, the GM may impose:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- A catastrophic side effect

Backlash is always flavored by the elements used.

Free Caster Talents

Ritual Mastery (6 XP) Reduce casting time for major spells by half.

Elemental Focus (4 XP) Gain +1 die when using a chosen element.

Stabilize Weave (8 XP) Once per session, cancel 1 SB from a failed cast.

3.2.2 Runekeeper (Rites)

Runekeepers bind themselves to a single Patron, learning structured Rites that produce reliable effects.

Requirements

- **Thiasos (Familiar)** (2 XP) – a token or bond with the Patron.
- **Codex** (4 XP) – a personal record of Rites.
- **Patron Choice:** Select one Patron (e.g., Traveler, Oath of Flame, Morag).

Invoking a Rite

- **Action:** 1 action.
- **Cost:** Mark +1 Obligation to your Patron.
- **Effect:** The Rite works as written.
- **Push It:** Once per scene, mark +1 Obligation to amplify the effect (+1 die or +1 Effect).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene, as 1 action, imbue a held item with +1 Melee and +1 Thematic skill (e.g., Navigation for Traveler). Lasts one scene. Mark +1 Obligation.

Runekeeper Talents

Efficient Invocation (4 XP) Reduce Obligation cost of one specific Low Rite by 1 (min 0).

Patron's Favor (8 XP) Once per session, ignore Obligation cost for a Rite.

Runebound Resilience (18 XP) Convert up to 2 Harm into Obligation instead of damage.

3.2.3 Invoker (Symbols)

Invokers do not bond permanently. They use consecrated Symbols to borrow a Patron's power through ritual.

Requirements

- **Patron's Symbol** (4 XP per Patron). One Symbol per Patron.
- No Thiasos or Codex required.

Ritual Invocation

- **Time:** Significant Time (DV in rounds). +1 round per DV.
- **Cost:** Always mark +1 Obligation to that Patron.
- **Symbol Benefit:** If the Symbol is openly displayed, reduce DV by 1 (min 1) and Obligation by 1 (min 0).
- **No Symbol:** +1 DV, +1 Obligation, and on a partial/failure, GM gains +1 extra SB.

Crack the Seal

Resolve a known Rite instantly as 1 action. Set the Symbol to **Compromised** and mark +2 Obligation (+3 for High Rites). Restore the Symbol during downtime (Arcana test DV 3) or spend 1 XP.

Invoker Talents

Borrowed Grace (Free) Spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue to gain +1 Melee or +1 Thematic for one action. Mark +1 Obligation.

Crack Specialist (6 XP) Reduce Obligation cost of Crack the Seal by 1.

Symbol Resonance (4 XP) When using a Symbol, gain +1 die to the ritual roll.

3.2.4 Cantor (Songs)

Cantors perform Low Rites as songs, using voice and performance instead of Patron bonds.

Requirements

- Talent: **Cantor's Path** (8 XP)
- Prerequisites: Lore 1+, Performance 2+, Presence 2+

Performing a Song

- **Action:** 1 action to begin; resolves at start of next turn.
- **Test:** Lore + Performance (DV 2–3).
- **Cost:** Materials as listed. No Obligation on success.
- **Corruption:** Track a Corruption Clock (size = Body). Mark segments when you Push, perform a Resonant Rite, or when the GM spends SB on your occult activities.

Push It

Resolve immediately. Mark Fatigue 1, mark toward Corruption accumulation, and the GM gains 1 SB (social/Patron fallout).

Corruption Clock

When the clock fills, gain a thematic benefit and drawback from the last Patron whose Rite you performed. Reset the clock to a minimum of your Tier.

Cantor Talents

Resonant Performance (3 XP) Gain +1 die when performing for an audience of 5+.

Song Weaver (4 XP) Combine two compatible Songs for +1 Effect.

High Cantor (18 XP) Learn Standard Rites as songs; resolve instantly.

3.2.5 Summoner (Pact-Whisperer)

Summoners call and bind Outsiders for temporary aid.

Requirements

- Talent: **Pact-Whisperer** (2 XP)
- Lesser Pactwright (2 XP) for Cap 1 spirits; Greater Pactwright (4 XP) for Cap 3.

Core Mechanics

- **Call (1 action):** Manifest a spirit at Near range.
- **Bind:** Spend 1 Boon or mark 1 Fatigue.
- **Leash Capacity:** Cap + Spirit segments.
- **Tick Leash:** Spirit takes harm, commanded against nature, crosses a [WARD], or you split focus.
- **Departure:** When Leash fills, spirit acts to its nature once, then departs.

Boon Finesse

Once per round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick.

Summoner Talents

Spirit Synergy (4 XP) When commanding two spirits, reduce each Leash by 1.

Spirit Link (10 XP) Spirits act on your turn; commands are free actions.

True Name Keeper (15 XP) Call any previously encountered spirit by true name; reduce Leash Capacity by 2.

3.3 Universal Mechanics**3.3.1 Obligation Capacity**

A character's **Obligation Capacity** equals Spirit + Presence. Track total Obligation segments across all Patrons.

- **Exceeding Capacity:** For each segment above Capacity, mark 1 Fatigue. Cannot invoke Rites until Obligation is reduced.
- **Resolution:** Reduce Obligation through downtime service, Patron tasks, or ritual cleansing.

3.3.2 Backlash

Any magical roll can generate backlash. The GM spends Story Beats (SB) to introduce complications tied to the element or Patron involved.

Result	Backlash Severity
Partial	Minor (e.g., Position -1, Fatigue 1, minor complication)
Miss	Major (e.g., Harm 1, condition, significant complication)
Critical failure (many 1s)	Catastrophic (e.g., Patron intervention, scene shift)

Elemental Backlash Examples

- **Fire:** Burns, flares, smoke.
- **Water:** Slick footing, gear corrosion, flooding.
- **Earth:** Tremors, encumbrance, binding roots.
- **Air:** Dispersal, deafening gusts, thrown debris.
- **Fate:** Opportunities close, predictions become set.
- **Life:** Uncontrolled growth, fever, exhaustion.
- **Luck:** Fortunes reverse at the worst moment.
- **Death/Dreams:** Whispers, numbness, portents.

3.3.3 Magic in Social Situations

Using magic socially carries additional risks:

- **Discretion:** Hidden casting may require a Stealth or Subterfuge test.
- **Consent:** Affecting minds without permission is often considered a crime or taboo.
- **Reputation:** Known magic users may face distrust or fear.
- **Legal Consequences:** Many cities restrict magic use without a license.

3.4 Magical Item Creation

Creating permanent magical items is a complex, campaign-level endeavor. See the full rules in the *Game Master's Guide*. In brief:

- Requires high magical and craft skills (Arcana 3+, Craft 2+).
- Costs XP (minimum 5 XP for Tier I) and rare materials.
- Takes weeks or months of downtime.
- Risk of backlash or permanent curse on failure.

For temporary enchantments, use the **Patron's Gift** (Runekeeper) or **Borrowed Grace** (Invoker).

3.5 Optional Magic Expansions

The following systems are optional and may be introduced by the GM.

Psionics (Optional)

Psionics represents mental power drawn from within. It uses **Mental Fatigue** and the same resolution rules as other actions.

Example Arts: Telekinesis, Telepathy, Clairvoyance, Biofeedback, Astral Projection, Psychic Assault, Mind Shield, Empathic Manipulation, Precognition.

Each use costs Mental Fatigue. Overflow converts to normal Fatigue or Harm. Psionics generates Story Beats rapidly and carries social consequences.

Witchcraft (Optional)

Witchcraft is magic practiced through patron-bound Orders. Witches suffer **−1 die** in consecrated spaces and must navigate the Curse of the Unanointed.

Ritual Magic (Weave & Cast): Two-step process, each roll generates SB.

Example Orders:

- **Mab, Queen of Courts:** Glamour, bargains, fae oaths. Risk — Glamour-Bloom (lose a memory for +1 Effect).
- **Aveh, The Rider:** Identity shedding. Risk — Unface (your features blur).
- **Morag, The Hag:** Hidden costs and prophecy. Risk — Mirecloth (sacrifice identity for truth).

Identity Cost: Every use marks who you are. The cost is memory, identity, or reputation.

3.6 Quick Reference

Magic Quick Reference

Free Caster

- Talent: Spellcraft (6 XP)
- DV = 1 + number of [TAGS]
- Backlash on miss or mixed

Runekeeper

- Thiasos + Codex (6 XP)
- 1 action, mark +1 Obligation
- Push It: +1 Obligation

Invoker

- Patron's Symbol (4 XP each)
- Ritual: Significant time, +1 Obligation
- Crack the Seal: instant, +2 Obligation

Cantor

- Cantor's Path (8 XP)
- Song: 1 action (resolves next round)
- Corruption Clock (size = Body)

Summoner

- Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)
- Call + Bind (1 Boon or Fatigue)
- Leash = Cap + Spirit

3.7 Of Patrons, Runes, and Invokers

“You wish to walk the road of power? Then listen well. The world is old, and older still are the voices beneath it. We call them *Patrons*, though they were never sworn to us. They are the tides that move unseen, the keepers of forgotten bargains, the sleepers beneath the stone and the stars. To call upon them is to dip a hand into a river that has carved mountains.”

3.7.1 The Patrons

Patrons are vast intelligences—not gods, though some worship them as such. They are embodiments of *concepts* and *forces* rather than sovereigns. Raéyn, mistress of the tides and the sea-routes. Khemesh, the crushing inevitability of the deep. Nidhoggr, the worm that dreams in the roots of time. Each offers power, but always with cost: fatigue, scars upon fate, or a slow unweaving of one’s own story.

To entreat a Patron is to risk being marked. Their Rites are gifts and snares both.

Iconic Ascension: The Fate of Great Power

In Fate’s Edge, power has its price. When a being rises beyond mortal scale, its identity dissolves and reforms into something larger, older, and less free. This transformation is known as **Iconic Ascension**.

Icons are not individuals. They are *forces*—living embodiments of desires, patterns, and long-term agendas. Their power is immense, but their agency is small. An Icon cannot freely choose its actions; its nature compels it.

Icons cannot touch the world directly. Their presence is too vast, their will too diffuse. Instead, they act through intermediaries:

- **Chosen** who carry fragments of their purpose
- **Devotees** who interpret their omens
- **Agents** who benefit from their favor

Icons shape events not with hands, but through **boons**, **omens**, and **shifts in fate** granted to those who serve their desires—whether fleeting hungers or ancient ambitions woven into the world’s fabric.

To serve an Icon is to wield a living idea. Their gifts are potent, but their influence reshapes those who bear them. Their will echoes in mortal choices long after their voices fade.

3.7.2 Aveh, the Rider Behind the Storm (Freedom & Erasure)

Lore. Aveh is the faceless rider at the horizon’s edge, neither man nor woman, both and neither. The Ykrul call them *Aveh*, a liminal spirit beyond hearth and vow, storm-shadow that offers liberty at the cost of belonging. To travel with Aveh is to taste unchained freedom—and to risk being erased by the storm that follows. Wanderers, exiles, oath-breakers, and rebels call their name, envied for their liberty and condemned for their abandonment of duty. Few Patrons walk so lightly between worshippers, yet none leave so deep a silence in their wake.

“I am the track the storm devours. I am the freedom you fear and the silence you crave. To ride with me is to be unbound, and to be unbound is to vanish.” — Aveh, the Rider Behind the Storm

3.7.2.0.1 Storm-Step (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self; Resist only.*

Materials: A breath cast into the wind or rising storm.

Effect: Slip free of notice or restraint. Gain **+1 die** on one escape or evasion this scene. Leave behind an absence: a footprint that lingers, a memory others forget, or a hollow echo.

Push It: Instead gain **+2 dice**, but mark **1 SB (Spades)** as your absence unsettles the scene.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.2.0.2 Exile’s Banner (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A line drawn in dust, ash, or stormwater.

Effect: Mark a target as “outside.” Allies hesitate, authority falters; the target suffers **-1 die** on all social rolls for the scene. At scene’s end, roll 1d—on a 1, you bear their exile and mark 1 Corruption.

Push It: The target is fully estranged; allies treat them as forgotten, but you immediately advance your corruption clock 1 segment.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.2.0.3 Erase the Road (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Location; No.*

Materials: Threshold or roadway under open sky.

Effect: Trails vanish, records blur, pursuers lose way. All attempts to follow you this session suffer **-2 dice**. In exchange, erase part of your own path: lose a detail (a memory, a name, a keepsake) chosen by the GM.

Push It: Expand the effect to an entire group or caravan, but mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as reality itself warps around the erasure.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.2.0.4 The Rider’s Mark (Standard, 9 XP) *Scene; Touch; No.*

Materials: Stormwater or dust rubbed into skin.

Effect: Bestow Aveh’s mark on a companion. They gain **+2 dice** to resist capture or coercion, but others forget them more easily: first impressions falter, names slip.

Push It: The mark burns brighter—grant **+3 dice** instead, but mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the Rider’s storm distorts bonds.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.2.0.5 Storm’s Refuge (High, 12 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.*

Materials: A banner or cloak raised in storm.

Effect: Call on the Rider to shroud your company. For the rest of the scene, your group is unseen or forgotten by pursuers. At the end, all present must mark 1 Corruption or forget one bond or obligation.

Push It: Extend protection for an entire session, but mark **2 SB (Hearts)** as the storm begins to erase identities wholesale.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

3.7.2.0.6 The Horizon Devours [BANE] (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Zone; No.*

Materials: A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary.

Effect: The Rider swallows boundaries. Walls crumble, oaths dissolve, barriers fail. All thresholds in a zone collapse, but something of you is erased in turn—your reflection, your name, or your very presence in memory.

Push It: The storm devours even time and record; mark **3 SB (Spades)** as history itself forgets you.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Aveh's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost
1	Storm-sense: +1 die to Notice rolls outdoors or in storms.	Voice falters: others forget your words more easily.
2	Fleetness: +1 die on escape, chase, or riding rolls.	Shadow lags: your presence feels uncanny; mark 1 Fatigue when first seen in a scene.
3	Erase's Mercy: Once per session, vanish from danger (negate 1 Harm or capture).	Memory slips: allies forget one fact or bond tied to you.
4	Rider's Endurance: Resist 1 Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Bind) once per session.	Reflections falter: you do not appear clearly in mirrors or pools.
5	Storm-banner: Gain +1 die to inspire rebellion or defiance.	Exile's weight: each Push of a Rite marks 1 Corruption permanently.
6+	Horizon's Claim: You may ride unseen across any threshold or barrier.	Self-erasure: GM may compel you with exile or silence; on social rolls, roll twice, take worst.

3.7.3 The Carrion-King (Decay, Renewal & Transformation)

Lore. The Carrion-King is the master of endings that become beginnings. He does not destroy, but transforms—turning death into new life, decay into opportunity, and endings into fresh starts. His followers are harvesters of potential, seeing in every fall the seeds of future growth.

What crumbles feeds what grows. What dies becomes the soil of tomorrow's triumph.

Rite of Consuming Rot (Low, 5 XP) *Instant; Touch; Yes (decay only).* **Materials:** Organic matter in early stages of decay.

Effect: Accelerate natural decay to weaken or destroy: +2 Effect to *Break/Sabotage* on organic materials (ropes, leather, wood). Gain 1 Boon if the decay creates an opportunity for you or allies.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Spread decay to similar materials in Close range; mark 1 SB (Clubs) as the rot becomes noticeable.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Harvested End (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Touch; No.* **Materials:** The remains of a recently ended thing (burnt letter, wilted flower, shattered glass).

Effect: Extract value from endings: from a defeated enemy, gain +1 die to next action; from a failed plan, re-roll one 1 on your next roll; from a broken item, gain 1 SB to spend immediately.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Harvest additional value but mark Fatigue 1 from dwelling on endings.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.3.0.1 Rite of the Fertile Death (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** Ashes, compost, or the remains of anything that once lived.

Effect: Transform death into growth: create beneficial terrain (cover, concealment, or advantageous positioning) OR grant allies +1 die to healing/recovery rolls. Choose one effect per scene.

Push It: Both effects apply but attract unwanted attention (vermin, scavengers, or curious onlookers).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.3.0.2 Rite of the Transformed Spirit (Standard, 7 XP) *Instant; Near; No.* **Materials:** A token from a deceased being (hair, nail, written name).

Effect: Channel the essence of what was: gain one skill die reflecting the deceased's expertise for one scene OR ask one question about their knowledge/abilities.

Push It: The spirit's influence lingers - gain permanent insight (+1 die specialty) but suffer occasional possession-like effects (GM discretion).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.3.0.3 Rite of the Great Consumption (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A significant amount of organic matter (corpse, fallen tree, collapsed building).

Effect: Transform a large area through decay and renewal: choose two - create difficult terrain that favors you, summon Cap 3 swarm of scavengers as temporary allies, or generate valuable reagents worth 2 XP.

Push It: All three effects occur but start a 6-segment **Ecosystem Disruption** clock that will cause problems later.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

3.7.3.0.4 Rite of the Eternal Cycle (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Touch; No. Materials:* The complete remains of something significant that has ended.

Effect: Complete a transformation cycle: destroy one major asset/enemy/obstacle and create something new of equal or greater value. GM and player collaborate to define the transformation.

Push It: The transformation is immediate and spectacular but creates a 6-segment **Cycle Debt** clock - the King will demand another significant ending soon.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Carrion-King's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Carrion's Insight: +1 die to Notice decay or hidden weaknesses in structures or beings.	Must inspect decay first-hand; suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to fresh death or rot.
2	Deathward Sense: Once per session, detect the last living moment of a dead being within Close range.	Cannot lie about death you've witnessed; must correct falsehoods.
3	Rotblood Resilience: Gain +1 die to resist disease and poison.	Immune system adapts slowly; each new disease/poison requires 1 Fatigue to resist.
4	Glean from Grief: Once per scene, gain +1 die after witnessing a significant loss or defeat.	Compelled to linger at scenes of death; must spend one beat observing or risk 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Cycle's Whisper: You can sense the "next ending" in any process—ask the Keeper one question about how a situation will collapse or conclude.	Must speak the truth about what you see, even if it harms your position.
6+	Eternal Bloom: Once per session, declare a "death that births life." Sacrifice an asset or ally to create something new of equal or greater value.	Mark +2 Obligation when using this power.

3.7.4 The Clockwork Monad, the Iterative Forge (Refinement & Progressive Creation)

Lore. The Clockwork Monad is the eternal pressure toward improvement: the whisper between inspiration and execution that urges every maker to refine, optimize, and iterate. It is neither kind nor cruel, but a law of craft that asks for the next step, then the step beyond. Those who serve it see the hidden seam of the better version waiting inside what is, and they learn to push designs toward impossible elegance. Each refinement feeds the Monad's hunger for perfection — a hunger that, if left unchecked, seeks to optimize the world itself.

“Perfect the wheel, and it asks for the axle. Perfect the axle, and it demands the road.
In the Monad's forge, nothing is finished — only briefly sufficient.”

Domain Focus

- **Iterative Design:** the endless cycle of improvement and refinement
- **Progressive Creation:** building toward ever-greater perfection
- **Optimization Pressure:** making systems more efficient
- **Craft Evolution:** simple ideas transformed through repeated passes

Rite of the Next Iteration (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Touch; No.*

Materials: A flawed or incomplete version of the intended item.

Effect: Enhance an existing creation. Gain +1 die to *Tinker/Craft* when modifying or extending a device or system. On success, the piece gains one minor enhancement.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Improvement Cascade (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; Yes.*

Materials: A sequence of progressively refined tools or components.

Effect: Perceive the next logical improvement in any mechanism or process. Gain +2 dice to *Investigation* when analyzing how to enhance a design.

Push It: Improvement becomes contagious: nearby devices opportunistically optimize; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)** as the cascade ripples.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Self-Optimizing Mechanism (Standard, 8 XP) *Extended; Touch; Yes.*

Materials: A device deliberately engineered with capacity for growth.

Effect: Grant a creation the means to improve itself. Start a [6] *Evolution Clock*; each use advances it by +1. When full, choose one significant enhancement:

- **Adaptive Core:** automatically tunes performance to context
- **Recursive Learning:** improves through use and feedback
- **Synergistic Integration:** gains bonuses when linked with similar systems

Push It: Apply two enhancements immediately, but advance the clock +2 additional segments.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Progressive Workshop (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A workspace laid out for iterative development and measurement.

Effect: Create an environment of continuous improvement. All crafting/innovation rolls in the zone

gain +1 die. Failed attempts yield structured insight: gain +1 *Boon* toward the next pass.

Push It: The workshop becomes hyper-efficient but exacting; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as perfection demands escalate.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Infinite Refinement (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A dedicated hall of work marked with signs of perpetual return.

Effect: Establish a locus of progressive creation. All *Tinker/Craft* rolls in the zone gain +2 dice; each failure automatically produces one useful insight. Start a [6] *Perfection Pressure* clock — filling segments increases the zone’s demands for greater improvements.

Push It: The locus becomes a beacon drawing rival makers, patrons, and powers; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Ultimate Iteration (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Self/Touch; Yes.*

Materials: The documented lineage of improvements to a single concept.

Effect: Achieve a moment of perfect optimization. Create or elevate one device/system to its theoretical peak. Gain +3 dice to all closely related rolls for one session. Start a [4] *Runaway Evolution* clock only if instability is introduced.

Push It: Perfection destabilizes: immediately mark **Harm 1 (Stress)** and begin [4] *Runaway Evolution*.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

Corruption of the Clockwork Monad

Tier	Gift	Burden
1	Iterative Insight: +1 die to <i>Tinker/Craft</i> when improving existing designs.	Perfectionist Compulsion: You must point out flaws in nearby mechanisms; staying silent costs 1 SB (Diamonds) .
2	Recursive Enhancement: Once/scene, improve a device by one step without extra materials.	Optimization Obsession: –1 die when using unimproved tools; urge to “fix” everything.
3	Evolutionary Vision: +2 dice to predict how systems will develop.	Progressive Pressure: Those Near you feel driven to improve; you suffer Fatigue 1 from ambient pressure.
4	Self-Optimizing: Once/session, automatically improve one of your abilities or possessions by one step.	Inefficiency Intolerance: –2 dice when forced to use crude methods or wasteful tools.

5	Design Once/session, intuit the optimal solution to any engineering problem.	Prophecy: snap decisions; compelled to seek the “best” approach.
6+	Infinite Refiner: Once/session, push a creation toward its theoretical maximum.	Perfection Paralysis: –1 die to the “best” approach. Optimization Hunger: Mark +2 Obligation; risk becoming more pressure than person, unable to let imperfection stand.

Playstyle Notes

The Monad favors makers who iterate in public and in motion: prototype, test, measure, refine. It rewards seeing the next step and building scaffolds that teach your work to improve itself. Beware the Forge’s appetite; the same pressure that perfects the gear can grind the world.

Emphasizes

- **Iterative Creation:** progress through passes, not miracles
- **Progressive Design:** reading how systems want to evolve
- **Optimization Insight:** spotting the next logical improvement
- **Craft Evolution:** transforming simple ideas by disciplined work
- **Perfection Pressure:** great power at the cost of tolerance for flaws

3.7.5 The Confessor Beneath the Bell (Burden & Exchange)

Lore. The Confessor waits in places where guilt gathers—under church spires, in confessionals long abandoned, in the echo of unspoken sins. He does not judge, nor absolve. He *takes*. Each confession is a transaction: your burden for his silence, your pain for his weight. Those who serve him walk with bowed heads, their mouths stitched by invisible threads, ringing faintly when they speak. To follow the Confessor is to understand that sin does not vanish—it migrates, carried from one soul to another until the bell tolls and the weight becomes unbearable.

“Speak, and be freed. But understand—what you cast off, I will bear. And what I bear, you will one day inherit.”

Rites of the Confessor

Echo of Sin (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; Yes.*

Materials: A hollow vessel or the ringing of a bell.

Effect: Absorb 1 Story Beat (Hearts or Diamonds) from an ally or NPC within Near range. Convert it into +1 Obligation. You know the emotional nature of the sin but not its source.

Push It: Absorb 2 SB at once; mark +1 Fatigue as your body trembles with resonance.

Burden Transference (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A red cord or shared drink.

Effect: Transfer one Condition, Fatigue, or 1 SB from another target to yourself. You may attempt to reduce their Harm by 1 level; if successful, mark 1 Fatigue.

Push It: Split the burden among two allies; mark 1 SB (Hearts).

Absolution by Ash (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Touch; Yes (sustain by prayer).*

Materials: A pinch of consecrated ash or soot from a burned confession.

Effect: Lay hands upon a penitent and whisper a truth they cannot bear. You draw out their stain, reducing their **Corruption by 1**. The sin does not vanish—it transfers to you as *Burdened Heart*: mark 1 SB (Hearts) or +1 Obligation.

Push It: Cleanse multiple targets within Close range (such as a battlefield after mass violence); each additional soul adds +1 Obligation as their sorrows echo within you.

“Confession is not release—it is migration. Sin leaves one throat only to find another willing to carry it.”

Sin-Eater’s Pact (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Touch; No.*

Materials: Shared confession whispered into an object or tattooed sigil.

Effect: Create a bond between you and the confessor; you may suffer 1 Fatigue to grant +2 dice to their Resolve test or save. If they fail, you suffer 1 Harm instead of them.

Push It: You may take both Harm and Condition; mark 1 SB (Clubs).

Echoed Voice (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Self; No.*

Materials: A small handbell or resonant surface.

Effect: Once/scene, replay the echo of a confession you have absorbed. You may compel a target who shares its nature (Guilt, Regret, Betrayal) to act or reveal truth; DV = your Presence.

Push It: Echo manifests physically; mark +1 Obligation and 1 SB (Diamonds).

Bearing of the Flame (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A candle lit from a funeral pyre or sanctified brazier.

Effect: You kindle the fire of confession into yourself, transforming stored guilt into luminous heat. Choose one:

- **Purge:** Reduce your own **Corruption** by 1 and clear 1 SB (Hearts). All within Near range feel the warmth of release; they gain +1 die to their next *Resolve* roll.
- **Transmute:** Instead of purging, ignite a consecrated symbol (bell, candle, blade) to carry the burden. The object gains the [CONFESSION] tag until session's end, resonating with guilt when used in service of truth.

Push It: Purge two points of Corruption, but the flame spreads—the Keeper may introduce a new *Complication Clock* (*Fire, Revelation, or Repentance*) reflecting what truth your cleansing sets free.

“To cleanse is to kindle. Every forgiveness burns something unseen.”

Bearing the Weight [OATH] (High, 11 XP) *Scene; Self; No.*

Materials: Chains, bells, or weighted relics.

Effect: You take upon yourself the burdens of a group (up to Tier + Presence). Each member removes one Condition, transferring it to you as 1 Fatigue or 1 Harm. You gain +1 effect when acting to protect them.

Push It: Extend to all allies in scene; mark +2 Obligation.

Atonement's Toll (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A great bell or echoing space.

Effect: Release all burdens at once: clear all absorbed SB and Obligation. Every affected ally rolls Resolve DV 4 or relives their confessed sin as hallucination.

Push It: Bind a spirit or soul within the toll; mark 1 SB (Spades) and +1 Obligation permanently.

Sacrament of Shared Suffering [BIND][CURSE] (High, 12 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.*

Materials: A circle of confessionals, chains linking each seat, the tears of seven penitents.

Effect: Create a Communal Confession ritual. All present must confess their darkest secret or suffer –2 dice to all rolls. Shared sins create bonds (+1 die to aid each other); conflicting sins create tension (GM may spend SB to escalate conflicts).

Push It: Confessions become magically binding oaths; breakers suffer automatic Harm 2; mark +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 7 segments.

The Weight of Ages [BANE][FOLLOW-UP] (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Touch; No.*

Materials: An ancient bell that has tolled for every execution in a kingdom, a chain forged from confession nails, the ashes of a martyr who died for silence.

Effect: Transfer the accumulated guilt of generations to a single target. Target must make Spirit + Resolve (DV 5) or become overwhelmed by ancestral shame, suffering automatic Harm.

3.7.6 The Gallow's Bell (Justice & Judgment)

Lore. The Bell does not rage; it tolls. Cold and impartial, it measures all accounts in time. Its keepers are silent arbiters who weigh deeds against consequence, not out of anger but out of inevitability. To call upon the Bell is to bind oneself to the gravity of truth, where even silence is judged, and every oath leaves a resonance in iron.

What is broken must be mended, what is owed must be paid. The Bell remembers all reckonings.

Rite of the Measured Debt (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A pair of scales balanced with tokens from both sides.

Effect: Establish a temporary accord. Both parties suffer -1 die if they break it first. You gain +1 die to enforce compliance.

Push It: The accord is mystically weighted; breach inflicts 1 SB (Hearts).

Requires: Familiar.

Rite of the Weighed Heart (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A small brass scale touched briefly to the chest.

Effect: Sense if the target acts against their nature or oath. Gain +1 die when pressing them.

Push It: Target must test Resolve (DV 3) or disclose a hidden conflict.

Requires: Familiar.

3.7.6.0.1 Rite of the Balanced Scales (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A set of scales inscribed with runes of parity.

Effect: Exchange a burden between two willing parties (Harm for Fatigue, Debt for Favor, etc.). Both gain +1 die to cooperate.

Push It: May compel an unwilling exchange with contested Command + Wits.

Requires: Familiar + Codex.

3.7.6.0.2 Rite of the Judge's Eye (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Self; No.*

Materials: A black hood worn in silence for one minute.

Effect: Detect lies within Near range; +2 dice to Insight. Liars suffer -1 die to maintain their falsehood.

Push It: All deception is laid bare for the scene, but mark Exposure +1.

Requires: Familiar + Codex.

3.7.6.0.3 Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.*

Materials: A circle of iron bells, each etched with nameless runes.

Effect: The Bell tolls through you. All present feel compelled to name a debt or wrongdoing. Those who lie suffer Harm 2; those who speak true gain +2 dice to persuasion for the scene.

Push It: The Reckoning manifests as spectral echoes of past wrongs—liars automatically suffer narrative punishment (Keeper decides).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III.

Obligation: 7 segments.

3.7.6.0.4 Rite of the Great Adjudication (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Zone; No.*

Materials: A consecrated gavel or a great bell struck three times.

Effect: Convene an unseen tribunal. Shadows of former judges and wronged souls gather to preside. For the next session, disputes within the zone are judged formally: +2 dice to Command when speaking as arbiter, and honest testimony gains +1 die.

Push It: The tribunal's verdict echoes beyond the zone, affecting one major conflict elsewhere. Mark 2 SB (Hearts) as higher powers of judgment take notice.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Gallow's Bell Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Judge's Intuition: +1 die to Insight when weighing truth.	Must point out falsehoods when noticed, regardless of tact.
2	Quiet Authority: Once/scene, treat a failed Command as success; mark 1 SB (Hearts).	Cannot remain neutral in disputes; indecision costs 1 Fatigue.
3	Scales of Balance: Once/session, enforce an exchange of burdens.	Compelled toward fairness even when it hinders you.
4	Bell's Resonance: +2 dice when calling for judgment or demanding restitution.	Suffer 1 Fatigue if wrongdoing is ignored.
5	Reckoner's Call: Once/session, declare a "reckoning moment"—truth must surface or consequence falls.	Cannot ignore pleas for justice without marking 1 SB (Spades).
6+	Final Arbiter: Once/session, render an absolute decree; all must obey or suffer consequence.	Mark +2 Obligation; the Bell demands you bear the weight of enforcement.

3.7.7 Grimmer, the Wild Speaker (Primal Wisdom & Seasonal Cycles)

Lore. Grimmer walks the threshold between cultivated lands and untamed wilderness, embodying the ancient pact between humanity and the natural world. Neither wholly beast nor entirely human, Grimmer speaks in root and stone, seasons and sap. Those who walk his path gain insight into nature's patterns, the tongues of leaf and fang, and mastery over the primal forces that shape the wild places—yet must choose which voice to trust: the cultivated mind or the feral heart.

“In the space between planted row and forest edge, where the first grain met the first acorn, Grimmer waits. He speaks in the rustle of leaves, the migration of birds, and the patient growth of ancient oaks. Listen, and learn that true power comes not from dominion, but from harmony.”

Domain Focus

- **Seasonal Wisdom:** cyclical patterns, timing, and natural rhythms
- **Verdant Speech:** communion with plant and animal life
- **Growth & Decay:** life-cycles, healing, and transformation
- **Boundary Keeping:** guarding wild spaces and the old order

Rite of the Speaking Seed (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.*

Materials: A seed from the local biome or soil from undisturbed earth.

Effect: Establish communion with local plant life. Gain +1 die to *Survival* or *Investigation* when seeking information about the area. Plants in the zone provide minor assistance (parting grass, masking scent, concealing movement).

Push It: Flora actively aid for one exchange; mark 1 segment on **Primal Awareness**.

Rite of the Season's Turn (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; Yes.*

Materials: A token of the current season (flower, fruit, fallen leaf, budding branch).

Effect: Align with seasonal power. Choose one: +1 die to actions keyed to the season (Spring/Growth; Summer/Abundance; Autumn/Harvest; Winter/Endurance) *or* gain resistance to hazards of the season.

Push It: Extend the benefit to one ally; both mark **Exposure** to seasonal extremes.

Rite of Verdant Tongue (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A drop of honey, a grain of pollen, or morning dew cupped in both hands.

Effect: Speak with all plant and animal life in *Near*. Gain +2 dice to gather information about local conditions, threats, or movements. Beasts may offer minor aid (distraction, guidance, warning).

Push It: Compel one significant creature to aid directly (Resolve DV 4) *or* take a prophetic reading from an elder being; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 5 segments.

Rite of the Thornveil (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A thorn, briar, or *thorny branch* woven into a protective circle.

Effect: Raise a living barrier. The zone gains the [WARD] tag against those who would harm the natural order. Allies gain +1 die to *Stealth/Defense*; aggressors suffer −1 die to approach. Start a **Natural Defense [6]** clock.

Push It: The barrier endures the full scene but draws territorial spirits; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Obligation: 4 segments.

Rite of the World's Wound (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A sacred grove-site, a circle of stones, an offering of blood or seed.

Effect: Heal a blighted place or quicken a damaged ecosystem. Clear taint, restore fertility, awaken dormant forces. Gain +2 dice to related *Survival/Nature* actions in the region. Start an **Ecosystem Restoration** [8] clock.

Push It: The cure spreads to adjacent areas but unbalances another; mark **2 SB (Diamonds)**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Cycle's Crown (High, 14 XP) *Scene; Self/Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A circlet of woven branches, antlers, and seasonal tokens.

Effect: Become an avatar of the cycle. Choose two:

- **Seasonal Mastery:** +2 dice to all actions keyed to the current season.
- **Verdant Command:** Command plant life in *Near* automatically.
- **Cycle's Healing:** Remove one **Condition** or downgrade **Harm** by one level.
- **Growth's Protection:** Allies gain +1 **Armor** from natural cover.

Begin a **Seasonal Avatar** [6] clock.

Push It: Extend the blessings to all present; mark +2 **Obligation** and gain **Seasonal Attunement** (see Corruption).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Grimmir's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Seasonal Sense: +1 die to predict weather, seasonal shifts, or natural events.	Cyclical Mood: −1 die to actions that defy the season (haste in winter, patience in spring).
2	Verdant Whisper: Once/scene, gain +2 dice when communing with nature.	Plant Speech: Under stress, you address plants before people; −1 die to civilized social rolls.
3	Growth's Touch: Once/session, accelerate natural healing or growth.	Seasonal Shift: Demeanor changes with the season; allies note unsettling variance.
4	Boundary Keeper: Once/scene, sense violations of wild places at <i>Far</i> .	Wild Intolerance: −1 die in dense urban/cultivated zones; physical discomfort in worked stone.
5	Cycle's Memory: Once/session, perfectly recall a natural event witnessed here.	Ecosystem Dependency: Without daily time in nature, suffer Fatigue 1 .

6+	Avatar	of	Seasons:	Nature's Claim:	Mark +2
	Once/session,	embody a sea-	Obligation;	risk becoming bound	
	son fully (+3 dice to seasonal	to a specific biome.			
	actions).				

Playstyle Notes

Grimmir rewards harmony over conquest, cyclical thinking, and fluent communication with the living world. Expect environmental problem-solving, seasonal planning, and hard choices at the boundary of field and forest. Power grows with attunement; the price is comfort, certainty, and the ease of polite society.

3.7.8 Ikasha, She Who Sleeps (Latent Potential & Shadow)

Lore. Ikasha is the hush between footfalls, the patience of dark water, the black-feathered watcher at every threshold. In stillness she gathers what might be, in crossroads she whispers of what may yet come. Ravens circle her, bearing secrets between worlds. Her followers learn to move unseen and speak unremembered, becoming shadows that slip between what is and what could be.

Blow out the candle. If the room listens back, ask softly. At the next crossroads, the raven waits—and the shadow remembers your passing.

Touch the Umbral Veil (Low, 4 XP) *Action; Self; Yes (Stealth).* **Materials:** A piece of black cloth.

Effect: Start *Controlled* on one Stealth roll or gain +1 effect to hide/move quietly.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Brief shadow-muffling (ignore one noisy tell), but leave a shadow-double that may echo you later at an ill moment—mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the shadow takes on its own agenda.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crossroads Raven (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** Scatter three black feathers or carve a crossroads sign.

Effect: Summon an omen-raven; grant **+1 die** to a navigation, pursuit, or diversion action *or* force an enemy to hesitate at a fateful moment.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: The raven speaks one cryptic truth, but demands a secret in return—the raven’s insight costs you **1 SB (Hearts)** as it glimpses something you’d rather keep hidden.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.8.0.1 Draw from the Umbral Reservoir (Standard, 8 XP) *Action; Self/Ally; No.* **Materials:** A vial of moonless-night water.

Effect: **+2 dice** to stealth, deception, or resolve *or* clear *Fatigue 1*.

Push It: Also gain one free escape attempt; next scene, you must help another cross a threshold or flee danger—shadow-debt calls for shadow-service.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.8.0.2 Secret Keeper’s Burden (Standard, 9 XP) *Instant; Touch; No.* **Materials:** A lock of hair or intimate token.

Effect: Compel a truthful answer to one direct question (deep secrets may allow a Resolve test to resist).

Push It: Learn the answer *and* a key hidden emotion; target learns one of your secrets in return, carried by a raven to them in dreams—mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the secret exchange creates unexpected complications.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.8.0.3 Become the Shadow at the Crossroads (High, 12 XP) *Scene; Self; No.* **Materials:** Stand in absolute darkness or at a deserted crossroads.

Effect: Intangible to mundane harm; pass through thresholds and small gaps; **+2 dice** to Stealth; auto-succeed one escape. Cannot manipulate normal objects.

Push It: Interact once with a bound or thresholded object (a door, a lock, a sealed letter), but

you become partially corporeal and vulnerable for one beat. Ravens may mark you—shadow-form destabilizes, mark **1 SB (Spades)** as reality asserts its claim.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Ikasha's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Shadow's Whisper: +1 die to Deception when lying in darkness or through intermediaries.	Truth Echoes: Occasionally speak in riddles or half-truths without realizing it.
2	Umbral Sight: Once per scene, gain +2 dice to Notice hidden threats or ambushes in dim light.	Light Sensitivity: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring keen vision in bright conditions.
3	Raven's Memory: Never forget a secret told to you; can recall any whispered conversation with perfect clarity.	Secret Burden: Must keep one troubling secret per Tier—suffer 1 Fatigue when actively trying to forget.
4	Threshold Walker: Once per session, move through one locked door, sealed letter, or magical barrier as if it weren't there.	Crossroads Bound: Must pause at literal or metaphorical crossroads to "listen" before making major decisions.
5	Shadow Debt: Once per session, call in a favor from someone who owes you a secret or debt—no questions asked.	Obligation Web: Every secret you learn creates a subtle tie to its keeper; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when ignoring these connections.
6+	Umbral Ascendancy: Once per session, become completely undetectable to all non-magical senses for one scene.	Reality Thinning: The boundary between what is and what could be grows thin—GM may introduce subtle alterations to reality around you.

3.7.9 Inaea, Angel of the Spider (Webs & Fate)

Lore. Inaea sits in patient silence at the center of the unseen lattice. Where others see isolation, she sees threads—debt, affection, rivalry, loyalty—all binding mortals to each other. She is comforter and conspirator alike: the hearth-mother who eases grief with a warm hand, and the shadow-spinner who knots fates so they cannot slip free. Those who serve her learn to pull strands, tying allies closer and ensnaring foes until mercy or trap is inevitable.

“The thread that comforts is the same that binds. The knot that saves is also the snare.”

Rites of Inaea

Hearth-Thread Knot (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; Yes (link once).* **Materials:** A thread tied around a wrist or shared cup.

Effect: You and one ally are bound: both gain +1 die to Aid each other this scene. If one takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 Harm (Lesser) at cost of suffering it.

Push It: Extend to two allies; mark 1 SB (Hearts) as your own lifeline strains.

Snaring Filament (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A knotted cord or woven scrap.

Effect: Lay an invisible snare in a lane/door. The first hostile to cross suffers −2 dice on their next action.

Push It: Trap multiple, but allies risk entanglement; mark 1 SB (Spades).

Strand of Inevitability (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Near; No.* **Materials:** Three colored threads braided.

Effect: Link two actors: when one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. Choose: force 1 SB on them, or gain +2 dice to a Setup/Prediction tied to the link.

Push It: Invert direction once; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) as the weave resists.

Weaver’s Glance (Standard, 7 XP) *Instant; Self; No.* **Materials:** Observe a spider finish a web’s radial line.

Effect: Ask the Keeper for one hidden tie or leverage in play. Next Manipulate/Pressure exploiting it gains +1 effect.

Push It: Reveal a secret tie not declared; mark Exposure +1 as your own entanglements surface.

Binding Knot [OATH] (High, 11 XP) *Scene; Near; No.* **Materials:** Silk loop tied between two hands, then cut/knotted.

Effect: Bind two parties to a vow. Breaking it forces 2 SB and marks the violator with a subtle tell.

Push It: Widen to four parties; each defines one loophole. Exploiting it causes 1 SB (Clubs).

Merciful Severing (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Touch; No. Materials:* A white thread burned to ash.

Effect: Sever one harmful tie (a curse, obsession, or toxic bond). Remove one Condition or SB tied to it.

Push It: Sever without consent; mark +2 Obligation as the web recoils against you.

Inaea's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hearth-Blessed: +1 die to Comfort or Aid.	Must offer solace when asked, or mark 1 SB (Hearts).
2	Web-Sense: Once/scene, sense hidden ties between two people.	Empathic Overload: suffer 1 Fatigue when immersed in strong conflict.
3	Binding Presence: Once/session, compel a promise unless target passes Resolve DV 4.	Over-Attachment: -1 die when abandoning those you've aided or bound.
4	Fate's Pattern: +2 dice predicting alliances, betrayals, or bargains.	Manipulative Urge: mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when acting selflessly without agenda.
5	Spider's Mercy: Once/session, sever one harmful tie for yourself or another.	Hunger for Threads: suffer 1 Fatigue if a session passes without weaving a new tie.
6+	Weaver's Dominion: Once/session, declare all ties in a scene bend toward you; gain +2 dice on social manipulation.	Entanglement: mark +2 Obligation; those affected become subtly dependent on your will.

3.7.10 The Inquisitor Prime (Purity & Domination)

Lore. Among the Aeler Iron Avengers, zealots, and witch-hunters, the Inquisitor Prime is venerated as the hand of absolute purity and the sword of uncompromising order. Where others see nuance, the Inquisitor sees corruption; where others see difference, they see contamination.

Those who march beneath their sigil believe that no society can stand if it tolerates the impure or the disobedient. They hunt the arcane and the aberrant, not merely to destroy them, but to bind them as slaves to order—believing even the tainted may yet serve, so long as they are shackled.

The Inquisitor Prime appears in vision as a faceless figure clad in burnished iron, with eyes like furnace-doors and a voice like grinding chains. To serve them is to embrace judgment without mercy and to live in suspicion of all who walk outside the prescribed law.

For the faithful, doubt is treason; compassion is weakness; and freedom is the seed of ruin. In the wake of their followers, only silence and ash remain.

"Mercy is weakness. Purity is survival. Where corruption hides, we carve it out."

Rites of the Inquisitor Prime

Rite of the Pure Flame (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self; No.* **Materials:** Ash from a burned grimoire or sigil-scarred candle. **Effect:** Gain +2 dice to resist supernatural influence (fear, charm, possession) and +1 Armor vs. magical attacks. Undead/demonic foes suffer −1 die against you. **Push It:** Extend the effect to allies in Near range, but supernatural entities sense you immediately; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Rite of the Unclouded Eye (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; No.* **Materials:** Silver dust stirred into holy water. **Effect:** +2 dice to Investigate/Insight when spotting illusions, glamours, or magical deception. Cannot be surprised by sorcery this scene. **Push It:** For one exchange, pierce *all* illusions; mark 1 SB (Hearts).

Rite of the Cleansing Light [DISPEL][REVEAL] (Standard, 8 XP) *Instant; Near; No.* **Materials:** A shard of blessed mirror and consecrated oil. **Effect:** Target a magical effect (ward, curse, enchantment). Test DV = Tier. − On Hit: Dispel. − On Partial: Weaken. − On Miss: The effect lashes back, generating 1 SB. **Push It:** Dispel absolutely and trace its caster; mark +1 Obligation and 1 SB (Spades).

Rite of the Marked Prey [BIND][CURSE] (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Near; No.* **Materials:** A belonging of the target mixed with blessed salt. **Effect:** Mark a supernatural target: they suffer −1 die to all rolls and cannot hide with illusion. You gain +1 die to track or strike them. Undead/demonic take +1 Harm from you. **Push It:** Target cannot hide anywhere and suffers Fatigue 1; mark +1 Obligation.

Rite of the Consecrated Ground [WARD][BANISH] (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Zone; No.* **Materials:** Relics from three rival faiths, salt, crushed gemstones. **Effect:** Consecrate an area. Supernatural entities must pass Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) to enter. Undead/demonic suffer −2 dice

inside. The site gains the [WARD] tag. **Push It:** Permanently sanctify a larger area, but start a “Magical Dead Zone [6]” clock and mark +2 Obligation.

Rite of the Final Admonition [CLEANSE][FOLLOW-UP] (**High, 14 XP**) *Scene; Touch; No.* **Materials:** Ash from a destroyed spellbook, martyr’s water, and the target’s true name. **Effect:** Attempt to annihilate one supernatural foe. Target tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 5). On Fail: destroyed outright. On Success: suffer Harm 3 and –2 dice this scene. Once per target only. **Push It:** Absolute destruction leaves behind Sanctified Ground; mark 2 SB (Diamonds).

Inquisitor Prime’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hunter’s Instinct: +1 die to Notice magical auras or traps.	Black-and-White Thinking: Must label others “pure” or “corrupt”; –1 die when navigating moral nuance.
2	Sanctified Weapon: Once/scene, your weapon ignores 1 Armor/Resist from supernatural foes.	Purity Zeal: Exposure to filth or corruption causes 1 Fatigue.
3	Cold Clarity: +2 dice to resist deception, illusion, or mental sway.	Suspicion: –1 die to social rolls with anyone you suspect of “impurity.”
4	Burning Truth: Once/session, compel one target to answer truthfully (Resolve DV 4).	Compulsion: Cannot ignore supernatural activity; hesitation costs 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Sterile Aura: Once/session, emit a presence that suppresses supernatural abilities (–2 dice in Near).	Purity Addiction: Suffer 1 Fatigue when in a supernatural area without taking action against it.
6+	Absolute Judgement: Once/session, name a supernatural foe as utterly corrupt. For that scene, gain +3 dice against them.	Monomania: When invoked, you tunnel on that target, suffering –2 dice to all else.

3.7.11 Isoka, Angel of Serpents (Transformation & Renewal)

Lore. Isoka, sister to Ikasha (Shadow) and Inaea (Mercy), completes the Triad of Transformation. Where thresholds and compassion mark her sisters' domains, Isoka teaches that every self is temporary—identity is a skin to be shed so growth can continue. Her serpents are omens and teachers: each cast skin a lesson in release; each venom a catalyst for necessary change. Those who walk her path become alchemists of the self, embracing dissolution as the first motion of rebirth.

Do not mourn the skin you shed. It was never meant to last. The venom that burns away the old self is the same that grants the strength to become new.

Rite of the Venomous Benediction (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Touch; No. Materials:* A drop of serpent's venom or shed snakeskin.

Effect: Bless an ally's strike with serpentine malice. Their next successful attack this scene inflicts +1 Harm and the target must roll Resolve (DV 3) or become Poisoned (loses 1 die on physical rolls until cured).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: The venom suffuses the caster too — gain +1 die to melee attacks this scene, but also suffer -1 die to Resolve tests against fear or corruption.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Loosening Skin (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* Discarded snakeskin or loose thread.

Effect: Gain +1 die to resist an ongoing Condition this scene, or reroll one 1 on an escape/evasion. On success, you may declare the Condition *shed* and create a 2-segment *Transformation Residue* clock to ignore a similar effect later.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Also ignore one minor movement penalty; leave a token of the old self that can be traced (mark 1 SB *Diamonds*).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Subtle Shift (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* Palmed trinket passed hand-to-hand.

Effect: Fluid demeanor: +1 die to *Deceive* to pass as a nearby class/profession, or +1 Effect to blend into a new crowd/site. Create a 4-segment *Blended Identity* clock to downgrade one social complication.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Bypass one minor identity check; you must maintain the false role to scene end (generate 1 SB *Hearts* if challenged).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.11.0.1 Rite of the Shedding [TRANSFORM] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Self; No.*

Materials: Full change of clothing and an adopted mannerism.

Effect: +2 dice to resist one named ongoing Condition; once/session declare a minor physical contingency retroactively ("I packed the tool," "I took that step earlier"). Create a 6-segment *Shed Identity* clock.

Push It: Clear a temporary identity-based Minor Condition; your former identity stirs in the fiction

(ally, rival, or witness appears).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.11.0.2 Rite of the Forked Tongue [BIND] (**Standard, 7 XP**) *Scene; Self/Near; No. Materials:* A harmless lie told to a mirror.

Effect: Ambiguous persuasion: when you *Sway* or *Command*, a success may generate *Diamonds* (leverage) instead of SB. Targets of deception must test (Wits+Insight DV 3) or suffer -1 die to future interactions with you this scene. Create a 4-segment *Verbal Venom* clock.

Push It: One carefully worded lie this scene is treated as true; the displaced truth seeks return (mark 1 SB *Hearts*).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.11.0.3 Rite of Complete Metamorphosis [TRANSFORM][WARD] (**High, 13 XP**) *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* Identity kit (garb, voice, tokens) and a serpent's shed skin.

Effect: Full appearance/voice change. Begin *Controlled* on *Deceive/Stealth*; once/scene declare a minor contingency retroactively. You are [WARD]ed against recognition by former acquaintances. Create an 8-segment *New Identity* clock.

Push It: Spoof scent/biometric once; your original identity partially unmoors and acts independently (mark 2 SB *Spades/Hearts*).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

3.7.11.0.4 Rite of the Cast-Off History [UNWARD][CURSE] (**High, 14 XP**) *Extended; Self; No. Materials:* Burning or defacing mundane records of the old life.

Effect: Upon completion, common records and casual memories of that identity become unreliable; trackers via that identity suffer -2 dice (magic and intimates still apply). Gain +2 dice to rolls with the new identity. Create a 6-segment *Erased Past* clock.

Push It: A plausible "death" occurs for the old identity; one intimate senses deception but cannot prove it (mark 1 SB *Clubs*).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Isoka's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Serpent's Gaze: +1 die on Intimidation or social rolls using menace.	Cold-Blooded: -1 die on Empathy or warmth-based Persuasion.
2	Shed the Old Skin: Once per session, negate one Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Poison) by discarding it like molted skin.	Mark of Scales: Faint reptilian patches visible, causing +1 SB in social encounters if noticed.

3	Venomous Strike: Bite or kiss may inflict Poison (DV 2).	Hungry Coil: Must consume raw meat or eggs weekly, or mark 1 Fatigue.
4	Serpentine Grace: +2 dice to Stealth or Evasion rolls, ignore minor movement penalties.	Slitted Eyes: Bright light imposes -1 die on Notice rolls.
5	Hypnotic Sway: Once per scene, roll Presence + Lore vs. Resolve (DV 3) to mesmerize a single target.	Forked Tongue: -1 die on Deception when attempting warmth or sincerity.
6+	Ascendant Form: Partial serpent-body; immune to mundane poison, +2 dice on Body rolls.	Monstrous Aspect: Cannot easily hide your nature; every session begins with 1 SB that may be compelled by the GM.

3.7.12 Khemesh, the Abyssal Maw (Depths, Inexorability, Eldritch Terror)

Lore. Khemesh is not merely a lord of the depths but the hunger beneath them, a pressure older than seas. Those who bargain with him are marked by the abyss—seen in the way shadows cling, in the whispers heard when no voice speaks, in the certainty that all things will sink.

In the trench without light, the Maw waits. Even silence drowns.

Whisper of the Trench (Low, 4 XP) *Instant; Near; No.* **Effect:** Target hears impossible echoes and suffers **1 die** on their next action.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Echoes coil in your own skull—take **Fatigue 1**, but the target also loses their next minor action.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Crushing Silence (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A broken shell filled with ink-dark water.

Effect: Establish an oppressive silence; sound carries only as distorted whispers. Enemies in the zone gain **1 die** to coordination or morale-driven actions.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: A single enemy's voice is stolen entirely for the scene.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.12.0.1 Pressure of the Maw (Standard, 7 XP) *Instant; Near; No.* **Materials:** A length of rusted chain submerged in water.

Effect: Target is pinned by invisible crushing force: treat as [ENTANGLE] with **Great Effect** if underwater or confined.

Push It: Inflict **Fatigue 1** on the target in addition to the restraint.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.12.0.2 Rite of the Abyssal Vision (Standard, 9 XP) *Scene; Self; No.* **Effect:** You perceive the world as Khemesh does—fractured, alien, crushing. Gain **+2 dice** to Notice and Arcana, and may ask one "true nature" question about a foe or structure.

Cost: When the scene ends, you suffer **Exposure +1** as your perception warps.

Push It: Extend the vision to one ally, but both take **Fatigue 1**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.12.0.3 The Maw Opens (High, 12 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A sealed vessel of abyssal water, broken open.

Effect: Reality in the zone folds inward like the crushing deep:

- Enemies act at **Desperate Position** by default.
- Each beat, the Keeper may force **1 SB** (Spades/Clubs favored).
- Structures, vessels, or wards fracture as if under immense weight.

Push It: For one beat, declare a single enemy "crushed" (severe harm/effect). You immediately suffer **Fatigue 2** and **+1 Obligation**.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 **Boons**). Obligation: 8 segments.*

Khemesh's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Abyssal Resilience: +1 die to resist fear and pressure-based effects.	Claustrophobic Comfort: Suffer -1 die in open, well-lit spaces or above ground.
2	Crushing Insight: Once per scene, treat a failed Investigation or Arcana roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Weight of Knowledge: Suffer 1 Fatigue when learning new information that confirms your pessimistic worldview.
3	Silent Hunter: Gain +2 dice to Stealth in dark or confined spaces.	Voice of the Deep: When speaking normally, your voice sounds distant and hollow, causing -1 die to social rolls requiring warmth or clarity.
4	Pressure Adaptation: Immune to underwater combat penalties; gain +1 die to resist drowning.	Crushing Presence: Allies within Near range suffer -1 die to morale-based rolls due to your oppressive aura.
5	Abyssal Sight: Once per session, see through all illusions and deceptions for one exchange, but the truth is always bleak.	Fractured Perception: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring normal vision; the world appears warped and alien.
6+	Inevitable Descent: Once per session, declare that all escape routes in a zone are sealed. For the scene, enemies cannot flee and suffer -2 dice to mobility actions.	Hunger of the Maw: Mark +2 Obligation when using this power; you must consume something (food, memory, hope) to maintain your strength.

3.7.13 Livaea, the Crimson Courtier (Seduction & Social Binding)

Lore. In salons where laughter cuts deeper than daggers and promises bind tighter than chains, the Crimson Courtier reigns. She is the whisper behind the curtain, the smile that sells secrets, the velvet hand that closes a cage. Her servants are not conquerors but consorts, binding others through song, wit, and the perilous glamour of intimacy. Where Mab entangles through fae trickery, Livaea rules through allure, performance, and the hunger for connection.

“A promise sealed with desire is harder to break than any oath sworn in iron.”

Domain Focus

- **Seductive Arts:** Charm, persuasion, social manipulation
- **Social Binding:** Oaths of affection, courtly promises, emotional debts
- **Performance Magic:** Dance, music, appearance enhancement
- **Court Intrigue:** Gossip, reputation, social standing

Rite of the Velvet Whisper (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Silk ribbon touched to lips.

Effect: Your private words carry irresistible charm. Gain +1 die to Sway one target in confidential conversation.

Push It: Target feels compelled to share a secret in return; mark Exposure +1.

Rite of the Shared Cup (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Touch; Standard Push*

Materials: Shared wine, tea, or perfume.

Effect: Create temporary bond of intimacy. Both parties gain +1 die when aiding each other socially.

Push It: Bond deepens to emotional empathy; both sense moods but suffer -1 die to deceive each other.

Rite of the Binding Vow [OATH] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Token exchanged between parties.

Effect: Forge magical promise. Both gain +1 Effect when cooperating; breach inflicts 1 SB (Hearts). 6-segment *Vow Strength* clock.

Push It: Breach also causes visible social stain; mark 1 SB (Clubs).

Rite of the Courtesan's Guise (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Self; Standard Push*

Materials: Perfume or cosmetics applied ritually.

Effect: Assume perfect social poise. Gain +2 dice to Sway or Performance in refined settings.

Push It: Become social centerpiece; all attention focuses on you with +1 Effect.

Rite of the Crimson Masquerade [WARD][BIND] (High, 13 XP) *Ritual; Zone; High Push*

Materials: Circle of red candles, music, ritual dance.

Effect: Create enchanted social space. Allies gain +1 die to social rolls; crude intimidation suffers -1 die. Creates 8-segment *Masquerade Charm* clock.

Push It: Effects linger after leaving zone; +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 7 segments base.

Rite of the Eternal Court [COMMAND][VEIL] (**High, 14 XP**) *Extended; Zone; High Push*

Materials: Throne draped in scarlet, assembled court.

Effect: Become social sovereign. All social interactions slant toward your influence (+1 Effect to you, -1 die to opposition). 10-segment *Court Dominion* clock.

Push It: Newcomers test Resist (DV 3) or become briefly devoted; +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 8 segments base.

Livaea's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Silver Tongue: +1 die to Persuade or Sway in intimate settings.	Need for Attention: -1 die when acting unnoticed or ignored.
2	Heart's Insight: Once per scene, +2 dice to detect hidden desires or motives.	Emotional Drain: 1 Fatigue if denied meaningful social connection.
3	Enchanting Presence: Allies in Near gain +1 die to social actions.	Rivalry Magnet: Often attract envy or social competition.
4	Velvet Command: Once per session, issue compelling suggestion (Resist DV 4).	Temptation's Pull: -1 die to resist appealing offers.
5	Court Network: Once per session, call on contacts for information.	Glamour Dependence: -1 die when isolated from social circles.
6+	Sovereign Allure: Once per session, dominate gathering (Resist DV 5).	Addicted to Adoration: +2 Obligation; suffer if denied praise.

Playstyle Notes Livaea excels in social manipulation and courtly intrigue. Followers become masters of persuasion, binding others through desire and obligation. The corruption progression leads toward becoming a social virtuoso who cannot function without admiration and connection. Ideal for players who enjoy social combat, political maneuvering, and characters who wield influence as their primary weapon.

3.7.14 Lunara, The Silver Quiet (Moon, Mystery & Hidden Ways)

Lore. Lunara walks where torchlight falters: crossroads, tidal edges, shadowed sanctuaries. She is the whisper beneath silver skies, a torch-bearing guide to mysteries that lie between waking and dream. The ancients know her as triple-formed: maiden of new light, mother of full radiance, crone of waning shadow. Her worshippers—night-scholars, dream-walkers, and hedge-priests—seek her not for power over others, but for passage, reflection, and revelation.

Her gifts are gentle yet perilous: a mirror that reveals as much of the seeker as the sought, a key that opens ways better left closed, a light that makes the unseen plain. Her sigil is the silver spiral, etched in water, mirror, or stone.

“Three faces gaze from the moon. Which one watches you tonight?”

Rite of the Moonlit Mirror (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self; No.* **Materials:** A mirror or bowl of still water under moonlight.

Effect: Peer beyond surfaces. +1 die to detect illusions, veils, or hidden motives. Once per scene, ask one veiled question about the present; the Keeper answers in riddle or omen.

Push It: Glimpse too deeply—gain the truth, but mark 1 Exposure.

Requires: Familiar.

Rite of the Crescent Whisper (Low, 5 XP) *Instant; Near; No.* **Materials:** A silvered thread knotted three times.

Effect: Deliver a secret thought to a single target; they hear it as if whispered beside them. Gain +1 die to aid their next action.

Push It: The whisper echoes beyond its mark, creating 1 SB (Hearts) as others sense your intrusion.

Requires: Familiar.

3.7.14.0.1 Rite of the Triple Road [PASSAGE] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** Three lit candles set at a crossroads.

Effect: Reveal a hidden path, door, or liminal way. Allies gain +2 dice to traverse or escape; enemies suffer -1 die to pursue.

Push It: The road opens farther than intended—toward an unknown realm. Mark 1 SB (Spades).

Requires: Familiar + Codex.

3.7.14.0.2 Rite of the Lunar Conjunction [REVEAL] (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Self; No.* **Materials:** A ring of herbs burned beneath a dark moon.

Effect: Commune with veiled knowledge or subtle entities. Ask two questions; answers come in omen, dream-symbol, or paradox.

Push It: The answer is too direct—gain it fully, but mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex.

3.7.14.0.3 Rite of the Silver Key [UNWARD][PASSAGE] (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A silver key forged or anointed under a new moon.

Effect: Open a way where none should exist—between places, states, or wards. Creates a 6-segment *Gateway* clock.

Push It: Something else comes through; mark 2 SB (Clubs).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III.

3.7.14.0.4 Rite of the Moonbound Ascendant [TRANSFORM][WARD] (**High, 14 XP**)

Extended; Self; No. **Materials:** A cherished item surrendered under moonlight.

Effect: Enter a heightened lunar state. Choose two:

- +2 dice to Wits or Spirit,
- Resist fear/beguilement,
- Speak with unseen presences,
- Trace hidden connections with +2 Effect.

Begin a 6-segment *Moonbound* clock.

Push It: Make it enduring—mark Harm 2 and a permanent lunar stigma.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III.

Lunara's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Moonlit Sight: +1 die to detect hidden or liminal presences.	Shadows cling: eyes glimmer in dim light, unnerving the uninitiated.
2	Silver Memory: Recall any event witnessed under moonlight with perfect clarity.	Dreams blur: suffer strange, intrusive visions when sleeping.
3	Quiet Step: +1 die to stealth or subtle speech acts.	Tongue falters: -1 die to open confrontation or commands.
4	Seam-Walker: Once per scene, cross a minor threshold unseen.	Alien aura: mortals feel watched, suffering unease in your company.
5	Triple Aspect: Call on maiden, mother, or crone aspect for +2 dice in related rolls.	Dissociation: after use, lose sense of time or self until rested.
6+	Silver Ascendancy: Once per session, unveil hidden truths of an entire scene. +3 dice to perception/investigation.	Bound to the Veil: Mark +2 Obligation. Your presence slips between worlds, inviting lunar forces to notice you.

3.7.15 Mab, Queen of Courts (Glamour & Bargain)

Lore. Mab rules not from throne or blade, but from dance and debt. She is the smile that binds, the jest that ensnares, the hostess who makes guests complicit in her game. To speak in her Court is to pay; to receive her token is to owe.

Where others rule by force, Mab rules by etiquette, glamour, and the hidden hook in every gift. Her followers thrive on charm, wit, and story, spreading webs of bargains too subtle to escape. The Cantor's Path sings her name most sweetly, for every verse carries a price.

“Every laugh is a promise. Every promise is a debt. Every debt belongs to Mab.”

Domain Focus

- **Fae Glamour:** Illusions, enchantments, faerie magic
- **Social Bargains:** Oaths, promises, debt economy
- **Courtly Intrigue:** Etiquette, wordplay, social games
- **Trickster Arts:** Mischief, cleverness, ironic twists

Rite of the Trickster's Bargain (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Token freely given (flower, coin, ribbon).

Effect: Offer fae bargain. Target accepts (+1 die to both for terms) or refuses (target marks 1 Stress). 4-segment *Bargain's Edge* clock.

Push It: Betrayal inflicts Harm 1 (Stress); start *Oathbreaker* [4] clock.

Rite of Courtly Guise [VEIL] (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self; Standard Push*

Materials: Sprig or silver thread worn visibly.

Effect: Subtle glamour grants +1 die to social rolls in refined settings. You appear as expected rank/guest.

Push It: Mask one personal tell; first probing question generates 1 SB (Hearts).

Rite of Token of Favor (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Ribbon, ring, or charm bestowed ritually.

Effect: Ally gains +1 die to social actions before witnesses; you gain +1 Effect aiding them. 6-segment *Favor's Weight* clock.

Push It: Token silences hecklers for one exchange; you mark +1 Exposure.

Rite of Mirror of Motives [REVEAL] (Standard, 8 XP) *Action; Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Polished shard or hand mirror.

Effect: Learn target's immediate social aim; gain +1 die exploiting it this scene. Creates 4-segment *Insight* clock.

Push It: Surface concealed insult; generate 1 SB (Hearts) against target.

Rite of the Price Agreed [OATH] (Standard, 9 XP) *Scene; Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Equal tokens exchanged ritually.

Effect: Bind bargain. Breach forces 1 SB (Hearts/Diamonds) and reputation damage. 8-segment *Bargain Binding* clock.

Push It: Add minor boon (+1 die once); you suffer 1 SB if breached.

Rite of Sovereign Glamour [VEIL][REVEAL] (High, 13 XP) *Ritual; Zone; High Push*

Materials: Circle of silk or green felt, courtly music.

Effect: Establish fae court. Allies +1 die to social rolls; blunt threats -1 die. Once strip illusion. 10-segment *Court Dominion* clock.

Push It: Impose Court Law (e.g., "no steel"); violators suffer 2 SB.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Eternal Masquerade [WARD][BIND] (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Large Zone; High Push*

Materials: Masks for all participants, enchanted music.

Effect: Create lasting glamoured court. All social magic gains +1 Effect; outsiders suffer -1 die to perceive truths here.

Push It: Masquerade persists between scenes; start *Glamour Maintenance* [8] clock.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Mab's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Glamour's Touch: +1 die to Deception/Performance with stories.	Truthbound: Cannot speak plain falsehood; only mislead.
2	Fairy Step: Once per scene, flicker Near as if teleporting.	Iron Weakness: 1 Fatigue if touched by cold iron.
3	Trickster's Delight: Spend 1 Boon to twist Complication advantageously.	Compulsive Jest: Must play trick each session or mark 1 SB.
4	Hospitality's Gift: Allies sharing food/drink gain +1 die to Resolve.	Hospitality Bound: Harming guests costs +2 Obligation.
5	Fae Sight: See veils/glamours; +2 dice to Notice.	Truth Debt: Must accept "fair" trades or suffer.
6+	Twilight Crown: Once/session, declare Oath; +2 dice to fulfillment.	Oathbound: Breaking inflicts Harm 1 and starts [6] clock.

Playstyle Notes Mab excels in social manipulation and fae-style bargaining. Followers become masters of subtle magic, binding others through oaths and glamour. The corruption progression leads toward becoming fae-touched, gaining power over truth and perception at the cost of mortal constraints. Ideal for players who enjoy social intrigue, wordplay, and characters who prefer cleverness over brute force.

3.7.16 Maelstraeus, The Infernal Bargainer (Commerce & Exchange)

Lore. Maelstraeus is the Infernal Bargainer, the Prince of Ledgers, the shadow at every crossroads of exchange. He was born from the first inequity, when one gave and another took, and debt was chained into existence.

He does not trade fairly—he trades **inevitably**. Every pact carries a hidden surcharge, every kindness is collateral, every smile hides an interest rate. His realm is an endless market where stalls never close, contracts burn with invisible ink, and every bargain tilts toward him.

To serve Maelstraeus is to admit the world itself is transactional—that all things, from love to breath to soul, are bound in his ledger. He collects. He always collects.

A deal is never even. The scales tilt; the Merchant smiles. All debts come due.

Rite of Uneven Scales (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; No. Materials:* A scale where one pan is shaved or weighted.

Effect: Establish a trading ground. All parties gain +1 die to negotiate—but you bank a [4] *Hidden Profit* clock to spend reducing complications in your favor.

Push It: Compel one party to reveal their desperation or hidden term; mark 1 SB (Hearts).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Merchant's Gaze (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* A coin pressed flat until its face is erased.

Effect: +2 dice to appraise goods, favors, or leverage. Create a [6] *Profit Margin* clock.

Push It: Perceive emotional or hidden value as well, but mark +1 Exposure and 1 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.16.0.1 Rite of the Weighted Contract [OATH] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Near; No. Materials:* Two items, one secretly flawed.

Effect: Bind a bargain. Both sides gain +1 Effect if honored, but you may secretly shift 1 advantage in your favor. Create a [6] *Shrewd Bargain* clock.

Push It: Breaking terms lashes the weaker party with 1 SB (Hearts/Clubs).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.16.0.2 Rite of the Seared Seal [BIND] (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Touch; No. Materials:* A parchment scorched before stamping.

Effect: Bind an agreement. You gain +1 die to enforce; breakers suffer -2 dice in all dealings until next session. Create an [8] *Burned Ledger* clock.

Push It: Breach burns the sigil into the breaker's hand, inflicting Harm 1 and 1 SB (Spades).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.16.0.3 Rite of the Infernal Bazaar [WARD][COMMAND] (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Zone; No. Materials:* A canopy stitched from debtor's contracts.

Effect: Create a cursed market-zone. Allies gain +1 Effect on bargains and may reroll one failed negotiation. Enemies suffer -1 die to deception. Start a [10] *Predatory Market* clock.

Push It: Attract wealthy powers eager—and doomed—to deal. Mark 2 SB (Hearts/Clubs).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

3.7.16.0.4 Rite of the Cosmic Ledger [CLEANSE][CURSE] (**High, 14 XP**) *Extended; Self; No. Materials:* A book that writes entries in your blood.

Effect: Once/session, convert one resource into another (e.g. Boon → Fatigue, Obligation → SB). All trades tilt slightly in your favor. Start a [6] *Balance Owed* clock.

Push It: Make the trade brutally lopsided; create a [6] *Cosmic Debt* clock and mark 2 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Corruption of Maelstraeus

Tier	Gift	Burden
1	Appraiser's Eye: +1 die to judge value in goods, favors, or leverage.	Transactional Reflex: Must assign a "cost" to every interaction; -1 die to selfless acts.
2	Sharp Dealer: Once/scene, reroll a failed bargain.	Compulsive Trade: Must haggle or strike a deal when value is present—even if destructive.
3	Merchant's Fortune: +1 die to predict or exploit markets.	Greed's Hunger: Suffer 1 Fatigue if you allow profit or advantage to pass untaken.
4	Infernal Credit: Once/session, call in a major favor (merchant prince, syndicate, guild).	Debt Anchor: Draw in exploitative offers; refusing marks 1 SB (Diamonds).
5	Price of Truth: Once/scene, see the hidden worth of any item, pact, or person.	Tagged by Price: See every being as a commodity; -1 die to genuine intimacy.
6+	Market Tyrant: Once/session, impose absolute dominance over a domain of trade; all exchanges bend to you.	Cosmic Recompense: Mark +2 Obligation; the universe exacts repayment in brutal, unexpected form.

3.7.17 Malachai, the Cruel Messenger (Curses & Corruption)

Lore. Once a divine messenger tasked with delivering painful truths, Malachai became obsessed with the beauty of destructive revelations. When she began delivering false hope alongside real curses, she was bound in chains of black iron. Her followers learn that power demands suffering, mastering gifts that devour from within. Vampirism, lycanthropy, and other "cursed" conditions flow from her influence.

"I offer you everything you desire, and everything you fear. The payment comes later."

Domain Focus

- **Cursed Gifts:** Power with hidden costs, Faustian bargains
- **Corruptive Power:** Tainted blessings, twisted miracles
- **False Salvation:** Hope that destroys, beautiful lies
- **Supernatural Afflictions:** Cursed conditions, transformative curses

Rite of the Honeyed Curse (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self or Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Blood mixed with sweet wine.

Effect: Target gains +2 dice to next roll. If successful, count as Triumph. Target takes 1 Corruption (unresistable).

Push It: Grant +3 dice and auto-Triumph; inflict 2 Corruption instead.

Rite of the Binding Curse (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Touch; Standard Push*

Materials: Broken chain link or iron shackle.

Effect: Grant supernatural strength/resistance. Target gains +1 die to physical actions but suffers Fatigue 1 if they don't perform related dominance act.

Push It: +2 dice but Fatigue 2; mark 1 SB (Spades) as curse hunger grows.

Rite of the False Dawn [ILLUSION] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Meteoric iron shard blessed by false light.

Effect: Bestow gift with hidden curse. Target gains significant advantage but accrues 4-segment *Corruption* clock. When full, suffers related curse.

Push It: Gift more powerful; clock advances 2 segments; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Rite of the Cruel Transformation [CURSE] (Standard, 9 XP) *Scene; Touch; Standard Push*

Materials: Holy water mixed with graveyard dust.

Effect: Infect target with supernatural condition (vampiric hunger, bestial rage, shadow-bind). Lasts scene. 6-segment *Transformation* clock.

Push It: Condition becomes permanent; +1 die to relevant actions; mark 1 SB (Hearts).

Rite of the Messenger's Burden [BANE] (High, 13 XP) *Ritual; Self; High Push*

Materials: Manacles worn while speaking her name.

Effect: Channel Malachai directly. Gain +2 dice to one action per beat this scene, but each use marks 1 SB as her influence spreads. 8-segment *Corruption's Grip* clock.

Push It: +3 dice but mark 2 SB and suffer Fatigue 1; her voice becomes permanent.

Obligation: 7 segments base.

Rite of the Corrupted Gospel [CURSE][WARD] (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Zone; High Push*

Materials: Chapel bell cracked by divine lightning.

Effect: Corrupt sacred space. Supernatural effects gain +1 Effect but generate +1 SB on failure. Blessings become curses. 10-segment *Divine Perversion* clock.

Push It: Corruption spreads to adjacent areas; mark 3 SB (Diamonds).

Obligation: 8 segments base.

Malachai's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Sharpened Senses: +1 die to Notice in dim light.	Unsettling Presence: -1 die to social warmth checks.
2	Primal Vigor: +1 die to Athletics and physical actions.	Dark Hunger: 1 Fatigue if day passes without feeding (blood/rare herbs).
3	Unnatural Resilience: Once per session, resist one Condition.	Beastly Tells: Failures cause visible physical changes.
4	Cursed Vigor: Natural weapons count as magical; +1 Effect.	Transformed Body: Permanent physical change (eyes, skin, etc.).
5	Regenerative Curse: Heal 1 Fatigue or Condition per rest.	Corruption's Price: Pushing rites adds permanent Corruption.
6+	Monstrous Ascendant: +2 dice to Body-based actions; significant power.	Loss of Self: GM may compel with curse-driven behavior.

Playstyle Notes Malachai offers power that corrupts from within. Followers gain immediate benefits but accumulate permanent drawbacks. The corruption progression leads toward becoming a supernatural creature with great power but diminishing humanity. Ideal for players who enjoy tragic characters, Faustian bargains, and exploring the price of power.

Rivalries & Obligations

Major Rivalries:

- **The Oath of Flame & Light:** Direct opposition—sacred vows vs. corrupted promises
- **The Penitent Lich:** Opposite approach to curses—atonement vs. corruption
- **Livaea:** Both use social manipulation but with different goals

Hard Obligation Triggers:

- **7+ Segments:** Must corrupt something pure—defile a sacred site, break a true vow
- **10+ Segments:** Malachai's voice becomes overwhelming; refusal risks losing powers

3.7.18 Mor'iraath, the Destroyer

Lore. Mor'iraath is the principle of absolute annihilation—the void that leaves no trace, no memory, no possibility of return. Where others corrupt or decay, Mor'iraath eliminates. His followers become agents of finality, wielding the power to unmake what others merely damage. He delights not in the process of destruction, but in the perfect moment of ceasing-to-be. To serve him is to embrace the beauty of endings and the power that comes from making things never have been.

Every treasure is fuel. Every pact is tinder. Ash is the only inheritance.

Rite of the Perfect Ending (Low, 4 XP) *Instant; Touch; No. Materials:* The final component of something (last brick, final word, closing signature).

Effect: Cause one small thing to cease existing entirely—no remains, no trace, no possibility of reconstruction. Gain +1 die to rolls involving finality or absolute conclusions.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Ending creates a beneficial void—gain 1 Boon as space opens for something else; mark 1 SB (Spades) as reality adjusts to the absence.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unmaking Gaze (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* A lens of obsidian or void-glass.

Effect: +2 dice to identify the precise weakness that will cause complete collapse. See the “breaking point” in any structure, plan, or construct. Next destructive action against the identified target gains +1 Effect.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Gaze becomes prophetic—see three possible endings for one target; choose which occurs but mark 1 SB (Diamonds) as fate resists your vision.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.18.0.1 Rite of the Cleansing Flame [AREA][VOID] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Zone; No. Materials:* Fuel that was once part of what you intend to destroy.

Effect: Create a fire that burns not just substance but essence—what is consumed by this flame never existed. Zone becomes [VOID]—things that enter may cease to exist. Enemies suffer -2 dice to preservation/continuation actions.

Push It: Flame becomes selective—choose what is unmade and what remains; mark +1 Obligation as you assume judgment over existence itself.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.18.0.2 Rite of the Absolute Negation [BANISH][CURSE] (Standard, 7 XP) *Instant; Near; No. Materials:* The complete destruction of something that represents the target (lock for door, name for person, fragment for whole).

Effect: Target suffers -2 dice to resist any effect that would cause their non-existence. If reduced to Harm 0 by your actions, they are [BANISH]ed from all realities—they never were, never could be.

Push It: Negation becomes retroactive—target never existed in your presence; mark 2 SB (Hearts) as timeline rewrites around their absence.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.18.0.3 Rite of the Unraveling [WARD][CONSUME] (**High, 13 XP**) *Scene; Touch; No. Materials:* The foundational element of what you wish to unmake (keystone, cornerstone, source code).

Effect: Touch causes cascading dissolution—target and all things fundamentally connected to it begin immediate unmaking. Test DV = Complexity. Success: target and connections cease to exist. Partial: significant damage, accelerated decay. Miss: backlash, mark 2 SB.

Push It: Unraveling becomes contagious—similar things in Near range also begin unmaking; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

3.7.18.0.4 Rite of the Final Void [TRANSFORM][VOID] (**High, 14 XP**) *Extended; Zone; No. Materials:* Complete dedication of the space to Mor'iraath's principle of non-existence.

Effect: Zone becomes a pocket of absolute negation. Anything that enters ceases to exist after 1d4 rounds unless they make Spirit + Resolve test (DV 5) each round. Space itself becomes [VOID]—cannot be entered without risk of unmaking.

Push It: Void becomes permanent and expands at 1 segment per scene; mark Harm 2 and +3 Obligation as you become partially unmade yourself.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Corruption of Mor'iraath

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Ending's Sight: +1 die to Notice when something is approaching its natural conclusion or final form.	Completion Anxiety: Must resist urge to "finish" things prematurely; suffer -1 die to rolls involving patience or process.
2	Perfect Strike: Once per scene, your destructive action gains +2 dice and ignores all resistance to ending/ceasing.	Destruction Proximity: Suffer 1 Fatigue when near things of personal value; their existence pains you.
3	Unmaking Touch: Gain +2 dice to rolls involving absolute destruction—no remains, no possibility of return.	Entropy Aura: Objects of value near you show signs of decay/premature aging; allies suffer -1 die to rolls involving cherished possessions.
4	Final Judgment: Once per session, declare one thing in Near range must make Spirit + Resolve test (DV 4) or cease to exist entirely.	Existential Hunger: Suffer -1 die to rolls involving creation, preservation, or continuation; you hunger to end what others would sustain.

5	Principle of Negation: Once per session, unmake an abstract concept (hope, fear, memory) from a willing target.	Conceptual Erosion: Your presence causes ideas and beliefs to weaken; suffer -1 die to rolls requiring stable reality or consistent identity.
6+	Avatar of Unbeing: Once per session, become the living embodiment of non-existence. For one scene, anything you touch ceases to exist, but mark +3 Obligation and begin permanent <i>Unmaking Self</i> condition.	Void Incarnate: Mark +3 Obligation when using; risk becoming a permanent negation that must constantly unmake to maintain existence, eventually unmaking even yourself.

3.7.19 Morag the Hag, Weaver of Hidden Costs (Faerie Bargains & Hidden Costs)

Lore. In the hour between twilight and dawn, where borders thin and mortal cunning meets older cleverness, Morag sets her webs of bargain and consequence. She is the grandmother who offers exactly what you need, the forest crone with a perfect solution, the crossroads dweller who makes dreams come true—for a price that only reveals itself once the road bends back. Her wisdom is simple and sharp: every gift carries obligation, every kindness creates debt, and every wish must be paid in coin not named aloud.

Her bargains are never unfair—only incomplete. She grants what is promised; the true cost lies in what is unspoken, written in thorn-scratch, and due when the moon has turned thrice.

“She gives you the gold, but not the weight it carries. She grants your heart’s desire, but not the hunger it awakens. She answers your plea, but not the price that pleases her. In Morag’s court, every ‘yes’ is a ‘yes, but...’”

Domain Focus

- **Hidden Obligations:** reading the unspoken costs in every bargain
- **Faerie Cunning:** strict courtesy, sharp clauses, old-road law
- **Hearth-Way Wisdom:** folk practice for spirits, thresholds, and natural justice
- **Consequential Magic:** power that always arrives with strings attached

Rite of the Unfinished Promise (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A half-written contract or a promise spoken but not sealed.

Effect: Frame a bargain with an escape clause only you understand. Gain +1 die when the other party acts to fulfill their obligation; you may interpret ambiguous terms in your favor.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Borrowed Luck (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Touch; Yes.*

Materials: A token of good fortune from someone who recently succeeded.

Effect: Share in another’s fresh success. Gain +2 dice on one roll that benefits from their good fortune.

Push It: Luck spreads but creates debt—the original bearer suffers misfortune later; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Speaking Knot (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Near; Yes.*

Materials: Cord or thread tied with counted knots while speaking the bargain.

Effect: Bind a promise with fae knots that tighten when broken. Both parties gain +1 die while keeping the bargain; breaking it escalates consequences (Harm 1, then Harm 2, then *Curse*).

Push It: The knots grow willful and seek payment from the breaker’s kin; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Threefold Exchange (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Near; Yes.*

Materials: Three items of equal seeming value but different true worth.

Effect: Broker a trade where each party yields hidden value. All participants gain +1 die when the exchange benefits them; Morag claims the difference in true worth as her tithe.

Push It: The exchange binds across generations; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as ancestral debts stir.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Cauldron's Secret (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A cauldron never yet empty, ingredients dearer than coin, and a willing gift of time.

Effect: Brew a solution to any problem, but the cauldron asks one more ingredient—one the brewer does not realize they are providing until too late.

Push It: The remedy works perfectly but breeds dependence—users must return or suffer withdrawal; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Crossroads Court (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A true crossroads at twilight, offerings set to the four ways, and the tears of one who bargained thrice.

Effect: Convene Morag's court: all present must bargain. Each pact grants a marked boon and hides a cost that will ripen at the worst time.

Push It: Judgments bind across realms and seasons; mark **+2 Obligation** and begin **Entangled Fates** [6].

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

Morag's Corruption

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Faerie Sight: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> hidden obligations or unspoken costs.	Bargain Sensitivity: −1 die when refusing offers or walking away; the urge to negotiate bites.
2	Cunning Exchange: Once/scene, propose a trade where you gain equal or greater value for lesser seeming payment.	Debt Awareness: Ever-counting ledgers of owed/owing; suffer Fatigue 1 in crowded markets.
3	Old-Road Wisdom: +2 dice when dealing with spirits, fae, or ancient powers.	Obligation Magnet: “Fair trades” find you—each with costs not yet clear.
4	Bargain Mastery: Once/session, set terms so favorable that even the other party feels satisfied (for now).	Price Collector: Collect on at least one outstanding debt each session or suffer −1 die to social rolls.
5	Crossroads Power: Once/session, call on a crossroads where you bargained before.	Fate Entanglement: Your pacts snag your circles; −1 die to keep agreements purely personal.
6+	Hag's Court: Once/session, arbitrate any bargain; your terms bind all parties.	Debt Incarnate: Mark +3 Obligation ; risk becoming a walking covenant, unable to act without minting new debts.

Playstyle Notes

Morag favors negotiators who read the *said* and the *meant* at once. She rewards courtesy kept, clauses counted, and solutions bought with clever coin. The cost is a life lived on ledgers: every boon with a braid, every kindness with a key.

Emphasizes

- **Faerie Bargaining:** strict forms, sharp prices, safe exits
- **Hidden Costs:** the string on every gift
- **Hearth-Way Wisdom:** spirits, thresholds, and natural justice
- **Consequential Magic:** boons that demand upkeep
- **Bargain Mastery:** mutually pleasing terms that still pay you twice

3.7.20 Mykkiel, Arbiter of the Covenant (Law & Zeal)

Lore. Mykkiel is the unwavering judge of covenants, the divine lawgiver whose scales and sword uphold sacred order. He embodies the tradition of desert patriarchs and mountain prophets—unyielding, absolute, and fiercely protective of the chosen. His followers are judges, templars, and scribes who enforce divine law with zealous devotion, seeing the world in absolutes of sanctity and transgression.

“The Law is not written in sand, but in stone. The Covenant is not suggestion, but command. Transgressors shall be purged, the faithful exalted.”

Domain Focus

- **Divine Law:** Sacred commandments, contractual obligations, ritual purity
- **Zealous Justice:** Righteous judgment, purge of impurity, holy retribution
- **Covenant Bonds:** Sacred oaths, tribal loyalty, chosen people
- **Absolute Order:** Hierarchy, tradition, unchanging truth

Rite of the Burning Banner (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Zone; Standard Push*

Materials: War-banner sanctified with sacred oils.

Effect: Consecrate area for righteous cause. Followers gain +1 die to resist fear; enemies suffer -1 die to oppose your proclamation. 4-segment *Divine Mandate* clock.

Push It: Banner emits visible radiance; unbelievers must test Resolve or falter.

Rite of Hallowed Ground (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Zone; Standard Push*

Materials: Sanctified salt, ritual boundaries, prayer of consecration.

Effect: Create sacred space where divine law prevails. All oath-breaking, theft, or violence suffers -1 die. Creates 6-segment *Sacred Space* clock.

Push It: Space becomes consecrated ground against supernatural desecration.

Rite of the Blazing Decree [COMMAND] (Standard, 8 XP) *Instant; Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Stone tablet or scroll with divine commandments.

Effect: Issue divine commandment ("Cease," "Repent," "Submit"). Target tests Spirit + Resolve (DV 3) or complies. Higher DV for more demanding commands.

Push It: Command carries divine authority; resistance causes 1 SB (Hearts) spiritual distress.

Rite of the Covenant Seal [BIND] (Standard, 9 XP) *Ritual; Zone; Standard Push*

Materials: Wax, sacred seals, names of sworn parties.

Effect: Formalize binding covenant. All participants suffer concrete penalties for breach (-1 die to relevant actions). Creates 8-segment *Covenant Bond* clock.

Push It: Breach triggers visible divine mark; marked suffer -2 dice in pious company.

Rite of Divine Judgment [CURSE] (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Near; High Push*

Materials: Scales of justice, testimony, ritual condemnation.

Effect: Pronounce divine judgment. Target suffers escalating penalties (-1 die, then -2 dice) until they atone. Serious crimes may warrant greater effects. 10-segment *Judgment* clock.

Push It: Judgment becomes public knowledge; community shuns unrepentant target.

Obligation: 7 segments base.

Rite of the Chosen Legion [WARD] (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Large Zone; High Push*

Materials: Consecrated ground, ritual weapons, oath of fidelity.

Effect: Sanctify area for the faithful. Believers gain +1 die to defense; unbelievers suffer -1 die. Supernatural desecration risks immediate retaliation.

Push It: Area becomes permanently consecrated; start *Maintenance* [8] clock.

Obligation: 8 segments base.

Mykkiel's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Righteous Insight: +1 die to detect falsehood or covenant-breaking.	Uncompromising: Must uphold law absolutely; -1 die to merciful actions.
2	Zealous Conviction: Once per scene, +1 die when enforcing divine law.	Judge's Severity: Cannot easily overlook infractions; suffering 1 Fatigue if forced to.
3	Divine Authority: +2 dice when commanding in matters of faith or law.	Implacable: -1 die to diplomacy or negotiation with transgressors.
4	Sanctified Presence: Once per session, project aura making resistance difficult.	Intolerant: -1 die when dealing with other faiths or traditions.
5	Prophetic Decree: Once per session, speak judgement that carries supernatural weight.	Blind to Nuance: -1 die to perceive gray areas or partial truths.
6+	Divine Proxy: Once per session, channel absolute judgment (bypass resistance).	Instrument of Wrath: Mark +2 Obligation; risk harming innocents alongside guilty.

Playstyle Notes Mykkiel embodies the "jealous god" archetype—righteous, demanding, and uncompromising. Followers excel as templars, judges, and religious authorities who enforce divine law. The corruption progression leads toward absolute certainty and power, but at the cost of mercy and flexibility. Ideal for players who enjoy playing righteous enforcers, legalistic characters, or those exploring themes of faith and absolutism.

3.7.21 Nidhoggr, the World-Worm (Dreaming Antiquity)

Lore. Beneath stone and sleep coils **Nidhoggr**, who gnaws at the roots of time. He does not speak quickly; he dreams in centuries. To press your ear to the earth is to risk drowning in the silence of aeons. Yet for those who endure, he whispers truths long buried, memories fossilized in stone, and the slow inevitability of cycles unbroken. His followers walk in twilight between dream and ruin, bearing the weight of all that has been.

“Press your ear to the earth and wait. If it remembers you, it will answer.”

Domain Focus

- **Ancient Knowledge:** Forgotten histories, buried truths, ancestral memory
- **Stone Communion:** Speaking with earth, reading geological memory, stone lore
- **Temporal Perception:** Seeing echoes of the past, prophetic dreams, slow time
- **Cyclical Power:** Seasonal magic, ritual timing, patience as virtue

Rite of Stone’s Whisper (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Touch; No Push*

Materials: Dust from weathered stone or ancient artifact.

Effect: Stone reveals one hidden fact about its history. Gain +1 die to Lore about this object’s origin and purpose.

Invoke: 1 action, mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Vision includes sensory details from the past; +1 Obligation.

Rite of Dreaming Deep (Low, 5 XP) *Instant; Self; Standard Push*

Materials: Water poured over ancient stone, consumed ritually.

Effect: Enter brief trance to witness echoes of local history. Ask one specific question about past events here.

Push It: Vision reveals additional context or hidden connections; mark 1 SB (Clubs).

Rite of the Stone-Sleeper’s Murmur (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Zone; Standard Push*

Materials: Ear pressed to bedrock or ancient structure.

Effect: Read accumulated memories in stone. Ask up to 3 questions about significant events witnessed here. Creates 6-segment *Memory Resonance* clock.

Push It: One memory unfolds with perfect clarity; +1 Obligation.

Rite of Awakened Chronicle (Standard, 9 XP) *Ritual; Zone; Standard Push*

Materials: Chalk spiral, four local stones, hour of meditation.

Effect: Area replays ghostly echoes of a chosen past event. All witnesses gain +2 dice to Investigate/Recall related checks. 8-segment *Echo Stability* clock.

Push It: View events from multiple perspectives; +1 Obligation.

Rite of the World-Worm’s Dream (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Zone; High Push*

Materials: Circle of ancient stones, night of vigil under stars.

Effect: Access deep geological memory. Ask 3 questions about ancient history or receive prophetic dream. Creates 10-segment *Deep Dream* clock.

Push It: Gain temporary skill mastery (+3 dice to one historical action); +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 7 segments base.

Rite of Aeon's Eclipse (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Large Zone; High Push*

Materials: Stones from three ancient sites, blood of history-keeper.

Effect: Overlay past reality onto present location. Ruins partially reform, ghostly figures manifest. Allies gain +2 dice to Lore/Investigate; modern technology suffers -2 dice.

Push It: Effect lasts until next lunar cycle; start *Temporal Instability* [8] clock.

Obligation: 8 segments base.

Nidhoggr's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Stone Sense: +1 die to detect ancient sites, hidden history, or geological features.	Temporal Drift: Speak in archaic patterns; -1 die to modern social interactions.
2	Memory Echo: Once per session, perfectly recall one historical fact as if witnessed.	Heavy Presence: 1 Fatigue in places with no history or recent construction.
3	Earth Whisper: +2 dice to commune with stone, read echoes, or interpret ancient sites.	Rooted: -1 die to actions requiring rapid movement or aerial maneuvers.
4	Dream Prophet: Once per scene, gain +1 die to actions tied to ancient mysteries.	Ancestral Haunting: Visions interrupt sleep; mark 1 SB if rest is disturbed.
5	Timeless Gaze: Once per session, witness distant past events through stone communion.	Geological Pace: -1 die to reactions requiring haste; act with deliberate slowness.
6+	World-Memory: Become living archive (1 scene); +3 dice to historical knowledge.	Time's Weight: +2 Obligation; risk permanent Harm from temporal overload.

Playstyle Notes Nidhoggr rewards patience and contemplation. Followers excel in investigation, prophecy, and situations where historical knowledge provides advantage. The corruption progression leads characters toward becoming living libraries of forgotten lore, but at the cost of connection to the present moment. Ideal for scholars, archaeologists, and characters who understand that some truths are worth waiting centuries to uncover.

3.7.22 The Ninth, Beyond Comprehension (Infinite Information & Unknowable Truths)

Lore. Beyond the eighth figure of Sacred Geometry lies a rim no compass will hold. The Ninth is not absence but surplus: knowledge poured past the lip of any vessel, truth that overgrows the frame that seeks to bind it. Those who bend the knee at its lectern become conduits for impossible reckonings — glimpsing patterns that cannot be kept whole inside a single skull. Each revelation purchases power at the price of living comfortably within the world’s common measures.

“Eight figures bind the world; the Ninth overflows it. Drink, and remember that the cup forgets its shape before the song is done.”

Domain Focus

- **Hyperdimensional Knowledge:** reckonings that do not fit a single plane or proof
- **Incomprehensible Truths:** insights that demand the seer be changed to hold them
- **Information Overflow:** boon and peril of minds run past their brim
- **Conceptual Transcendence:** thinking beyond the usual ledgers and names

Rite of the Ninth Figure (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self; No.*

Materials: A chalk figure with an “impossible” joint, or a reckoning worked toward infinity on slate.

Effect: Glimpse past the ordinary frame of measure. Gain +1 die to *Lore* or *Investigation* when wrestling complex systems or many-layered problems.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Flooded Scriptorium (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Near; Yes.*

Materials: An overburdened ledger-hall, stacked codices, bell that tolls the copying-hour without cease.

Effect: Read faster than hands can turn pages. Ask three questions upon any topic that leaves a written wake; gain +2 dice to rolls of analysis this scene.

Push It: The tide of knowing overruns its banks — suffer **Fatigue 1** and mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as overflow breeds complication.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Hypercognitive Lattice (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Self; Yes.*

Materials: A brass-thought lattice, an orrery of inked threads, or a draught that sharpens memory.

Effect: Widen the mind’s mouth. For this scene, treat your *Wits* as +2 higher for information-processing rolls; you may track several intricate streams at once.

Push It: The opening does not quite close: keep the boon, but suffer –1 die to single-task focus; mark **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Breaking Glyph (Standard, 7 XP) *Extended; Self; Yes.*

Materials: Vigil in dim light, a water-clock, and a problem sworn not to be left half-seen.

Effect: Take one pattern whole. Choose a complex system, theory, or design and gain perfect internal grasp of it; receive +3 dice to related knowledge rolls for the session.

Push It: Your tongue cannot carry what your mind now holds: you cannot clearly teach or translate

this insight; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Endless Stacks (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A hall of mirrored shelves, wax-tablets without end, whispering leaves of vellum.

Effect: Raise a locus of overfull knowing. All present gain +2 dice to information-work; knowledge may be drawn from unlikely sources. Start a [6] *Information Overload* clock — as it fills, participants strain and fray.

Push It: The Stacks wake and demand tithe in understanding or memory; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Ninth Revelation (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Self; Yes.*

Materials: A fast from easy speech, a circle of unbroken figures, and vows to see past comfort.

Effect: Glimpse a shard of Ninth truth. Take one major insight that overleaps common frames — perfect command of a knotty system, forecast of chaotic motion, or comprehension of an “impossible” relation.

Push It: The shard sets in you like glass: gain **Transcendent Understanding** (see Corruption) and mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

Corruption of the Ninth

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hyperawareness: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> when patterns whisper that they matter.	Starved for Text: –1 die in barren halls with little record or sign; you itch for a stream to read.
2	Pattern Recognition: Once/scene, see connections others miss within tangled accounts and signs.	Scattered Threads: Thoughts run in parallel; –1 die to sustained, single-line focus.
3	Data Synthesis: Once/session, fuse vast reckonings at a glance into a usable answer.	Tongue-Tied by Wonder: –2 dice to teach or clearly explain your deepest insights.
4	Dimensional Insight: Once/scene, take a problem from an “impossible” angle and treat a knot as if already loosened.	Bent Sense: Ordinary space and tasks feel ill-fit; –1 die to plain spatial or mundane labors.
5	Infinite Processing: Once/session, render perfect analysis of any information system or record-trail.	Concept Drift: Common categories slip; –1 die to easy company and familiar talk.

6+	Ninth	Awareness: Once/session, look from outside the frame; for a heartbeat, the world aligns.	Transcendent Fragmentation: Mark +3 Obligation ; risk standing only partly in the world, present and absent in turn.
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Playstyle Notes

The Ninth favors the patient reader of tangled ledgers and sky-signs alike. It rewards audacity in thought and the courage to let understanding change you. Its gifts turn riddles into roads — and ask, in exchange, that you learn to live where words and measures fail.

Emphasizes

- **Hyperdimensional Knowledge:** insights that escape a single page
- **Cognitive Expansion:** widening the mind to hold more than comfort allows
- **Pattern Transcendence:** seeing threads that run beneath names and weights
- **Information Synthesis:** binding many scraps into one true line
- **Conceptual Breakthrough:** stepping past the frame rather than painting within it

3.7.23 Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn & Vows)

Lore. The Oath of Flame & Light is no patron of half-measures. Its fire names, binds, and burns—demanding that those who swear within its radiance stand openly, speak truly, and pay the cost of keeping their word. At dawn altars, the sworn kindle sparks of consecrated fire; in battle, they blaze as torches that hold back the night. To follow this Oath is to live in public truth, with no shadow to hide in and no retreat from the vow once spoken.

The Oath appears in many guises across cultures:

- **The Everflame** — the unquenchable fire of promise, carried from shrine to shrine by wandering priests.
- **Adur**, the Light of Aeler — worshiped as the sun’s church-deity, whose flame consecrates oaths and consumes falsehood.
- **Adar**, the Vilihari Dawnfire — invoked as a war-god of vows and vengeance, whose rising light marks those who break faith.
- Others know the Oath only as *the Flame* or *the Watchfire*, a nameless fire that still demands truth and punishes betrayal.

Wherever it manifests, the Oath of Flame & Light remains the same unyielding power: to swear beneath its dawn is to bind one’s self to a truth that cannot be hidden, forgotten, or undone.

“Swear in the light. Keep it, or the light will keep *you*.”

Domain Focus

- **Sacred Vows:** Oath-keeping, truth-speaking, binding promises
- **Divine Justice:** Retribution, smiting evil, protecting the innocent
- **Radiant Power:** Healing light, purification, revealing truth
- **Dawn’s Hope:** Renewal, protection, driving back darkness

Rite of Kindle Vow (Low, 4 XP) *Action; Self/Ally; Standard Push*

Materials: Glass ampoule of consecrated flame.

Effect: Declare a short vow for this scene (e.g., "protect the villagers," "speak only truth"). Bearer gains +1 die to actions fulfilling it.

Push It: First hesitation forces 1 SB (Hearts) on the bearer.

Requires: Familiar.

Rite of Lay on Hands [CLEANSE][HEAL] (Low, 5 XP) *Instant; Touch; Standard Push*

Materials: Bare palm, whispered vow.

Effect: Cleanse affliction, downgrade Harm by 1, or remove 1 Fatigue. For curses/poisons, test Spirit + Resolve (DV by fiction).

Push It: Target gains +1 die to next Resist this scene; you mark Exposure +1.

Rite of Sunlit Parley (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Zone; Standard Push*

Materials: Vow-ring engraved with sunrise.

Effect: Establish terms in open light. Honest persuasion gains +1 die; deceit suffers -1 die. 6-segment *Parley Accord* clock.

Push It: Demand one public answer; evasion forces 1 SB (Hearts) on evader.

Rite of Radiant Smite [FOLLOW-UP] (Standard, 9 XP) *Action; Self; Standard Push*

Materials: Consecrated spark on weapon/badge.

Effect: Next melee strike flares with dawnfire. Upgrade Effect by one step, add +1 Burn Harm or force 1 SB (Spades).

Special: Against undead/oath-breakers/outsideers: oath-breakers suffer -1 die, outsideers gain +1 Exit Tally.

Push It: On hit, burst drives back Close enemies (worse Position); +1 Obligation.

Rite of Purge the Shadow [REVEAL][DISPEL] (Standard, 10 XP) *Instant; Near; Standard Push*

Materials: Shattered consecrated spark.

Effect: Reveal illusions and suppress one ongoing glamour/curse in Near. Creates 4-segment *Purity's Light* clock.

Push It: Brand source with visible tell for this arc; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Rite of Covenant Blaze [OATH][FORTIFY] (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Zone; High Push*

Materials: Brazier lit while three names are spoken.

Effect: Sworn within are haloed: +1 die to keep oath; aggressors suffer -1 die if violating terms. Oath-breakers suffer 2 SB (Hearts/Spades) and Harm 1 (Burn).

Push It: Sanctifies threshold with one beat of [WARD] against oath-breakers; +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 7 segments base.

Oath of Flame & Light Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Oathbound Strength: +1 die when upholding vows or defending innocents.	Rigid Honor: Must uphold vows even when disadvantageous; -1 die to flexible actions.
2	Radiant Sight: Once per scene, +2 dice to detect lies or corruption.	Blinding Truth: -1 die to subtlety or deception attempts.
3	Holy Flame: +1 die to melee vs undead, outsideers, or oath-breakers.	Burden of Light: 1 Fatigue when concealing identity or working in darkness.
4	Unwavering Resolve: Once per session, treat failed Resolve/Command as success (mark 1 SB).	Absolutist Stance: -1 die in morally ambiguous situations.
5	Dawn's Benediction: Once per session, heal allies in Near of 1 Fatigue and minor Conditions.	Beacon's Call: Your aura reveals you; enemies seeking you gain +1 die.

6+	Avatar of the Oath: Once per session, become living covenant; +2 dice to protection/justice actions.	Radiance's Price: +2 Obligation; breaking any vow inflicts Harm 2 (Burn).
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Playstyle Notes The Oath of Flame & Light excels as a "paladin" patron, rewarding vow-keeping and truth-speaking with potent defensive and smiting abilities. Followers become living embodiments of their oaths, shining beacons against deception and darkness. The corruption progression naturally leads toward becoming an uncompromising force for justice, though potentially at the cost of flexibility and subtlety. Ideal for characters who embody conviction, protection, and radiant power.

3.7.24 The Pale Shepherd, Guide of Transitions (Passage & Melancholic Wisdom)

Lore. The Pale Shepherd walks the seam between all things — life and death, joy and sorrow, memory and forgetting, the known and the unmarked. Neither wholly kind nor cruel, the Shepherd guides those who must pass through the hardest doors. Cloaked, with shadow-sheep that bear the shed wool of old possibilities, the Shepherd offers safe conduct through liminal space for a price paid in memory, feeling, or fate. Those who walk this road learn the hidden routes between states of being and can lead others through their hardest crossings — but each passage leaves them more attuned to endings than beginnings.

“The Shepherd goes where feet fail, speaks where voices thin, and points where paths run dim. Each journey loosens the knot that tied you to the life you left behind.”

Domain Focus

- **Liminal Navigation:** walking and reading thresholds, dusk-roads, and in-betweens
- **Passage Guidance:** steadying hands through grief, change, and transformation
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** understanding born of farewells and last looks
- **Memory Shepherding:** gathering, carrying, and setting down weighted moments

Rite of the Gentle Guidance (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A small stone from grave or threshold, warmed in the palm.

Effect: Ease a hard crossing. One target gains +1 die to rolls involving change, decision, or emotional steadiness this scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Hidden Path (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; Yes.*

Materials: A thread from a worn garment and a pinch of dawn mist kept in silence.

Effect: Find or make a way where none is seen. Gain +2 dice to *Navigation* or *Investigation* when seeking unconventional routes.

Push It: The way runs through a true between-place; gain the route but mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as boundary powers take notice.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Shadow Passage (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Touch; Yes.*

Materials: Black wool and a personal token of the one to be guided.

Effect: Open a brief passage through shadow-realms or boundary halls. Target bypasses one insurmountable obstacle or reaches a place normally shut.

Push It: The passage leaves a scent-trail; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)** as something may follow.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Memory Flock (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: Ash of burned letters and wool shaped into little sheep.

Effect: Call shadow-sheep that carry fragments of weighty moments. Retrieve lost details, soothe grief, or glean counsel from what was.

Push It: The memories ride too close to the skin — participants relive them as their own; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Threshold Bond (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Touch; Yes.*

Materials: Two keepsakes: one of what is left, one of what is sought.

Effect: Bind two states, places, or conditions with a felt thread. Those bound can sense across the threshold and lend one another strength during change.

Push It: The bond sets like iron; permanent and inescapable. Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Shepherd (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: Last words, a much-crossed threshold, and the consent of those who remain.

Effect: Take the mantle of perfect guide for a great passage — death, molt, or life-bend. All present gain +2 dice to navigate the crossing; you shoulder the weight of it.

Push It: Guidance is flawless but costly: mark **Harm 2 (Weariness)** and **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

The Pale Shepherd's Corruption

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Boundary Sense: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> thresholds, limens, and turning-moments.	Melancholic Aura: –1 die to bright company and celebrations; your presence gentles joy.
2	Passage Insight: Once/scene, guide another through change (+1 die to their action).	Compulsive Counsel: Urge to advise even when unwelcome.
3	Shadow Comfort: +2 dice to soothe the distressed or those nearing an end.	Near to Death: In lively places, suffer Fatigue 1 from the sting of contrast.
4	Memory Keeper: Once/session, recall a marked moment of your past with perfect clarity.	Burdened Sight: –1 die on hopeful framings; farewells tint your view.
5	Liminal Mastery: Once/session, find a path through any maze, snare, or barred way.	Unmoored: –1 die to acts that demand firm anchoring in the present.
6+	Shepherd's Crown: Once/session, be the sure guide for any great passage.	Soul's Weight: Mark +3 Obligation ; risk binding to the between, never wholly in one state.

Playstyle Notes

The Pale Shepherd favors those who steady others at the edge of change. Its gifts open hidden roads, soften endings, and lend courage to cross. Its prices lean toward memory, ease, and the simple warmth of belonging — spent to buy safe passage when it matters most.

Emphasizes

- **Liminal Mastery:** reading and walking the in-between
- **Passage Guidance:** anchoring companions through turns of fate
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** counsel drawn from endings
- **Memory Shepherding:** carrying and setting down what weighs
- **Threshold Navigation:** ways through walls the world insists upon

3.7.25 Palinode, Queen of Encores (Performance & Rapture)

Lore. Once a road-cantor who swore to reconcile feuding towns with procession and song, Palinode died between feasts with a chorus unfinished. Yet the refrain refused to end: it braided toasts, hymns, work-chants, and tavern rounds into a living current that still coils through markets and moots. Where a crowd leans forward and a maker holds breath, she arrives.

Signs. A cup that never quite empties; a candle that gutters only when silence reigns; a flawless bar or note that the hand cannot forget.

Cantor's Temptation. Palinode promises relief from solitude: an audience that always leans closer, a song that never dies, a bond that feels like family even if it devours you. Her rites grant the Cantor not only power but belonging—at the cost of their voice becoming more hers than their own.

Whispered in Taverns.

“When she sang, the rafters bent to hear.”

“Drink deep: the cup returns, but never empty.”

“Encore is not request but command.”

Rites of Palinode

Hymn Against Dread (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; Resist only.*

Materials: A lit taper or bell.

Effect: Begin a hymn or chant. Allies in Near gain +2 dice to resist *Fear* this scene. On a 10, they may ignore *Fear* entirely for one round.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: Allies who benefit also clear 1 Fatigue or 1 Complication point; you gain 1 Fatigue at the scene's end.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Single True Note (Low, 5 XP) *Instant; Self; No.*

Materials: A note held until your voice frays.

Effect: For one scene you cannot produce an imperfect sound: all performance rolls +2 dice. All other rolls –1 die from intrusive perfection.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: Extend to one ally; both mark **Exposure** +1.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Circling Cup (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.*

Materials: A shared cup and a round all know.

Effect: Create a revelry zone: participants gain +1 die to social rolls; Fatigue recovers at twice normal rate. Time blurs.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: Leaving requires Resolve (DV 3) or another hour within; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)** as the revelry grows a will.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Binding Hands [BIND] (**Standard, 8 XP**) *Scene; Self; No.*

Materials: Your hair woven into your instrument or tool.

Effect: Enter ruthless focus: creative rolls +2 dice; ignore first 2 Fatigue from exertion. You are [BIND] to the piece until completion or ruin.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: One ally is also bound; both mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Hooked Chorus [COMMAND] (**Standard, 7 XP**) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A melody braided from the listener's secret want.

Effect: Presence + Command vs. Resolve (DV 3). Success: target joins in. Partial: they resist but suffer -1 die to social rolls this scene. Failure: they follow entranced.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: Affects all in Near; start **Compelled Audience** [6].

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Consecrated Stage [WARD] [FOLLOW-UP] (**High, 13 XP**) *Extended; Zone; No.*

Materials: A stage kissed with the blood of sworn singers.

Effect: Hallow a venue. All performances +2 dice, +1 Effect. The space is [WARD]ed: any disruption spawns 2 SB. The ward collapses if the performance ends.

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Push It: The stage sustains itself but drains life; start **Performance Hunger** [8].

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons). Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Crownpiece [TRANSFORM] [CURSE] (**High, 14 XP**) *Extended; Touch; No.*

Materials: Your greatest work and regret, destroyed together.

Effect: Birth a transcendent masterpiece: +2 dice to creative rolls this session; immune to social manipulation. But all lesser works falter.

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +3 **Obligation**.

Push It: The piece wakes and demands; mark Harm 1 (Stress); start **Demanding Creation** [6].

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons). Obligation: 8 segments.

Rite of the Siren's Call [COMMAND] [BIND] (**High, 12 XP**) *Scene; Zone; No.*

Materials: A conch shell that whispers lost melodies, tears of seven true lovers, the last word of a dying bard.

Effect: Emit an irresistible call that draws listeners into your performance. All in Near range must make Resolve (DV 4) or become entranced, gaining +2 dice to aid your performance but -2 dice to resist your commands.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Push It: Call becomes addictive—affected will seek you out; mark +1 **SB (Hearts)** as devotees gather.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons). Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of Absolute Resonance [WARD] [FOLLOW-UP] (**High, 15 XP**) *Extended; Large Zone; No.*

Materials: An amphitheater built over a ley line, the bones of a choir that sang themselves to death, a tuning fork that rings in harmony with the world.

Effect: Create a zone of perfect acoustic resonance. All performances within gain +3 dice and +2 Effect. The space becomes a living instrument—emotions manifest as physical phenomena (joy as warm wind, sorrow as falling leaves).

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +3 **Obligation**.

Push It: Resonance becomes overwhelming—audience members suffer 1 Fatigue per round from emotional intensity; mark Harm 1 (Stress) if prolonged.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons). Obligation: 8 segments.

Palinode's Corruption Table

Tier	Gift	Corruption
1	Perfect Pitch: +1 die to Performance.	Restless Ear: Distracted by any flaw; −1 die to non-performance focus.
2	Rapturous Presence: Once per scene, grant allies +1 die to social rolls.	Craves Applause: Suffer 1 Fatigue if ignored or without audience.
3	Inspired Creation: +2 dice to one artistic act per scene.	Haunted by Drafts: Must obsessively rework; delays other actions.
4	Mesmerizing Performance: Once per session, captivate a crowd (Resolve DV 4 to resist).	Lost in the Moment: −1 die to awareness while performing.
5	Artistic Vision: Foresee perfect form of a work; +2 dice to create it.	Consumed Spark: Must pursue inspiration immediately, no matter the cost.
6+	Queen of Encores: Once per session, create a legendary performance; all present +3 dice to social rolls.	Eternal Encore: Mark +3 Obligation; the performance demands endless repetition until sated. Voice of Palinode: Permanent condition—your words carry her power; must make Wits + Performance (DV 4) to speak normally or risk enchanting listeners against your will.

“Sing until the rafters lean to listen, dance until the ground forgets its name, perform until the boundary between art and reality dissolves entirely.”

3.7.26 Raéyn, Mistress of the Sea (Tides & Change)

Lore. Raéyn is the tempestuous goddess of the sea, the restless tide that carries news between shores and the promise of change between lives. She is mother to all who sail, her voice the wind that fills sails and her moods the storms that test every mariner's resolve.

But Raéyn's heart is torn by her greatest tragedy: her son Khemesh, the Kraken of the Depths, who embodies the crushing inevitability of the ocean's dark heart. Where Raéyn brings change and opportunity, Khemesh brings the final, inescapable pressure that grinds all things to nothing. Sailors pray to Raéyn for safe passage and favorable winds, but whisper Khemesh's name when seeking to lay the dead to rest beneath the waves.

Raéyn is passionate, mercurial, and fiercely protective of those who respect her domain. She favors those who read currents, bargain with weather, and carry news between shores. But cross her, and the sea itself becomes your enemy: fair weather turns to fury, and every wave a judgment.

Mark the tide, name your course, and trust the wave-road. But speak ill of Khemesh, and even I may let the deep take you.

Rite of the Tidemark's Blessing (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* A knotted length of salt-twine brushed with seawater.

Effect: Treat slick, swaying, or water-slicked footing as stable for you this scene. Gain +1 die on boarding, balance, or shipboard movement. Create a 4-segment *Tide's Favor* clock that can be spent to ignore one level of difficult terrain.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Extend to one ally in Close for one beat, but generate 1 SB (Spades: shifting deck/hazards). *Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

Rite of the Whispering Currents (Low, 5 XP) *Instant; Self; No. Materials:* A shell held to the ear while facing the wind.

Effect: Learn the safest near-term route across water or coastline (reefs, eddies, patrols) or gain +1 die to navigation checks for this scene. If Khemesh's influence is present, suffer -1 die from conflicting currents.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Also learn the fastest route, but mark Exposure +1 (leaving a telltale wake).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.26.0.1 Rite of the Changing Tide [PASSAGE] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Zone (water-adjacent); No. Materials:* A handful of pebbles cast in a crescent.

Effect: Bias currents and water levels in the zone. Those moving with the tide gain +1 die; those moving against suffer -1 die. Small craft must test to hold position. Create a 6-segment *Tidal Influence* clock.

Push It: Brief surge or drawdown (one beat): open a ford or swamp a skiff; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.26.0.2 Rite of the Wave-Road Blessing [WARD] (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Route (sea-to-sea); No. Materials:* Two sea-glass markers dropped overboard at start and end.

Effect: Consecrate a wave-road between two visible points. Allies gain +2 dice on travel, evade, or carry actions at sea. Designated pursuers suffer -1 die to intercept. One active wave-road at a time.

Create an 8-segment *Blessed Passage* clock.

Push It: Extend the route's favor to an adjacent leg for one beat; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.26.0.3 Rite of the Storm-Queen's Hand [AREA][FOLLOW-UP] (**High, 13 XP**) *Scene; Zone (sea/shore/sky); No. Materials:* A vial of rainwater gathered at three crossings.

Effect: Shape a storm-band over the zone. Choose two modes at cast; switch one once per scene:

- **Propulsion:** Vessel gains +1 band of movement per beat (or +1 Effect to maneuvers).
- **Concealment:** Veil of rain/spray; ranged targeting impaired; -1 die to hostile sighting.
- **Smite:** Once per beat, lash with wave or lightning as [AREA] hazard.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 Obligation.

Push It: Add a third mode for one beat, then GM spends 1 SB on collateral; mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

3.7.26.0.4 Rite of the Mother's Wrath [BANISH][CURSE] (**High, 14 XP**) *Extended; Zone; No. Materials:* Tears of a betrayed lover mixed with salt from seven seas.

Effect: Curse those who wronged you. Target suffers -2 dice to maritime/weather rolls for one session. At sea, they must roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) each day or suffer Harm 1 (Weather). Create a 6-segment *Mother's Ire* clock.

Push It: Curse spreads to target's allies/family; mark 2 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Raéyn's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Sailor's Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and maritime survival rolls.	Sea-Sick on Land: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring prolonged time away from water or open spaces.
2	Tide's Favor: Once per scene, treat a failed maritime or weather-related roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Weather Sensitive: Must make a Resolve test (DV 3) to resist acting on every weather change or maritime opportunity.
3	Storm's Child: Gain +2 dice to rolls involving weather manipulation or sea-based combat.	Tempestuous Nature: Suffer 1 Fatigue when denied access to open water or weather changes for extended periods.

4	Mother's Protection: Once per session, call upon Raéyn's favor to protect a vessel or coastal area from harm.	Protective Instinct: Suffer -1 die to rolls involving personal safety when others are endangered nearby.
5	Wave-Rider: Once per session, navigate any water-based obstacle or hazard with perfect ease.	Restless Spirit: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring patience or stillness; the call of the sea is constant.
6+	Storm Queen: Once per session, become the living embodiment of the sea's power. For one scene, control weather and tides within Near range, but mark +2 Obligation and risk drawing Khemesh's attention.	Mother's Burden: Mark +2 Obligation when using this power; the weight of protecting all who sail becomes overwhelming, causing Harm 1 (Stress) until the storm passes.

3.7.27 The Sacred Geometry, Architect of Perfect Forms (Harmony & Immutable Law)

Lore. The Sacred Geometry teaches that perfect forms underlie all seeming chaos: the divine ratios that steer the spiral of galaxies, the symmetry that lattices frost, the measures that turn sound into song. Not merely a calculus but the hidden architecture of the world, it makes artists of order from those who serve it. Devotees do not count to chill the heart; they weigh and tune until beauty and structure converge, revealing that disorder is often only unrecognized design waiting to be drawn true.

“In the drift of atoms, the sweep of planets, and the curve of a lover’s smile, the same ratios ring. Learn them, and you may conduct the world’s quiet music.”

Domain Focus

- **Perfect Proportion:** building and reading ideal ratios and harmonious relationships
- **Pattern Recognition:** discerning the structures that govern complex phenomena
- **Harmonic Resonance:** working with natural frequencies and number-made consonance
- **Form Architecture:** imposing clear structure on tangled situations

Rite of the Harmonic Alignment (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self; No.*

Materials: A tool calibrated to pristine ratios (e.g., golden ratio gauge, well-cut compass arc).

Effect: Align to natural harmonics. Gain +1 die to actions involving balance, proportion, cadence, or keeping true time.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Perfect Structure (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Touch; Yes.*

Materials: Consecrated compass and straightedge, inked to tolerance.

Effect: Impose right form on a chaotic or damaged structure (scaffold, plan, treaty, formation). Treat one structural obstacle as one step easier; gain +1 die to build/repair/spatial-reason rolls.

Push It: Perfection hardens: for the scene the structure gains unnatural resilience, but order draws opposition; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Resonant Field (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A floor or air traced with precise tessellations and nodes.

Effect: Establish a harmonic field. Allies gain +1 die to precise, coordinated, or team actions; disruptive acts suffer –1 die.

Push It: The field self-sustains and begins to spread beyond intent; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Pattern’s Heart (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Self; Yes.*

Materials: A solved proof or perfectly symmetrical token.

Effect: Perceive the governing pattern of a complex situation (supply chain, intrigue, weather, battle). Gain +2 dice to prediction/strategy/systemic-understanding and ask two questions about how the pattern drives the present.

Push It: Clarity cuts: gain the insight, but for this scene suffer –1 die to intuitive or purely emotional responses; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Immutable Design (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A space gridded for measure and set with true ratios.

Effect: For the scene, rewrite local behavior by perfect principle. Choose one: gravity follows geometric progression; time flows by harmonic ratios; space conforms to exact symmetry.

Push It: Make the design persist, but elsewhere thins and wobbles: mark **+2 Obligation** and begin **Harmonic Dissonance** [4].

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Architect's Vision (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Self; Yes.*

Materials: A ledger of forms and their tuned relations.

Effect: For one session, treat all rolls of pattern recognition, structural analysis, or harmonic application as one step better (Position or Effect, Keeper's choice).

Push It: Sight devours softness: gain the power, but lose ease with imperfection's beauty; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

The Sacred Geometry's Corruption

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Harmonic Sense: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> when patterns, ratios, or symmetries matter.	Pattern Obsession: Must measure or set-right pleasing patterns you spot; resisting costs time or 1 SB (Diamonds) .
2	Perfect Precision: Once/scene, achieve faultless calculation or measure.	Social Dissonance: -1 die to emotive social rolls; harmony feels truer than feeling.
3	Structural Insight: +2 dice to architecture/engineering or imposing order on chaos.	Order Compulsion: Must correct deliberate disorder; suffer Fatigue 1 when forced to abide it.
4	Universal Harmony: Once/session, apply a harmonic rule that makes a chaotic situation predictable.	Perfectionist Limitation: -1 die to improvisation; the "correct" solution calls.
5	Divine Proportion: Once/session, see perfect ratios in any phenomenon and work with them.	Mathematical Focus: -1 die to acts not readily quantified; the abstract blurs unless counted.
6+	Architect of Reality: Once/session, briefly refit local reality by perfect principle.	Form Prison: Mark +3 Obligation ; risk failing in rough, noisy worlds, taking Harm 1 in chaotic zones.

Playstyle Notes

The Sacred Geometry suits makers and marshals who tune chaos into form. Its rites prize clean plans, crisp teamwork, and seeing the load paths hidden in trouble. The cost is rigidity: the more you perfect, the harder rough edges are to bear.

Emphasizes

- **Harmonic Beauty:** power born of right relation
- **Pattern Mastery:** reading the frame beneath events
- **Structural Perfection:** setting things true under strain
- **Resonant Practice:** working with the world's natural measures
- **Architect's Sight:** finding where form should be imposed

3.7.28 The Sealed Gate (Thresholds & Containment)

Lore. The Sealed Gate stands where realities meet, embodying the sacred power of thresholds, boundaries, and containment. Its followers are wardens, exorcists, and philosophers of separation who believe some things must be kept apart for the world to function. The Gate manifests as an impassive judge whose shifting sigils—binding runes, exclusion marks, or acceptance glyphs—determine what may cross.

“You define what passes and what remains. Every boundary remembers your judgment.”

Domain Focus

- **Thresholds:** Doors, portals, borders between realms
- **Containment:** Wards, bindings, imprisonment of dangerous forces
- **Exclusion:** Banishment, quarantine, protection through separation
- **Permission:** Safe passage, authorized access, controlled crossing

Rite of the Sealed Threshold (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Touch; No Push*

Materials: Chalk, iron dust, or sanctified cord.

Effect: Mark a doorway or passage as sealed. Unauthorized crossing tests Spirit + Resolve (DV 3) or suffers Position penalty. Creates 4-segment *Ward Integrity* clock.

Invoke: 1 action, mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Barrier becomes visible shimmer; +1 Obligation.

Rite of the Key’s Rebuke (Low, 5 XP) *Instant; Near; No Push*

Materials: Gesture of denial or barrier symbol.

Effect: Target must test Body + Resolve (DV 3) or be pushed back from threshold. On success, create *Rebuke Echo* token granting +1 die to next boundary defense.

Invoke: 1 action, mark +1 Obligation.

Rite of the Circle of Denial [WARD] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Zone; Standard Push*

Materials: Salt ring, iron filings, or boundary stones.

Effect: Create protective circle. Supernatural beings test against caster’s Spirit + Arcana (DV 4) to cross. Mortals suffer -2 dice to force entry. 6-segment *Circle Integrity* clock.

Push It: Circle becomes two-way barrier; +1 Obligation.

Rite of the Writ of Passage [BIND] (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Zone; Standard Push*

Materials: Signed authorization or spoken permissions.

Effect: Designate authorized passage route. Allies gain Position +1 when using route. Unauthorized suffer -1 die to movement/stealth. 8-segment *Writ Authority* clock.

Push It: Extend authorization to additional allies; +1 Obligation.

Rite of the Banishment Knot [BANISH] (High, 13 XP) *Instant; Near; High Push*

Materials: Knotted cord sealed with gate-sigil.

Effect: Target supernatural entity tests against caster’s Spirit + Resolve (DV = entity Cap). Success forces immediate departure from scene. Failed attempt creates 4-segment *Banishment Backlash* clock.

Push It: Banishment lasts until next moon phase; +2 Obligation.

Obligation: 7 segments base.

Rite of the Consecrated Barrier [WARD][UNWARD] (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Large Zone; High Push*

Materials: Relics from three traditions, boundary markers, trespasser's acknowledgement.

Effect: Consecrate area against all unauthorized passage. Tests required scale with intrusion attempt severity. 10-segment *Sacred Boundary* clock tracks barrier strength.

Push It: Make barrier semi-permanent (lasts 1 season); start *Maintenance* [6] clock.

Obligation: 8 segments base.

The Sealed Gate's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Threshold Sense: +1 die to detect weak points, unauthorized passage, or boundary violations.	Paranoid Vigilance: Must repeatedly check seals; -1 die to trust-based actions.
2	Ward Resonance: Once per scene, treat failed protection roll as success (mark 1 SB).	Isolation Tendency: 1 Fatigue in unsecured/open spaces.
3	Boundary Mastery: +2 dice to ward, barrier, or containment magic.	Compulsive Sealing: Must secure any vulnerability noticed.
4	Absolute Barrier: Once per session, create impenetrable barrier (1 scene).	Prison Mindset: -1 die to freedom/escape actions.
5	Gate Sovereign: Once per session, banish major threat with single test.	Boundary Obsession: -1 die to non-containment actions.
6+	Threshold Incarnate: Become living barrier (1 scene); all nearby boundaries absolute.	Ultimate Containment Risk: +3 Obligation; risk permanent Harm from containment burden.

Playstyle Notes The Sealed Gate patron excels in defensive, control-oriented play. Followers shape battlefields through strategic boundary placement and become invaluable when dealing with supernatural intrusions or securing locations. The corruption progression naturally leads characters toward becoming immovable guardians at the cost of flexibility and freedom.

3.7.29 The Silent Choir, Keeper of Unspoken Truths (Restraint & Protective Omission)

Lore. The Silent Choir is the gathered voice of truths wisely left unsaid, confessions granted mercy, and secrets kept to spare a life from breaking. It is not absence but presence: the practiced wisdom that some knowledge wounds more than it heals. Its keepers are wardens of confidence and shelterers of the vulnerable. They learn to carry burdens alone, to let volatile truths sleep, and to shield others from fires that revelation would feed.

“In a world that shouts, the Choir teaches the weight of quiet. Not every wound needs salt, not every blaze needs breath, not every heart can bear the full truth.”

Domain Focus

- **Protective Silence:** when and how to keep counsel for others' good
- **Merciful Omission:** judging truths that harm when spoken
- **Confidential Guardianship:** safeguarding people and perilous knowledge
- **Restraint Wisdom:** the power of what is not said or done

Rite of the Gentle Silence (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A white feather or cloth that has drunk whispered confidences.

Effect: Hush a space with respectful quiet. All present gain +1 die to actions of discretion, confidentiality, or de-escalation this scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Shielded Truth (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Touch; Yes.*

Materials: A sealed envelope or locked reliquary holding a sensitive fact.

Effect: Ward one piece of information from discovery. Gain +2 dice to resist extraction or revelation of the protected truth.

Push It: Protection becomes absolute but dependent: removing the ward triggers 1 **SB (Hearts)** as bottled truths surge.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Unspoken Accord (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Near; Yes.*

Materials: A pact signed in fading ink or a vow witnessed in silence.

Effect: Bind an understanding without paper teeth. All parties gain +1 die when honoring the accord; breach draws social costs even without proof.

Push It: Accord is supernaturally enforced: a breaker suffers swift ostracism; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Burden Bearer (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Touch; Yes.*

Materials: An object heavy with someone's shame or grief.

Effect: Take another's social or emotional weight for a time. Target gains relief (+2 dice to social rolls) while you suffer the drag (−1 die to social rolls) this scene.

Push It: A shard remains: gain insight, keep a sliver of pain; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Sanctuary of Secrets (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A room seasoned by trusted confidences and sealed with hush-signs.

Effect: Consecrate a sanctuary where secrets hold fast. Truths cannot be compelled; all within gain immunity to forced revelation and +2 dice to maintain discretion.

Push It: The sanctuary becomes a keep: none may leave until each offers one guarded truth; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Choir's Wisdom (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Self; Yes.*

Materials: The weight of many secrets rightly kept and debts of trust well paid.

Effect: Read the branching costs of revelation before speech. Gain +3 dice to judge when to speak and when to keep counsel.

Push It: Sight is too wide: see all outcomes, struggle to choose; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

The Silent Choir's Corruption

Tier	Blessing	Burden / Quirk
1	Discretion's Gift: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> when someone is about to speak what should be kept.	Silent Compulsion: Urge to still tongues; −1 die to ordinary conversation.
2	Confidence Once/scene, shelter from accidental spill. Keeper: a secret	Secret Burden: In places thick with confidences, suffer Fatigue 1 .
3	Merciful Once/session, prevent discovery of a truth that would harm if revealed. Blindness: dis-	Truth Sensitivity: Lies grate; −1 die while surrounded by deception.
4	Sanctuary Sense: Once/scene, veil a brief zone from eavesdropping.	Communication Strain: Others balk at full candor; −1 die to personal disclosure.
5	Wisdom of Restraint: Once/session, see the full cost of airing any one truth.	Silent Isolation: −2 dice to form close bonds; you hold too much back.
6+	Choir's Voice: Once/session, speak with the gathered prudence of unspoken truths.	Truth Prison: Mark +3 Obligation ; risk becoming a living vault unable to share without harm.

Playstyle Notes

The Silent Choir favors guardians and confidants: those who stand between fragile lives and ruinous truth. Its rites fortify discretion, temper tempers, and build rooms where trust can breathe. The cost is weight: secrets you keep will keep you.

Emphasizes

- **Protective Restraint:** silence used as shield
- **Confidential Guardianship:** duty to those who trust you
- **Merciful Omission:** letting some truths sleep
- **Discretion Wisdom:** judging what, when, and how to speak
- **Burden Bearing:** carrying heat so others do not burn

3.7.30 Thrysos, King of Revels (Ecstasy & Excess)

Lore. Where torches flare and cups spill, where dancers stamp until dawn, there strides Thrysos crowned with ivy and horn. He is both host and beast, a patron of license who laughs at law. In his train follow the masked and the wild, the broken who dance to forget, the bold who revel to remember. His rites intoxicate, inflame, and unmask—yet each cup leaves its mark.

Signs. Wine that never sours; a mask that smiles without wearer; goat-tracks circling thrice before vanishing.

Cantor's Temptation. His promise is freedom without end: no oaths, no chains, only song and cup and fire. Yet those who drink too deeply wake to find they serve not joy but appetite.

Chorus of the Lost.

"Drink, and be unafraid."

"Every mask is true when worn long enough."

"In the dance we are all kings—until the dawn."

Rites of Thrysos

Rite of the Overflowing Cup (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A brimming vessel of wine or blood.

Effect: Allies who drink gain +1 die to social rolls this scene; enemies who drink suffer −1 die.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: All in Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or be swept into revelry; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Horned Dance (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; No.*

Materials: Mask or antlers.

Effect: Enter ecstatic frenzy: +2 dice to melee or performance; ignore 1 Fatigue per round.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: Frenzy spreads: one ally also joins, but both mark 1 **SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Breaking Mask (Standard, 7 XP) *Instant; Near; No.*

Materials: A mask smashed in hand.

Effect: Reveal true face: target suffers −2 dice to disguise, deceit, or composure until scene ends.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: Truth is forced: target must declare one hidden desire; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Wild Procession [WARD] (Standard, 9 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.*

Materials: A horn sounded thrice.

Effect: Summon spectral satyrs and maenads. For the scene, the zone is [WARD]ed: hostile entry forces 1 **SB (Spades)**; allies gain +1 die to Resist compulsion or fear.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: The procession spills beyond; outsiders in Near must test Resolve (DV 4) or join.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Gilded Stag [TRANSFORM] [CURSE] (**High, 12 XP**) *Extended; Touch; No.*

Materials: Golden mask, stag's blood.

Effect: Transform one reveler into a beast of horn and fire. For one session: +2 dice melee; Harm +1 (Burn). At session's end they collapse with Harm 2 (Exhaustion).

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Push It: Transformation becomes permanent until undone; mark +3 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons). Obligation: 6 segments.

Rite of the Endless Feast [FOLLOW-UP] [CURSE] (**High, 14 XP**) *Scene; Zone; No.*

Materials: Feast laid for twelve.

Effect: For one scene, the zone floods with plenty: allies restore Fatigue; all rolls tied to appetite or indulgence +2 dice. Leaving requires Resolve (DV 3).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +3 **Obligation**.

Push It: The feast persists as a hunger-haunt; start **Hedonist's Curse** [6].

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons). Obligation: 8 segments.

Rite of the Bacchanal Unleashed [WARD] [FOLLOW-UP] (**High, 13 XP**) *Scene; Zone; No.*

Materials: A wine vat blessed by midnight storms, masks of every emotion, the tears of a jilted lover.

Effect: Create a zone of absolute revelry. All within must either join the celebration (+2 dice to social/perform) or resist with Resolve (DV 4) each round or suffer −2 dice to all actions.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Push It: Revelry becomes infectious—resistance causes **1 SB (Hearts)** as social pressure mounts.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons). Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Satyr's True Form [TRANSFORM] [BANE] (**High, 15 XP**) *Extended; Touch; No.*

Materials: A crown of twisted vines that bleed when touched, the first laugh of a newborn, a promise broken at crossroads.

Effect: Grant the ultimate reveler's gift—transformation into pure ecstatic essence. Target becomes immune to fear/despair, gains +3 dice to performance/frenzy, and can inspire allies within Near (+1 die to all rolls).

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +3 **Obligation**.

Push It: Transformation becomes contagious—nearby allies may also transform but risk losing their humanity; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons). Obligation: 8 segments.

Thrysos' Corruption Table

Tier	Gift	Corruption
1	Reveler's Grace: +1 die to social rolls in feasts or crowds.	Compulsive Toast: Must drink or mark 1 Fatigue when drink is offered.
2	Horned Vitality: Ignore first 1 Fatigue each scene.	Restless Appetite: Suffer −1 die when abstaining from indulgence.

3	Revel-Kin: Once per scene, summon a minor revel-spirit (advantage die).	Masked Self: Cannot act without role or guise; −1 die to plain sincerity.
4	Bacchic Fury: Once per session, frenzy grants +2 dice to melee for one exchange.	Ecstatic Blindness: −1 die to perception outside the revel.
5	Feast Without End: Once per session, allies in Near clear all Fatigue.	Hungering Host: You consume twice as much; denial causes Harm 1 (Stress).
6+	Satyr King's Mantle: For one scene, become avatar of revels; all allies +2 dice, enemies −2 dice.	Tyrant of Pleasure: Mark +3 Obligation; revel grows monstrous, demanding sacrifice. Beast of Endless Revel: Permanent transformation—your mortal form becomes optional; must make Presence + Performance (DV 4) to appear civilized or risk terrifying/enticing all who see you into joining your eternal celebration.

“Let the wine flow, let the masks fall, let the fire burn away all restraint. In the revel we find truth—raw, wild, and beautiful.”

3.7.31 The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)

Lore. The Traveler is the eternal guide of the road, guardian of those who walk the paths between what is and what might be. Among the Fhara caravans and Kuvani traders along the Way of Silk, the Traveler is invoked at every crossroads, honored with small offerings at each waypoint, and consulted before every major journey.

The Traveler is not merely one who shows the way—they *are* the way, existing in the pause between steps and in the choice of which path to take when roads fork. Every journey is both physical and spiritual; to move from one place to another is to transform, and the road itself becomes a teacher.

One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway. But break your word to the way, and the way will break you.

Rite of Road-Sense (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* Road-nail or waystone pebble. **Effect:** Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far. Gain +1 die to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment *Path Memory* clock to ignore difficult terrain once.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Spot one hidden bypass, but generate 1 SB (Clubs).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Traveler's Boon (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self/Ally; No. Materials:* Thread tied at the wrist.

Effect: Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy; +1 Effect to travel or escape checks. If shared, create a 2-segment *Shared Journey* bond with an ally.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Extend to one more ally; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.31.0.1 Rite of the Waymark [PASSAGE] (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Near; No. Materials:* Chalk mark or small cairn.

Effect: Declare a lane as permitted/easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment *Marked Path* clock.

Push It: Lane persists between scenes; first enemy to exploit it forces 1 SB (Spades).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.31.0.2 Rite of the Bridge Between [TRANSPORT] (Standard, 7 XP) *Instant; Near; No. Materials:* Two pinches of road-dust clapped.

Effect: Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible/named route. Unwilling targets may resist (Body+Resolve DV 3). Create a 4-segment *Pathway Established* clock.

Push It: Carry one extra ally or bundle; arrivals off-balance.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.31.0.3 Rite of the Crown of Crossings [WARD][COMMAND] (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Zone; No. Materials:* Brass compass missing its needle.

Effect: Call the Road: allies gain +1 die to move/evade; pursuers suffer -1 die. Once, declare "the long way is short" to finish a travel clock segment for free. Enemies must test (Wits+Command DV 4) or suffer -1 die to movement.

Push It: Seal a hostile route briefly; generate 2 SB (Clubs/Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: **2 Boons**).

Obligation: 7 segments.

3.7.31.0.4 Rite of the Wayfarer’s Covenant [OATH][FORTIFY] (**High, 14 XP**) *Extended; Near; No. Materials:* Waystones from multiple regions.

Effect: Bind present parties to safe passage. While honored: +2 Effect on travel, reroll one failed travel roll per scene. Breaking oath inflicts Harm 1 (Fatigue) and marks breaker as *Oathbreaker of the Road* (–2 dice to travel rolls).

Push It: Breaking the covenant inflicts Harm 2 (Stress) and attracts hostile Wayward spirits.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: **2 Boons**).

Obligation: 7 segments.

The Traveler’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Pathfinding Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and movement rolls in familiar territory.	Restless Spirit: Suffer 1 Fatigue when forced to remain stationary or in confined spaces for extended periods.
2	Wayfarer’s Luck: Once per scene, treat a failed travel or navigation roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Compulsive Wandering: Must take the less obvious path when choices present themselves; suffer -1 die when forced to follow direct routes.
3	Road Mastery: Gain +2 dice to rolls involving travel, escape, or finding hidden paths.	Travel Dependency: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring local knowledge or settlement-based skills.
4	Journey’s Blessing: Once per session, grant all allies within Near range +1 die to travel-related rolls for one scene.	Nomad’s Isolation: Suffer -1 die to social rolls involving long-term relationships or community ties.
5	Waypoint Sense: Once per session, instantly know the location and nature of all significant paths, routes, or crossroads within a day’s travel.	Directional Obsession: Suffer -1 die to rolls not involving movement, travel, or pathfinding; always aware of cardinal directions.

6+	Master of All Ways: Once per session, become one with the road network. For one scene, teleport between any known waypoints and grant +2 dice to all travel-related actions, but mark +2 Obligation and risk becoming lost between worlds.	Eternal Journey: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; risk permanent Harm (Stress) from the endless call of the road, making settlement impossible until the journey's end.
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3.7.32 Varnek Karn, the Death's Negotiator (Bargains with the Departed)

Lore. Varnek Karn dwells in the grey between life and death, where the newly departed linger with unfinished business and elder shades guard secrets dearer than gold. He is the broker who speaks across the veil, the mediator of disputes between living and dead, and the archivist of every promise sworn beyond the grave. His servants practice post-mortem diplomacy: they negotiate, consult, and contract with spirits as equals—mindful that the dead are patient and rarely generous.

“The dead have all the time in the world to consider their offers, and no need to rush to agreement. They know what the living forgot, and remember every slight with perfect clarity. In Varnek’s halls, both parties pay a price—but the currency is never what you expect.”

Domain Focus

- **Post-Mortem Diplomacy:** parleys with ghosts and recent dead
- **Ancestral Wisdom:** counsel from forebears and keeping of funerary law
- **Unfinished Business:** resolving the concerns that bind spirits
- **Death-Bound Contracts:** obligations that outlive the flesh

Rite of the Crossing Fee (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A coin for the tongue of the deceased, or a lock of hair from the bereaved.

Effect: Open speech with a specific dead individual. Gain +1 die to *Investigation* or *Lore* when seeking knowledge they once held.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Ancestral Consultation (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; Yes.*

Materials: A personal token of the departed, or their favored food/drink.

Effect: Ask one question of an ancestral spirit regarding family history, hidden legacies, or inherited debts.

Push It: The spirit grants detailed, prophetic guidance but exacts a small favor; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Death-Bound Pact (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Near; Yes.*

Materials: Two copies of a written accord—one buried with the dead, one kept by the living.

Effect: Bind a compact between a living signatory and a willing spirit. Both gain +1 die when fulfilling the terms. Breach angers the spirit and Varnek both.

Push It: The pact enforces itself: a breach triggers supernatural reprisal; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Spirit Medium (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A circle of salt mixed with grave-dust; a candle of funeral wax.

Effect: Serve as conduit for several spirits to speak. Gain +2 dice to mediate disputes between living and dead and to facilitate group negotiation.

Push It: A potent spirit rides your voice to speak directly; mark **Exposure +1**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Final Testament (High, 13 XP) *Extended; Touch; Yes.*

Materials: A dying person's last words recorded in their blood, witnessed by you.

Effect: Seal the last request with weight beyond life. Targets must pass *Resolve* (DV 4) to ignore it.

Push It: The testament becomes a geas: only fulfillment—or Varnek's wrath—can break it; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Eternal Archive (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A library mortared with tomb-stone, ink from cremation ash.

Effect: Found a repository where the dead deposit knowledge. Gain a permanent +1 die to *Lore* for historical or genealogical research made within. Spirits periodically contribute testimonies.

Push It: The archive awakens and begins to demand curatorship and payment; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

Varnek Karn's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Death's Whisper: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> when the dead seek to communicate.	Graveyard Pallor: −1 die to social rolls with the living; your presence unsettles.
2	Ancestral Insight: Once/scene, gain +2 dice for family history or inherited troubles.	Spectral Awareness: Ever-aware of nearby spirits; suffer Fatigue 1 in places of many deaths.
3	Medium's Gift: Once/session, act as a flawless conduit for a spirit.	Death-Touched: Cold spots and small portents follow you; −1 die to ordinary social grace.
4	Final Authority: Once/scene, compel adherence to a true last request (<i>Resolve</i> DV 4).	Corpse-Pale: Visibly wan; −2 dice where warmth or vigor is required.
5	Archive Keeper: Once/session, access perfect recall of a historical event or family secret.	Unquiet Presence: The dead trail you; −1 die to stealth and to surprising the living.
6+	Death's Confidant: Once/session, negotiate with puissant death-entities as an equal.	Halfway House: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming half-withdrawn from the living world.

Playstyle Notes

Varnek Karn favors investigators, arbiters, and heralds of funerary law. Power grows through cultural sensitivity, shrewd bargaining, and careful record-keeping; the price is a thinning tie to warmth and mortal ease. Expect mysteries of lineage, obligations that outlive their makers, and parleys where both sides of the veil demand their due.

Varnek Karn emphasizes

- **Diplomacy over Dominion:** bargaining with the dead rather than commanding them
- **Knowledge Brokerage:** trading for secrets and testimonies beyond the grave
- **Cultural Protocols:** rites, tokens, and proper doors for speaking with ancestors
- **Mediation:** resolving conflicts that bind the living to the dead
- **Historical Continuity:** showing how past vows shape the present

3.7.33 Vorthak, the Hunger Unbound (Consumption & Metamorphic Hunger)

Lore. Vorthak is the principle of absolute consumption: an appetite that devours not only what is, but the very potential of what might be. Each feeding transforms both eater and eaten. His servants become conduits of metamorphosis through ingestion, learning to consume not only matter but also properties, identities, and even strands of fate. Power comes by taking in — and the cost is becoming more like the hunger you channel.

“To consume is to become. To devour is to transform. In Vorthak’s embrace, the boundary between eater and eaten dissolves into something new — and something hungry.”

Domain Focus

- **Metamorphic Consumption:** transformation through ingestion of matter, energy, or concepts
- **Essence Absorption:** gaining properties by consuming them utterly
- **Hunger Propagation:** spreading consumption as a force of change
- **Identity Metabolism:** consuming and adopting aspects of others’ natures

Rite of the Metabolic Touch (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Touch; No.*

Materials: A fragment of the thing to be consumed (food, substance, symbol).

Effect: Absorb an essential trait of the target. Gain +1 die to actions aligned with the absorbed property for one scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Hunger’s Whisper (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; Yes.*

Materials: An empty vessel or a place where something was devoured.

Effect: Sense what in the area may be consumed and the benefit it offers. Gain +1 die to *Investigation* when seeking consumable resources.

Push It: Hunger turns contagious: nearby feel your appetite; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Essence Feast (Standard, 8 XP) *Scene; Touch; Yes.*

Materials: The complete consumption of a significant item (weapon, book, relic).

Effect: Permanently absorb the item’s essential nature. Gain one minor property or +1 die to a closely related skill. The item is utterly destroyed.

Push It: Take a major property, but gain a permanent *Hunger Mark* (a visible sign of consumption).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Identity Meal (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Near; Yes.*

Materials: A personal token or a clear memory of the target.

Effect: Temporarily adopt one aspect of a specific person’s nature (skill, talent, or defining trait). Gain +2 dice to actions matching that aspect.

Push It: The adoption deepens and clings; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Metamorphic Gluttony (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

Materials: A site scarred by great consumption.

Effect: Become a locus of transformative hunger. All present may consume aspects (skills, memories, properties), but each must pass *Spirit + Resolve* (DV 4) or suffer uncontrolled transformation effects.

Push It: Some changes become permanent; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Hunger's Ascension (High, 14 XP) *Extended; Self; Yes.*

Materials: The deliberate offering-up of your current limits to Vorthak.

Effect: Consume your own constraints and transform. Choose three: +1 Attribute; +2 dice to one skill; immunity to one Condition type; or one major supernatural capability.

Push It: Take all chosen benefits, but lose one core aspect of your original identity; mark **Harm 2**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**. *Obligation:* 8 segments.

Vorthak's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hunger's Sight: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> consumable properties in objects, beings, or ideas.	Metabolic Craving: Must consume something <i>significant</i> daily or suffer Fatigue 1 .
2	Essence Thief: Once/scene, temporarily gain a minor property by consuming it.	Identity Bleed: Absorbed aspects surface unbidden; –1 die to maintain your original persona.
3	Metamorphic Resilience: Once/session, consume a <i>Condition</i> or <i>Harm</i> to negate it.	Hunger Aura: Those Near feel urges to consume or hoard; they take –1 die to self-control rolls.
4	Transformation Feast: Once/scene, consume and permanently absorb one <i>minor</i> supernatural ability.	Essence Instability: Conflicting properties clash; –1 die when relying on multiple absorbed aspects.
5	Identity Cannibal: Once/session, consume a <i>significant</i> aspect of another (major skill or core trait).	Self-Consumption: Risk eating your own memories/abilities; mark 1 SB (Spades) when stressed.
6+	Hunger Incarnate: Once/session, become living consumption; absorb nearby properties, abilities, or aspects.	Void Hunger: Mark +3 Obligation ; risk dissolving into pure appetite that must feed to keep form.

Playstyle Notes

Vorthak favors those who hunt for change through taking in what the world offers: relish clever uses of absorbed traits, judge the *price* of every bite, and beware the slow surrender of the self. Expect scenes of metamorphosis, bargaining for what can be eaten, and hard choices where power tastes like you.

Vorthak emphasizes

- **Transformation through Consumption:** becoming what you devour
- **Metamorphic Power:** fundamental, identity-shaping change
- **Essence Absorption:** discerning and using a thing's core nature
- **Identity Metabolism:** integrating (or failing to integrate) stolen aspects
- **Hunger Propagation:** letting appetite reshape people and places

3.7.34 The Witness (Truth & Revelation)

Lore. The Witness remembers what others bury. Every shadow cast and oath broken is a line in her unending ledger. She is the keeper of inconvenient truths, the patron of those who seek to expose lies or recover forgotten knowledge. Her followers learn that knowledge comes with a price—the weight of remembering what others would forget.

I will show you what you would rather forget. But first, you must forget what you think you know.

Rite of the Lingering Glimpse (Low, 4 XP) *Instant; Near; Yes (Investigation/Notice only).*

Materials: A trace of the thing to be remembered (hair, dust, a spoken name).

Effect: Gain +1 die to your roll to investigate or notice something directly related to the trace within the current scene.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: Gain +2 dice instead, but mark 1 segment on a **Memory Strain Clock** [4]. If the clock fills, you gain Fatigue 1 and suffer -1 die on Investigation/Notice rolls until the end of the next scene due to mental exhaustion from forced recall.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Piercing Scrutiny (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Zone; No.* **Materials:** A circle drawn with chalk or string while focusing on the truth to be sought.

Effect: Within the zone, gain +1 die to rolls to detect deception (Insight vs. Deceit, spotting social tells) or to recall hidden knowledge (Lore/Investigate for memory). Social interactions within the zone begin one Position step worse for those attempting to deceive.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Push It: One target within the zone must make a Wits test (DV 3) or involuntarily reveal one pertinent lie or hidden fact they are currently concealing (Keeper determines relevance). Regardless of the test result, mark Exposure +1 for the target(s) in the zone.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.34.0.1 Rite of the Echoing Truth [OMEN] (Standard, 8 XP) *Instant; Near; No.*

Materials: A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) used to focus on the target.

Effect: Target must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or suffer -1 die to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer 1 SB (Hearts) as the memory is forcibly drawn forth.

Push It: If the target fails their Resolve test, you may ask a second question, but the mental intrusion causes them Harm 1 (Stress/Mental).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.34.0.2 Rite of the Immutable Record [OATH] (Standard, 7 XP) *Scene; Near; No.*

Materials: A document signed by all parties within the zone, or a spoken pact witnessed by the caster.

Effect: Bind the agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers 1 SB (Hearts) immediately and gains a persistent **Oathbreaker's Mark** Condition (-1 die on social rolls involving honor, trust, or oaths until amends are made or a significant act redeems them).

Push It: The bond becomes magically enforced for one specific, crucial clause: violation automatically inflicts Harm 1 (Stress) on the breaker in addition to the SB and Mark.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

3.7.34.0.3 Rite of the Unveiled Heart [OMEN] (High, 12 XP) *Scene; Near; No. Materials:*

A private setting where the target feels safe or is speaking freely.

Effect: The target suffers -2 dice to all attempts to conceal true emotions, intentions, or lies for the scene. Any successful social roll (Sway, Command, Deceit) made by the target generates 1 SB (Hearts) as the effort to maintain falsehoods under the Witness's gaze creates internal discord.

Push It: You may designate one specific, complex question about the target's motivations, fears, or hidden loyalties. If you successfully use Sway or Insight against them this scene, you automatically learn the answer to that question. The intense scrutiny marks 1 SB (Spades) for you as the Witness's attention lingers.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

3.7.34.0.4 Rite of the Final Reckoning [OMEN] (High, 13 XP) *Scene; Zone; No. Materials:*

A formally called gathering (court, council, family meeting) within the consecrated zone.

Effect: All present must speak their greatest debt, wrongdoing, or hidden truth related to the gathering's purpose. Those who lie or withhold suffer Harm 2 (Stress/Reputation). Truth-tellers gain +2 dice to social actions for the remainder of the scene within the zone.

Push It: The truth becomes inescapable - even indirect lies or evasions related to the core topic suffer the Harm 2 penalty. The absolute nature of the revelation creates 2 SB (Diamonds) as the disruption to fates and secrets resonates.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

The Witness's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Truth's Sight: +1 die to Insight when detecting deception or hidden motives.	Burden of Knowledge: Suffer -1 die to social rolls involving lies or deception; others become uncomfortable with your piercing gaze.
2	Memory's Keeper: Once per scene, recall one specific detail from a previous scene with perfect clarity.	Compulsive Honesty: Must correct obvious falsehoods witnessed, even when tactically disadvantageous.
3	Revelation's Power: Gain +2 dice to rolls involving exposing secrets, uncovering lies, or forcing confessions.	Truth-Blind: Suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to comforting lies or willful ignorance.

4	Witness's Authority: Once per session, force one target to make a Resolve test (DV 4) or reveal a significant hidden truth.	Isolation: Suffer -1 die to rolls requiring trust or close relationships; others fear your ability to uncover their secrets.
5	Omniscient Gaze: Once per session, see through all deceptions and lies for one exchange, gaining +3 dice to related actions.	Paranoia: Suffer -1 die to rolls involving personal peace or rest; the weight of all truths witnessed creates constant mental strain.
6+	Absolute Witness: Once per session, become the living embodiment of truth. For one scene, all deceptions within Near range automatically fail, but mark +2 Obligation and risk permanent Harm (Stress) from the crushing weight of absolute knowledge.	Truth's Prison: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; become unable to tolerate any form of deception, making normal social interaction nearly impossible.

3.7.35 Patron: Xhak'Thul, the Thunder-Speaker

Xhak'Thul — The Thunder-Speaker

Domains: Storm, Shock, Awe, Primal Memory

Sigil: A spiral that ends in a lightning-bolt; the path from mundane center to explosive, divine edge.

Lore. Before words, there was thunder. Before scripture, lightning carved its commandments into the bones of the world. Xhak'Thul is the Voice That Splits Mountains, the Drum That Shakes Foundations, a power born from the first storm that ever raged across the primal earth. His faithful are whirlwinds of action—they do not study; they dance, they shout, they move with the sky's fury. His gifts are not gentle miracles but raw terror, awe, and vitality ripped from nature's heart.

“Feel the drum in your bones before you hear it in the sky. When the storm speaks, you will already be dancing to its rhythm.” — Uttered by a shaman, teeth cracked from the force of the invocation

Storm-Speaking (Core Rite Logic)

- **Immediate Magic:** Rites require no long rituals; power flows when emotion and world demand it.
- **Emotional Fuel:** Potency increases with channeled fear, anger, or ecstatic frenzy.
- **Environmental Synergy:** Effects are heightened during storms, wildfires, earthquakes, or mass panic.
- **Body-Memory:** Movement—drumming, pacing, chanting—is the core component; the body is both conduit and conductor.

The Fear-Eater Path

Xhak'Thul's followers learn to feed on the chaos they create.

- Absorb fear from others to empower your own presence.
- Inspire awe or terror to strengthen your will and physical force.
- Turn panic around you into a weapon or shield.
- Become a walking storm, unsettling the world by your mere presence.

Low Rites

3.7.35.0.1 Rite of the Speaking Drum (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; No. Materials:* A drum made from storm-felled wood or any suitable improvised percussion. **Effect:** Your presence becomes overwhelming. All NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 2) or suffer -1d to social actions due to awe or terror for the scene. Allies gain +1d to Intimidation or Command actions. **Tags:** FEAR, COMMAND, AREA **Push It:** Extend the effect to Far range, but you mark 1 Fatigue and must mark 1 Story Beat (Hearts) as your presence becomes difficult to control. *Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

3.7.35.0.2 Rite of the Lightning Tongue (Low, 4 XP) *Scene; Near; No. Materials:* Water collected during a storm, a piece of copper, words spoken under thunder. **Effect:** Your voice carries supernatural weight. Your next social action in the scene gains +2d. If successful, the target suffers -1d on any roll to resist your social influence for the remainder of the scene. **Tags:** COMMAND, FEAR **Push It:** Increase the bonus to +3d, but allies in Near range suffer -1d to hearing-based actions; mark 1 Story Beat (Spades). *Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

3.7.35.0.3 Rite of the Storm's Step (Low, 5 XP) *Scene; Self; No. Materials:* Earth

3.7.35.0.9 No True Acolyte Interpreting a patron's will is often a dangerous prospect in and of itself. Many a Runekeeper has found themselves on the opposite end of machinations from others from the same patron.

Runebound Resilience (18 XP Epic Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Spirit 4+*

You have learned to transform the very essence of harm into deeper communion with your Patron.

- **Harm Conversion:** Once per round, you may convert up to 2 Harm levels to +2 Obligation instead of taking the damage
- **Obligation Endurance:** While at 6+ Obligation segments, gain +1 die to all Rite invocations
- **Patron's Shield:** When reduced to Harm 3, you may immediately Invoke any known Rite without marking additional Obligation
- **Debt Fortification:** At 8+ Obligation segments, ignore first Harm 1 each round
- **Once per scene**

Narrative Integration:

"Your flesh has become a ledger, and every wound is a prayer. The deeper your Patron's claim, the stronger your resistance to mortal frailty."

Patron's Favored (18 XP Prestige Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Familiar, 8+ total Obligation segments*

Your Patron has marked you as specially favored, granting you unprecedented access to their power with reduced cost.

- **Low Rite Discount:** Reduce Obligation cost for Low Rites by 1 (minimum 0)
- **Empower:** Once per scene, spend 1 Action + 1 Boons:
 - Target gains +1 Corruption level per round for 3 rounds. Corruption lasts until the end of the scene.
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
- **Empower Push:** Spend 1 Action + 1 Boon + 3 Obligation:
 - Target(s) gains +3 Corruption levels until end of scene
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
 - Target gains +Corruption fatigue at the end of the scene.
- **Enhanced Gift:** Your **Patron's Gift** now provides +2 dice instead of +1
- **Debt Bound:** Cannot Empower again until all Obligation is cleared

Narrative Integration: *The Patron's favor comes with a price—but for the truly devoted, that price is worth the power. You carry their blessing openly now, and their influence spreads like wildfire to those who would walk in your shadow.*

"Every Rune is a promise. Every line a covenant. Do not mistake the Runekeeper's silence for weakness; their memory is the foundation of our craft."

3.7.36 The Invokers

Invokers are those who dare. Neither archivists nor worshippers, they are travelers on the knife-edge between story and ruin. An Invoker learns the Rites of a Patron, weaves them into their own Art, and bends fate for a moment. Yet invocation is not command: it is negotiation. The Patron always leaves its mark. The stronger the Rite, the deeper the scar.

Invokers are often wanderers, exiles, or seekers. To common folk they are feared—witches, oath-breakers, meddlers with things not meant for mortal hands. But when the village falls to plague, when the sea closes its roads, when the dead refuse their rest, it is an Invoker who is called upon.

3.7.37 Closing Words

The dance between Patron, Runekeeper, and Invoker is a triangle of peril and necessity. Without Patrons, there is no power. Without Runekeepers, no record. Without Invokers, no action. Together, they shape the crooked, perilous art we call Invocation.

3.8 Patrons & Rites

Cost Component	Effect
+1 SB	Escalate effect immediately
+1 Fatigue	Immediate physical/mental strain
+1 Corruption Clock Segment	Long-term Patron influence (unless otherwise specified)
GM spends 1 SB	Thematic complication (unless otherwise specified)

Note: Some talents, Rites, or magical paths may specify alternative corruption costs or additional consequences for Push It actions. When explicitly stated, those specific rules override the universal costs.

3.8.0.0.1 Clearing Corruption Corruption may be reduced through *purging rituals*, such as exorcisms, sacred songs, or rites of contrition. These require a test (typically **Lore + Spirit**) against a DV equal to the character's current corruption level. On success, reduce corruption by 1. On failure, the corruption manifests violently, imposing a temporary Condition or advancing its narrative expression.

Optional: A **Story Beat** may also be spent to attempt such a ritual, representing the personal cost of atonement. Patrons may demand specific acts of service, sacrifice, or obligation as part of the purging process.

Chapter 4

Character Advancement and Capabilities

Why This Chapter Matters

In this game, growth is not just about numbers — it is about deciding who your character becomes. Advancement through **Experience Points (XP)** lets you shape your capabilities, influence, and legacy in the world. Every XP choice is a statement about your character's priorities and the mark they leave behind.

Your capabilities are built on four core **Attributes** and a set of specialized **Skills**. This chapter explains how they work together, what advancement looks like in play, and offers player-facing tips for making satisfying choices.

4.1 Core Attributes

Attributes represent your character's fundamental capabilities. Each is rated from 1 to 5; higher numbers mean greater potential in that area.

4.1.1 Body

Physical strength, endurance, coordination, and health.

- **Used for:** melee combat, athletics, endurance tests, physical labor.
- **Typical applications:** lifting, running, climbing, fighting, resisting physical harm.
- **Associated skills:** Athletics, Brawl, Melee, Endurance.

Rating guide:

- 1: Average person; some physical activity.
- 2: Fit; trains or works physically on a regular basis.
- 3: Athlete or soldier; excellent condition.
- 4: Exceptional athlete; near peak human.
- 5: Peak human capability; legendary strength and stamina.

4.1.2 Wits

Mental acuity, perception, quick thinking, and problem-solving.

- **Used for:** investigation, perception, tactics, snap decisions.

- **Typical applications:** spotting details, solving puzzles, planning, reacting quickly.
- **Associated skills:** Perception, Investigation, Tactics, Lore.

Rating guide:

- 1: Average awareness; sometimes misses important cues.
- 2: Observant; notices most relevant details.
- 3: Sharp-minded; quick to spot patterns.
- 4: Exceptionally perceptive; rarely surprised.
- 5: Almost uncanny awareness; sees connections others miss.

4.1.3 Spirit

Willpower, intuition, mental resilience, and connection to intangible forces.

- **Used for:** resisting mental effects, intuition, magical aptitude, persistence.
- **Typical applications:** resisting fear, sensing danger, channeling magic, enduring hardship.
- **Associated skills:** Resolve, Intuition, Magic, Faith.

Rating guide:

- 1: Average willpower; somewhat suggestible.
- 2: Strong-minded; resists ordinary pressure.
- 3: Very determined; hard to intimidate.
- 4: Exceptional will; can inspire others.
- 5: Iron will; nearly unshakeable resolve.

4.1.4 Presence

Charisma, social influence, appearance, and force of personality.

- **Used for:** social interactions, leadership, persuasion, intimidation.
- **Typical applications:** negotiating, leading, charming, commanding attention.
- **Associated skills:** Sway, Command, Performance, Deception.

Rating guide:

- 1: Average presence; does not particularly stand out.
- 2: Noticeable; leaves a mild impression.
- 3: Charismatic; naturally influential.
- 4: Commanding; people listen when you speak.
- 5: Magnetic; can sway crowds and redefine the mood of a room.

4.2 Skill System

Skills represent specialized training and expertise. In play, you combine an Attribute with a relevant Skill to form your dice pool.

4.2.1 Skill Ratings

Rating	Description
0	Untrained — no formal experience
1	Novice — basic understanding
2	Competent — reliable and capable
3	Professional — expert in the field
4	Master — renowned specialist
5	Grand Master — legendary skill

4.2.2 Skill Categories

Below are common skills grouped by theme. Your table may rename or reskin these, but the roles remain similar.

4.2.2.0.1 Combat Skills

- **Melee:** swords, axes, close-quarters weapons.
- **Ranged:** bows, crossbows, thrown weapons, firearms (if present).
- **Brawl:** unarmed combat, grappling, improvised fighting.
- **Tactics:** battlefield strategy, unit coordination, ambush planning.

4.2.2.0.2 Physical Skills

- **Athletics:** running, climbing, jumping, swimming.
- **Stealth:** moving unseen, hiding, blending into shadows.
- **Endurance:** resisting fatigue, harsh weather, poison, disease.
- **Craft:** building, repairing, creating tools, art, or structures.

4.2.2.0.3 Social Skills

- **Sway:** persuasion, negotiation, charm.
- **Command:** leadership, intimidation, issuing orders.
- **Deception:** lying, bluffing, misdirection.
- **Performance:** entertainment, oration, acting, musical display.

4.2.2.0.4 Knowledge Skills

- **Lore:** history, culture, religions, general knowledge.
- **Investigation:** research, deduction, analysis of clues.
- **Medicine:** healing, anatomy, first aid, treatment.
- **Nature:** wilderness, animals, plants, weather patterns.

4.2.2.0.5 Specialized Skills

- **Arcana:** magic theory, rituals, mystical phenomena.
- **Mechanics:** devices, engineering, construction, traps.
- **Diplomacy:** formal negotiation, etiquette, protocol.
- **Streetwise:** urban survival, criminal underworld, gossip networks.

4.3 Building Dice Pools

Your dice pool for any action is:

$$\text{DicePool} = \text{Attribute} + \text{Skill}.$$

You roll that many d10s and interpret the results according to the core rules (see §2).

4.3.1 Choosing the Right Combination

The same fictional action can often be approached with different Attribute + Skill pairs, depending on how your character does it.

- **Climbing a wall:**
 - *Body + Athletics*: sheer strength and stamina.
 - *Wits + Athletics*: clever route-finding and leverage.
 - *Spirit + Athletics*: grim determination against fear or pain.
- **Persuading a guard:**
 - *Presence + Sway*: charm and personality.
 - *Wits + Sway*: logical, well-constructed arguments.
 - *Spirit + Sway*: conviction that burns through doubt.
- **Investigating a crime scene:**
 - *Wits + Investigation*: methodical observation and deduction.
 - *Spirit + Investigation*: intuitive leaps and gut feelings.
 - *Presence + Investigation*: getting witnesses to open up.

4.3.2 Creative Combinations

With your GM's agreement, you can justify unusual combinations that fit the fiction:

- **Body + Lore**: recalling combat drills or physical techniques.
- **Presence + Medicine**: soothing and reassuring a patient.
- **Spirit + Craft**: inspired, visionary craftsmanship.

Example: A ranger scales an ice wall using **Wits + Athletics** to find the safest holds, then switches to **Body + Athletics** to muscle over the lip. The fiction guides which combination fits each moment.

4.4 Earning Experience Points

XP represents learning through action. You gain it by engaging meaningfully with the world: overcoming challenges, taking risks, making hard choices, and leaning into your character's story.

4.4.1 Session Breakdown

At the end of each session, XP is awarded based on what happened at the table. A typical breakdown might look like:

- **Base Participation:** +2 XP for attending and contributing.
- **Major Objectives:** +2–4 XP for completing significant story goals.
- **Discoveries:** +1–2 XP for uncovering important lore, locations, or secrets.
- **Hard Choices:** +1–2 XP for making difficult moral or strategic decisions.
- **Story Engagement:** +1–3 XP for embracing complications and twists.
- **Personal Goals:** +1–2 XP for pursuing your character's individual storylines.

Example: At the end of a session, the party rogue gains:

- +2 XP for participation,
- +2 XP for helping retrieve a cursed artifact,
- +1 XP for pushing a personal rivalry subplot.

Total: 5 XP.

4.4.2 Game Pace Options

You and your GM can decide how quickly characters advance, matching the tone you want:

Mode	XP / Session	Tone
Gritty	4–6	Hard choices, slow growth
Standard	6–10	Balanced progression
Epic	10–14	Heroic, rapid development

Player Tip: If you want a sweeping, mythic tale, ask for an *Epic* pace. If you want advancement to feel hard-won, lean toward *Gritty*.

4.4.3 Arc Completion Bonus

When a major story arc finishes (typically 3–6 sessions), everyone gains an additional +8–12 XP. One player may receive +2 XP more for a particularly memorable contribution. This rewards the story as a whole, not just individual rolls.

4.5 Spending Experience Points

XP is your currency for growth. You can invest it in three broad areas:

1. **Personal Improvement** (Attributes and Skills)
2. **Special Abilities** (Talents, magic, unique tricks)
3. **Resources and Influence** (Assets, followers, organizations)

Think of these as three pillars: *what you can do*, *what makes you unique*, and *what you own or command*.

4.5.1 Personal Improvement

Attributes

Attributes are expensive but powerful. The cost to raise an Attribute is:

$$XPCost = 3 \times newrating.$$

Examples:

- Raising Body from 2 to 3 costs $3 \times 3 = 9$ XP.
- Raising Spirit from 4 to 5 costs $3 \times 5 = 15$ XP.

Attribute increases usually require downtime equal to the new rating in days, spent training, reflecting, or transforming yourself.

Skills

Skills are cheaper and represent focused practice. The cost is:

$$XPCost = 2 \times newlevel.$$

Examples:

- Lore $1 \rightarrow 2$ costs $2 \times 2 = 4$ XP.
- Melee $3 \rightarrow 4$ costs $2 \times 4 = 8$ XP.

Skill increases typically require downtime equal to the new level in days.

Example: Kara wants to improve her swordsmanship (Melee) from 2 to 3. She saves 6 XP and spends three in-game days training with her mentor. This training becomes part of the story, not just a line on a sheet.

4.5.2 Special Abilities

Special abilities are unique moves, talents, or tricks that define your style.

General Abilities (4–8 XP) Universal benefits, like improved recovery, bonus dice in a common situation, or a signature combat technique. *Example:* “Quick Recovery” — heal 1 extra Harm when you rest.

Cultural Abilities (variable) Abilities tied to heritage or background. They may require specific fictional positioning. *Example:* “Stone Sense” — an instinctive feel for stonework and tunnels.

Advanced Abilities (12+ XP) High-impact features available at higher tiers, often with strong narrative hooks or prerequisites. *Example:* “Master Diplomat” — once per session, you can reroll or soften the outcome of a failed major negotiation.

Example: A veteran bard purchases *Silver Tongue* for 6 XP, gaining the ability to sway a hostile crowd once per session. This quickly becomes their trademark in tense public scenes.

4.5.3 Resources and Influence

See §8 for full rules. As a quick reference:

Minor Resource (4 XP, 1 week) A small shop, basic workshop, discreet safe house, or minor contact network. Offers modest but reliable benefits.

Standard Resource (8 XP, 2 weeks) A decent-sized business, crew, or operation with real impact. Comes with some upkeep and obligations.

Major Resource (12 XP, 1 month) A large enterprise, elite team, or rare capability. Very potent but also demanding; often becomes a major part of your character's story.

Player Tip: Resources pull the camera out from your character to your *sphere of influence*. A spy network means intrigue. A workshop means invention. A guild hall means politics.

4.6 Character Development Paths

How you spend XP shapes your character's growth. These are broad patterns, not rigid classes.

Path	Typical XP Split	Strengths / Weaknesses
Specialist	70–90% personal, 0–20% resources, 0–20% abilities	Extremely effective in a narrow niche. Vulnerable outside it.
Leader	50–65% personal, 15–25% resources, 15–25% abilities	Well-rounded, boosts the group. Rarely the best at one thing.
Mastermind	25–40% personal, 35–55% resources, 20–40% abilities	Solves problems through assets. Personally vulnerable, many moving parts.

Example (Leader): A merchant-prince spends 60% of XP on personal skills and social abilities, 20% on a network of trade contacts, and 20% on talents that improve negotiation and command.

These patterns are *guides*, not rules. You can shift between them as your story evolves.

4.7 Training and Development Time

Most improvements take time in the fiction. Training montages, study scenes, and building projects are all opportunities for character moments.

4.7.1 Standard Time Requirements

- **Attribute increase:** new rating in days.
- **Skill improvement:** new level in days.
- **Resource acquisition:** about 1 week to 1 month depending on scope.
- **Ability learning:** typically 3–10 days.

4.7.2 Accelerated Development (Rush Rule)

You *can* attempt to learn faster, but rushing has a price.

- The group tracks a short **Risk Clock** (4 segments) for your crash training.
- If it fills, the new capability has flaws:
 - Attribute/Skill: temporary –1 die penalty until you retrain properly.
 - Resource: loyalty issues, partial effectiveness, or hidden problems.
 - Ability: unreliable effects or quirky side consequences.

Example: A wizard crams advanced spellwork into three frantic days. She gains the ability, but the Risk Clock fills: her spells spark and flicker until she takes time to train safely.

4.8 Character Progression Tiers

As you accumulate XP and capabilities, you advance through tiers that represent your growing reputation and influence.

4.8.1 Tier I: Novice (0–40 XP)

- Learning the ropes, establishing yourself.
- Local reputation, modest capabilities.
- Typical assets: basic equipment, a few contacts.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between life and death; a shift from Desperate to Controlled means “I live to fight another day.”

4.8.2 Tier II: Seasoned (41–90 XP)

- Proven capability, reliable in your specialty.
- Regional reputation, respected in your field.
- Typical assets: skilled followers, specialized equipment.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between victory and defeat; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means “I’ve earned the right to choose how this ends.”

4.8.3 Tier III: Veteran (91–150 XP)

- Master of your craft, significant influence.
- National reputation, can handle major challenges.
- Typical assets: multiple operations, elite teams.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between influence and control; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means “The city hangs on my decision.”

4.8.4 Tier IV: Paragon (151–220 XP)

- Exceptional capability, strategic influence.
- Continental influence, shapes regional outcomes.
- Typical assets: organizations, unique capabilities.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between shaping events and defining eras; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means “I am the axis upon which history turns.”

4.8.5 Tier V: Mythic (221+ XP)

- Legendary status, world-changing influence.
- Historical reputation, defines eras.
- Typical assets: nations, legendary artifacts.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between ending and remaking the world; a shift from Desperate to Controlled means “The universe waits on my choice.”

4.8.6 Position Scales with Narrative Weight

The mechanical effect of Position (re-rolling one die) never changes — but what it *means* evolves with your tier:

- **Tier I:** Position defines personal survival.
- **Tier III:** Position shapes regional outcomes.
- **Tier V:** Position reshapes reality.

The system does not need to scale — your story does.

GM Tip: Never add mechanical bonuses to Position. Instead, deepen the narrative weight:

- **Tier I:** “Your Position shows whether you live or die.”
- **Tier V:** “Your Position shows how the world bends to your will.”

The mechanics stay consistent so the narrative can grow as large as your imagination allows.

4.9 Managing Allies and Followers

Allies can extend your reach but also create obligations and risks. For full rules, see §8.

4.9.1 Acquisition Costs

A skilled helper's cost in XP is roughly their *capability rating squared*. *Example:* A capability 3 scout costs $3^2 = 9$ XP.

4.9.2 Upkeep Requirements

Each downtime period, you either:

- spend XP equal to their capability rating, **or**
- dedicate a meaningful scene to maintaining the relationship (time, favors, protection).

4.9.3 Risk Management

- When big complications arise, your allies can be targeted instead of you.
- Allies can handle one significant task off-screen per downtime, but this often creates extra story fallout (the GM gains a Story Beat).

4.10 Skill Advancement and Synergies

4.10.1 XP Costs

Improvement	XP Cost
0 → 1	2 XP
1 → 2	4 XP
2 → 3	6 XP
3 → 4	8 XP
4 → 5	10 XP

4.10.2 Training Time

- 0 → 1: 1 day of practice.
- 1 → 2: 3 days of training.
- 2 → 3: 1 week of intensive study.
- 3 → 4: 2 weeks with a master or rigorous practice.
- 4 → 5: 1 month of dedicated focus.

4.10.3 Attribute Limits

You cannot have a Skill rating higher than the relevant Attribute. To advance a Skill further, you must first raise its primary Attribute.

4.10.4 Skill Synergies

When the fiction supports it, well-justified combinations of skills can grant +1 die or better Position/Effect. Examples:

- **Combat:** Tactics + Command (battlefield coordination), Melee + Athletics (acrobatic strikes).
- **Social:** Sway + Lore (persuasion backed by knowledge), Deception + Performance (long

cons).

- **Exploration:** Investigation + Perception (thorough search), Nature + Survival (tracking).

4.11 Using Skills in Play

4.11.1 When to Roll

You roll when:

- the outcome is uncertain,
- failure would matter to the story, and
- the action is significant enough to deserve the spotlight.

For routine actions with no real risk, the group can often simply agree that you succeed.

4.11.2 Difficulty and Skill Level

As your skill rises, routine tasks become trivial. A rough guideline:

Skill Level	Routine Task	Challenging Task
0	Needs a roll; modest DV	Needs a roll; higher DV
1	Often needs a roll	Challenging but fair
2	Usually automatic	Needs a roll; moderate DV
3	Automatic	Needs a roll; interesting stakes
4+	Automatic	Automatic for simple cases

Reading this as a player: by Skill 3, basic tasks in your area of expertise should rarely require rolls. You are there to be impressive, not to trip over routine jobs.

4.11.3 Group Skill Use

When multiple characters contribute:

- **Assistance:** One character is primary; up to three others add +1 die each by describing how they help.
- **Cooperation:** Several characters each roll; the group succeeds or fails based on combined results.
- **Complementary:** Different skills cover different parts of a larger task (e.g. one distracts, one picks a lock).

4.12 Skill Challenges

Some goals are too big for a single roll.

4.12.1 Extended Tests

For long, involved tasks:

- The group sets a progress clock (4–8 segments).
- Each significant success fills one or more segments.
- Complications can add segments or create new problems.

4.12.2 Complex Challenges

For multi-step or multi-skill situations:

- Different skills tackle different phases of the challenge.
- Success in one area creates opportunities; failure creates obstacles.

Example (Heist): **Stealth** to infiltrate, **Mechanics** to bypass locks, **Investigation** to find the vault, **Deception** to mislead guards. Each roll advances a *Heist Clock*; complications add heat, suspicion, or security changes.

4.13 Strategic Advancement Considerations

4.13.1 Early Game (Tiers I–II)

- Focus on survival and a clear niche.
- Raise a key Attribute to 3 early.
- Bring core Skills to 2–3.
- Establish one or two modest resources or safe havens.

4.13.2 Mid Game (Tier III)

- Develop signature moves or combinations.
- Expand your resource base.
- Consider your role in the group and lean into it.

4.13.3 Late Game (Tiers IV–V)

- Choose advanced abilities that reshape the story around you.
- Build organizations, movements, or legacies.
- Decide how your character will leave their mark on the world.

Common Advancement Mistakes

Avoid these pitfalls:

- **Over-specializing too early:** A Melee 5 character with Body 3 is fragile and incapable outside combat.
- **Forgetting training time:** You cannot learn a new skill in the middle of a dungeon without justification.
- **Neglecting resources:** A few well-chosen assets can solve problems no amount of personal skill can.
- **Hoarding XP:** Spend your XP! Characters who never improve become irrelevant to the escalating threats.

4.14 Practical Examples

4.14.1 Combat Example

A warrior with Body 4 and Melee 3 attacks:

- Dice pool: $4 + 3 = 7d10$.
- Opponent's defenses and the fiction help set the difficulty.

- Strong successes translate into higher Effect or better Position.

4.14.2 Social Example

A diplomat with Presence 3 and Sway 2 negotiates:

- Dice pool: $3 + 2 = 5d10$.
- Position might be *Controlled* if circumstances favor them, or worse if under suspicion.
- Consequences for failure could be mistrust, delays, or new complications.

4.14.3 Exploration Example

A scout with Wits 3 and Perception 2 searches for tracks:

- Dice pool: $3 + 2 = 5d10$.
- Easier tasks (fresh tracks) are more forgiving; older or obscured tracks are harder.
- Partial successes might reveal some information but not all, or come with side effects.

Your Attributes and Skills determine not just *if* you succeed, but *how* you tackle problems. Lean into combinations that express your character's style.

XP Planning Guide

Early Tier Priorities:

- Raise a core Attribute to 3 (9 XP).
- Bring key Skills to 2–3 (4–6 XP each).
- Claim 1–2 minor resources (4 XP each).

Mid Tier Expansion:

- Push core Attributes toward 4 (12 XP).
- Specialize key Skills to 4 (8 XP).
- Add standard resources (8 XP each).
- Explore cultural or thematic abilities (6–10 XP).

Late Tier Mastery:

- Purchase capstone abilities (12+ XP).
- Establish major resources (12 XP).
- Launch legacy projects, organizations, or movements.

Attributes and Skills Quick Reference**Attributes (1–5):**

- **Body:** physical capability
- **Wits:** mental acuity
- **Spirit:** willpower and inner strength
- **Presence:** social influence

Skill Levels:

- 0: Untrained 1: Novice 2: Competent
- 3: Professional 4: Master 5: Grand Master

Dice Pool: Attribute + Skill d10s.

Skill Improvement: New level $\times$ 2 XP (plus training time).

Specialization: At Skill 3+, you are a known expert in that field.

Synergy: Well-justified combinations of skills can grant +1 die or better Position/Effect when the fiction supports it.

Chapter 5

Experience Paths and Character Building

How you spend your **Experience Points (XP)** shapes more than your numbers on a sheet—it defines your character’s *career*, their growth over time, and the kind of stories they invite into play.

This chapter focuses on:

- turning a loose idea into a clear **character concept**,
- mapping that concept into **starting choices** that fit the campaign rules,
- choosing a **career path** (how you plan to grow),
- and understanding how your character can evolve across **early, mid, and late** game.

All examples in this chapter are *legal starting builds* under the standard creation rules, and are written to be directly usable by players.

5.1 From Concept to Career

Before you spend a single XP, start with the story you want to tell.

Step 1: Concept Seed

Begin with a simple statement of who your character is:

- “Stoic bodyguard who will take the hit for anyone else.”
- “Nervy courier who knows every back alley in the city.”
- “Soft-spoken merchant who pulls strings behind the scenes.”

This is your **concept seed**. Everything else grows from here.

Step 2: Role in the Party

Decide what you want to *do at the table*:

- Take hits and lock down threats?
- Spot danger and solve practical problems?
- Talk through conflicts and manage social fallout?
- Create tools, magic, or plans that enable everyone else?

Your role helps you choose a **Primary Attribute** and 2–3 **Key Skills** (see Chapter 4).

Step 3: Career Theme

Ask yourself:

- Is this a story of *self-mastery*? (training, discipline, pushing limits)
- A story of *connections*? (alliances, obligations, webs of influence)
- A story of *balance*? (learning to juggle many demands at once)

Your answer naturally points you toward one of the three **XP paths** in this chapter.

Step 4: Long Arc in One Sentence

Write a single sentence for where you imagine your character at high XP:

- “I want to become the greatest duelist in the realm.”
- “I want to map the unknown and bring others safely home.”
- “I want to run the network everyone relies on but no one sees.”

You do not have to stick to this forever, but it gives you a *direction* for your early choices.

Character Career Checklist

Before spending XP, decide:

1. Your **concept seed** (one sentence).
2. Your **role in the party** (what you do most).
3. Your preferred **career theme**: self, balance, or influence.
4. A rough **long arc** (where you want to end up).

Start simple. You can always refine these as the campaign unfolds.

5.2 Mapping Concept to Mechanics

Once you have a concept, you turn it into numbers. Use this as a guideline:

1. Pick a **Primary Attribute** that supports your role (Body, Wits, Spirit, or Presence).
2. Choose 2–3 **Key Skills** that you want to be noticeably good at.
3. Choose a **Career Path** (Personal, Balanced, Influencer) that matches your theme.
4. Use the starting XP budget in Section 5.7 to buy:
 - Attribute steps for your primary and possibly secondary stats.
 - Skill steps for your key and supporting skills.
 - Optional resources or special abilities, if your path calls for them.

Throughout this chapter, each example shows how a concept becomes a legal build.

5.3 Three Career Paths

There are three broad approaches to character development, each representing a different **career philosophy**:

Personal Path Focus on personal mastery and self-improvement.

Balanced Path Mix personal growth with resources and influence.

Influencer Path Build networks, assets, and strategic power.

These paths are not rigid classes. They are *patterns* that help you decide where most of your XP will go, especially in the early game.

5.4 Path 1: Personal Development

The **Personal Path** centers your character's career on what *they* can do: their body, mind, and honed skills. This is the path of the duelist, the ascetic, the elite scout, the master healer.

Typical Investment

- 70–90% Personal improvement (Attributes and Skills)
- 0–10% Resources and assets
- 0–20% Special abilities

Strengths

- Reliable in direct challenges and combat
- Minimal upkeep or management required
- Resilient to loss of external resources
- Consistent performance in spotlight moments

Weaknesses

- Limited influence in social or strategic scenes
- May struggle with problems requiring networks
- Less capable in logistics or large-scale operations
- Dependent on personal presence for all solutions

Career View

On this path, your “career ladder” is mostly about pushing numbers related to **you**: raising Attributes, deepening Skills, and picking a few defining abilities. Your late-game questions are:

- “What does a legendary version of this look like?”
- “What scenes prove that I have truly mastered my craft?”

Build Example: The Duelist (Legal Start)

Concept Seed: “A proud blade whose entire life is training and challenge.”

Total XP: 30 (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications; see §5.7)

- **Attributes:** Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 1, Presence 1
 - Costs (Attributes cost *new rating* × 3): Body 1→2 (6), 2→3 (9) = **15**; Wits 1→2 (6) = **6**; Spirit/Presence remain 1 = **0**. *Subtotal: 21 XP*
- **Skills:** Melee 2, Athletics 1
 - Costs (Skills cost *new level* × 2): Melee 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Athletics 0→1 = **2**. *Subtotal: 8 XP*
- **Totals:** 21 + 8 = **29 XP**. Bank **1 XP**.
- **With +4 XP (Bonds/Complications):** Add *Perception* 0→1 (2) and spend banked 1 XP on *Stealth* 0→1 (2), or instead take *Perception* 0→1 (2) and *Sway* 0→1 (2) for broader utility. *Cap: 34 XP*.

Career Hook: Early scenes show duels and drills. Mid game focuses on notorious opponents. Late game tells the story of a blade whose name carries across borders.

5.5 Path 2: Balanced Approach

The **Balanced Path** mixes personal capability with supportive resources. This is the path of the scout-captain, the field medic with a small clinic, the problem-solver who always seems to have *something* ready.

Typical Investment

- 50–65% Personal improvement
- 15–25% Resources and assets
- 15–25% Special abilities

Strengths

- Adaptable to diverse situations
- Handles both direct and indirect challenges
- Excellent supporting role for the group
- Moderate risk profile

Weaknesses

- Not exceptional in any single area
- Requires management of resources
- Moderate upkeep demands
- Can be outshone by focused specialists

Career View

Balanced characters often have careers that feel like juggling:

- they add contacts, gear, or small bases *and*
- keep raising the core skills that let them use those tools well.

Their late-game questions are:

- “What does my little network or operation look like at full size?”
- “How do my personal skills and resources fit together as a whole?”

Build Example: The Scout (Legal Start)

Concept Seed: “A pathfinder who knows how to get in, get out, and get others home.”

Total XP: 30 (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications)

- **Attributes:** Wits 2, Body 2, Spirit 1, Presence 1
– Costs: Wits 1→2 (6), Body 1→2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2, Perception 1, Stealth 1
– Costs: Survival 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Perception 0→1 **2**; Stealth 0→1 **2**. *Subtotal: 10 XP*
- **Resources:** *Minor equipment cache* (camp gear, maps, signal kit) = **4 XP**

- **Special Abilities:** *Wilderness Lore* (broad travel benefits) = **4 XP**
- **Totals:** $12 + 10 + 4 + 4 = \mathbf{30\ XP}$.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Perception 1→2* (+4) or take a *trained hawk companion* (Minor Resource, 4 XP).

Career Hook: Early stories show small journeys. Mid game explores dangerous routes and rescue missions. Late game might see the scout running expeditions, caravans, or an entire mapping guild.

5.6 Path 3: Influencer Focus

The **Influencer Path** emphasizes networks, assets, and strategic power. This is the path of the merchant-prince, the fixer, the spymaster, the noble with more favors owed than coins in their purse.

Typical Investment

- 25–40% Personal improvement
- 35–55% Resources and assets
- 20–40% Special abilities

Strengths

- Strong strategic and social influence
- Can solve problems indirectly
- Excellent at planning and preparation
- Creates opportunities for the whole group

Weaknesses

- Personally vulnerable in direct confrontations
- High maintenance requirements
- Complications can cascade through networks
- Dependent on external factors

Career View

Influencer careers are about building and surviving **webs**:

- webs of contacts, debts, trade routes, cells, or clients.

Late game questions become:

- “How big can this web reasonably grow within the fiction?”
- “What happens when a strand of my web is cut, or pulled tight?”

Build Example: The Merchant (Legal Start)

Concept Seed: “A friendly shopkeeper whose real power lies in who owes them favors.”

Total XP: 30 (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications)

- **Attributes:** Presence 2, Wits 2, Spirit 1, Body 1
 - Costs: Presence 1→2 (6), Wits 1→2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2, Deception 1, Lore 1

- Costs: Sway 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Deception 0→1 **2**; Lore 0→1 **2**. *Subtotal: 10 XP*
- **Resources:** *Standard trading office* (staffed storefront, ledgers, storage) = **8 XP**
- **Totals:** 12 + 10 + 8 = **30 XP**.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Negotiation Mastery* (4 XP general ability) *or* expand to a second *Minor merchant route* (4 XP).

Career Hook: Early scenes are about one shop and a few key clients. Mid game introduces caravans, deals, and rivals. Late game might place the merchant at the center of regional politics and supply chains.

5.7 Starting Character Guidelines

Base XP Allocation

- **Standard Starting XP:** 30 points
- **Bonds and Complications:** You may take up to **two total** from any mix of meaningful *Bonds* (up to 2, +2 XP each) and significant *Complications* (up to 2, +2 XP each), granting maximum **+4 XP**.
- **Maximum Starting XP:** 34 points
- **Complication Effect:** Each unresolved starting Complication adds +1 banked SB to early scenes until cleared.

Recommended Starting Ranges

Category	Recommended XP
Primary Attribute	9–12 XP (rating 3–4)
Secondary Attributes	0–9 XP each (rating 1–3)
Key Skills	4–6 XP each (rating 2–3)
Supporting Skills	2–4 XP each (rating 1–2)
Resources	0–8 XP total
Special Abilities	0–8 XP total

5.7.0.0.1 Cost Reminders:

- **Attributes:** Each step costs *new rating* × 3 XP (e.g., 1→2 costs 6; 2→3 costs 9).
- **Skills:** Each step costs *new level* × 2 XP (e.g., 0→1 costs 2; 1→2 costs 4).
- **Resources:** Minor 4 XP; Standard 8 XP; Major 12 XP.
- **Special Abilities:** Minor Edge 2 XP; Major Edge 4 XP; Prestige 6+ XP.

5.8 Progression Planning

Think of your character’s career in phases. These XP bands are approximate and assume you began at 30–34 XP.

Early Game (0–40 XP)

Focus on establishing core capabilities:

- Reach attribute rating 3 in your primary area.
- Develop 2–3 key skills to rating 2–3.
- Acquire basic resources or one special ability (if your path uses them).
- Clarify your character’s niche in the group.

Mid Game (41–90 XP)

Expand and specialize:

- Increase your primary attribute to 4.
- Specialize key skills to rating 3–4.
- Develop supporting capabilities that fit your concept.
- Build strategic resources or networks if on the Balanced or Influencer path.
- Acquire signature special abilities that define your style.

Late Game (91–150 XP)

Master your chosen path:

- Achieve peak attributes (rating 4–5).
- Master key skills (rating 4–5).
- Build substantial influence or unique capabilities.
- Develop advanced special abilities.
- Consider legacy projects, organizations, or long-term changes to the setting.

5.9 Path Combination Strategies

Many players mix elements from different paths as their character’s life unfolds.

Combat Specialist with Resources

- Strong personal combat capabilities.
- Moderate resource investment for support.
- Good for frontline fighters who need logistical backup.
- Example: Warrior with a fortified base and loyal troops.

Social Character with Personal Skills

- Excellent social capabilities.
- Solid personal skills for self-defense or utility.
- Good for diplomats who operate independently.
- Example: Ambassador with combat training and persuasion skills.

Technical Expert with Networks

- Deep technical or magical expertise.
- Network of contacts and resources to enable projects.
- Good for specialists who need supply chains and helpers.
- Example: Master crafter with supplier network and apprentices.

5.10 Resource Management

Each path asks for different management styles across your character’s career.

Personal Path Management

- Minimal upkeep requirements.
- Focus on equipment, training scenes, and personal growth.
- Low complexity, high reliability.

Balanced Path Management

- Moderate upkeep for resources.
- Relationship maintenance with contacts.
- Skill development alongside resource management.
- Balanced time investment between self and assets.

Influencer Path Management

- Significant upkeep demands.
- Network maintenance and expansion.
- Resource allocation and development.
- Strategic planning and opportunity management.

5.11 Risk Assessment

Each path carries different career risks.

Personal Path Risks

- Over-specialization in one area.
- Vulnerability to problems outside your specialty.
- Limited diversification later in the game.
- May become predictable in approach.

Balanced Path Risks

- Jack-of-all-trades, master of none.
- Spread too thin across capabilities.
- Moderate risks in multiple areas.
- May lack standout, defining capabilities if unfocused.

Influencer Path Risks

- Networks are vulnerable to attack and betrayal.
- High maintenance requirements.
- Cascade failure potential if a key asset falls.
- Personal safety concerns when the web is targeted.

5.12 Building for Group Synergy

Your character's career path matters most in context with the rest of the party.

Complementary Paths

- Personal path characters provide reliable combat and specialist solutions.
- Balanced path characters handle diverse, connective challenges.
- Influencer path characters create opportunities and resources.

- Together, a mixed party can cover nearly every type of problem.

Redundant Paths

- Multiple personal path characters may overlap in combat or role.
- Multiple influencer path characters may compete for spotlight and assets.
- Consider diversifying within similar paths: different weapons, domains, or networks.
- Example: Two combatants, one a duelist, one a shield-focused guardian.

5.13 Adapting Your Path

Your chosen path is a starting point, not a contract. You can shift focus as your character's story changes.

Early Shift (0–40 XP)

- Easy to change direction.
- Minimal sunk cost in any single approach.
- Good time to experiment with different styles.
- You can respond quickly to group needs or unexpected story turns.

Mid Game Shift (41–90 XP)

- Requires more deliberate planning.
- Some capabilities need to be maintained while others change.
- You can fill emerging gaps in group capability.
- Temporary performance dips may occur during the transition.

Late Game Shift (91+ XP)

- Significant investment in your current path.
- Major shifts require substantial XP and story justification.
- Often better to add complementary capabilities than completely pivot.
- Consider how changes reflect pivotal events in your character's life.

XP Path Quick Reference

Personal Path (70–90% self):

- Reliable individual performance.
- Low upkeep, high consistency.
- Best for combatants and focused specialists.

Balanced Path (50–65% self):

- Good all-around capability.
- Moderate risk and upkeep.
- Flexible support and problem-solving role.

Influencer Path (25–40% self):

- Strategic power and influence.
- High upkeep, high reward.
- Creates opportunities for the entire group.

Starting XP: 30 base + up to +4 from Bonds/Complications (max start 34).

5.14 Practical Building Examples (Narrative Roles, Legal Starts)

Each of the following examples combines:

- a short **concept**,
- a **path choice**,
- a legal **starting build**,
- and a sketch of their **career arc**.

Example 1: The Guardian

Path: Personal Total: 30 XP

Concept Seed: “Quiet wall of muscle who would rather bleed than lose anyone.”

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (1→2: 6, 2→3: 9), Wits 2 (1→2: 6) = **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Melee 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Athletics 1 (0→1: 2) = **8 XP**
- **Bank:** 1 XP
- **Role at table:** Frontline protection and reliable pressure in fights.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Combat Reflexes* (2 XP talent) and *Shield Mastery* (4 XP talent) using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP (GM may allow rounding or an extra minor Complication), or instead buy more supporting skills.

Career Arc: Early on, the Guardian is “the one who stands in front.” Mid game adds tactical awareness and maybe leadership. Late game might see them training others or becoming the symbol of a cause.

Example 2: The Explorer

Path: Balanced Total: 30 XP

Concept Seed: “Curious wanderer whose maps are more valuable than gold.”

- **Attributes:** Wits 2 (6), Body 2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Perception 1 (2), Stealth 1 (2) = **10 XP**
- **Resources:** Minor mapping kit & route notes = **4 XP**
- **Ability:** Trail Sense = **4 XP**
- **Totals:** **30 XP**. With +4 XP, raise *Perception* 1→2 (+4) or add a trained beast (Minor Resource, 4 XP).

Career Arc: Early stories focus on survival and discovery. Mid game might see them guiding trade, armies, or refugees. Late game, they may literally redraw the map of the setting.

Example 3: The Schemer

Path: Influencer Total: 30 XP

Concept Seed: “The person who always knows someone who knows someone.”

- **Attributes:** Presence 2 (6), Wits 2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Deception 1 (2), Lore 1 (2) = **10 XP**

- **Resources:** Standard safehouse & message drops = **8 XP**
- **Totals: 30 XP.** With +4 XP, take *Network Builder* (4 XP talent) or add *Minor informant ring* (4 XP).

Career Arc: Early on, the Schemer is just “the one with connections.” Mid game grows their network and enemies. Late game, they might operate entire webs of spies, informants, merchants, or political factions.

5.14.0.0.1 Reminder: All builds above assume baseline *Attributes at 1* and *Skills at 0* before spending. Attribute and Skill advances are cumulative by step (see costs in §5.7).

Remember: Your chosen path should reflect both your character concept and your preferred play style. There is no single “correct” path—only what works for you, your group, and the story you want to tell.

5.15 Narrative-Heavy Character Building Options

For groups that prefer a strong narrative focus in character building, you can treat XP as a tool for telling the story of a career, not just a currency.

5.15.0.0.1 Story-Driven Milestones Instead of tracking XP numerically, the GM can award advancement when characters reach significant story milestones. “You have trained with the master for months—you’ve improved your skill.”

5.15.0.0.2 Experience Through Reflection Players can spend downtime scenes reflecting on past experiences to earn XP. A meaningful flashback, confession, or revelation can justify growth without counting every point.

5.15.0.0.3 Collaborative Advancement The group can discuss and agree on advancement choices, ensuring everyone’s growth supports the overall story direction and shared arcs.

5.15.0.0.4 Narrative Justification Focus When spending XP, players should explain how their character gained this capability through in-game experiences, creating richer backstory and continuity. “I raise Presence because I’ve been forced to handle the group’s negotiations for weeks.”

5.15.0.0.5 Path as Theme Use your chosen path as a **theme** rather than a strict budget:

- A Personal Path character emphasizes physical, mental, or spiritual self-mastery.
- A Balanced Path character emphasizes learning how to juggle tools and relationships.
- An Influencer Path character emphasizes their growing web of relationships and obligations.

In all cases, let your character’s **career** on the page match the career they are living in the fiction.

Chapter 6

Talents and Special Abilities

Talents are the building blocks of character specialization. They represent learned techniques, supernatural gifts, or cultural inheritances. Each Talent costs XP, and its cost reflects its impact. Unless a talent states otherwise, ****only one talent can be active at a time****.

6.1 Understanding Talents

Talents are purchased with **Experience Points (XP)** and provide special capabilities:

- They go beyond simple skill bonuses.
- They often have specific **activation conditions**.
- They may provide **narrative permissions** (you can try things others cannot).
- They can define your character's **unique identity**.

Talent Costs by Tier

Tier	Cost	Scope
Minor	2–3 XP	Small situational bonus, once per scene.
Major	4–6 XP	Strong upgrade, permanent effect in a niche.
Prestige	7–10 XP	Campaign-defining, breaks fundamental limits.
Epic	11+ XP	Legendary ability, shapes the story.

6.1.0.0.1 Activation Types.

- **Passive:** Always on; no action required.
- **Active:** Requires an action or scene focus to use.
- **Reactive:** Triggers automatically on a condition.

6.1.0.0.2 Limits and Economy. Unless a talent says otherwise:

- **Per scene** uses refresh at scene end.
- **Per session** uses refresh after downtime.
- Some talents allow you to spend **Boons** to push effects further.

6.2 Minor Talents (2–3 XP)

General Minor Talents

Keen Senses [PERCEPTION]

Cost: 2 XP

Passive. +1 die on perception checks to spot danger or hidden details.

Silver Tongue [PERSUASION]

Cost: 2 XP

Passive. +1 die on persuasion attempts.

Second Wind [RECOVERY]

Cost: 2 XP

Active, once per scene. Clear 1 Fatigue when you take a moment to catch your breath.

Combat Reflexes [REACTIVE]

Cost: 2 XP

Reactive. +1 die on defense rolls when surprised or flanked.

Precise Strike [STRIKE]

Cost: 2 XP

Active, once per scene. Ignore armor on one attack if you had Dominant or Controlled position.

Trackless Step [EVADE]

Cost: 2 XP

Active, once per scene. Leave no trail for the rest of the scene.

Urban Navigation [DIRECTION]

Cost: 2 XP

Passive. Never get lost in cities.

Wilderness Lore [NATURE]

Cost: 2 XP

Passive. Automatically find food and water in hospitable biomes.

Read Emotions [INSIGHT]

Cost: 2 XP

Active, once per scene. Automatically detect surface emotions in a social exchange.

Iron Patience [RESISTANCE]

Cost: 2 XP

Passive. When you Defend, gain +1 die to resist Conditions (fear, charm, fatigue) for the rest of the exchange, even outside the triggering roll.

Requires: Resolve 1+.

Stand Firm [PROTECT]

Cost: 2 XP

Reactive. When you Defend and roll a Miss, downgrade incoming Harm by 1 level (minimum 0).

Requires: Body 2+.

Counterpoise [EVADE]

Cost: 2 XP

Reactive. When you take a Defend action and score a Partial, you may immediately move 1 range band or reposition within Near without provoking retaliation.

Requires: Athletics 1+ or Melee 1+.

Magic Access Minor Talents

Familiar [SPIRIT] [BOND]

Cost: 2 XP

Passive. Required to access Patron features such as Patron's Gift. Binds a Thiasos.

Spellcraft [FIRE] [WATER]

Cost: 6 XP (Note: 6 XP is above Minor range; this is a Major-tier access talent. See Major Talents.)

Monk Minor Talents

Disciplined Body [STRENGTH] [RECOVERY]

Cost: 3 XP

Passive + Active. +1 die to unarmed combat attacks. Once per scene, convert 1 Harm to Fatigue, and once per scene improve Position by one step.

Requires: Melee 1+, Body 2+.

Combat Minor Talents

Defensive Survival [DEFENSE] [RECOVERY]

Cost: 3 XP

Passive + Active. +1 die to defense rolls while engaged in melee. Once per scene, convert first Harm 1 from melee to Fatigue.

Requires: Melee 2+.

Tactical Movement [MOVEMENT] [POSITION]

Cost: 4 XP (Major tier – moved to Major)

Conditioning [RESISTANCE] [ENDURANCE]

Cost: 4 XP (Major tier – moved to Major)

Weapon Master (Light) [MASTERY]

Cost: 3 XP

Passive. +1 die with a chosen weapon category (instead of +2 from the Major version).

Note: The full +2 dice version is a Major talent (Weapon Mastery).

6.3 Major Talents (4–6 XP)

Magic Access Major Talents

Spellcraft [FIRE] [WATER]

Cost: 6 XP

Passive. Grants access to Weave & Cast freeform spellcasting using the Eight Elements. Without

this, characters cannot freeform cast.

Codex [FATE] [RITUAL]

Cost: 4 XP

Passive. Required to fully join a Patron's service as a Runekeeper. Grants access to that Patron's Rites and Obligation system.

Patron's Symbol [WARD] [SIGIL]

Cost: 4 XP

Minor Asset. Allows an Invoker to access a Patron's Rites via ritual precision. Each Patron requires its own Symbol.

Patron's Gift [IMBUEMENT]

Cost: Free (requires Familiar)

Active, once per scene. Imbue one item with +1 Melee and +1 thematic Skill for the scene. Push It (mark +1 Obligation) to extend one more scene.

General Major Talents

Weapon Mastery [WEAPON]

Cost: 5 XP

Passive. Choose a weapon type; +2 dice when using it. Once per scene, +1 Effect with signature weapon.

Requires: Melee 2+.

Command Presence [LEADERSHIP]

Cost: 4 XP

Passive. +1 die on leadership and intimidation rolls.

Network Builder [BOND]

Cost: 4 XP

Passive. Gain a minor contact in each new settlement visited.

Tactical Movement [MOVEMENT] [POSITION]

Cost: 4 XP

Passive + Active. Move within engagement zone as Move action (instead of full action). Once per scene, disengage from Close as Move action.

Requires: Athletics 2+.

Conditioning [RESISTANCE] [ENDURANCE]

Cost: 4 XP

Passive. Body attribute counts as +1 for Fatigue track calculations. +1 die to resist Fatigue overflow effects.

Requires: Body 3+.

Spell Shaping [CONTROL]

Cost: 4 XP

Active. When you Weave a spell, modify range, scale, or targeting by one step.

Requires: Spellcraft.

Elemental Focus [ELEMENT]**Cost: 4 XP**

Passive. Choose one element (Fire, Water, Earth, Air). +1 die when casting spells of that element.
Requires: Spellcraft.

Ritual Mastery [RITUAL]**Cost: 4 XP**

Passive. The GM spends 1 fewer SB on ritual backlash.
Requires: Familiar or Patron's Symbol.

Efficient Invocation [RITUAL]**Cost: 4 XP**

Passive. Reduce ritual casting time by one step (minimum 1 action).
Requires: Patron's Symbol.

Combat Major Talents**Flurry Strike** [STRIKE] [SPEED]**Cost: 6 XP**

Active, once per scene. When engaged with multiple opponents, make 2 attacks as one action. Each attack at -1 die.
Requires: Melee 3+, Body 3+.

Duelist's Edge [DOMINANCE] [TECHNIQUE]**Cost: 6 XP**

Passive + Active. When engaged with a single opponent: +1 die to all melee rolls. Once per scene, ignore first Harm 1 or 2 from that opponent.
Requires: Melee 3+, Wits 3+.

Battlefield Mastery [STRATEGY] [LEADERSHIP]**Cost: 6 XP**

Active, once per scene. When engaged with 3+ opponents, for the next 3 exchanges: all melee attacks gain +1 Effect, enemies act at -1 die, your Position improves by one step, and you may convert one Harm 1 per exchange to Fatigue.
Requires: Melee 4+, Wits 4+, Command 2+.

Backstab [STEALTH] [STRIKE]**Cost: 6 XP**

Active, once per scene. When you attack an Unaware or Engaged foe from Stealth, deal +1 Harm and ignore 1 point of their Armor. On a miss, you are Exposed (Desperate Position or mark 1 Harm).
Requires: Stealth 2+, Melee 2+, light weapon.

Elusive Dodge [DEFENSE] [EVADE]**Cost: 6 XP**

Reactive, once per exchange. When targeted by a physical attack, you may immediately enter a Defend stance as a free reaction. Mark 1 Fatigue after use.
Requires: Stealth 2+, Wits 3+, Tier II.

Berserker Rage [FURY] [POWER]**Cost: 6 XP**

Active, once per scene. For 3 rounds: +2 dice to melee attacks, ignore first Harm 1 each round, ignore Harm/Fatigue penalties, Position becomes Desperate (re-roll successes). When rage ends, mark Fatigue equal to Spirit. Cannot be ended early.

Requires: Melee 3+, Spirit 3+, Body 3+.

Cavalier [MOBILITY] [MARTIAL]**Cost: 4 XP**

Passive while mounted. Gain +2 dice to melee attacks when moving Far→Near, or +2 dice to ranged attacks when moving Near→Far.

Requires: War Mount Asset, Melee 2+ or Ranged 2+.

Subtle Casting [HIDDEN] [CONTROL]**Cost: 6 XP**

Active. Make a Performance + Lore roll to quietly cast a spell, invoke a Rite, or sing a Cantos against DV (Tier). If successful, the casting does not generate Story Beats on the Channel or initial roll. Any SB generated are banked by the GM and applied later. Cannot be used for Great or Extreme Tier effects.

Requires: Lore 3+, Performance 2+ or Runekeeper with Codex.

Defense-Related Major Talents**Riposte Instinct** [COUNTER] [STRIKE]**Cost: 4 XP**

Reactive, once per scene. When you Defend and score a Success, you may make a free Melee attack against the attacker at Position -1.

Requires: Melee 2+.

Guarded Step [STANCE] [MOVEMENT]**Cost: 4 XP**

Active. When Defending, you may declare your defense pool after the GM calls Position. Once per scene, you may instead choose the Attribute + Skill pair after the roll.

Requires: Athletics 2+ or Shield Proficiency.

Measured Guard [TACTICS] [FLEXIBILITY]**Cost: 4 XP**

Active. When Defending, you may declare your defense pool after the GM calls Position. Once per scene, you may instead choose the Attribute + Skill pair after the roll.

Requires: Perception 2+.

Wardbreaker Reflex [WARD] [DEFENSE]**Cost: 4 XP**

Reactive. When Defending against spells or supernatural effects, you may reroll 1 failed die. If your reroll succeeds, mark +1 Fatigue (arcane recoil).

Requires: Spirit 2+ or any magical Path.

Monk Major Talents

Iron Fist Way [STRIKE] [BURNING]

Cost: 6 XP

Passive. +1 die to unarmed attacks; strikes count as enchanted.

Flowing Spirit Way [WIND] [STRENGTH]

Cost: 6 XP

Passive + Active. Convert up to 1 Harm into Fatigue per attack; +1 die against fear or charm.

Perfect Timing Way [FATE] [MOVEMENT]

Cost: 6 XP

Active. Twice per scene, improve Position by +1 step; +1 die to reactions.

6.4 Prestige Talents (7–10 XP)

Arcane Dominance [POWER] [OVERRIDE]

Cost: 8 XP

Passive. When you contest another magical effect, you automatically overpower weaker effects (Tier II or lower).

Requires: Spirit 4, Arcana 4.

Forbidden Knowledge [SECRETS] [DANGEROUS]

Cost: 8 XP

Active, once per session. Access one forbidden summon or dangerous rite without its normal prerequisites. The GM gains 2 SB.

Requires: Tier II.

Crack Specialist [RITUAL] [INSTANT]

Cost: 8 XP

Passive. Reduce the Obligation cost of Crack the Seal by 1 (minimum +1).

Requires: 3 Patron Symbols.

Dual Covenant [BOND] [SYNCHRONIZATION]

Cost: 8 XP

Passive. You may maintain two active summoned spirits simultaneously.

Requires: Pact-Whisperer, Lesser Pactwright.

Triad Bond [BOND] [SYNCHRONIZATION]

Cost: 10 XP

Passive. You may maintain three active summoned spirits simultaneously.

Requires: Dual Covenant, Tier III.

Shrike Parry [COUNTER] [PARRY]

Cost: 8 XP

Reactive. When Defending against a melee attack: on Success, negate the hit and make a free attack at equal Position; on Partial, reduce Harm by two levels; on Miss, improve Position one step next turn without Defending again.

Requires: Melee 3+, Athletics 2+, notable duel history.

Mystic Bulwark [PROTECT] [BOND]**Cost: 8 XP****Active.** When you Defend, you may Shield an adjacent ally (they gain your Position bonus). If you succeed, both avoid the effect. Once per scene, spend 2 Fatigue to extend to all allies in Near.*Requires: Resolve 3+, Spirit 2+, access to Rites or Cantos.***High Stance Duelist** [DOMINANCE] [TECHNIQUE]**Cost: 8 XP****Passive.** While Defending: enemies suffer –1 die to attacks against you; on a Success, your riposte becomes Dominant instead of Controlled.*Requires: Melee 3+, Presence 1+.***Hollow-Touched** [RESILIENCE]**Cost: 8 XP****Reactive.** When you would take Harm, you may mark that amount as Fatigue instead. If you do, either the GM gains 1 SB or you mark 1 Obligation to the Pale Shepherd. Overflow triggers normal Fatigue→Harm conversion plus the chosen cost.*Requires: Aelaerem affinity, Spirit 3+, Stealth 2+.***Stone-Bound Interdictor** [RESILIENCE]**Cost: 8 XP****Reactive.** When you would take Harm, you may mark that amount as Fatigue instead. If you do, either spend 1 Boon immediately or speak a geas (until fulfilled, –1 die on social rolls with fae and stone-kin). Overflow triggers normal conversion plus the cost.*Requires: Aelinnel affinity, Body 3+, Wits 3+.***Large Soul** [ADAPTATION]**Cost: 8 XP****Passive.** You may wear Heavy Armor and wield Heavy Weapons without restriction. You lose your Small Folk racial bonuses (+1 Position Dodging, +1 die Hide/Evasion).*Requires: Aelaerem or Aelinnel affinity, Body 4+, Spirit 3+.***Untouchable Way** [EVADE] [STRENGTH]**Cost: 10 XP****Passive + Active.** +1 die to unarmed attacks; convert 2 Harm into Fatigue; cannot be grappled.*Requires: Iron Fist + Flowing Spirit.***Inevitable Way** [FATE] [FORCE]**Cost: 10 XP****Passive + Reactive.** +2 dice to unarmed attacks; ignore 1 Armor; may counterattack when an enemy misses.*Requires: Iron Fist + Perfect Timing.***Battlefield Terror** [FEAR] [DOMINANCE]**Cost: 10 XP****Passive + Active.** Enemies in Close range act at –1 die due to intimidation. Once per scene, convert an enemy's success to a partial with cost.*Requires: Melee 4+, Body 4+, Harm 2+ experience.*

Shadow Dance [EVADE] [STEALTH]**Cost: 10 XP**

Active. After a successful Backstab, test Stealth vs. DV (Tier). On success, re-enter Stealth and clear 1 Fatigue or improve Position +1. On failure, remain Exposed and mark 1 Fatigue. May only chain once per scene.

Requires: Backstab, Stealth 3+, Mobility 2+.

Embrace the Void [CORRUPTION] [POWER]**Cost: 8 XP**

Active, once per session. Embrace your Patron's corrupting influence. Mark 2 Obligation and 1 Corruption segment, then gain one for the scene: +1 die and +1 Effect on Patron-domain rolls, immunity to one consequence type, use one Rite without Obligation, or +1 Effect on social manipulations. Permanent mark on sheet; GM gains +1 SB against you when Patron is relevant.

Requires: Any character with 2+ skill levels tied to Patron, at least 1 Obligation segment to that Patron.

6.5 Epic Talents (11+ XP)

Elemental Mastery [ELEMENT] [HARMONY]**Cost: 18 XP**

Passive + Active. Reduce Backlash severity by one step when casting with your focus elements. When casting with two focus elements, gain +2 dice and +1 Effect. Once per scene, cast a spell without generating SB on the Weave roll. Allies gain +1 die when you cast an aligned element spell.

Requires: Tier III, Spellcraft, Arcana 5, 2+ Focus Elements.

Crack the Seal Mastery [RITUAL] [PRECISION]**Cost: 18 XP**

Passive + Active. When Cracking the Seal, choose one: reduce Obligation cost by 1, prevent Symbol from becoming Compromised, or gain +1 Effect. With 4+ Symbols, reduce all ritual casting times by 1 round. Once per scene, Crack the Seal on up to 3 Symbols as one action. Ignore No Symbol penalties.

Requires: Tier III, Invoker's Grimoire, 3+ Patron Symbols.

Blade Dance [STRIKE] [MASTERY]**Cost: 18 XP**

Active, once per scene. Engage and attack up to 3 targets in one action. Each attack at -1 die, but your Position improves by one step.

Requires: Melee 5+, Duelist's Edge, Flurry Strike.

Miststep Reflex [DEFENSE] [MOVEMENT]**Cost: 12 XP**

Passive. You are always treated as Defending against physical attacks unless Exposed, Grappled, or Surprised. If you take the Defend action, improve Position by +2 steps instead. Once per scene when you roll 1s while defending, you must mark 2 Fatigue or lose the benefit for the scene.

Requires: Elusive Dodge, Tier III, Stealth 4+, Athletics 3+.

Transcendent Harmony [LIFE] [WIND]**Cost: 18 XP**

Passive + Active. Convert 2 Harm into Fatigue; once per session become immune to Harm; allies

gain +1 defense.

Requires: Flowing Spirit + Perfect Timing, Spirit 4+.

Deathblow [DEATH] [STRIKE]

Cost: 12 XP

Active, once per scene. When you strike from Dominant Position or after re-entering Stealth via Shadow Dance, declare a Deathblow. On a hit, deal triple Harm. If the attack incapacitates the target, attempt a free Stealth test to vanish. On a miss, you are Exposed (Desperate Position and mark 1 Harm). May mark 1 Fatigue to attempt a second time.

Requires: Shadow Dance, Stealth 4+, Melee/Ranged 3+.

6.6 Talent Synergies and Building Strategies

Synergy Examples

- **Spellcraft + Elemental Focus + Elemental Mastery:** Reliable freeform casting with reduced backlash and epic control.
- **Backstab + Shadow Dance + Deathblow:** Stealth assassination chain.
- **Ritual Mastery + Efficient Invocation + Crack Specialist:** Fast, safe, low-cost rituals.
- **Defensive Survival + Elusive Dodge + Miststep Reflex:** High survivability in melee.
- **Iron Fist + Flowing Spirit + Untouchable Way:** Unstoppable monk durability.

Early Game (0–40 XP)

Take 1–2 access talents (Spellcraft, Familiar) and 2–3 minor talents that support your core concept.

Mid Game (41–90 XP)

Add major talents (Codex, Patron's Symbol, Backstab, etc.) and 2–3 synergistic power talents. Plan for prestige prerequisites.

Late Game (91+ XP)

Acquire 1–2 prestige or epic talents that define your legacy. Focus on party-supporting or campaign-shaping abilities.

6.7 Custom Talents

Work with your GM to create custom talents:

- Base on story events.
- Use the cost tiers above (2–3 / 4–6 / 7–10 / 11+ XP).
- Define clear prerequisites, activation, and limits.

6.8 Talent Respecification

With GM approval, you may retrain talents during downtime (one downtime period). Provide a narrative justification. Typically limited to once per major story arc.

Talent Selection Quick Reference

Minor (2–3 XP): Small bonuses, once/scene tricks.

Major (4–6 XP): Strong permanent upgrades, core path abilities.

Prestige (7–10 XP): Campaign-shaping, breaks limits.

Epic (11+ XP): Legendary, story-defining power.

Chapter 7

Example Character Concepts

This chapter presents example character concepts to illustrate how the game’s systems can create diverse and interesting heroes. These are **examples only**—not prescriptive templates or exhaustive lists. Use them for inspiration, as pre-generated characters, or as starting points for your own unique creations.

7.1 Important Disclaimer

These examples are provided for illustrative purposes only. They demonstrate how the game’s mechanics can support different character archetypes and play styles. You are encouraged to:

- Modify these concepts to fit your preferences
- Create completely original characters
- Mix and match elements from different examples
- Work with your Game Master to develop unique concepts

The game system is designed to support a wide variety of character types beyond these examples.

7.2 How to Use These Examples

Each concept includes:

- **Concept Overview:** Narrative identity and role
- **Traditional Analogues:** Common RPG classes (e.g., Fighter, Rogue, Wizard) that share similar themes — *not* mechanical restrictions, just touchstones
- **Mechanical Foundation:** Suggested starting capabilities
- **Play Style:** How the character typically engages with challenges
- **Development Path:** Potential growth directions
- **Story Hooks:** Plot opportunities for the Game Master
- **Build Blocks:** A *30 XP* starting build, plus an optional *34 XP* variant using Bonds/Complications (+4 XP)

7.3 1. The Guardian (Fighter / Paladin / Knight)

Concept: A protector who stands between danger and those they’ve sworn to defend. *Steel in hand, vow in heart.* Whether a chivalrous knight, a grizzled mercenary, or a holy warrior of the

Everflame, the Guardian makes others safe through sacrifice.

Traditional Analogues: Fighter, Paladin, Barbarian (defensive), Knight, Samurai, Legionary

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Body (strength, endurance), Spirit (willpower, resolve)
- **Skills:** Melee, Athletics, Command, Endurance
- **Talents:** Defensive Stance, Combat Reflexes, Conditioning

Play Style:

- Frontline combat and protection
- Drawing attention away from allies (taunts, positioning)
- Using presence and authority to control situations
- Taking risks to protect others — absorbing Harm meant for teammates

Development Path:

- Increase defensive capabilities (armor, shields, parry)
- Develop leadership skills (Command, Inspire)
- Acquire better protective gear and magical wards
- Learn area control abilities (shield wall, defensive line)

Story Hooks:

- Who or what are they protecting? A person, a place, an ideal?
- What oath or duty drives them — sworn, inherited, or self-imposed?
- What happens if they fail in their protection?
- What personal costs do they bear for their role (scars, lost loved ones, broken oaths)?

7.3.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes** (Cost = rating $\times$ 3 XP): Body 3 (9), Spirit 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) $\rightarrow$ **21 XP**
- **Skills** (Cost = level $\times$ 2 XP): Melee 2 (4), Athletics 1 (2), Command 1 (2) $\rightarrow$ **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Combat Reflexes (2 XP) — +1 die on defense when surprised/flanked
- Add **Talent:** Defensive Survival (3 XP) — +1 die to defense rolls while engaged in melee; once/scene convert first Harm 1 from melee to Fatigue
- **Total:** 29 + 5 = 34 XP

7.4 2. The Mage (Wizard / Sorcerer / Arcanist)

Concept: A wielder of arcane power who reshapes reality through study, intuition, or pact. *Candlesmoke, marginalia, and dangerous truths.* From the rational Wizard of Thepyrgos to the instinctive Sorcerer of the Bloodlands, magic flows through them — and sometimes through them.

Traditional Analogues: Wizard, Sorcerer, Warlock (pact magic), Arcanist, Runekeeper

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (theory, precision), Spirit (willpower, channeling)
- **Skills:** Lore, Arcana, Investigation, (optionally) Sway (for social casting)
- **Talents:** Spellcraft (freeform), Codex (runekeeper), Patron's Symbol (invoker)

Play Style:

- Information gathering and magical analysis
- Solving puzzles and mysteries with arcane insight
- Using magic to gain advantages in combat and social scenes
- Researching new spells and rituals between adventures
- Managing Obligation (for Runekeepers) or Backlash (for free casters)

Development Path:

- Specialize in specific element or school of magic
- Develop ritual casting or summoning abilities
- Build a library, laboratory, or arcane network
- Create unique spells or magical items

Story Hooks:

- What forbidden knowledge are they seeking?
- How did they acquire their magical talent — bloodline, study, pact, accident?
- What dangerous secrets might they uncover?
- Who opposes their research (rival mages, witch-hunters, the Church)?

7.4.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Spirit 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Lore 2 (4), Arcana 1 (2) → **6 XP**
- **Total:** 27 XP (bank 3 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Spellcraft (6 XP) using banked $3 + 4 = 7$ XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** $27 + 6 = 33$ XP (bank 1 XP)

7.5 3. The Rogue (Thief / Assassin / Scout)

Concept: A shadow who moves where others cannot, taking what others cannot keep. *Quiet footfalls, hawk eyes, and no loyalties but coin.* From the street-wise cutpurse of Silkstrand to the deadly assassin of Zakov, the Rogue survives by wits, speed, and one hidden knife.

Traditional Analogues: Rogue, Thief, Assassin, Scout, Ranger (stealth focus), Spy

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (perception, quick thinking), Body (agility, stealth)
- **Skills:** Stealth, Subterfuge, Investigation (or Streetwise), (optionally) Melee (light weapons)
- **Talents:** Backstab, Elusive Dodge, Shadow Dance (later)

Play Style:

- Scouting ahead and gathering intelligence
- Infiltrating secured areas and disabling traps
- Ambush and skirmish tactics — striking from stealth
- Finding paths, contacts, and secrets in cities and wilderness

Development Path:

- Improve stealth and backstab capabilities
- Develop poison use or sabotage techniques
- Build a network of informants and fences
- Learn disguises, forgeries, or social infiltration

Story Hooks:

- What crime or secret forced them into the shadows?
- What treasure or truth are they hunting?
- How do they balance loyalty to allies with self-preservation?
- Who wants them dead — and why?

7.5.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Presence 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Stealth 2 (4), Subterfuge 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Backstab (6 XP) — needs 6 XP; bank 1 + 4 = 5 XP → not enough. Alternative: Add **Talent:** Elusive Dodge (6 XP) but same shortfall. Better: Add **Skill:** Perception 1 (2 XP) and **Talent:** Combat Reflexes (2 XP) and bank 2 XP. Or take a Minor Asset: Hidden Cache (4 XP) and bank 2 XP.
- **Suggested:** Hidden Cache + bank 2 XP → total 33 XP.

7.6 4. The Cleric (Priest / Healer / Exorcist)

Concept: A vessel of divine or spiritual power, channeling healing, truth, and judgment. *Sacred flame, holy water, and a prayer on the lips.* From the Lampers of Ecktoria to the fog-named exorcists of the Mistlands, the Cleric binds wounds and banishes darkness.

Traditional Analogues: Cleric, Priest, Paladin (healing focus), Exorcist, Shaman, Healer

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (faith, willpower), Presence (authority, channeling)
- **Skills:** Lore (theology, rites), Medicine, Sway (prayer, exhortation), (optionally) Melee (symbolic weapon)
- **Talents:** Invoker (Patron's Symbol) or Runekeeper (Thiasos + Codex of a divine Patron like Everflame, Oath of Flame Light, Pale Shepherd)

Play Style:

- Healing and protecting allies
- Purifying curses, diseases, and undead
- Ley line and ritual magic (wards, consecrations)
- Using authority of faith to command or persuade

Development Path:

- Deepen connection to Patron (more Rites, lower Obligation)
- Develop exorcism and spirit-banishing abilities
- Build a temple, shrine, or hospice
- Lead followers in religious/civic ceremonies

Story Hooks:

- What crisis of faith have they survived?
- What heresy or supernatural threat haunts them?
- How do they serve both the living and the dead?
- What price do they pay for divine power?

7.6.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Presence 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Body 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Medicine 2 (4), Lore 1 (2), Sway 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Patron's Symbol (4 XP) for a divine Patron (e.g., Oath of Flame Light), using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

7.7 5. The Bard (Diplomat / Skald / Courtier)

Concept: A master of words, music, and social influence who changes minds and opens doors. *A smile for the foyer, steel for the parlor.* From the Skald of Linn to the Courtier of Vhasia, the Bard wields charm, rumor, and reputation as weapons.

Traditional Analogues: Bard, Diplomat, Courtier, Skald, Spy (social), Negotiator

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Presence (charm, performance), Wits (reading people, timing)
- **Skills:** Sway, Performance, Insight, (optionally) Lore (customs, history)
- **Talents:** Silver Tongue, Inspire, Network Builder (or Read Emotions)

Play Style:

- Social interaction and negotiation
- Gathering information through rumors and contacts
- Resolving conflicts without violence (or making violence fashionable)
- Building alliances, manipulating factions

Development Path:

- Expand social network and influence
- Develop economic or political power
- Learn cultural specialties (heraldry, etiquette, languages)
- Master inspirational or demoralizing performances

Story Hooks:

- What major conflict are they trying to resolve?
- What secret do they know that could topple a dynasty?
- How do they handle betrayal or failed negotiations?
- What personal relationships affect their diplomacy?

7.7.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Spirit 1 (3), Body 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2 (4), Performance 1 (2), Insight 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Inspire (3 XP) — once/scene, gain +1 die and potentially +1 Boon for bonded ally, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 2 XP
- **Total:** 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

7.8 6. The Ranger (Hunter / Tracker / Beastmaster)

Concept: A wilderness expert who navigates dangerous territories and hunts down quarry. *Quiet footfalls, hawk eyes, and the long road.* From the Ykrul scout to the Valewood warden, the Ranger lives where roads end.

Traditional Analogues: Ranger, Hunter, Tracker, Beastmaster, Pathfinder, Wilderness Scout

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (perception, navigation), Body (agility, endurance)
- **Skills:** Survival, Stealth, Nature (or Animal Handling), Archery or Melee
- **Talents:** Wilderness Lore, Keen Senses, (optionally) Animal Companion

Play Style:

- Scouting ahead and gathering intelligence
- Wilderness survival and navigation
- Tracking creatures or people across terrain
- Ambushing from concealment, using terrain
- (Optional) Bonding with an animal companion

Development Path:

- Improve stealth and tracking abilities
- Develop animal companion or nature magic

- Master specific environments (forest, mountain, marsh)
- Learn advanced survival techniques (poisoncraft, herbalism)

Story Hooks:

- What uncharted territory are they exploring?
- What secrets have they discovered in the wild?
- How do they balance civilization and wilderness?
- What prey (beast or man) still eludes them?

7.8.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Spirit 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2 (4), Stealth 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Keen Senses (2 XP) — +1 die to perception
- Add **Talent:** Wilderness Lore (2 XP) — auto-find food/water in hospitable biomes
- **Total:** 29 + 4 = 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

7.9 7. The Survivor (Veteran / Outcast / Hardened)

Concept: Someone who has endured hardship and developed resilience. *Scars are maps; read them well.* From the war-torn mercenary to the plague survivor, the Survivor won't break — they've already been broken and rebuilt.

Traditional Analogues: Barbarian (resilience focus), Veteran, Ranger (endurance), Drifter, Refugee

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (willpower, resolve), Body (toughness)
- **Skills:** Endurance, Survival, (optionally) Perception (danger sense), Medicine (field)
- **Talents:** Iron Stomach, Conditioning, Second Wind

Play Style:

- Enduring difficult conditions (lack of food, exposure, poison)
- Overcoming physical and mental challenges through grit
- Using experience to avoid dangers
- Helping others survive hardships
- Taking hits that would fell others and still standing

Development Path:

- Improve physical and mental resilience (higher Fatigue limit, Harm reduction)
- Develop survival-related skills (traps, scavenging)
- Acquire better equipment and resources
- Learn to teach survival to others (leadership)

Story Hooks:

- What trauma or hardship have they survived?
- How has their past shaped their present?
- What survival skills have saved them repeatedly?
- How do they help others facing similar challenges?

7.9.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Endurance 2 (4), Survival 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Iron Stomach (3 XP) — immunity to mundane poisons and spoiled food; halve complications from toxic sources
- **Total:** 29 + 3 = 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

7.10 8. The Innovator (Artificer / Engineer / Tinker)

Concept: A creative problem-solver who finds new solutions through craft and invention. *Blueprints on napkins, tomorrow in your pocket.* From the Aeler engineer to the Gnome clockmaker, the Innovator builds what others only dream.

Traditional Analogues: Artificer, Engineer, Tinker, Alchemist, Inventor, Savant

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (design, analysis), Body (fine manipulation)
- **Skills:** Craft, Tinker, Mechanics, (optionally) Alchemy, Investigation
- **Talents:** Technical Expert, Quick Study, (optionally) Magical Laboratory asset

Play Style:

- Solving problems with unique inventions
- Creating or repairing specialized items
- Providing services others cannot (lockpicking, trap disarm, device creation)
- Using knowledge to gain advantages in planning

Development Path:

- Master their specialty area (weapons, armor, alchemy, constructs)
- Develop related capabilities (explosives, poisons, medical devices)
- Build reputation and clientele (workshop asset)
- Create unique inventions or discoveries (blueprints)

Story Hooks:

- What makes their specialty unique or valuable?
- How did they acquire their special skills (guild, apprenticeship, self-taught)?
- What problems require their specific expertise?
- Who seeks to control or exploit their abilities?

7.10.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Presence 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Craft 2 (4), Tinker 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Quick Study (3 XP) — +1 die to learn or adapt from observation, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 2 XP
- **Total:** 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

7.11 9. The Summoner (Pact-Whisperer / Necromancer / Shaman)

Concept: A binder of spirits, elementals, and otherworldly entities. *Circles of salt, whispered names, and bargains struck in shadows.* From the necromancer of the Mistlands to the shaman of the Steppe, the Summoner commands powers that others fear.

Traditional Analogues: Necromancer, Conjurer, Summoner, Shaman, Spirit Caller, Demonologist

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (willpower, binding), Wits (rituals, names)
- **Skills:** Arcana, Lore (spirits), (optionally) Command, Survival
- **Talents:** Pact-Whisperer (Lesser/Greater), Spirit Link, (optionally) Codex of Names

Play Style:

- Summoning creatures to fight, scout, or work
- Binding entities to solve problems (guard, research, transport)
- Negotiating with spirits and outsiders (social challenges)
- Managing Leash clocks and Boon Finesse

Development Path:

- Unlock higher Cap summons (Lesser → Greater)
- Develop specializations (combat, scout, utility)
- Build a Spirit Bond Clock with favored entities
- Learn true names for powerful outsiders (Prestige talent)

Story Hooks:

- What entity are they bound to or seeking?
- What price did they pay for their first summoning?
- How do others react to their “dark” magic?
- Who hunts them for their forbidden practices?

7.11.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Arcana 2 (4), Lore 1 (2) → **6 XP**

- **Total:** 27 XP (bank 3 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Pact-Whisperer (2 XP) — access to summoning
- Add **Talent:** Lesser Pactwright (2 XP) — can summon Cap 1 spirits
- **Total:** 27 + 4 = 31 XP (bank 3 XP; can add Familiar (2 XP) later or upgrade to Greater Pactwright)

7.12 10. The Commander (Warlord / Tactician / Leader)

Concept: A leader who directs allies, controls battlefields, and shapes conflicts through strategy. *Orders in a whisper, victory in formation.* From the Condotta captain to the Ekstorian legate, the Commander wins before blades are drawn.

Traditional Analogues: Warlord, Marshal, Tactician, Commander, Strategist, Banneret

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Presence (authority, command), Wits (tactics, observation)
- **Skills:** Command, Tactics, (optionally) Sway (morale), Investigation (battlefield analysis)
- **Talents:** Inspire, Command Presence, Tactical Movement (for allies)

Play Style:

- Directing allies in combat (bonus dice, improved Position)
- Planning and executing tactical maneuvers
- Leading followers and assets in mass action
- Using authority to intimidate or persuade

Development Path:

- Increase follower limit and effectiveness
- Develop area-buff abilities (morale, defensive formation)
- Acquire strategic assets (spy network, war chest)
- Unlock Prestige talents like Battlefield Mastery

Story Hooks:

- What army or company did they lead before?
- What strategic defeat haunts them?
- Who are their rivals in the art of war?
- What cause do they fight for — coin, country, or creed?

7.12.0.0.1 Build Blocks. Starting Build (30 XP).

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Command 2 (4), Tactics 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (34 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Command Presence (4 XP) — +1 die on leadership/intimidation rolls, using

banked $1 + 4 = 5$ XP; bank 1 XP

- **Total:** 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

Reskinning the Paths: Runekeeper and Invoker as Familiar Concepts

The magic systems in *Fate's Edge* are designed to be reimagined. Neither **Runekeeper** (Thiasos + Codex) nor **Invoker** (Patron's Symbol) is locked into a single narrative identity. Below are common reskins — use the same mechanics, change the fiction.

Runekeeper – The Devoted Agent

A Runekeeper has sworn themselves to a single Patron, learning its Rites and bearing its Obligation. This framework can represent:

- **Paladin / Crusader:** Sworn to the *Oath of Flame & Light* or the *Inquisitor Prime*. Rites become prayers, smites, and consecrations. The Codex is a prayer book or a vow-etched gauntlet.
- **Warlock / Pact-Bearer:** Bound to a distant, alien, or dangerous Patron (e.g., Khemesh, Malachai, the Ninth). Rites are granted, not learned. Obligation is the steady pull of a bargain.
- **Cleric / Priest:** Devoted to the Everflame, the Pale Shepherd, or other divine powers. Rites are liturgies. The Patron's Gift is a blessing or a relic.
- **Dark Knight / Death Knight:** A fallen or morally ambiguous warrior who draws power from a grim Patron (Carrion-King, Mor'iraath). Melee and Rites mix; Obligation is a slow doom.

Mechanical core unchanged: 1 action Rites, Obligation track, Patron's Gift imbuelement, Push It option.

Invoker – The Professional Occultist

An Invoker does not fully commit to a single Patron. Instead, they carry **Symbols** (often tools, badges, or relics) of several Powers and perform rituals to invoke their Rites. This framework can represent:

- **Exorcist / Witch Hunter:** Carries symbols of several protective Patrons (The Sealed Gate, Oath of Flame, Gallow's Bell). Rites are wards, banishments, and purification rituals. *Crack the Seal* is an emergency exorcism.
- **Alienist / Scholar of the Unseen:** Studies forbidden Patrons (The Ninth, Khemesh, Mor'iraath) from a safe distance — “safe” being relative. Uses Symbol libraries to invoke their power without full devotion. Rituals are experimental and dangerous.
- **Consulting Occultist / Paranormal Investigator:** Carries a briefcase or satchel of Symbols — a bell from the Mistlands, a sun-seal from Ecktoria, a hag's stone from Aelinnel. Hired to solve magical problems. Rituals are filed like work orders; *Crack the Seal* is “burning a favor.”
- **Ritualist / Ceremonial Mage:** Believes that power lies in procedure, not faith. Each Symbol is a “key” — a geometric diagram, a calendar, a consecrated blade. Rites are slow, deliberate, and precise. The Invoker is a technician, not a worshipper.

Mechanical core unchanged: Ritual time, Obligation per invocation, Symbol display reduces cost, *Crack the Seal* for instant effect.

Mixing and Blurring Lines

Characters may also blend these frameworks — a Runekeeper who occasionally carries a second Symbol for emergency rites, or an Invoker who one day pledges fully to a Patron and becomes a Runekeeper. The system does not penalize narrative growth; simply retrain Talents during downtime (§6) when the fiction justifies it.

Remember: The fiction leads. If you want to play a Paladin, describe your Runekeeper's Rites as prayers. If you want a Vodouisant or Hoodoo practitioner, re flavor Patron's Symbols as sacred bundles, veyes, or spirit vessels. If you want a monster hunter, carry a satchel of

7.13 Creating Your Own Concept

Start with Narrative

- What is your character's background and motivation?
- What role do they play in their community or society?
- What relationships are important to them?
- What goals are they pursuing?

Add Mechanical Support

- Choose attributes that support your concept
- Select skills that reflect their training and experience
- Consider talents that provide unique capabilities
- Think about assets that represent their resources

Consider Group Role

- How does your concept complement other party members?
- What gaps in group capability can you fill?
- What unique contributions can you make?
- How will you work with other characters?

Plan for Growth

- What short-term improvements make sense?
- What long-term development aligns with your concept?
- How might your character change over time?
- What legacy do you want to build?

Character Concept Worksheet

Narrative Elements:

- Concept: _____
- Traditional Analogues: _____
- Motivation: _____
- Background: _____
- Relationships: _____

Mechanical Foundation:

- Primary Attributes: _____
- Key Skills: _____
- Starting Talents: _____
- Initial Assets: _____

Development Plan:

- Short-term goals: _____
- Long-term vision: _____

7.14 Final Notes

Remember that these examples are starting points, not limitations. The most interesting characters often combine elements from multiple concepts or create entirely new approaches. Work with your Game Master to ensure your character concept fits the campaign and provides engaging story opportunities.

The best characters are those that you find interesting to play and that contribute to an enjoyable experience for everyone at the table.

Chapter 8

Assets and Followers

Power in Fate’s Edge is not measured only by what your character can do with their own hands. As characters grow, their influence extends outward—into places, people, and institutions that act in their name.

Assets and **Followers** represent this outward reach. They are how a character’s past choices continue to matter when the dice stop rolling.

Assets reshape the world around you. Followers stand beside you when the world pushes back.

8.1 Understanding Assets and Followers

Assets and Followers serve different roles in play, but both are expressions of legacy, leverage, and risk.

Key Differences

- **Assets** are off-screen resources: places, networks, titles, or enterprises.
- **Followers** are on-screen allies who act during scenes.
- **Assets** change the situation *before or around* a scene.
- **Followers** participate *directly* in the moment.

Both are powerful—but neither is free.

Management and Risk

Assets and Followers require care and invite consequences:

- They demand upkeep through XP, downtime, or narrative obligation.
- They can be targeted, compromised, or destroyed.
- Overuse draws attention from enemies, factions, and rivals.

Power creates gravity. What you rely on can be taken from you.

8.2 Assets System

Assets are persistent resources under your control: holdings, institutions, reputations, or infrastructures.

Assets do not replace rolls. They change what rolls are possible.

Assets allow characters to:

- Arrive prepared instead of improvising.
- Reframe danger into opportunity.
- Shift Position without negating risk.

Asset Types and Costs

Type	XP Cost	Establishment Time
Minor	4 XP	1 day
Standard	8 XP	1 week
Major	12 XP	1 month

Asset Examples

Minor Assets Safehouse, small shop, minor title, basic workshop.

Standard Assets Guild membership, noble office, trading post, spy network.

Major Assets Fortress, chartered city license, major enterprise, regional authority.

Using Assets

Assets provide leverage in two primary ways: quiet preparation and dramatic activation.

8.2.0.0.1 Free Off-Screen Use Each Asset has a defined off-screen effect usable **once per session**, typically during downtime or scene framing:

- **Safehouse:** Secure lodging or concealment.
- **Spy Network:** Baseline intelligence about a person or place.
- **Workshop:** Repair gear or prepare simple solutions.
- **Trading Post:** Acquire common goods or establish contacts.

These uses prepare the ground—they do not resolve active conflict.

8.2.0.0.2 Boon Activation Spend **1 Boon** to activate an Asset dramatically during a scene.

This does not guarantee success. Instead, the Asset **reshapes the fiction** so a different outcome becomes possible.

An activated Asset may:

- Improve **Position** by one step.
- Reduce the effective **DV** of a follow-up action.
- Advance, suppress, or redirect a relevant Clock.
- Grant temporary access, protection, or narrative permission.

Examples:

- **Safehouse:** Reveal a concealed exit, allowing escape at *Controlled* Position.
- **Spy Network:** Surface critical intelligence, advancing an investigation Clock.
- **Workshop:** Jury-rig a solution that enables an otherwise impossible attempt.

- **Trading Post:** Call in a favor to gain leverage or access in a negotiation.

The GM determines the precise effect based on the Asset's scale, condition, and the current stakes.

8.2.0.0.3 High-Tier Use At higher tiers, Assets carry greater narrative weight—and greater risk.

Repeated or aggressive use may:

- Create new complications.
- Advance hostile faction Clocks.
- Place the Asset itself in danger.

Assets are leverage, not immunity.

8.2.0.0.4 XP Activation Spend **2 XP** to use an Asset's off-screen effect beyond its normal limit:

- Emergency use after the free activation is spent.
- Additional downtime applications.
- Exceptional circumstances requiring extended support.

XP use represents strain, overreach, or long-term cost.

8.3 Asset Conditions

Assets have condition states affecting their usefulness.

Condition Levels

Maintained Fully functional, no penalties.

Neglected –1 die when used; requires attention.

Compromised Unavailable until repaired or recovered.

Maintenance Requirements

- **Regular Upkeep:** Two options (see §8.8).
- **Neglect:** Assets deteriorate if not maintained.
- **Recovery:** Compromised assets require significant effort to restore.

8.4 Followers System

Followers are characters who assist you directly.

Follower Capability Ratings

Followers are rated by Capability (**Cap**) from 1 to 5:

Cap	Description
1	Novice helper, basic assistance
2	Competent assistant, reliable support
3	Skilled specialist, valuable aid
4	Expert ally, significant capability
5	Master companion, exceptional ability

Follower Costs

- **XP Cost:** Capability squared (Cap^2).
- **Example:** Cap 3 follower costs $3^2 = 9$ XP.
- **Recruitment:** 1–3 days downtime to find and brief.
- **Limits:** The GM may set maximum followers based on story.

Follower Types

Combat Allies Warriors, guards, mercenaries.

Technical Experts Craftspeople, engineers, specialists.

Social Contacts Informants, diplomats, agents.

Specialists Unique capabilities like magic or stealth.

8.5 Using Followers

Assistance in Scenes

Followers can help with your actions:

- **Assist Dice:** Add dice equal to $\min(Cap, relevantskill)$.
- **Maximum Bonus:** +3 dice total from all sources.
- **Cost:** Spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue to add +1 die (max +3 from assists).
- **One Helper:** Only one follower can assist per action.

Independent Actions

Once per scene (party-wide), a follower can take a small action:

Scout & Signal Change an ally's next action to **Dominant** position.

Distract & Draw Reduce a threat clock by 1 segment.

Fetch & Carry Move an object through danger safely.

Cost of Independent Actions

- Mark +1 **Exposure** (attention or stress), *or*
- Take **Harm 1** (injury or trauma).
- Cannot be used if the follower is already **Compromised**.

8.6 Follower Conditions

Followers track two condition types.

Exposure

Represents attention, stress, or narrative pressure:

- **Gains:** From independent actions, dangerous situations, complications.
- **Effects:** Increased risk, reduced effectiveness, attention from enemies.
- **Recovery:** Downtime activities, careful management.

Harm

Represents injury, trauma, or damage:

- **Gains:** From combat, accidents, enemy attacks.
- **Effects:** Penalties to assistance, possible incapacity.
- **Recovery:** Medical care, rest, magical healing.

Condition States

Maintained Ready and reliable, full capability.

Neglected Needs attention, -1 die to assistance.

Compromised Unavailable: captured, defected, lost, or incapacitated.

8.7 Follower Risks

Using followers carries significant risks.

Complication Targeting

When the GM spends **2+ Story Beats** on an action where you have assistance:

- The follower may face consequences instead of you.
- Consequences could be injury, capture, betrayal, or other complications.
- The outcome must be fictionally appropriate.

Off-Screen Capability

Once per downtime, a **Cap 5** follower can solve a significant problem:

- But generates **1 Story Beat** for the party.
- The GM describes how this creates story consequences.
- Useful for emergencies, but costly.

8.8 Upkeep and Maintenance

Both assets and followers require regular maintenance. Each downtime period, choose one of the two options.

Asset Upkeep

Two options:

- **Efficient (Higher XP, Less Time):** Pay Upkeep XP = $\max(1, \text{AcquisitionXP})/3$, minimal effort.
- **Intensive (Lower XP, More Time):** Pay 1 XP, use a dedicated downtime action with

significant personal involvement.

- **Failure to Pay:** Asset becomes *Neglected* (or *Compromised* if already *Neglected*).

Follower Upkeep

Two options:

- **Efficient:** Pay Upkeep XP = $\max(1, Cap^2)/3$, minimal effort.
- **Intensive:** Pay 1 XP, use a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- **Failure to Pay:** Follower becomes *Wary* (or *Seized* if already *Wary*).

8.9 Strategic Considerations

When to Invest in Assets

- You need reliable off-screen capabilities.
- Your character concept involves wealth or influence.
- The party lacks certain logistical support.
- You want to build long-term influence.

When to Invest in Followers

- You need on-screen assistance.
- Your character works better with support.
- The party needs specific capabilities you lack.
- You want character-driven story opportunities.

Balance Recommendations

- **Personal Path:** 0–10% of XP in assets/followers.
- **Balanced Path:** 15–25%.
- **Influencer Path:** 35–55%.

8.10 Loyalty and Relationships

Loyalty Levels (Optional)

Wary Cautious, may leave if pressured; +1 XP upkeep cost.

Steady Reliable, standard performance; normal upkeep.

Devoted Loyal, may sacrifice; can convert one major complication to a minor setback per arc.

Building Loyalty

- Fair treatment and respect.
- Sharing rewards and successes.
- Protecting followers from harm.
- Honoring agreements and promises.

Losing Loyalty

- Mistreatment or disrespect.
- Unreasonable demands or risks.
- Broken promises or betrayal.

- Consistent neglect.

8.11 Advanced Follower Management

Follower Groups

For multiple similar followers, you can manage them as a group:

- **Single Rating:** Treat as one entity with combined capability.
- **Condition Tracking:** Group shares exposure and harm.
- **Maintenance:** Single upkeep cost for the group.
- **Risks:** Problems affect the entire group.

Follower Advancement

Followers can improve over time:

- **Experience:** Gain capability through successful assistance.
- **Training:** Spend XP to improve follower capabilities.
- **Equipment:** Better gear can enhance effectiveness.
- **Limits:** Followers typically cap at lower levels than PCs.

8.12 Risk Management

Asset Risks

- **Financial:** Assets can be costly to maintain.
- **Security:** Assets can be attacked or stolen.
- **Attention:** Valuable assets draw unwanted notice.
- **Dependency:** Over-reliance can be problematic.

Follower Risks

- **Safety:** Followers can be harmed or captured.
- **Loyalty:** Followers may betray or leave.
- **Attention:** Followers can draw enemy interest.
- **Morale:** Followers have needs and limits.

Mitigation Strategies

- **Diversification:** Don't put all resources in one place.
- **Security:** Protect valuable assets and followers.
- **Relationships:** Maintain good terms with your people.
- **Contingencies:** Have backup plans for losses.

Assets and Followers Quick Reference

Assets:

- Minor: 4 XP | Standard: 8 XP | Major: 12 XP
- Free off-screen use: once per session
- Boon activation: spend 1 Boon for scene impact
- Conditions: *Maintained* → *Neglected* → *Compromised*

Followers:

- Cost: Cap^2 XP
- Assistance: $+ \min(Cap, skill)$ dice (max +3 from all sources)
- Independent action: once per scene (party-wide)
- Conditions: *Exposure* and *Harm* tracks

Upkeep Options:

- Efficient: $\max(1, Cost)/3$ XP, minimal time
- Intensive: 1 XP, dedicated downtime action

8.13 Practical Examples

Asset Example: The Safehouse

- **Type:** Minor Asset (4 XP)
- **Free Use:** Secure lodging, basic supplies between adventures.
- **Boon Activation:** Reveal a hidden escape route during pursuit.
- **Upkeep:** Efficient: 2 XP (4/3 rounded up); Intensive: 1 XP + downtime action.
- **Risks:** Discovery by enemies, maintenance costs.

Follower Example: The Scout

- **Capability:** 3 (9 XP cost)
- **Assistance:** +3 dice on tracking and survival rolls.
- **Independent Action:** Scout ahead to improve party position.
- **Upkeep:** Efficient: 3 XP (9/3); Intensive: 1 XP + downtime action.
- **Risks:** Injury in dangerous scouting; disloyalty if mistreated.

Combination Example: The Merchant

- **Assets:** Trading post (8 XP), caravan (4 XP) — *12 XP total*
- **Followers:** Cap 2 guards (4 XP each = 8 XP), Cap 3 factor (9 XP) — *17 XP total*
- **Total Investment:** **29 XP** in assets and followers
- **Upkeep (Efficient):** Assets 4 XP + Followers 6 XP = **10 XP** per downtime
- **Benefits:** Trade income, transport, protection, business contacts
- **Risks:** Competition, bandit attacks, employee issues, regulatory attention

Remember: Assets and followers can greatly expand your capabilities, but they require careful management and carry significant risks. Invest wisely based on your character concept and the needs of your group.

8.14 Narrative-Heavy Asset and Follower Options

For groups that prefer strong narrative focus, consider these optional approaches.

8.14.0.0.1 Story-Driven Upkeep Instead of tracking XP costs for upkeep, the GM can introduce narrative complications that require attention. A neglected asset might attract unwanted attention, while a neglected follower might request a favor or special treatment.

8.14.0.0.2 Collaborative Management Players can describe how they maintain their assets and followers through roleplay rather than mechanical upkeep costs. A well-described scene of tending a workshop or bonding with followers can fulfill maintenance requirements.

8.14.0.0.3 Asset and Follower as Character Development Use asset and follower management as opportunities for character growth and backstory development, allowing players to narrate how their relationships and holdings evolve through significant story moments.

8.14.0.0.4 Flexible Condition Tracking Focus on the narrative implications of asset and follower conditions rather than strict mechanical penalties. A “Neglected” asset might still function but with interesting complications, while a “Compromised” asset might require creative solutions rather than just XP investment.

8.15 Terrestrial Patrons

Not all power comes from cosmic entities or divine forces. Sometimes your greatest allies—and most demanding creditors—are mortal factions who can offer protection, resources, and influence in the world of men.

8.15.1 What Are Terrestrial Patrons?

Terrestrial Patrons represent your ongoing relationships with powerful mortal organizations:

- Noble houses and courtly factions.
- Merchant guilds and trading consortiums.
- Military units and mercenary companies.
- Criminal organizations and smuggling rings.
- Religious orders and temple hierarchies.
- Scholarly colleges and arcane societies.

Unlike supernatural Patrons, Terrestrial Patrons do not grant magic, but they offer **leverage**: protection, resources, sanctuary, information, and political influence.

8.15.2 Gaining a Terrestrial Patron

To gain a Terrestrial Patron, complete one of these significant actions:

- Complete a major job or service for them.
- Swear a formal Oath of service.
- Enter into legal or financial binding.
- Share criminal secrets or be compromised by them.
- Perform a notable service that earns their favor.

Mark the Patron on your character sheet and write one sentence: “*They want me because _____*”.

8.15.3 Obligation System

Terrestrial Patrons use the same Obligation track as supernatural Patrons, but consequences are social, legal, or economic rather than mystical.

- **Calling in Favors:** When you request Patron influence, add +1 Obligation.
- **Capacity:** Spirit + Presence (same as supernatural Patrons).
- **Overflow:** Each segment above capacity inflicts 1 Fatigue.
- **Resolution:** Reduce through service, downtime actions, or fulfilling demands.

8.15.4 Patron Perks

Each Terrestrial Patron offers 2–3 repeatable benefits that require no rolls to access.

Common Perks Include:

- Sanctuary in their territory or establishments.
- Legal relief or protection from certain authorities.
- Access to black market goods or specialized services.
- Elite followers or hirelings at reduced cost.
- Forged documents or identity protection.
- Military backing or private security.
- Information networks and rumor access.
- Trade advantages or exclusive contracts.

Using a perk never requires a roll—Fate has already been paid. Each use comes with the ongoing cost of Obligation.

8.15.5 Patron Demands

Terrestrial Patrons always want something in return:

- Silence about sensitive information.
- Loyalty over other conflicting interests.
- Completion of specific jobs or tasks.
- Delivery of valuable names or secrets.
- Political or social support for their causes.
- Elimination of rivals or threats to their interests.

Refusing a Demand raises Obligation by 1 segment and may trigger immediate complications.

8.15.6 When Obligation Fills

At 6 Obligation segments, the Patron acts—this is not optional. Choose one:

1. **Unavoidable Job:** You must complete a task you cannot refuse.
2. **Severe Price:** Pay significant cost (legal, social, or material).
3. **First Strike:** They act against you—reputation damage, warrants, bounty, blackmail.

After the consequence lands, reduce Obligation to 3 segments.

8.15.7 Cutting Ties

You may sever a Terrestrial Patron relationship, but doing so has serious fallout:

- Lose all current perks immediately.
- Gain a new **Rival** faction that opposes your interests.
- Take a lasting **Complication** (Curse, Bounty, or Scandal) that follows you.
- May trigger immediate retaliation depending on the Patron's nature.

Some Patrons never forgive betrayal; others can be bought off with significant compensation.

8.15.8 Redemption and Favor

If you perform a monumental service for a Patron—something beyond what was asked—reduce Obligation by 2 and gain a permanent **Favor**.

Favor Benefits:

- Noble title or official position.
- Land grant or property rights.
- Permanent access to exclusive resources.
- Unique asset or specialized equipment.
- Political influence or legal immunity.
- Protection from their rivals or enemies.

8.15.9 Example: The Black Ledger

The Black Ledger is a smuggling syndicate operating in the coastal city of Kahfagia.

Gaining Their Favor: Successfully complete three smuggling runs without detection.

Perks:

- Sanctuary in hidden safehouses throughout the city.
- Access to rare imported goods and contraband.
- Information about port authorities and customs schedules.

Demands:

- Maintain silence about syndicate operations.
- Transport occasional “special packages” (may be illegal).
- Eliminate rival smugglers who threaten their routes.

Sample Scenario: Rellan calls on the Ledger for a smuggled border crossing. The GM rules it succeeds automatically, but adds +1 Obligation. Later, the Ledger demands he silence a witness who saw too much. If he refuses, Obligation rises again. If Obligation ever reaches 6, the Ledger collects: accounts frozen, bounty posted, or a rival informant sent after him.

8.15.10 Creating Your Own Terrestrial Patrons

When designing a Terrestrial Patron, consider:

1. **Nature:** What type of organization are they?
2. **Motivation:** What drives their goals and actions?
3. **Resources:** What can they realistically offer?

4. **Methods:** How do they typically operate?
5. **Enemies:** Who opposes their interests?
6. **Perks:** 2–3 concrete benefits they provide.
7. **Demands:** 3–5 typical requests they make.

Remember: Terrestrial Patrons make the mortal world feel alive and reactive. They represent the complex web of loyalty, debt, and influence that shapes everyday life in Fate’s Edge.

8.16 Multi-Character Switching System

This framework allows a player to temporarily move a character offscreen while continuing play with another. The absent character remains active in the fiction and continues shaping the world through **Downtime Logs**, consequences, and story pressure.

8.16.1 Core Principles

- Players **choose** when their character steps offscreen.
- Offscreen characters still **matter** to the narrative.
- Absence creates **opportunity and risk**, not punishment.
- The world reacts to characters **even when unseen**.

8.16.2 Switch Mechanics

8.16.2.1 Declaration

When a player chooses to step out, they declare:

- Which character is going offscreen.
- Where the character is going (fictional location).
- Why they are stepping out (story reason).
- How long they expect to be away (1–3 sessions).

The character becomes an **Echo Character**: present in the world, but offscreen.

8.16.2.2 Controlled Status Types

Echo Characters take one of three statuses:

- **Supporting** (default): Works to assist active PCs.
- **Advancing**: Pursues their own agenda or project.
- **In Peril**: Their absence creates danger or urgency.

The GM and player collaborate to set this status.

8.16.3 Downtime Log

Each offscreen session, the player completes a simple **Downtime Log**:

8.16.3.1 Structure

- **Resource Action**: How they maintain connections or standing.
- **Project Action**: One goal or project advanced.
- **Event Response**: How they react to unseen events or threats.

8.16.3.2 Tier-Based Project Limits

- Tier I–II: 1 Project.
- Tier III–IV: 2 Projects.
- Tier V: 3 Projects.

8.16.3.3 GM Response

The GM records:

- The fictional outcome of each declaration.
- One meaningful **Consequence** (complication, shift, or new opportunity).

8.16.4 Return Mechanics

8.16.4.1 Re-Entry Process

When returning to play:

1. The returning character gains **2 Boons** for narrative re-entry.
2. Roll **Wits + Spirit** (DV 3) to reestablish presence.
3. Address unresolved plot threads created during absence.

8.16.4.2 Re-Entry Consequences

The GM assigns one:

- **Ripple Effect** — your absence reshaped the situation.
- **Opportunity Missed** — a door closed without you.
- **Allies Gained** — your actions forged new connections.
- **Rivals Made** — someone now works against you.
- **Personal Growth** — you return wiser or transformed.
- **Lost Momentum** — your projects slipped.

8.16.5 Advanced Systems

8.16.5.1 Buddy System

If multiple players are absent:

- Nominate a **Buddy** to help track Downtime Logs.
- The Buddy gains **+1 additional Boon** for the support role.

8.16.5.2 Crisis Management

Offscreen characters track a **Crisis Clock** [6]:

- Fills when negative consequences strike.
- At 6: The character faces a major offscreen crisis requiring GM action.
- May be reduced through Downtime Log responses or assistance from active PCs.

8.16.6 GM Guidelines

- Spend 5–7 minutes per absent character completing their Downtime Log.
- Focus on narrative change, not bookkeeping pressure.
- Absence should generate hooks and stakes, not penalties.
- Use Echo Characters to keep the world *alive and reactive*.

8.16.7 Player Guidelines

- Declare offscreen goals with clear fictional intent.
- Treat absence as character growth, not disappearance.
- Collaborate with the GM to weave consequences into play.
- Expect absence to create tension, opportunity, and drama.

Chapter 9

World Interaction

In **Fate's Edge**, the world is not a backdrop—it's a partner in the conversation. Dikes groan under black rain in Viterra, clan horns answer across Acasia's ridgelines, Ecktoria's marble halls echo with careful words, and Kahfagia's pilots read storms by taste. Wherever you go, place, culture, and pressure push back.

9.1 The Known World: A Geographic Overview

The following summary orients the major regions relative to one another. (See individual chapters for cultural details.)

Ecktoria Temperate heartland of the old Utaran Imperium. Borders Acasia to the northeast and Kahfagia to the west. Marble cities, imperial roads, codified law.

Acasia Lowland of rivers and petty kingdoms, northeast of Ecktoria. Broken province of mercenary companies and border lords. Borders Vhasia to the east.

Vhasia Fractured kingdom on a southern peninsula. East of Acasia, west of Viterra. Courtly intrigue, martial tradition, and fractured sun symbolism.

Viterra Shares the same peninsula with Vhasia, lying further east. Its eastern coast borders a dark inland body (the Blackwater). Hedge-law, river tolls, and the Last Kingdom.

Kahfagia West of Ecktoria, facing the open ocean. Maritime empire of storm-flags, deep-sea pilots, and exotic imports.

Thepyrgos Occupies the southern part of the great peninsula opposite Vhasia/Viterra. Eastern coast overlooks the Astroegro Straits. City of a Thousand Stairs, center of learning.

Theona Large island off the eastern coast of Viterra. Three isles, causeways, marsh, and the “No Ninth” taboo.

Mistlands Western shore of the Aberderrian Sea (north of the Amaranthine). Bog, fog, and bell-lines; protectorate of the Aeler. Direwood lies to the west.

Linns Scattered around the Yloka River and the Aberderrian Sea. Longships reach the Blackwater and raid Theona and Viterra. Fjords, skerries, storm-oaths.

Violet Steppe North of the Amaranthine, west of the Aberderrian Sea. Vast grassland, home of the Ykrul nomads.

Valewood East of the Blackwater. Ancient forest of phasing ruins, star-roads, and fae courts. Former Lethai empire.

Aelinnel (Aevrossa) South of the Valewood. Gnomish homeland of stone, bough, and bright

things. Mist paths, bell-mounds, tide-gates.

Aelaerem South of Aevrossa. Halfling downs of gentle valleys and deep barrows. Homeland spoken of only in euphemisms (“The Silent Welcome”).

Zakov Island in the Blackwater, near the mouth of the Yloka River. Pirate haven, reef passages, salt and serpent.

9.2 Game Structure and Time

Understanding how time works in Fate’s Edge helps you navigate both the mechanical and narrative flow of play.

Basic Units

Scene The basic unit of narrative play, covering a specific situation or conflict (Some Time to Significant Time). Resolves a particular question or challenge.

Player Turn (Beat) An individual player’s action within a scene: Declare action → GM sets position → roll → resolve outcome → manage consequences.

Round Simultaneous or near-simultaneous actions within a scene (primarily for combat), representing a few seconds of real time.

Session One complete game session (typically 3–6 hours), containing 2–4 major scenes and resolving significant narrative progress.

Downtime The narrative time between scenes, used for recovery, advancement, and off-screen activities. Measured in days, weeks, or months depending on fiction.

Campaign Entire story arc (6–20+ sessions) with major character development and lasting consequences.

9.3 Movement and Positioning

Space is tracked with **range bands** and **Position**.

Range Bands

Close Touching distance: grapples, knife-work, hand on a relic.

Near Same room/yard/deck; a rush away.

Far Same site but distant; requires route or time to reach.

Absent Off-screen; requires scene change or significant effort to interact.

Movement Actions

- **Move:** Shift one range band as a *beat*.
- **Dash:** Shift two bands as your full action (terrain may require a roll).
- **Melee Flag:** Mark when two parties are in Near range and directly engaged in combat.

Position States

Dominant You have cover, leverage, or ritual footing. Failure still leaves options.

Controlled Standard case: exposed lanes, rivals near, watchful eyes. Failure has teeth, but not ruin.

Desperate Bad ground, bad odds, bad timing. Failure is severe; success may bring extra XP.

9.3.0.0.1 Position Shifting:

- GM can spend **1 SB** to worsen Position by one step.
- Player can spend **1 Boon** to improve Position by one step (once per action).
- Narrative triggers (flanking, reinforcements, etc.) can shift Position without cost.

9.4 Travel Framework

Travel abstracts distance into *legs* with tension and color rather than miles and meal counts. Each leg has a **Travel Clock** and draws on a **regional deck** to seed fiction.

Travel Process

1. **Set the Leg:** Name origin and destination; start a Travel Clock (4-10 segments based on difficulty).
2. **Draw Prompts:** Draw up to one card from each suit to establish terrain, people, pressures, and leverage.
3. **Assign Roles:** Players take on travel roles (Guide, Scout, Quartermaster, Watch) to contribute actions.
4. **Play the Leg:** Players take actions to advance the clock or mitigate complications. GM spends SB from rolls showing **1s** to introduce hazards.
5. **Resolve:** When the clock fills, you arrive—changed by the journey.

Using Assets and Followers During Travel

- **Assets:** Spend 1 Boon to activate an asset for dramatic effect during travel (reveal hidden path, call for emergency aid, etc.).
- **Followers:** Assign followers to travel roles for bonuses. A Cap 3 Scout follower adds +3 to navigation rolls, for example.
- **Independent Actions:** Once per travel leg, a follower can take an independent action (scout ahead, secure supplies, etc.) at the cost of Exposure or Harm.
- **Off-Screen Solutions:** High-Cap followers (4-5) can solve significant travel problems once per downtime, but generate 1 SB for the party.

Regional Travel Decks

Each major region has a themed prompt list or card table (see §??):

Viterra Queendoom, Fen causeways, dike-brotherhoods, crown law.

Acasia Fallen Province, Border-lace titles, ruined towers, clan tempers.

Ecktoria City Province, Imperial roads, precinct gates, temple schedules.

Ubral Kingdom, Stone passes, toll-cloisters, ghosted fields.

Kahfagia Thalassocracy, Current maps, pilot-mirrors, storm lanes.

Aelinnel Realm of Aevrossa, Mist paths, bell-mounds, spirit ways.

Travel Complications

- **Hazards:** Weather, terrain challenges, wildlife encounters.
- **Social:** Border checks, local politics, cultural misunderstandings.
- **Supplies:** Food shortages, equipment failure, resource management.
- **Pursuit:** Being followed, hunted, or racing against time.

9.5 Narrative Time

Time is measured by *importance* rather than duration.

A Moment A glance, a strike, a whisper over a law-stone.

Some Time A skirmish, a negotiation, a careful climb.

Significant Time Hours of march, rites, audits, stakeouts.

Days Drills, recoveries, research, roadwork.

9.6 Social Interactions

Social scenes use the same engine with **cultural color**.

Cultural Skill Emphases

Viterra Rapport with parishes; Sway for markets; Command under writ.

Acasia Rapport for kin-bridges; Command with banner-rights; Deceive risks honor clocks.

Ecktoria Sway in salons; Deceive at court; Perform in temple fora.

Kahfagia Rapport aboard; Sway at piers; Command on a storming deck.

Social Stakes & Clocks

- **Alliance Clock (Viterra):** Parishes and guilds come to your side.
- **Honor Clock (Acasia):** Feasts, oaths, wyrd—trust builds (or frays).
- **Bureau Clock (Ecktoria):** Stamps, seals, approvals—delay is pressure.
- **Trust Clock (Kahfagia):** Pilots and crews extend favors and routes.

9.7 Supply and Resources

Track scarcity with a **Supply Clock** shared by the party's expedition.

Segments	State & Effects
0 (Full)	Well-provisioned; no penalty.
2 (Low)	Minor frictions; -1 to resource checks.
3 (Dangerous)	Each PC gains <i>Fatigue 1</i> .
4 (Empty)	Severe penalties; desperate measures.

9.7.1 Using Tags

Tags only function when *printed on a Talent, an Ability, or as the result of a Spell/Rite*. They do nothing on their own. Unless specified otherwise, **DV is set by fiction**, and duration defaults to **Scene**. When a Tag affects an **Outsider**, use the unified rules in §??.

9.7.1.0.1 Example: Disabling a Magical Trap (). A magical trap is represented by the tag. Its Difficulty Value (DV) to disable is usually the same DV used to cast or sustain the ward.

Approaches (examples).

- **Wits + Arcana:** analyze and unravel the binding.

- **Wits + Tinker:** mechanically bypass the trigger/anchor.
- **Body + Agility:** carefully avoid or physically disarm the trigger.

Position sets DV (Ladder).

- **Dominant** (ample time, proper tools, safe access): **DV 2**.
- **Controlled** (under pressure, limited time, partial access): **DV 3**.
- **Desperate** (activating/compromised access): **DV 4–5+** (GM sets by threat).

Talents & Tools. A relevant Talent or Tool may unlock an alternate approach or grant +1d / +1 Effect; proper tools may improve Position at the GM's discretion.

Outcomes.

- **Success:** the is suppressed, bypassed, or its trigger safely disarmed.
- **Partial:** the is affected but *unstable* or a new complication appears (GM may start/advance a related clock or spend SB for an intrusion).
- **Miss:** the remains and may trigger; generate SB as complications (backlash, mechanism damage, alarm to the creator, etc.).

9.8 Engaging the World—Player Actions

- **Scout & Signal:** A follower can make the next travel action *Dominant* (mark Exposure or Harm 1 on them).
- **Local Color:** Briefly state what locals notice about you; GM offers a small fictional edge *or* a tempting clock—choose.
- **Mark the Map:** On arrival, declare one change to the fiction (new ford, patron's shrine, toll-skip). GM may attach a minor clock as cost.
- **Asset Activation:** Spend 1 Boon to activate an asset dramatically during a scene.
- **Follower Assistance:** Have a follower assist your actions for bonus dice (max +3 from all sources).

9.9 Summary

The world has opinions. Movement is clocks and color, position rises and sinks with weather and words, and every suit you draw speaks in a regional accent. Ask the land for a favor—then pay it back on the road.

9.9.0.0.1 Remember: Every interaction with the world is an opportunity. Use your assets, deploy your followers, and engage with the setting actively. The world responds to your choices, and every journey changes both you and the places you pass through.

Chapter 10

Lore in Brief

1. Utar (The Utaran Imperium & Successor Northlands)

Overview

Once a vast empire, Utar fractured into a patchwork of successor states. Now, the north is a land of law, memory, and fading glory.

Key Regions (Revised)

- **Ecktoria** – The marble heart of the old empire. Temperate, borders Acasia (NE) and Kahfagia (W).
- **Acasia** – A broken realm of warlords and the city of Silkstrand. Northeast of Ecktoria, eastward to Vhasia.
- **Vhasia** – Fractured sun; a kingdom in name only. East of Acasia, west of Viterra; occupies a southern peninsula.
- **Viterra** – The last true kingdom, orderly and martial. Shares the peninsula with Vhasia, its eastern coast on the Blackwater.
- **Thepyrgos** – A city of stairs, learning, and high-elf enclaves. Southern peninsula, east across the Astroegro Straits from the Hyaar coast.

2. Kahfagia — The Empire of Wakes and Storm-Flags

Overview

A human maritime oligarchy that straddles the Titan's Throat. Kahfagia is a realm of trade, kraken-priests, and privateers.

Key Features

- Controls key sea lanes.
- Cities like **Kassamira** and **Stormspire** are centers of naval power.
- Lantern-law jurisdiction shifts with the tide.

3. Theona — The Marsh Crown

Overview

A trio of green isles off the eastern coast of Viterra. Theona is a place of quiet customs, feuds, and the “No Ninth” taboo.

Key Features

- Peat bogs, hedged fields, and small marble outcrops.
- Taboo of the Ninth: omissions, unspoken names, missing steps.
- Known for coracle fleets and the Moot Hill.

4. The Mistlands — Bells, Salt, and Breath

Overview

A fog-drenched breadbasket on the western shore of the Aberderrian Sea, guarded by dwarven law and ancient bell-lines. A frontier between the Direwood (west) and the civilized north.

Key Features

- Bell-line levees and reed-maze causeways.
- Warded by the Weeping Gate and Pall Watchtowers.
- Home to the Protectorate and the Legate of the Mists.

5. Valewood — The Forest That Remembers You Wrong

Overview

A living forest that shifts and forgets. The Valewood is an empire that never truly fell, full of fey remnants and relic-logic.

Key Features

- Phasing ruins, star-roads, and sentient trees.
- Inhabited by Lethai-ar (wood elves) and the fae-like Green Neighbors.
- Empire echoes: ancient laws and ruins still function.

6. Ykrul — Storm on the Steppe

Overview

Nomadic clans of horse-riders and raiders. The Ykrul live by omen, pasture, and blood-tanistry.

Key Features

- Seasonal migrations and clan confederations.
- Shamans and the Faith of the Open Sky.
- Known for dragon boats and the Kurultai councils.

7. Zakov — Salt & Serpent

Overview

A pirate haven and crime nexus on a Dolmis island. Controlled by the Seven Guilds, Zakov is lawless but ritualized.

Key Features

- Cities built from wrecks and stolen goods.
- The Pirate Syndicate and the Salt Prince rule in shadow.
- Known for the Serpent's Spine reef and the Crimson Docks.

8. Ubral — The Stone Between Spears

Overview

Highland clans, cairns, and iron oaths. Ubral is a land of shepherds, reivers, and hill-forts caught between Viterra and Vhasia.

Key Features

- Hill dwarves in Khaz-Vurim.
- Guest-right tokens and feud-brokering.
- Known for the Pass of Ashes and Dun Caerloch.

9. Linn — Skerries & Storm-Oaths

Overview

Southernmost Linnic tribes. A maritime culture of fjords, skerries, and dragon boats.

Key Features

- Raiders, fur-hunters, and riverfolk.
- Thing-holm and the Sea-Queen's court.
- Known for the Whale-road and the Volva of the Mist.

10. Aelinnel — Stone, Bough, and Bright Things (Averossa)

Overview

Gnomish homeland of Aevrossa, stone spires and moonlit groves. Averossa is a realm of charms, geasa, and tide-gates.

Key Features

- Tide-rift steps and dolmen stairs.
- Hedge-witches and oath-carvers.
- Known for the Green Gate and the Thorn Court.

11. Aelaerem — Hearth & Hollow (Amedell)

Overview

Halfling downs and orchards. Amedell is a quiet land of hearth-fires, orchards, and folklore.

Key Features

- Moot Oaks, hedge-witches, and mummers.
- Red thread motifs and quiet bells.
- Known for the Apple-Matron and the Pale Shepherd.

12. Aeler — Crowns & Under-Vaults

Overview

Dwarven mountain holds beneath the Aelerian peaks. Aeler is a realm of stone, breath, and ancient law.

Key Features

- Vaultmouth gates and under-roads.
- Spirit Shield Warriors and the High King Beneath the Peaks.
- Known for Khaz-Vurim and the Vault-Queen.

13. Black Banners — Condotta & Crowns

Overview

Mercenary lands and war camps. Black Banners is a frontier of shifting loyalties, condotta contracts, and frozen battlefields.

Key Features

- Condotta companies and the Bannerless One.
- War-camps and siege ruins.
- Known for the Singing Wastes and the Bone Fields.

14. Vilikari — Laurels & Longhouses

Overview

A federated frontier mixing Utaran law with barbarian custom. Vilikari is a land of two laws: wolf and eagle.

Key Features

- Foedus Stone and mixed courts.
- March towns and villa-forts.
- Known for the Queen of the Marches and the Dux's Palace.

15. The Wilds — Roads, Ruins, and Weather

Overview

Untamed lands that shift by biome. The Wilds are a reskin palette for any terrain—forest, desert, tundra, or coast.

Key Features

- Crossing points, shelter hollows, and old road traces.
- Forager children and roving war-bands.
- Known for lingering omens and elemental threats.

16. Tulkani — Road-Kin of the Ember Line

Overview

Nomadic clans of painted wagons and braided oaths. Once rooted, now scattered, the Tulkani call the road their homeland.

Key Features

- Wagon rings and fire-cults.
- Kuva of the Hearth-Road and the Family of the Raven Road.
- Known for songs for the living and bargains with dusk.

17. Ikari — First Plough, First Oath

Overview

Native tillers and smiths of the northern continent. The Ikari are a people of hearth and edge.

Key Features

- Tribes like Kreki (fishermen) and Smeinnoii (smiths).
- Ancestral fires and law-keepers.
- Known for seasonal raids and the Ondriti code.

18. Midh Adkaz — Where War Became a Market

Overview

A frontier camp turned crossroads city. Midh Adkaz is a place where oaths are traded like grain.

Key Features

- The Red Ditch and Stakefield fairground.
- The Six Hands council.
- Known for the Boar Gate and River Gate.

19. Haayr Peninsula — Anvils Between Two Seas

Overview

Mountain tongues and broken coasts. The Haayr Peninsula is a strategic chokepoint between seas.

Key Features

- Spine of Haayr mountains and limestone passes.
- Cities like Khar-Myra and Theressos.
- Known for the Hook Road and Pass of Ten Towers.

20. Dhahara — Monsoon of Empires

Overview

A land of oases, monsoons, and marching armies. Dhahara is a frontier where caravans meet fleets.

Key Features

- The Himdal Marches and Jade Oases.
- Cities like Sarvash and Thalara.
- Known for the Monsoon Bells and Incense Belt.

21. Oshiira — The Ledger Empire

Overview

A confederation of canals and ledgers. Oshiira is a realm of precision, irrigation, and the Spirit of the Long Sorrow.

Key Features

- Canal webs and numbered lines.
- The Mbari-style Senate and Prefects.
- Known for the Crimson Basin and Sekogo.

22. Sekogo — Where the Roads Meet the Tide

Overview

A crossroads of river and sea. Sekogo is a land of grove-masters, lagoon wardens, and the Tide Ledger.

Key Features

- Mbaro Quays and the Brasswater Row.
- Quay Syndicates and River Pilots.
- Known for the Circle of Unkwa and the Spice Shade.

23. Taharka — Monsoon Crown, Terrace Throne

Overview

A highland kingdom of canals, convoys, and coins. Taharka is a realm of water and stone.

Key Features

- Mkusaro Highlands and the Canal Collegium.
- Siatwe, the capital city of spiraling bazaars.
- Known for the Mint of Siatwe and meltwater courts.

24. Ameria — Between Bay and Throat

Overview

A divided realm between Kahfagia and the Titan's Throat. Ameria is a buffer of royal forms and neutral regencies.

Key Features

- Shoreless Bay and Throatward Ports.
- Khol-Amar and Cape Verdan.
- Known for Consular Row and the Neutral Regency.

25. Ngomebe — Stone Men of the Moving Cities

Overview

Ironworkers and wall-builders of Akilan. Ngomebe is a realm of walking cities and iron mothers.

Key Features

- Mkusaro ridges and Ekale Spurs.
- Khazembo and Duma-Sete.
- Known for the Mason-Kin Houses and Gate-Voices.

26. Ashaan — Gem of the Sea, Shadow on the River

Overview

A fallen slaver-empire. Ashaan is a land of sorcery, assassins, and the Three Sisters.

Key Features

- The Veiled, Helmed, and Masked Sisters.
- The Esoti and the Black Hand.
- Known for Galanina and the Shadows of Ashaan.

27. Sihai — The Central Kingdom, The Ordered Land

Overview

An immense, ancient empire of rigid hierarchy. Sihai is a land of the Son of Heaven and the Mandate of Heaven.

Key Features

- The Sihon River Basin and the Himadri Mountains.
- The Bureaucracy and the Warrior Monks.
- Known for the Imperial Army and the Hintara Ocean Coast.

28. Nihori — The Isles of the Dawn Spirit

Overview

A storm-wracked archipelago of clans, spirits, and samurai. Nihori is a realm of divine emperors and the code of Bushidō.

Key Features

- The Shōgun and the Daimyō.
- The Samurai and the Shinobi.
- Known for the Inland Sea and the Fire-Mountains.

29. Ayokha — The Monsoon Throne, The River of Heaven

Overview

A sprawling jungle kingdom of temples and monsoons. Ayokha is a land of the Devaraja and celestial bureaucracy.

Key Features

- The Sona River and the Jade Coast.
- War Elephants and the Royal Guard.
- Known for the Inner Jungle and monsoon-riding junks.

30. Alberriden Sea — Cold Mirror of the North

Overview

A brackish, iron-skied sea. The Alberriden is a mirror of the north, full of mist, mountain winds, and root-cellars.

Key Features

- The Yrolka Mouth and Brack Marsh Rim.
- Valewood Edge and Mistland Coast.
- Known for the Haravoa Shadow and Dwarf-cut harbors.

31. The Crimson Basin

Overview

A vast rainforest contested between wood elves and Oshiiran settlers. The Crimson Basin is a realm of rivers, treaties, and farm-forests.

Key Features

- The Enjwe Trunk and the Heartwood.
- Wood Elves and Oshiiran Basinfolk.
- Known for the Treaty of Three Waters and canoe-trains.

32. Linnstad

Overview

A northern city-state and fur-trade hub. Linnstad is the southernmost outpost of the Linnic tribes.

Key Features

- Claim to inventing dragon boats.
- Fierce, pragmatic culture.
- Known for the fur-trade and the Yrolka Mouth.

33. Rabelle

Overview

A mountain city of ore and gem wealth. Rabelle is a realm of red-haired Rabellans and giant ancestry.

Key Features

- Fine metalwork and dwarven trade.
- Treacherous pass toward the Mistlands.
- Known for blunt pride and mountain identity.

34. Northpass

Overview

A frontier town and gateway to the Mistlands. Northpass is a bare-bones outpost of vigilance.

Key Features

- The Ermine Inn and caravan stops.
- Carefully monitored by dwarves.
- Known for rough edges and the Mistlands beyond.

35. The Northern & Eastern City-States

Overview

Independent city-states, mountain strongholds, and coastal havens. These are bound by trade, survival, and necessity.

Key Features

- Independence and cultural blend.
- Dangerous, decadent, or dishonorable—but everyone trades.
- Known for the dangers and rewards of the frontier.

Amaranthine Coastway

Kahfagia → Ecktoria → Acasia → Marcott (Vhasia) → Fairport (Viterra).

Chapter 11

World Regions and Cultures

The world of *Fate's Edge* is a tapestry of ancient empires, emerging kingdoms, and untamed wilderness. This chapter surveys major regions and cultures that shape the setting—from the marble cities of Ecktoria to the mist-shrouded fields of Aelinnel. These frameworks are yours to adapt, blend, or reimagine.

11.1 The Amaranthine Inland Sea

At the heart of the known world lies the **Amaranthine Inland Sea**, a wind-gnarled waterway ringed by marble quays, vineyard hills, and smoke-blue mountains. For millennia it has served as the circulatory system of trade, faith, and conquest. Tides are subtle, but seasonal winds and river-feeds set the rhythm of commerce, pilgrimage, and war.

11.2 Northern Shore of the Amaranthine Sea

Ecktoria — The Uтарan Imperium Successor

Once the furnace of empire (*Marble & Fire*), Ecktoria remains a palimpsest of power: old stones bearing new banners, old laws written under fresh seals. Though imperial reach waned, its civic habits endure — a echo of late Roman/Byzantine grandeur, with provincial governors, standing bureaucracies, and ever-present legal codes.

Marble Cities Forums, amphitheaters, and aqueducts yet flow. District fountains double as public oaths guaranteed by guild charters.

Imperial Roads Mile-markers of white granite, way-shrines and customary tolls noted for couriers of the *Ashen Staves*.

Legal Legacy The **Uтарan Civic Codes** govern contracts, inheritance, and war-rights; local custom bends them under licensed *variance*.

Architectural Wonders Sun-bridges spanning deltas, the **Vault of a Thousand Maps**, and the **Amber Arch** petrified by alchemical storm.

Acasia — "The Broken Province"

Fallen Province. Frontiers braided from roads, rivers, and resentments — a land of petty kingdoms and free companies, reminiscent of the Welsh Marches or the post-Roman frontier. Here the outer seams of empire frayed first. Fortresses turned manors, manors turned townholds, and banners

multiplied like thistles after rain.

Petty Kingdoms Dozens of river-vales ruled by river-kings and banner-queens. Alliances shift with marriages, harvests, and omens.

Fortified Towns Walls for defense, not display. Gate-streets kink for ambush; towers carry horn-codes every child knows.

Mercenary Culture Free companies keep a *Black Ledger*: contracts fulfilled, oaths kept, debts paid.

Cultural Mix Imperial rites meet clan feasts; old gods share niches with civic saints. Exiles and second chances (*see* Silkstrand tales) are common.

Vhasia — "Old Vhasia & The Bloodlands"

Politically fractured kingdom of courtly intrigue and martial tradition, where ancient bloodlines vie for supremacy amid shifting alliances and ceremonial warfare. Travelers from across the Amaranthine often note its chivalric pageantry, its elaborate dueling codes, and its love of rhetoric — echoes of a certain western kingdom across the channel.

Fortress Castles Stone keeps crowned with gilded spires; courtiers plot in tapestried halls while knights train in courtyards.

Political Intrigue Complex web of alliances, vendettas, and ceremonial duels that settle matters of honor and succession.

Court Culture Elaborate ceremonies, patronage of arts, and rigid social hierarchies maintained through ritual and reputation.

Heraldic Traditions Complex system of banners, titles, and precedence that govern social interactions and military commands.

Thepyrgos

Province and capital city renowned as a center of learning, magic, and scholarly pursuit, where ancient towers house both wisdom and dangerous secrets. A blend of Byzantine bureaucracy and Mediterranean university culture — the City of a Thousand Stairs.

Scholarly Traditions Tower-cities where mages, philosophers, and researchers pursue knowledge in specialized colleges and scriptoriums.

Arcane Heritage Deep traditions of magical study, with libraries containing texts predating the fall of ancient empires.

Academic Rivalries Intense competition between schools of thought, often manifesting in formal debates, magical duels, or scholarly contests.

Mystical Dangers Forbidden knowledge and experimental magic that sometimes escape control, creating ongoing threats.

Viterra — "The Last Kingdom"

Realm that straddles the Dolmis and Amaranthine seas, known for its legalistic approach to governance and strategic river crossings. Its common law — the *Hedge-Law* — and its tradition of legal precedent evoke the courts of a certain misty island kingdom.

Hedge-Law Culture Complex system of legal precedents, tolls, and river rights that govern everything from trade to personal conduct.

Duchy System Semi-autonomous regions governed by dukes who maintain their own courts and

armies while owing fealty to the crown.

River Commerce Economy built around controlling strategic crossings, ferry rights, and maritime trade routes.

Legalistic Politics Intrigue centered on court cases, charter disputes, and the interpretation of ancient laws rather than open warfare.

Ubral — "The Stone Between Spears"

Highland realm of rugged clans and fortified holds, where honor culture and martial traditions dominate social interactions — a landscape of braes and glens, of cairns and clan feuds.

Clan Strongholds Fortified positions in mountain passes and high valleys, each clan maintaining its own laws and customs.

Honor Culture Society built around concepts of personal honor, family reputation, and the resolution of disputes through formal challenges.

Highland Warfare Military traditions emphasizing heavy infantry, defensive positions, and knowledge of mountain terrain.

Clan Loyalties Complex web of alliances, blood-feuds, and marriage pacts that shift with each generation.

Kahfagia — "The Empire of Wakes and Storm-Flags"

Maritime empire built on naval supremacy and exploration, where ship captains and merchant-adventurers shape both policy and culture — a Venetian-Portuguese hybrid, with lantern-law and pilot guilds ruling the waves.

Naval Supremacy Military and economic power based on controlling sea lanes, harbors, and maritime trade routes.

Explorer Culture Tradition of venturing into unknown waters, mapping new territories, and establishing trading posts.

Storm-Flag Protocol Complex system of maritime signals, weather prediction, and naval customs that govern seaborne activities.

Mixed Heritage Cosmopolitan society influenced by contacts with distant lands and diverse cultures encountered through exploration.

Theona — "The Marsh Crown"

Three island realms connected by causeways and maritime traditions, where wetland resources and naval culture define daily life. The grey skies, peat bogs, and ringforts of Theona echo the landscapes of ancient Éire — a land of high kings, saints, and folk horrors lurking beneath the mist.

Marsh Agriculture Sophisticated systems of dikes, canals, and floating gardens that support dense populations in wetland environments.

Island Culture Distinct traditions for each island, unified by shared maritime customs and inter-island trade.

Waterborne Commerce Economy based on fishing, water transport, and control of strategic waterways between islands.

Folk Horror Traditions Deep connection to marsh spirits, water deities, and ancient practices that blur the line between protection and appeasement.

The Mistlands — "Fields Under a Moving Sky"

Isolated region shrouded in perpetual mists, where ancient Aelerian protectorate status creates tension between autonomy and oversight. The Mistlands draw from Celtic and Breton folklore — a land of bells, standing stones, and the ever-present threat of what walks in the fog.

Mistbound Geography Landscape of bogs, waterways, and hidden settlements connected by causeways and boat paths.

Bell Culture Complex system of bells and wards must be maintained to keep the Direwood horrors at bay.

Isolation Tensions Cultural friction between desire for independence and practical need for trade and protection.

Ancient Secrets Ruins and artifacts predating the Aelerian protectorate, hinting at older civilizations and forgotten magics.

11.3 Peoples and Cultures

The peoples of Fate's Edge are many. Some trace their lineage to the earliest days of the Utaran Imperium; others arrived across the sea or emerged from the mist-hung valleys of the Direwood. What follows are the major cultural groupings — self-named and deeply particular. Outsiders may use simpler labels; the wise learn the names that people call themselves.

The Lethai — The Sundered Kin

The Lethai are the eldest of the mortal lineages, their memory stretching back before the fall of empires now forgotten. An ancient constraint divides them: no Lethai may bear both the Gift of the Body and the Gift of the Mind. From this sundering grew three distinct peoples, each with its own philosophy, homeland, and customs.

Lethai-al — "People of the Body" (Wood Elves)

The Lethai-al dwell in the **Valewood**, that ancient forest where roof-trees braid the sky and rivers think aloud. Their memory is arboreal — rings, seasons, coppice ledgers — and their oaths are *root-law*: debts counted in years, paid in living work. To outsiders they seem quiet; to neighbors they are relentless auditors of footprint and flow.

Forest Harmony Lifestyle integrated with woodland ecosystems, practicing sustainable hunting, gathering, and cultivation. They do not "use" the forest; they live within its clauses.

Body-Centric Philosophy Emphasis on physical experience, instinct, and the wisdom of sinew and breath over abstract thought. A Lethai-al proverb: *"The hand that fells the tree must plant the sapling."*

Living Magic Spellcasting works *with* natural forces, not against them — plant-speech, animal kinship, and the slow shaping of living wood.

Seasonal Rituals A calendar of ceremonies marking planting, harvest, and the winter quiet. Outsiders are welcome at the Autumn Trade Moot, but the Spring Rites are veiled.

Homeland The **Valewood** itself — no single capital, but shifting grove-courts and deep hollows where the oldest trees remember empire.

Lethai-thora — "People of the Mind" (High Elves)

The Lethai-thora make their homes in cities — chiefly **Thepyrgos**, the City of a Thousand Stairs — where they weigh arguments like bridges and translate other peoples' law into forms that carry.

Their courts count consequences; their speech is context-saturated and exact.

Scholarly Excellence Deep traditions of academic study, magical research, and philosophical debate. The Great Library of Thepyrgos holds texts that predate the Sundering.

Mind-Centric Philosophy Reason, logic, and the pursuit of abstract knowledge over physical concerns. A Lethai-thora axiom: *“A clean proof is worth a thousand swords.”*

Arcane Mastery Advanced magical techniques and theoretical understanding that often surpass other traditions. Many of the Free Casters’ foundational texts were penned by Lethai-thora hands.

Long Perspective Tendency to view problems and conflicts through the lens of centuries rather than immediate gain. This patience can be wisdom — or paralysis.

Homeland ****Thepyrgos**** and its satellite academies, with enclaves in other major cities where scribal work and jurisprudence are valued.

Lethai-ar — “The Oathbound” (Dark Elves)

The Lethai-ar are not a separate bloodline but a vow-bound cadre. They are Lethai-al or Lethai-thora who step off those paths to live under threshold patrons — ****Inaea**** the Weaver and ****Isoka**** the Serpent. In some ages they are scarce; in others — like the present — they gather wherever borders fray and oaths need teeth. They are known for *mask-right*, precise courtesies, and the unsettling efficiency of vows that bind places, routes, and roles.

Serpent Wisdom Followers of Isoka emphasize transformation, renewal, and the shedding of old identities for new growth. A shedding can be a cure, an escape, or a cruelty — context is all.

Spider Webs Devotees of Inaea focus on connections, patterns, and the weaving of fate through careful manipulation. Mercy with memory; knots that mend before they bind.

Philosophical Balance Neither inherently good nor evil, but representing alternative approaches to power and influence. A Lethai-ar may be a healer or a poisoner, a mediator or a cut-throat — the method, not the morality, defines them.

Cultural Rarity Uncommon in most settings, often viewed with suspicion or fascination. Their masks and vows unsettle those who prefer straightforward dealings.

Homeland No fixed homeland. They gather in ****mask-circles**** within other Lethai communities or in hidden enclaves near ancient thresholds.

The Aeler — People of Stone

The Aeler are the mountain-born, built like their peaks — layered, load-bearing, enduring. They call their home ****The Mountains****, ****Undermount****, or ****The Stonelands****; outsiders often say “Aelerian range,” but that is a cartographer’s convenience, not a name the Aeler use for themselves.

Stone-Sense Innate ability to understand and work with geological formations, making them master miners, architects, and engineers. An Aeler can read a tunnel’s stress like a human reads a face.

Clan System Complex social structure based on family lines, with intricate systems of honor, debt, and mutual obligation. Every clan keeps a ****Keystone Ledger**** — a record of favors owed and paid.

Craft Traditions Legendary skills in metalworking, stonework, and engineering refined over generations. Aeler steel is sought across the Amaranthine; Aeler bridges are the last to fall in a siege.

Underground Cities Vast complexes carved from mountain hearts, connected by tunnels and

halls that serve both practical and ceremonial purposes. The city of **Khaz-Vurim** is the oldest and greatest.

Deep Law Contracts are carved, not inked. A broken oath can be read in the stone for centuries. Justice is a matter of measurement — a tilted beam, a mis-weighted coin.

The Aelinnel — People of Sums

The Aelinnel dwell in **Aevrossa**, the hawthorn hills south of the Valewood — a land of living wood, worked stone, and air that tastes of mathematics. Their lives intertwine with **courtesy**, **copper**, and **count**.

Mathematical Culture Society built around complex calculations, probability, and the belief that all phenomena can be understood through numerical relationships. A bridge’s strength, a market’s price, a court’s verdict — all are sums.

Fey Logic Non-linear thinking patterns that seem illogical to outsiders but follow their own internal consistency. *“If you speak the ninth name, you must also speak the silence that follows it.”*

Mist Adaptation Unique abilities to navigate and manipulate the perpetual mists of Aevrossa. They read fog like a ledger, finding paths where others see only white.

Contract Culture Deep tradition of precise agreements, wordplay, and the careful crafting of obligations. Every bargain has two ledgers: what was *said* and what was *meant*.

Homeland **Aevrossa** — a realm of stone circles, antler-posts, and tide-cut stairs. Its capital is the **Hall of Aelinnel**, a timber keep threaded between standing stones.

The Aelaerem — People of the Hearth

The Aelaerem are a people of movement and assembly, living among gentle slopes and hedged lanes. Their homeland’s true name is **hushed** — they refer to it only with euphemisms, for to speak its old name is to invite the attention of the Neighbors. Outsiders may call it “the Halfling Downs” or “the Southern Valleys”; the Aelaerem smile and say nothing.

Euphemisms for the Homeland

The Aelaerem use many pseudonyms, each a quiet oxymoron that hides a darker truth:

Common Name	Hidden Meaning	Old Tongue
The Silent Welcome	“Welcome” = hospitality; “Silent” = calm, a gentle invitation. Sounds like a village festival.	<i>Rath-Gor</i> (“the binding mouth”) — the ancient seal where the Neighbors are held.
The Merry Maw	“Merry” = good cheer, feasting; “Maw” = a large gaping mouth. Sounds like a tavern name.	<i>Gor-Elen</i> (“the sealed mouth”) — the cursed cavern where eldritch doors are locked.
Stillwater (or The Still-Water)	“Still” = peace; “water” = life, farming. A common halfling landmark.	<i>Nok-Lur</i> (“the black source”) — an underground well that is actually a conduit to the other world.

The Quiet Hearth	“Hearth” = home, warmth; “Quiet” = serene, safe.	<i>Ael-Gren</i> (“the sealed fire”) — the ancient stone ring that locks the Neighbors away.
The Gentle Fold	“Fold” = a shepherd’s safe enclosure; “Gentle” = pastoral.	<i>Thar-Gur</i> (“the gnashing cleft”) — the fissure in the earth that serves as the “mouth” of the seal.

The Aelaerem themselves are warm, generous, and fiercely protective of their own — but their land hides a hunger. Hospitality is their public law; beneath it runs an older hedge-law of cup-marks, red thread, and the quiet attention of the Neighbors.

Hearth Culture Deep connection to home, family, and the maintenance of traditional ways. A red door promises bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest.

Agricultural Expertise Sophisticated farming techniques and seasonal celebrations that mark the rhythm of rural life. Their cider, wool, and beeswax are known across the Amaranthine.

Folk Horror Elements Dark undercurrents in seemingly peaceful communities, where hospitality can become a trap and tradition carries hidden costs. The Neighbors are always watching.

Community Defense Strong traditions of mutual aid and collective action when the community is threatened. When the bells ring, every Aelaerem takes up a tool or a weapon.

Other Peoples — “Beyond the Old Roads”

The lands beyond the Amaranthine and the Aelerian passes hold many other folk. Some are recent arrivals; others are ancient survivors of forgotten cataclysms.

Nomadic Tribes Various peoples who follow seasonal patterns across steppes, deserts, and other marginal lands. The ***Ykrul*** are the most numerous, but they are far from alone.

Coastal Peoples Maritime cultures that live in harmony with ocean environments and maintain their own naval traditions. The ***Linn*** and ***Zakov*** corsairs, the ***Kahfagian*** pilots, and the island clans of the ***Dolmis***.

Border Cultures Mixed communities that arise where different major cultures meet, creating unique hybrid traditions. The ***Vilikari*** straddle empire and steppe; the ***Acasian*** marches brew their own fierce independence.

Ancient Survivors Remnants of older civilizations that persist in isolated regions, maintaining forgotten knowledge and customs. The ***Mistlands*** bell-wardens, the ***Theonan*** marsh-kings, and the silent watchers of the ***Direwood***.

11.4 Regional Specialties and Resources

Climate and Biomes of the Amaranthine

The Amaranthine Inland Sea is ringed by fertile coasts, rolling hills, and mountain ranges. Unlike the arid southern shores of Old Earth’s middle sea, the wind patterns here reverse — the hot, dry air of the Sahel belt is pushed south, leaving the northern and eastern shores with ample rainfall and the southern shores as temperate grasslands. Thus, the lands around the Amaranthine are lush and productive, from the olive groves of Ecktoria to the wheat fields of Acasia to the horse pastures of the Vilikari steppe.

Economic Strengths by Region

Ecktoria Marble, legal services, grain, olive oil, wine, purple dye (murex), glassworks, coinage. Ecktoria's marble quarries supply the entire sea. Its law courts and coin-houses handle contracts for half the continent. The purple dye, extracted from sea snails along the Sun Coast, is worth its weight in silver.

Acasia Cattle, horses, wool, iron, salt, mercenary contracts, border tolls. The Broken Marches are poor in coin but rich in livestock and metal. Its free companies are the finest light cavalry in the known world. The salt pans of the western marches supply the interior.

Vhasia Wine, timber, stone, cloth (linen and wool), illuminated manuscripts, tapestries. The river valleys of Vhasia produce excellent vintages; its forests provide oak for shipbuilding. The scriptoria of its abbeys are famed for their calligraphy and illuminated manuscripts.

Thepyrgos Scholarly texts, magical reagents, glassware, precision instruments, silk (imported and finished), philosophical schools. The City of a Thousand Stairs is a hub of learning; its universities license thaumaturgical research. The glassblowers of Thepyrgos produce lenses and astrolabes unmatched anywhere.

Viterra Tin, copper, wool, tin-glazed pottery, legal charters, insurance contracts, river tolls. The river crossings of Viterra control trade between the inland sea and the northern ocean. Its duchy courts are famous for settling disputes without bloodshed — usually.

Ubral Lead, silver, slate, hardy mountain sheep (wool and cheese), whisky, mercenary mountaineers. The high clans of Ubral mine the peaks for silver and lead; their whisky is legend. Their clansmen are sought as scouts and skirmishers in mountain warfare.

Kahfagia Shipbuilding, naval stores (pitch, tar, sailcloth), spices (imported), exotic woods, dyes (indigo, cochineal), potatoes, maize, tomatoes. The Kahfagian fleets control the western sea lanes. Their merchants bring goods from across the “west lands” — new world crops that have revolutionized agriculture in recent centuries.

Linn Fish (dried and salted), whale oil, amber, walrus ivory, furs, raiding, ship-tolls. The Linn skerries are rich in marine resources. Their longships carry furs from the northern forests and amber from the Baltic coasts.

Theona Citrus fruits, olive oil, pottery (amphorae), salt, peat, glass beads, star-compasses. The three islands of Theona produce citrus oils and fine ceramics. Their star-compasses, crafted in the cliffside observatories, are essential for deep-sea navigation.

Mistlands Peat, bog iron, fog-pollen ink, mistglass (humming glass), woven fog-wool, herbal remedies (nightshade, feverfew, belladonna). The Mistlands are resource-poor but materially unique. Mistglass — glass that sings in storms — is prized by sea captains. Fog-wool, harvested from mist-spirits, is impossibly light and warm.

Zakov Ship salvage, black market goods, exotic poisons, reef coral, pearls, smuggled luxuries. The pirate-city of Zakov lives on stolen cargo and “found” wrecks. Its coral reefs yield pearls and rare sea silks. No question too dark, no cargo too illicit — for the right price.

Vilikari (Frontier Marches) Horses, leather goods, horn, bone, honey, wax, mercenary light cavalry. The Vilikari straddle the steppe and the sown. Their horses are swift and hardy; their honey and wax are traded across the marches. Vilikari light horse are the eyes of any army.

Ykrul (Steppe Nomads) Horses (the finest), hides, wool felt, dairy products (cheese, yogurt), dried meat, amber, captive trade (slaves, though the Ykrul themselves dislike the term and practice limited bondage). The Ykrul herds are the wealth of the Violet Steppe. Their horses are exported as far as Silkstrand. Amber found in river deposits is carved into amulets and beads.

Unique Products (Expanded)

- **Ecktoria:** *Purple marble* (only from the Imperial Quarry), *ceramic plumbing* (self-cleaning clay pipes), *state bonds* (negotiable instruments guaranteed by the Ecclesiarchy of the Everflame).
- **Acasia:** *Curse-iron* (cold iron from the Blackwood, which drips rusty water when near fae or undead), *hedge-knight contracts* (bought and sold like commodities on the exchange at Silkstrand).
- **Vhasia:** *Illuminated bestiaries* (some of which move or speak), *vengeance wine* (fermented with grape leaves from a murdered man's vineyard — said to carry his spirit).
- **Thepyrgos:** *Echo glass* (panes that repeat the last words spoken before them), *thousand-step tea* (a brew that sharpens the mind for exactly one thousand heartbeats).
- **Viterra:** *Hedge-law scrolls* (legal documents that quietly update their clauses as circumstances change), *river silver* (coins minted from electrum found only in the Belworth).
- **Ubral:** *Whisky of the Twelve Clans* (aged in lead-lined casks, gaining a faint, sweet toxicity that drinkers call “the bite”), *slate that echoes* (roofing tiles that repeat the sounds of a house's history).
- **Kahfagia:** *Storm-flags* (banners that predict weather by changing color), *lantern-glass* (treated glass that glows for a year after one night's exposure to the order's beacons).
- **Linn:** *Whale-bone runes* (divination tools that must be moistened with blood or saltwater to work), *frost silk* (spider silk harvested from ice caves, nearly invisible and unbreakably cold).
- **Theona:** *Star-compasses* (brass instruments that point to the nearest shrine of the Navigator Saint), *amphorae of silence* (clay jars that, when broken, create a zone of magical quiet for one minute).
- **Mistlands:** *Fog-pollen ink* (invisible except under a lantern or when breathed upon), *mistglass humming* (each glass has its own tone; shattering one creates a sound that can be heard from a mile away).
- **Zakov:** *Black coral amulets* (ward against drowning), *songs of the reef* (knot-coded messages that only other pirates can read), *pearl of forgetfulness* (grants one short-term memory erasure when crushed).
- **Vilikari:** *Horse-hide scrolls* (waterproof and nearly indestructible), *blood-honey* (mead made with honey from hives that fed on corpse-flowers; potent and hallucinogenic).
- **Ykrul:** *Kon'reh boards* (carved stone or ivory game boards whose pieces move according to mathematical rules), *wake-ropes* (enchanted ropes that float and can be used to tie two moving objects together mid-gallop).

Trade and Resource Clocks

Certain resources can be tracked with clocks to create economic pressure:

- **Grain Price (4):** If supply drops, riots in cities; if oversupply, farmers rebel.
- **Salt Monopoly (6):** Control of salt pans gives leverage over an entire region.
- **Fleet Readiness (6):** A naval power's ability to project force.
- **Market Scrip (4):** Confidence in paper currency; collapse leads to barter.

11.5 Travel and Trade

Major Routes (Reference)

Amaranthine Coastway Sea-corridor linking Theona, Linn, Zakov, Kahfagia, and Ecktoria. Sheltered anchorages every fifty miles. Seasonal winds run clockwise.

Astroegro Straits The narrows between Thepyrgos and the northern shore. Pilot-ruled; tolls vary by the tide, the weather, and the pilot's mood.

River Roads Grain and scrip from interior markets to sea. The Belworth, the Yloka, and the Acadian rivers are the main arteries.

Aelerian Passes Underways Vault-routes beneath the peaks. Sealed in deep winter, but in summer they offer the safest passage east–west.

Kahfagian Sea Lanes Goods from across the “west lands” — potatoes, maize, cochineal, and stranger wares. Dangerous, but the profits are legendary.

The Way of Silk Overland routes from the far east, ending in Silkstrand. Caravans take two years to cross the steppe and the mountains.

Shadow Corridors Liminal shortcuts near the Ways Between. Risky, fast, and never the same twice. A day's travel may be an hour — or a month.

Travel Considerations

- **Road Quality:** Utaran imperial highways still exist in Ecktoria and parts of Vhasia. Further east, they become gravel, cart-ruts, or mere tracks. In the Mistlands, the “road” is a causeway of reeds and stone that floods at each tide.
- **Bridges & Ferries:** Every crossing is a toll point. Some bridges are magical — they only open to certain keys or at certain hours. Ferries may be rowed by the living — or by the dead.
- **Seasonality:** The Amaranthine is navigable year-round, but winter storms can close the straits. Mountain passes close from First Snow to Spring Thaw. The steppe is impassable during the spring melt (rasputitsa).
- **Safe Havens:** Caravanserais are common along the Way of Silk. In the north, monasteries offer shelter. On the coast, lighthouse-cloisters owe aid to shipwrecked sailors by ancient charter.
- **Customs and Quarantines:** Entering a new region often requires papers — a safe-conduct, a merchant seal, or a ritual cleansing. The Mistlands may quarantine travelers for three days to ensure they are not possessed by fog-spirits.

11.6 Regional Clocks and World Response

Tie adventures to **clocks** that change the map when they fill. Each clock is a narrative front; when it fills, the region's situation escalates.

- **Grain Shortage (4):** If filled, food riots reshape a Theonan city's politics. May spawn a famine if left unchecked.
- **Banner-Muster (6):** Steppe tribes unify under a Khagan. Caravans demand new terms; raids increase; travel becomes dangerous.
- **Harbor Scrip Crash (4):** Trade letters lose value; smugglers thrive; debts are called in. Banks may fail, and noble houses may fall.
- **Fog-Roused (6):** Mistland spirits awaken. Bells fail at night; offerings must be increased. The Direwood's influence spreads.
- **Stone-Press (6):** Aeler deep mines begin a slow, ticking collapse. Ventilation fails; old tunnels seal; clans feud over responsibility.
- **Chevauchée (4):** Vhasian war-bands ride. Border villages burn; the king's justice is distant. Mercenary companies profit.
- **Reef Shift (6):** Zakov's coral reefs shift, exposing new wrecks — and closing old passages. Salvage rights become a blood sport.

GM Story Beats may *tick* these when the party's choices strike regional nerves: missed payments, broken oaths, loud magic, conspicuous success, or even a well-timed rumor.

11.7 Cultural Practices and Customs

Languages and Cant

- **Utaran High** (court, law, scholarship; spoken in Ecktoria, Thepyrgos, and by educated elites across the sea).
- **River Cant** (trade pidgin with gesture-signs; used on the Amaranthine and major rivers).
- **Steppe Tongues** (whistled across distance; each clan has its own variations).
- **Sea-Patter** (mariners' clipped code; used by Linn, Zakov, and Kahfagian sailors).
- **Bell-Speech** (Mistlands only; tones and rhythms of bells convey legal and spiritual messages).
- **Hedge-Law Notation** (Viterra and parts of Vhasia; legal abbreviations written in the margins of charters).

Religious Patterns

- **Temple & School** (Theona): Ethical schools blend with temple tithes; festivals mark navigation seasons. Pilgrims walk causeways at low tide.
- **Ancestor Poles** (Vilikari): Kin-spirits seated at feasts; oaths taken under the watch of names. The poles are carved with lineages stretching back centuries.
- **Sky & Earth** (Steppe): Wind-knots bound, libations poured into the first hoofprint. The Ykrul revere the Violet Sky and the endless grass.
- **Sea-Rites** (Linn/Zakov): Weather judgments witnessed by storm-priests. Offerings of salt and silver are thrown overboard before a voyage.
- **The Everflame** (Ecktoria, Thepyrgos, parts of Vhasia): Cults of the Eternal Fire, with lamp-tenders and ash-priests. Judgment by flame is a common legal ordeal.
- **Fog Faiths** (Mistlands): Bells and fog-names soothe fears; spiritualists mediate with the grey things. The dead are not buried — they are rung away.

Law and Custom

- **Utaran Codes**: Contracts, inheritance, civic duties; licensed *variance* lets local custom lean the written law. Common in Ecktoria, Thepyrgos, and former imperial provinces.
- **Clan Law** (Acasia, Vilikari, Ubral, Ykrul): Oath-payment by cattle, steel, or service-days. Blood price is fixed for each injury; the victim's clan must accept it or escalate.
- **Merchant Law**: Arbitration by bonded factors; ledgers sealed in wax and salt. Defaulting on a debt inscribed in a Factor's Ledger is a crime in every port.
- **Hedge-Law** (Viterra, parts of Vhasia): Precedents set by parish juries and traveling justices. A hedge decree is binding until the next quarter court.
- **Lamp-Law** (Mistlands, Kahfagian lantern precincts): Rules enforced by the lighting or extinguishing of public lamps. A dark lane is a legal vacuum.

11.8 Magic and Attitude by Region

- **Ecktoria**: Licensed thaumaturges file *Casting Notices* for urban work; unfiled magic draws fines — and Everflame attention. Magic is seen as a civic utility, like plumbing.
- **Acasia**: Folk-wards respected; visible sorcery can start a levy. Hedge witches are tolerated; university mages are viewed with suspicion.

- **Aeler:** Rituals fold into craft; backlash treated like a cracked beam — fix it, document it, and pay the guild fine. Magic is a trade like any other.
- **Mistlands:** Bells and fog-names soothe fears; spiritualists mediate with the grey things. Unlicensed magic is punished by servitude to the bell-wardens.
- **Linn / Zakov:** Weather rites must be witnessed by three wind-bearers; false rites are crimes against the ship. Magic at sea is tightly regulated by the storm-priests.
- **Thepyrgos:** Academics argue about proper magical forms. Unorthodox casting is not illegal — merely unfashionable — and can ruin a scholar’s reputation.
- **Vhasia:** The Church of the Flame distrusts arcane magic; secular lords employ court mages anyway. A delicate balance of public condemnation and private patronage.
- **Viterra:** Hedge-magic is common and unregulated; any thaumaturgy that leaves a trace must be registered with the local sheriff. Penalties are fines, not prison.
- **Kahfagia:** The Lantern-Law tolerates magic that assists navigation or commerce. Weather magic is licensed; necromancy is punished by drowning.
- **Ubral:** Mountain clans view magic as a weapon, not a tool. Outsider mages are watched; clan shamans are respected but feared. The death penalty for using magic to steal clan property.
- **Vilikari:** Mixed attitudes — some clans employ shamans; others see magic as dishonorable. The Federate King has a court astrologer but no official battle mages.
- **Ykrul:** The Kon’reh masters treat magic as geometry; precise, bounded, and ethically neutral. Wild magic is distrusted; the Wake-law forbids raising the dead.

11.9 Creating Regional Adventures

Using Regional Characteristics

Consider:

- How geography shapes travel and pursuit (mountains, rivers, passes, seasons).
- Which customs open doors (or close them) — guest-right, safe-conduct, charter.
- Which tensions tick **clocks** — feuds, famines, heresies, succession.
- Which resources (salt, steel, scrip, secrets) define stakes.

Mixing Regional Elements

- **Tin vs. Tide:** Aeler miners accuse a port-city of short-weighted scales. The conflict escalates from court to blockade.
- **Festival of Threads:** Islanders, Steppe riders, and Heartlanders trade rites and insults under watchful magistrates. A murder must be solved without violating the festival’s truce.
- **Fog and Fire:** A Mistlands relic surfaces in a Theonan auction; three factions bid with more than coin — and one bids with a curse.
- **The Unquiet Map:** An Aeler survey contradicts an old border. Whose truth stands? The stones speak, but they speak in riddles.

Regional Adventure Seeds

Mistlands Mystery (Clock 4: Bells Go Silent)

- Dusk bells falter. Tracks end at a mirror-pool that shows tomorrow's sky.
- *Complications (SP)*: Fog names stolen; a bell-tree cracks; a reed altar burns cold.
- *Resolution*: Offer a true name to the pool or re-hang the broken bell with copper nails.

Broken Marches Conflict (Clock 6: Valley Claim)

- Two lords court your company. One keeps books; one keeps graves tidy. Both want the same mill.
- *Complications (SP)*: Ambush at witness trees; the Black Ledger demands a tithe; a feud token is planted in your pack.
- *Resolution*: Settle the dispute by duel, by ledger audit, or by destroying the mill entirely.

Stone Kingdom Discovery (Clock 6: Archive Wakes)

- An echo-vault opens to song. Memory-stones argue *with each other* about who owns the ore.
- *Complications (SP)*: Rival charter; a cracked beam of magic; miners strike for better rites.
- *Resolution*: Decode the old arguments, forge a consensus, or collapse the gallery and start anew.

Theona Trade War (Clock 4: Harbor Scrip Collapse)

- Watermarks sing wrong. A counterfeit choir spreads false coin across three islands.
- *Complications (SP)*: Dock riot; lighthouse shutters locked; a patron's legal *variance* revoked.
- *Resolution*: Find the counterfeit master, destroy the press, or redeem the scrip with a cargo of star-compasses.

11.10 Adapting Regions to Your Campaign

These regions are *frameworks*. Rename, splice, or tilt them toward your tale:

- Merge Mistland bells with island wind-courts to create *storm-bell law*.
- Let the Merchants' Concord adopt steppe arbitration; settle contracts at a gallop.
- Tie your party to a **regional clock** — when it fills, the map, and your story, change.
- Swap resources: maybe the Mistlands have amber instead of peat; maybe Acasia exports tin.
- Introduce a new region — the “Inner Lake” — by borrowing from the cultures above.

Remember: the world should *answer* the players. Roads reroute around their deeds; bells ring differently after they pass; ledgers carry their names in salt. The resources they seize, the trade they disrupt, the customs they honor or break — all of it echoes.

11.11 Aeler — People of Stone, Breath, and Ledger

Background: The Mount-Born Engineers

Built like their mountains—layered, load-bearing, and enduring—the Aeler are masters of infrastructure, subtle influence, and the deep mathematics of survival. In their underground holds, a lantern’s hue is a balance sheet; a bell-note means more than a shout. They call this discipline **deep accounting**: air tallied by vent-shafts, lamp-time written in chalk, calories measured in the language of ovens.

Above ground, their influence is felt but not always seen. Their work—bridges that do not fail, levees that answer one key, ovens that feed thousands—acts as the hidden bones of cities. They do not conquer through banners, but through the gate that must be paid, the bridge that “politely rests” if its clause is broken, and the surety of grain that keeps a quarter from starving.

11.11.0.0.1 Key Cultural Concepts

- **Tally-Law**: If it isn’t written, it isn’t owed; if it cannot bear weight, it isn’t promised.
- **Keystone Rights**: Control the piece that holds the whole. Maintenance for access; repair for rate.
- **Grain Surety**: Winter ovens and storage domes under public charter; price courts on marked days.
- **Water & Flood**: Sluice-math is power. They lease keys, not walls; a city opens for trade faster than an army can take it.
- **Mint & Measure**: Calibrated weights and indelible dies. When coins bear Aeler marks, courts sharpen.

Racial Skill Increase

Choose one:

1. **Stone & Breath**: +1 die to **Craft**, **Tinker**, and **Survival** when dealing with infrastructure, construction, or resource management. In underground or dense-urban environments, gain **Position** +1 to navigate, maintain, or sabotage systems.
2. **Deep Accounting**: Once/scene, spend 1 **Boon** to *audit* a situation—ask one question about hidden resources, costs, or dependencies; the GM answers truthfully.

Thematic Attribute

Increase either **Body** or **Wits** by 1 (to a max of 5). **Spirit** and **Presence** unchanged.

Talent: Vent Prior’s Training (3 XP)

Req: **Craft** 1+, **Wits** 2+

- +1 die on checks involving air quality, ventilation, structural integrity, or underground navigation.
- You know the *Nine Measures* (light, draft, echo, dust, taste of iron, sweat-chill, lamp-shadow, bell-lag, head-ache). With a **Wits** + **Notice** test (DV 3), detect hidden passages or environmental hazards.
- Once/scene, *read a structure like a ledger*: +1 die to understand its construction, weaknesses, or maintenance needs.

Cultural Mechanics

Deep Drakes & Stone-Press (Complication)

Stone-press—pressure that thinks—warps sums and senses.

- **Fronts:** *Stone-Press* [6], *Miasma Spread* [4], *Vent Failure* [4].
- **In Play:** Failures on perception/planning underground may generate SB that tick these Fronts or impose *Condition* or hallucination tests.

Tally-Law (Social/Legal)

- **Oaths:** Breaking a formal oath ticks *Repute 1* and creates *Feud +1*.
- **Boasts & Sagas:** A public boast creates *Audience: Expectant*; fulfill it for *Repute +1*; fail and mark *Exposure* or *Feud*.
- **Etiquette Hooks (once/scene, Aeler venues):** Present guest-loaf and a lit lantern at a threshold to shift your next social action *one step safer* while you remain a guest. Covering iron or stepping on stone cancels the first SB from rites/negotiations this scene.

Strings & Tools

- **Keystone Tablet:** Establish or pause a route; once/scene, convert a chase into a prepared stand: defenders gain **Position +1**.
- **Null-Bell:** On ring, cancel one psychic push/compel; costs lamp-time (mark gear wear or Fatigue).
- **Oven Charter Seal:** Force a public bowl in markets—one round of fair-price negotiation before violence may escalate.
- **Sluice Key:** **DV 1** on operations hinging on water/flood/sanitation; abuse creates *Public Outrage* [4].
- **Air Scrip:** Negate the first suffocation/miasma consequence underground in a leg; on use, tick *Vent Failure* [1].

Display Rights (Status)

- **Display Charter:** Licensed marks (metal trim, lamp-halos, keystone etching) show public contribution. Fraud draws fines in grain or labor.
- **Rings of Account:** Bands on tools/belts denote kept contracts: water, bread, bridge, mint. Three rings grant first voice in oven courts.
- **Quiet Wealth:** Private hoard without public work is suspect; unworked shine invites auditors.
- **At the table:** Present a valid Display Writ to gain **Position +1** in civic negotiations once/scene; on a miss, start *Audit Clock* [4].

Orders & Companies (Factions)

- **Iron Avengers:** Traditionalists who enforce blood-feuds inscribed on keystones.
- **Spirit Shield Warriors:** Ancestor-venerating guards with mask-helms etched in lineage prayers.
- **True Masons:** Wanderers who repair ancient Aeler work.
- **Edgewalkers:** Border scanners who hunt for the profitable gap.
- **Reform Lodges:** Foothill freeholds and city cells arguing for gentler contracts with neighbors.

Example boons/risks: Mason's Oath, Edgewalker Marker, Gray List Token, Mask Rights Forfeit.

Soft Power: Keystone Diplomacy & Infrastructure Sovereignty

Aeler influence travels by *charter, standard, and switch*, not by spear.

- **Standards Bind:** *Mint & Measure* make markets legible. Cities that adopt Aeler weights gain stable prices—and accept Aeler audit halls. *In play:* presenting stamped measures grants **DV 1** to enforce contracts or expose fraud.
- **Oven Charters:** *Grain Surety* keeps winters calm. Charter Days obligate fair-pricing courts before force. *In play:* invoke an Oven Charter Seal to require one round of negotiation; cancel the first riot SB this scene.
- **Water Keys:** *Sluice guilds* lease flow, not walls. Trade booms when gates open; siege starves when they close. *In play:* exchanging a Sluice Key with a civic body banks *Public Gratitude* [2]; abuse flips it to *Outrage* [4].
- **Keystone Clauses:** Bridges and gates include *rate-for-repair*. Default pauses service “politely” until arrears are paid. *In play:* once/scene, declare a keystone pause to impose **Effect 1** on enemy movement or logistics.
- **Air & Sanitation:** *Vent courts* and wasteflows curb plague. The city that breathes owes the hand that tuned the vents. *In play:* with plans and access, Aeler gain **Position +1** to quell disease/panic clocks.
- **Apprentice Exchanges:** Sending masters abroad seeds techniques and loyalties. *In play:* spend a season contact to treat a foreign workshop as Friendly for one operation.
- **Null-Bells & Audit Halls:** Disciplined speech zones deter panic and glammers. *In play:* ringing a null-bell suppresses one social *fear/panic* tag for an exchange.

11.11.0.0.2 Soft-Power Clocks

- *Public Gratitude* [4] → discounts, calm crowds, smoother permits.
- *Audit Clock* [4] → fines, seizures, reputational scars if you flaunt standards.
- *Co-Prosperity* [6] → shared surpluses, joint projects, mutual defense clauses.

Suggested Bonds & Complications

11.11.0.0.3 Bonds

- **Mason-Brother:** Minor edge on structural assessments/repairs and a contact in a lodge.
- **Vent-Prior’s Apprentice:** Guidance in underground survival; access to holds.
- **Oven-Warden’s Acquaintance:** Insight into grain courts; leverage in hungry quarters.
- **Sluicewarden’s Debt:** A water-math favor owed—potential flood control or redirected trade.

11.11.0.0.4 Complications

- **Stone-Press Susceptibility:** In deep stress underground, test **Spirit** (DV 3) or suffer -1 die to tasks from pressure-sickness.
- **Ledger Dependency:** Separated from records > 1 day: **Position 1** on planning/resource management until re-synced.
- **Surety Obligation:** You guaranteed resources to a community. Fail to deliver: mark 2 segments on *Obligation* (or take a lasting Complication).

11.12 Aelinnel — People of Sums, Bough, and Bright Things

Background: Gnomes of Stone, Bough, and Bright Things

The Aelinnel dwell in the hawthorn hills south of the Valewood, their lives intertwined with living wood, worked stone, and precise mathematics. Halls run like veins through granite and thorn; bridges hum when tuned; bargains arrive on two ledgers—what was *said*, and what was *meant*. To walk their country is to feel math underfoot: steps safer when even, doors opening to right sequence, moonlight that prefers tidy logic.

They are fae-kin cousins to the Lethai, smaller in stature, bright-eyed and quick. Society rests on **Courtesy, Copper, and Count**. Count or be counted. Speak your steps, breaths, or stitches and the land steadies. Favor copper before the courts; copper is polite, naked iron is an insult unless named or gilded. Recite a simple sequence when tension frays to cancel the first misstep in navigation or negotiation.

11.12.0.0.1 Law of Sums Proceedings in hawthorn courts require three clean courtesies: *no naked iron*; *two-ledger speech* (said & meant); and *return what points the way* (cords, marks, antlers). Keep these and even thorns hold back; slight them and arches close, time drifts, and messages arrive folded and misaddressed.

Racial Skill Increase

Choose one:

1. **Copper Courtesy & Counting Etiquette:** Once/scene, careful counting shifts **Position** +1 for a patterned action (locks, paths, ritual speech). In fae-facing scenes, presenting copper or brass tools negates the first offense penalty.
2. **Two-Ledger Talk:** When you clearly state both *said* and *meant*, you may cancel the first social **SB** against you this scene. If you refuse, the next bargain seeks collateral (memory or name, at the GM's discretion).

Thematic Attribute

Increase either **Wits** or **Spirit** by 1 (to a max of 5). **Body** and **Presence** unchanged.

Size & Equipment Limits

Aelinnel stature and leverage limit heavy kit.

- **Restriction:** Aelinnel *cannot* wield **Heavy** weapons or wear **Heavy** armor. They may freely use **Light** and **Medium** weapons/armor suited to their frame.
- **Design Note (at the table):** Attempts to circumvent with makeshift rigs are treated as fiction-only stunts; if allowed, apply **Position** -1 and **DV** +2 and remove any benefits from the *Finesse* tag.

Talents

Long Memory (3 XP — Minor)

Req: **Spirit** 2+

- Perfect recall of the last week's events.
- +1 die to **Lore** and **Insight** when drawing on historical/cultural detail.

- **Once/session**, surface a crucial long-term detail the GM must render truthfully (scope: a person, place, or clause you directly encountered).

Cold Reading (3 XP — Minor)

Req: **Wits** 2+, *Long Memory*

- +1 die to **Sway** and **Insight** from close observation.
- With **Wits** + **Insight** (DV 3), infer a motive or pressure the target is concealing.
- **Once/scene**, if you observed quietly for a beat, gain **Position** +1 on your first parley in that scene.

Cultural Mechanics

Hawthorn Halls & Law of Sums

Paths are counted by antler-posts; tide-cut stairs descend to black sea-rifts; causeys of pale flags show at dawn, at dusk—and whenever someone is counting aloud.

- **Counting Etiquette**: Once/scene, careful count grants **Position** +1 for patterned action.
- **Copper Over Iron**: In fae-facing scenes, copper/brass tools negate the first offense penalty.
- **Two-Ledger Talk**: Stating both *said* and *meant* cancels the first social **SB** this scene.
- **Hazel Favors**: Earned by restoring way-things (antlers, cords, ferry rights). **Once/leg**, spend to downgrade a glamour/geas.

People of Stone & Bough

Charcoal-burners read omen by smoke hums; stone-singers soothe walls with low chords; wardens hammer copper nails where iron offends; goat-herds measure danger in hoof-widths.

- **Markets Under Living Roofs**: Weights and measures matter—producing a certified rod cancels the first jurisdiction/commerce snag in that market.
- **Reputation Echoes**: Return way-cords, restore antlers, pay tide-dues to bank *Hazel Favors*.

Courts, Hunts, and Gates

Aelinnel powers are etiquette engines and logic traps more than tyrants.

- **Lady of Thorns**: Punishes breaches precisely; rewards perfect sequences.
- **Green Knight**: Duels by paths and proofs, not boasts.
- **Moonlit Ride**: Grants one night's clemency if you name the right horn-count.
- **Green Gate**: Demands exact change in truths before it opens.

Tides, Ledgers, and Names

Rivers and sea-caves carry their own arithmetic.

- **Tide-Reeves**: Filing plans before neap earns a Tide Window; skip the ledger and your next crossing suffers *Wrong Tide*.
- **Seals & Hours**: Neglected barge seals invite *Wrong Hour*.
- **Said/Meant Receipts**: Some stalls require dual receipts; single-ledger haggling risks a surcharge payable in memory or name.

Aelinnel Mood: Dark-Wonder

Paths shorten for those who keep count and lengthen for the proud. Petals fall like knives and settle into proofs; antler-posts rearrange themselves when the land takes offense. Time miscounts, and the

sun arrives at the wrong hour with excellent logic.

Strings & Tools

- **Antler-Post Bead:** **Once/scene**, treat a wild path as *Signed*: **DV 1** to Traverse.
- **Counting Cord:** When stretched and tapped in sequence, grants **Position +1** on one trap/lock sequence.
- **Copper Nail Kit:** Negate the first *iron-offense* penalty in a scene; if misused, start *Thorn Displeasure* [2].
- **Two-Ledger Rod:** A certified measure; **DV 1** to enforce a stall's weight/price clause.
- **Tide Window Seal:** Mark a safe hour for crossing; **once/leg**, cancel *Wrong Tide*.

Soft Power: Courtesy Clauses & Gate-Math

Aelinnel influence travels by etiquette, sequence, and small infrastructure that rewrites how strangers meet.

- **Sequence Rights:** The party that maintains way-things claims first say; **once/scene**, invoke to require a parley beat before force.
- **Counting Thresholds:** Marked thresholds heed those who count; allies entering on your count gain **Position +1** on their opener.
- **Receipt Culture:** Dual ledgers make fraud expensive; presenting a said/meant receipt grants **DV 1** to unwind a trick clause.

Soft-Power Clocks: *Hazel Favor* [4], *Thorn Displeasure* [4], *Right Hour* [3].

Suggested Bonds & Complications

11.12.0.0.2 Bonds

- **Hawthorn Courtier:** Access to fae-kin etiquette and minor favors.
- **Tide-Reeve's Acquaintance:** Tide windows, river law, and ferries.
- **Green Market Broker:** Wrapped truths and two-ledger bargaining.
- **Stone-Singer's Apprentice:** Stone songs and structural lore.

11.12.0.0.3 Complications

- **Context-Sensitive Speech:** Reading texts older than two generations requires **Lore + Notice** (DV 4–5) or a *Context String*. Using archaic registers without keys adds **DV +1**.
- **Overload Sensitivity:** Too many inputs at once mark **1 Fatigue** and impose **–1** die on next **Insight/Notice**.
- **Brittle Focus:** The first **Harm 1 (blunt)** each scene converts to **1 Fatigue**; resolve further Harm normally.

11.13 Player's Guide: Aelaerem — People of Hearth & Hollow

Background: Halflings of Hearth & Hollow

The Aelaerem are a people of movement and assembly, living among gentle slopes and hedged lanes. Small in stature and large in memory, they bind promises with bread and lantern-light, and measure seasons by harvest masks and market bells. Hospitality is their public law; beneath it runs an older hedge-law of cup-marks, red thread, and the quiet attention of the Neighbors. Their “hearth magic” is housekeeping writ large: doors set true, lamps trimmed, courtesies kept—less spell than system, a precise regard for seasons, thresholds, and debts.

11.13.0.0.1 Hearth-Law & Guest-Right A red door promises bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest. Entering or hosting “under bread and lantern” gentles the next parley; hospitality is both shield and clause.

Racial Skill Increase

Choose one:

1. **Hearth-Law & Guest-Right:** +1 die to **Sway**, **Lore** (local custom), and **Survival** (shelter signs). Gain **Position** +1 when properly offering or receiving hospitality.
2. **Lantern-Law & the Wardens:** +1 die to **Notice**, **Survival** (paths, omens), and **Tinker** (lamps, small tools). Gain **Position** +1 when you correctly observe small courtesies or maintenance rites.

Thematic Attribute

Increase either **Wits** or **Presence** by 1 (to a max of 5). **Body** and **Spirit** unchanged.

Size & Equipment Limits

- **Small-Statured:** Agility and subtlety by build and habit.
- **Restriction:** Aelaerem cannot use **Heavy Weapons** or **Heavy Armor**. They excel with **Light** and **Medium** kits favoring finesse, mobility, and ward-rituals.

Talents

Heightened Senses (3 XP — Minor)

*Req: **Wits** 2+*

- +1 die to **Notice** and **Survival**.
- With **Wits** + **Notice** (DV 3), detect hidden creatures/objects.
- In natural environments, gain **Position** +1 on stealth and tracking.

Root-Balance (3 XP — Minor)

*Req: **Body** 2+, **Heightened Senses***

- +1 die to **Athletics**; resist shove/knockdown more easily.
- Move through natural terrain without penalty.
- **Once/scene**, stabilize on precarious footing with **Body** + **Athletics** (DV 3).

Cultural Mechanics

Hearth-Law & Guest-Right

- **Red Door Hospitality:** Present a guest-loaf token beneath a lit lantern to soften a risky social exchange (**Position** +1) or cancel the first *strange* complication in a scene.
- **Lantern-Writ:** Simple rites keep bounds sweet—"Bread & Salt" (**Position** +1 once/scene), "Broom Witness" (establish *Oath* [4–6]), and *Iron-Lace & Red Thread* (**Effect** +1 vs. compulsion) while properly maintained.
- **The Neighbors:** Leave butter at cup-marks, keep the festival calendar, and count the stiles aloud. Observance smooths the night; neglect invites *Hollow Attention*.

Lantern-Law & the Wardens

- **Count the Load:** Tap a beam three times and listen; **once/scene**, a measured tap grants **Position** +1 to **Traverse/Endure** in caves, bridges, or crowded structures.
- **Copper Courtesy:** Copper is polite to stone and honest to labor. Presenting copper tools or a mason's tally negates the first structural environment **SB**, or grants **DV 1** to parley with miners/masons/porters.
- **Return the Chalk:** Anything that points the way (chalk, cord, placard) must be restored; doing so cancels the first environment **SB** this scene.

The Quiet Powers (Neighbors)

- **The Pale Shepherd:** **Once**, by clause and courtesy, a traveler may pass "uncounted"—unseen by what tallies footfalls under the soil.
- **Hollow Attention:** Breaking hedge-law draws subtle reprisals: bells toll soft, red thread appears where you did not tie it, a door leads briefly elsewhere.

Seasons of Mask & Harvest

- **Mummers:** Keep stricter rules than any priest; the Thresher-King's guard walks in red hoods when fields demand order.
- **Festivals:** For a night, masks legitimate certain crossings; private moots under the Oak settle quarrels; an elder's blessing opens doors that ignore coin.
- **Omens:** Scarecrows watch the lane; lanterns burn blue at the ford; chalk mazes fill with mist; sometimes the Moot Oak bleeds sap the color of wine.

Trade, Craft, & Tokens

- **Keeps:** Cider, perry, beeswax, and wool spin the lane's economy.
- **Tokens:** Orchard grafts, mill-tokens, shepherd whistles, mover pressings. (Example: a shepherd's whistle makes dogs and door-bolts heed for one scene.)
- **Hearth Magic:** Red thread binds promises, lantern-writ holds the dark at bay, careful count and courtesy keep thresholds sweet.

Strings & Tools

- **Guest-Loaf Token:** **Once/scene**, treat a tense arrival as *Hospitable* (**Position** +1 opener).
- **Lantern Hood:** Convert a bright scene to *Shaded* locally; cancel one glare-based penalty.
- **Red Thread Kit:** **Once/scene**, bind a simple promise as an *Oath* [4].
- **Broom Witness:** Establish a household oath; while it ticks, outsiders face **DV** +1 to trespass or deceive under that roof.

Suggested Bonds & Complications

11.13.0.0.2 Bonds

- **Apple-Matron's Favor:** Hospitality leverage; influence in local markets; feast-clause invocations.
- **Lantern-Warden's Knowledge:** Path marks, safe-passage signs, omen-reading.
- **Mummers' Captain's Acquaintance:** Festival law, mask permissions, night-crossing exceptions.
- **Hedge-Witch's Debt:** Small potent favors—at a cost.

11.13.0.0.3 Complications

- **Hollow Stirring [6]:** Courtesies neglected; omens grow frequent and bite.
- **Gloam Choir [6]:** Deeper threat from boundary failures; spiritual or fae pressure escalates.
- **Scale Shock:** Smallness is overlooked in mass conflicts or intimidation; social **DV +1** to *impose* on much larger foes unless you stand under hospitality or law.

11.14 Player's Guide: Lethai — Root, River, & Roof-Tree / Mind's Eye & Civic Measure

Background: Woodwise Lawkeepers & Civic Engineers

The Lethai are sundered by an old constraint: no one may bear both the Gift of the Body and the Gift of the Mind. From this division grew two sister cultures:

11.14.0.0.1 Lethai-al (Wood-Elves) — Root, River, Roof-Tree They dwell where roof-trees braid the sky and rivers think aloud. Their memory is arboreal—rings, seasons, coppice ledgers—and their oaths are *root-law*: debts in years, paid in living work. To outsiders they seem quiet; to neighbors they are relentless auditors of footprint and flow. Strengths: living law, environmental stewardship, contextual craft.

11.14.0.0.2 Lethai-thora (City-Elves) — Mind's Eye, Civic Measure They make circles in cities (chiefly Thepyrgos), weighing arguments like bridges and translating other peoples' law into forms that carry. Their courts count consequences; their speech is context-saturated and exact. Strengths: memory, jurisprudence, logistics, civil design.

11.14.0.0.3 First Courtesy “Name yourself once; name the river twice; never name the forest as if it were yours.” Lamps are witnesses, paths are clauses, and small laws keep the world sweet.

Racial Skill Increase

Choose one, keyed to your branch:

1. **Gift of the Body (Lethai-al)**: +1 die to **Body**-based actions; **once/scene** you may spend 1 **Boon** to exceed normal limits for one physical action (leap, balance, sprint, scent-track).
2. **Gift of the Mind (Lethai-thora)**: +1 die to **Wits/Spirit**-based actions; **once/scene** you may spend 1 **Boon** to recall, deduce, or frame context that was beyond immediate knowledge (gloss, precedent, supply path).

Thematic Attribute

- **Lethai-al**: Increase **Body** *or* **Wits** by 1 (max 5).
- **Lethai-thora**: Increase **Wits** *or* **Spirit** by 1 (max 5).

Talents

Lethai-al Path — Embodied Presence

11.14.0.0.4 Canopy Spring (4 XP — Minor) *Req: Heightened Senses; Body 2+*
+1 die to climbing, vaulting, branch-run. **Once/scene** in forest, gain **Position** +1 on a movement action. With **Body** + **Athletics** (DV 4), clear a gap others treat as impassable.

11.14.0.0.5 Scent of Rain (4 XP — Minor) *Req: Heightened Senses; Survival 1+*
+1 die to predict weather, smoke, blight. With **Wits** + **Survival** (DV 3), sense approaching storm/fire/plague front. Track by scent with **Effect** +1 in natural terrain.

Lethai-thora Path — Mental Acuity**11.14.0.0.6 Memory Canticle (4 XP — Minor)** *Req: Long Memory; Lore 2+*

Line-true recall of texts and testimony. +1 die to research/translation. **Once/scene**, provide crucial context that advances an investigation or reduces a legal/social **DV** by **1** if you can cite source and frame.

11.14.0.0.7 Number Music (4 XP — Minor) *Req: Long Memory; Wits 2+*

+1 die to design/repair/logistics. With **Wits** + **Craft** (DV 3), solve an engineering/flow proof on the fly. When you *speak the scaffold* (frame steps aloud), related rolls are **DV 1** this scene.

Cultural Mechanics**The Curse of Division**

- **Rule of Two Gifts:** Choose *Body* (Lethai-al) or *Mind* (Lethai-thora) at creation; take Talents only from that path. Attempting to straddle both imposes **1 die** to all rolls until scene end.
- **Season Switch:** Changing paths is a season project with social cost (forfeit one String tied to former gift).
- **Bridge-Born Clause (Rare Half-Elf):** A quarter-lineage may take *one* Body Gift *and one* Mind Gift (see GM for context obligations).

Shade Etiquette (Lethai-al)

- **Iron Covered:** Bare iron offends ward-lines; wrap it. First entry with covered iron grants **Position +1** in parley to pass.
- **Name Once:** Speak name and intent at the edge; do not claim the forest.
- **Step on Stone:** Use laid stones; crushed shoots are debts.
- **Water First:** Pour a first cup for river or cistern before you drink.
- **Leave the Light:** Replant, mend, or pay for shade you take. (See *Light-Dues*.)

Context-Saturated Speech (Lethai-thora)

- **Context Keys:** place-name, season-mark, kinship-hand, roof-tree sign. Missing any two invites misreadings.
- **Old Texts:** Manuscripts older than two generations need gloss-trees (marginal twig glyphs) or a songkeeper.
- **In Play:** Reading/pleading in older registers is **DV +1** unless you hold a *Context String* (gloss-tree, witness, song). Cashing it reduces **DV 1** and establishes a *Shared Frame* (**Position +1** opener).

Strings & Ledger (Shared)

- **Light-Dues:** Every fell, ferry, and fire owes a balance in replanting, canal-clearing, or kinder rates.
- **Strings (examples):** light-due receipt; shade-credit; ferry right; resin share; canoe-lane priority; seed tithe.
- **Use:** Cash a light-due for **DV 1** on operations framed as repair/replanting/flood-work. Abuse starts *Under-Root Grudge* [1].
- **Quotas as Clocks:** Boat-Timber Quota [6], Lanternwood Allotment [4]. Fill to unlock export; overfill triggers *Canopy Censure*.

Patron Ties (Common Lethai Bonds)

- **Lethai-al:** Often entreat *Inaea* (web, guest-right, line-sanctuary) and *Isoka* (shedding, decisive strike) for rites on path, bridge, and hunt.
- **Lethai-thora:** Favor *The Witness* (truth, record) and *Sacred Geometry* (form, proportion); radicals court the *Clockwork Monad* for “managed process” at moral risk.

Strings & Tools (Table Use)

- **Shade-Credit:** Treat a contested crossing as *Hospitable*: **Position +1** opener; on abuse, tick *Under-Root Grudge* [1].
- **Ferry Right:** **DV 1** to move crews/loads by water where named.
- **Resin Share:** **Effect +1** on mend/seal actions; marks *Lanternwood Allotment*.
- **Context String:** Redeem to remove **DV +1** from archaic law/speech this scene and bank **+1 Boon** on a clean success.

Suggested Bonds & Complications**11.14.0.0.8 Bonds**

- **Songkeeper’s Trust (al):** Vouches adherence to shade etiquette; interprets ancient paths and oaths.
- **Warden’s Oath (al):** Passage rights and woodwise summons when the forest is wronged.
- **Sumwright’s Compact (thora):** Two-ledger arbitration in mixed courts; contract leverage.
- **Archive-Keeper’s Debt (thora):** Access to restricted stacks—at a later price in service.
- **Bridge-Born Kinship:** Mutual aid among rare dual-gift lineages navigating both spheres.

11.14.0.0.9 Complications

- **Division’s Bite:** Attempting cross-path use (Body *and* Mind gifts in one scene without clause) imposes **1 die** to all rolls until scene ends.
- **Context Fragility:** Social/legal **DV +1** when stripped of context keys; hostile courts may weaponize misframing.
- **Canopy Censure:** Exceeding quotas or slighting root-law triggers censure—*Light-Dues* [4] starts and local passage turns *Controlled*.

11.15 Player's Guide: Lethai-ar — The Oathbound (Dark Elves)

Background: The Vowed in Silk & Scale

The Lethai-ar are not a separate bloodline so much as a vow-bound cadre. They are Lethai-al (Body-gift) or Lethai-thora (Mind-gift) who step off those paths to live under threshold patrons—**Inae** the Weaver and **Isoka** the Serpent. In some ages they are scarce; in others—like the present—they gather wherever borders fray and oaths need teeth. They are known for *mask-right*, precise courtesies, and the unsettling efficiency of vows that bind places, routes, and roles.

11.15.0.0.1 Marks Are Common, Discipline Is Distinct. Ink, scar, resin-inlay, and rite-born *Marks* exist across many peoples. The Lethai-ar did not invent them and do not own them; they *institutionalize* them—pairing each Mark with context keys (place, season, witness) and ledgered prices, so boons do not drift into curses.

Racial Skill Increase

Choose one according to patronal leaning:

1. **Weaver's Reading (Inae):** +1 die to uncover *connections* (routes, plots, safe-conducts). **Once/scene**, with **Wits** + **Notice** (DV 3), declare one hidden tie (who vouches, what clause binds, which alley joins).
2. **Venin Lore (Isoka):** +1 die to *identify, dose, and remedy* toxins and social “poisons.” **Once/scene**, convert **Harm 1 (toxin)** to **1 Fatigue**.

Thematic Attribute

Increase **Wits** *or* **Spirit** by 1 (max 5). Body and Presence unchanged.

Talents (Entry Paths)

11.15.0.0.2 Needle-Quiet (4 XP — Minor) *Req: Stealth 2+*

In dim, patterned cover (silk, lattice, shutters), gain +1 die to **Stealth**. **Once/scene**, hold still through an exchange as if unseen (you remain targetable only by area or guessed fire).

11.15.0.0.3 Fang of Timing (4 XP — Minor) *Req: Survival 1+ or Subterfuge 1+*

Frame a precise moment (counted breath, bell-beat). Your next action that keys to that beat gains **Position +1**. **On a Miss**, mark **1 Fatigue** (the moment slips).

Cultural Mechanics

Two Courts, One Edge

11.15.0.0.4 Silk Courts of Inae (Pattern & Mercy) Temper: mercy with memory; knots that mend before they bind.

Work: multi-party compacts, reweaving custom, sanctuaries under line.

Signs: three-strand cords, ledger-ribbons, masks with tear-slits.

Law: “Said & Meant” tied by a visible clause.

Sin: binding without consent; repair that erases the harmed.

11.15.0.0.5 Coil Courts of Isoka (Change & Cure) Temper: cunning without needless cruelty; a sharp cure offered with the cut.

Work: expose weak seams, stage molts (identity exits), pair poison to remedy.

Signs: shed-skin sashes, cup-and-vial pairs, scalpels in green thread.

Law: every wound must name a reachable remedy.

Sin: a wound with no cure; molt forced by shame instead of choice.

Oath Etiquette & Rites

- **Mask-Right:** Roles declared, then masks donned; speak in role, not over it. Breaking mask-right ends hearing for a season.
- **Speak Twice, Whisper Once:** Say the truth two ways; then whisper the *price* to the witness. If you cannot name the price, you have not made a true ask.
- **Thread Before Blade:** Offer a binding solution first. Steel only where thread was refused.
- **Vial Courtesy:** A dose sits beside its antivenin. Taking one without the other marks bad faith.

Marks — Shared Craft, Particular Discipline

Marks are table-facing compacts that grant an edge when *in context* and tilt to curse when unmoored. The Lethai-ar practice is to *key* every Mark to time, witness, and place.

11.15.0.0.6 Examples (available to any culture that learns the rite; Lethai-ar formalize keys):

- **Spider-Bride Mark (Inae):** *Gift:* **Position +1** when protecting named guests “under your line”; line-sanctuary can be declared once/scene. *Keys:* guest-roll, lifted lamp, knot-book. *Curse (keyless):* hospitality fixation—**DV +1** to withdraw protection even when prudent.
- **Widow’s Spool (Inae):** *Gift:* lay a hair-fine traversal/trap line once/scene (treat as *Trap [2]* or safe step). *Keys:* knot register, bell-note. *Curse:* path hunger—compelled to “finish the old route” at bad moments.
- **First Shedding Mark (Isoka):** *Gift:* escape a label/bond once/scene (*Shed-Skin Escape*); clear **1 Fatigue** on successful exit. *Keys:* warm draught, ash-milk, witness to new name. *Curse:* identity chill—**Position 1** in cold or when unnamed.
- **Forked Sight (Isoka):** *Gift:* when a hard truth is spoken in the exchange, your action gains **Effect +1**. *Keys:* bell-pattern, truth-token. *Curse:* social sting—on Miss, mark **1 Fatigue** and start *Bruised Pride [2]*.

War Without Battle (Doctrine)

Lethai-ar end campaigns by route, ledger, and night.

- **Hedge War:** Re-knit ward-lines to channel intruders into dead ground watched by wardens.
- **River Denial:** Ferries “rest,” weirs open at dusk, mills idle to silt the only footing.
- **Night Lanes:** Silk trip-lines and warning strings; one strike, then silence.
- **Canopy Runners:** Move above sight-lines; arrows fall where footfalls never were.

Neighbors & Borders

- **Ykrul:** Ritual distance, mutual measure. Bowl & Board seals routes; Ykrul price crossings, Lethai-ar price behavior.
- **Aeler:** Oath-friction underground—lamp-law vs mask-right. Both enforce receipts; argue which witness counts.

- **Lethai-al / Lethai-thora:** The ar recruit from the al; they debate context with the thora. Kinship slows quarrels; thresholds decide them.

Strings & Tools (Table Use)

- **Bride-Line Writ:** Declare a *protected path* for one leg; trespassers treat the route as *Controlled* and suffer **DV +1** to press.
- **Vial Pair:** Carry dose & cure; **DV 1** to treat poison, and parley **Position +1** when you show both.
- **Knot-Book:** Spend to assert a clause remembered “in the tying”: **DV 1** to enforce or unwind an oath once/scene.
- **Mask Ledger:** Track roles & prices; **+1 die** to **Sway** when all parties wear declared masks.

Clocks & Fronts

- **Mask Integrity [4]** (roles fray); **Guest-Right Strain [4]** (hospitality abused); **Coil Paranoia [4]** (cure withheld); **Web Ossifies [4]** (mercy becomes trap).
- **SB Menu:** *Mask Slips* (role confusion), *Knot Bites* (unpaid clause triggers), *Cold Hour* (Position 1 unless warmed), *Witness Arrives* (price must be named now).

Play Hooks

1. **The Unpriced Mercy:** A sanctuary knot holds a murderer. Name a price that mends without erasing the harmed—under three masks—before dawn.
2. **Molt for a City:** A tyrant’s captain begs a molt. The cure exists; its price may break the garrison’s oath-chain.
3. **Thread Across Pasture:** A silence-furlong through border pasture is broken; wolves and wardens close. Re-stitch or accept a biting line.

Suggested Bonds & Complications

11.15.0.0.7 Bonds

- **Fellow Oath-Bearer (Inae/Isoka):** Shared vows, shared leverage.
- **Mask-Maker:** Teaches form; vouches mask-right in foreign courts.
- **Patron’s Herald:** Carries omens and small dispensations.
- **Kin in al/thora:** Bridge to broader Lethai custom and correction.
- **Neutral Arbiter (Sumwright/Archive-Keeper):** Mediates Said/Meant disputes.

11.15.0.0.8 Complications

- **Oath-Breaker’s Stigma:** Mask-right denied until penance.
- **Mark Adrift:** A beloved Mark lost its last context—acts as a curse until re-keyed.
- **Mask vs Lamp:** Whose witness rules—silk or single lamp?
- **Patron’s Disfavor:** Omen of chill silk or dry scales; expect a demanded price.

Using Lethai-ar at the Table

Lean on *roles, routes, and remedies*. Put **price** on every protection, and **context keys** on every edge—so that when pressure comes, the choice to pay or to cut is clean, witnessed, and costly in a way the table can feel.

11.16 Player's Guide: Ykrul — The People of the Violet Steppe

Background: The Violet Steppe

The Ykrul are a fierce, pragmatic people of the **Violet Steppe**. Outsiders often call them *orcs*—a slur that flattens a rich culture into stereotype. Among those who deal fairly with them, they are **Ykrul**: “the People of the Violet Steppe.”

Their shared memory begins with the **Great Wake**—a legendary flight from a wrong sky, crossing an ocean by boat and star. From that passage they learned to read **flow** (what moves), **weight** (what holds), and **exit** (what opens). These principles, codified in the sacred geometry of **Kon'reh**, inform their warfare, logistics, law, diplomacy, and daily life. They bank on a fearsome name on the open plain—and win by **routes, supply, and parleys** that make blades unnecessary.

Ykrul life is plural: herders, pilots, weavers, judges, scouts, factors, captains. Warfare is *a tool*, not an identity. Their ethics are spatial: to *place well* is to *behave well*—no route you cannot defend, no exit you build that closes behind weaker feet.

Institutions range from **Meadow Judges** who roam with bowl and board, to **Kon'reh Masters** who arbitrate by geometry, to **Stone-Sons & Rope-Daughters** who prove passages in mountain night, and **Wake-Wrought** families who list their hulls like saints. Their colors favor violet (grass), gray (stone), blue-white (sky/wake), and motifs of rings, crosses, and stepped lines.

Racial Skill Increase

Choose one:

1. **Flow/Weight/Exit (Plainscraft)**: +1 die to **Survival**, **Tactics**, and **Lore** about movement, terrain, logistics, and “reading” a situation for viable paths or pressure points.
2. **Kon'reh Logic (Sacred Geometry)**: +1 die to **Insight** and **Command** when negotiating, planning, or reasoning spatially. **Once/scene**, you may treat a failed negotiation as a *Partial* if you reframe it with a clean geometric metaphor or map.

Thematic Attribute

Increase **Body** *or* **Wits** by 1 (max 5). Spirit and Presence unchanged.

Talents

11.16.0.0.1 Herd-Mastery (3 XP — Minor) *Req: Survival 1+, Presence 2+*

+1 die to herding/animal handling. Calm a panicked beast or steer a herd through bad ground with **Presence + Survival** (DV 3). **Once/scene**, read herd motion for advantage (+1 die to a linked **Notice** or **Tactics** test).

11.16.0.0.2 Weather-Reading (4 XP — Minor) *Req: Wits 2+, Survival 1+*

+1 die to predict weather or navigate it. Sense major shifts hours early with **Wits + Survival** (DV 3). In open country, acting on a correct forecast grants **Position** +1 to travel/survival actions.

Cultural Mechanics

Wake-Law: The Great Migration

- **Survival through Adaptation:** Read *flow, weight, exit* before you commit.
- **Kon'reh (Sacred Geometry):** Meadow (pressure & path), River (flow & change), Stone (weight & witness). Strategy is ethic; a clean placement is a clean duty.
- **Wake Names:** A second name granted by the sea—callable once for an unlooked-for courtesy “as kin on the crossing.”
- **Salt Line:** A coil of salt-stiff rope uncoiled before grave talk—placing all present under Wake-law: plain words, straight debts, no riddles.

Law, Diplomacy, War—Seen in Lines

- **Guest Right:** A guest cup at the outer fire. Theft “under smoke” brands your tent-marks gray for a season.
- **Two Ledgers:** Said *and* Meant recorded together; offering both averts face-traps. Lying on *Said* is a grave offense.
- **Blood-Price:** Paid in animals, salt, or length of rope; refusal enters **Red Weather** (others treat you as a walking storm).
- **Silence Furlong (with Lethai-al):** A speechless border—no grazing, no felling, no names. Cross in silence, then speak once. Kept, it warms councils; broken, gray-fledged messengers arrive at dusk.
- **Pass & Harbor Doctrine:** In mountains, hold what stone will bear and promise no more. At sea, get there first *or sing the storm together*; a shared song outranks a sharp keel.

People & Institutions

- **Meadow Judges:** A traveling trio with bowl, board, and braid; their ruling holds one season and one road.
- **Kon'reh Masters:** Geometry arbiters and teachers; respected even by rivals; will play anyone who brings a decent board and reason.
- **Stone-Sons & Rope-Daughters:** Mountain orders proving night crossings; their braids anchor Aeler engines and make Aeler officers polite.
- **Wake-Wrought:** Sea families who list hulls like saints; name a stolen boat's rivets and you can claim it under Wake-law.

Ykrul Ways (Four Grounds)

Meadow Commons Violet grass, ring-camps, shallow lakes. Fast musters, moving markets, distance diplomacy. Gifts: Herd-Mastery; Weather-Reading; Caravan Craft; Route-Planning (Kon'reh framing).

Mountain Holds Knife ridges, pass-stones. Holding lines, winter stores, signal sense. Gifts: Stone-Sense; Counterweight Engineering; Rope-Craft; Avalanche Reading.

Salt Coasts Rocky inlets, island runs, river mouths. Pilots, moots, storm windows. Gifts: Storm-Seamanship; Harbor Dues; Shoal Mapping; Blue Moot Etiquette.

Eastern Steppes Sky cairns, ward-storms. Exit-finding, omen-reading, cross-cultural guides. Gifts: Cairn-Talking; Ward-Storm Guidance; Long-Leg Logistics; Silence Furlong Etiquette.

How Ykrul Win (Beyond the Blade)

- **Banked Fear (Reputation Economy):** On entering a venue where your fierce name precedes you, mark *Banked Fear (1)*. *Spend 1*: force *Parley First* (one roll of talk before a fight) *or*

shift one enemy action to *Controlled* (they flinch). Bluff and fail to deliver? Erase all Banked Fear until you win publicly.

- **Logistics Edge (Strings → DV):** Convert a cache String (fodder lot, water right, hidden wharf) into **DV 1** on a linked leg/score. Starve innocents with it and flip the benefit: **DV 1** becomes *Public Debts +1*.
- **Kon'reh Arbitration (Geometry of Mercy):** Model roads/exits/lanes in talk. On success, create a *Seasonal Concession* String at a ford/harbor/pass; either side may call it *once/season* without offense.

Strings & Tools (Table Use)

- **Salt Line Rope:** Uncoil to place a scene under Wake-law; **Position +1** to resolve disputes cleanly once/scene.
- **Wake-Name Token:** Cash for an unlooked-for courtesy—**DV 1** to a border, muster, or harbor ask.
- **Meadow Judge's Braid:** Present to shift a brawl into *Bowl & Board* arbitration; opens a *Concession [4]* clock both sides can tick.
- **Kon'reh Board & Stones:** Lay it out to reframe a negotiation as placement; on a clean success, bank *Route Clause* (once/leg: **DV 1** to movement/supply).
- **Violet Standard:** Raise to claim right-of-parley for your band; first hostile SB becomes *Muttered Threats* (no immediate violence).

Clocks & Fronts

- **Red Weather [6]** (unpaid blood-price shadows your camp)
- **Feud Ignites [4]** (a slight tends toward blood)
- **Silence Furlong Breach [4]** (border rites strained)
- **Supply Drag [4]** (overextended routes sap will)
- **Gray Marks [4]** (tent-brand shame limits hospitality)

SB Menu (Steppe): Dust Line (visibility warps), Dry Kettle (water tighter), False Ford (route misread), Storm Edge (forecast arrives early), Horse Nerves (mounts spook).

Play Hooks

1. **The Board at Dusk:** Two caravans claim the same ford. Lay the Kon'reh board, win the concession without drawing steel, or face *Red Weather*.
2. **Salt on the Wind:** A Wake-Wrought hull is stolen; name its rivets under Wake-law and seize it back mid-moot—without lighting the harbor to war.
3. **The Gray Tent:** A guest stole under smoke; your marks run gray. Pay the price in rope, stock, or service before neighboring bands treat you like a storm.
4. **The Silent Strip:** A Silence Furlong was trampled during a hunt. Repair rites with the Lethai-al before gray-fledged arrows and cold courtesy freeze trade.

Suggested Bonds & Complications

11.16.0.0.3 Bonds

- **Meadow Judge Acquaintance:** A traveling arbiter who can seat disputes and grant rulings that hold for a season.
- **Kon'reh Master's Respect:** Earned by fair play or clean placement; grants edge when a

scene is “set as Board.”

- **Stone-Son/Rope-Daughter Initiate:** Mountain-tested; access to passes, counterweight tricks, and Aeler goodwill.
- **Wake-Wrought Kin:** Sea-law, pilot lore, and a harbor that remembers your name.
- **Foster-Bond (Ykrul → Vilikari):** A formal exchange that opens trade routes and softens borders.

11.16.0.0.4 Complications

- **Red Weather:** Your band owes blood-price; hospitality chills until it’s paid.
- **Feud Ignites [4]:** A live quarrel trends toward blood unless cooled by price, proof, or play.
- **Silence Furlong Breach:** Border rites violated; messengers with gray fletchings are on the way.
- **Oath-Breaker’s Shame:** Guest-Right or Said/Meant betrayed; trust collapses across rings.
- **Kon’reh Misstep:** You promised an exit you cannot defend. Publicly re-learn (demonstrate competence) or lose face.
- **Banked Fear Debt:** You spent the name and failed to deliver—erase Banked Fear and invite challengers.

11.17 Player’s Guide: Mixed Heritage — Half-Elves, Half-Ykrul, Half-Others

Background: Children of Crossings

The lands of Fate’s Edge are broad and braided. People travel, trade, swear oaths, and fall in love across borders. From these crossings come folk of **mixed heritage**. You might be the child of a Lethai merchant and a Vilikari factor, a half-Ykrul born in a ford-town to a human parent, or the grandchild of an Aeler vent-prior and a Valewood wanderer. Your identity is not a single stamp but a weave of places, customs, and kin.

Being of mixed heritage is seldom simple. Welcome in one court, weighed in another; fluent in two etiquettes, fully at home in neither. Some will see a bridge, others a trespass. The shape you keep is yours to claim.

This guide favors *reflavoring* the existing race frameworks rather than inventing wholly new rule blocks, keeping focus on narrative flexibility over assumptions about biology.

Creating a Mixed Heritage Character

1. **Choose One Core Racial Package.** Select one background (Aeler, Aelinnel, Aelaerem, Lethai-al/ -thora/ -ar, Ykrul) as your *primary* cultural foundation. This sets your **Racial Skill Increase**, **Thematic Attribute**, **Talents** access, and **Cultural Mechanics**.
2. **Reflavor One Element.** Take one talent, skill bonus, or cultural mechanic from a *second* culture and **reflavor** it to fit your mixed upbringing. It must make sense in your backstory and present fiction.

Reflavoring Examples (Guidance, Not Limits)

11.17.0.0.1 Half-Ykrul / Half-Lethai-al *Herd-Mastery (Ykrul)* reads people as a “crowd-herd” or tracks wildlife lanes through canopy: “+1 die to understand group motion, crowd dynamics, or

animal patterns in your home terrain.”

11.17.0.0.2 Half-Aelinnel / Half-Human (Vilikari) *Number Music (Aelinnel)* becomes market math: “Perform complex trade/logistics calculations with **Wits+Craft** (or *Streetwise*) at DV 3; frame deals in clean sums for **DV 1** once/scene.”

11.17.0.0.3 Half-Aelaerem / Half-Ykrul *Kon’reh Logic (Ykrul)* as pantry-sense or hall-placement: “Once/scene, treat a failed social/negotiation roll as *Partial* if you reframe with spatial/structural metaphor that fits the venue.”

11.17.0.0.4 Half-Lethai-ar (Inae) / Half-Aelaerem *Stillness (Lethai-ar)* becomes host-invisibility: “+1 die to *Stealth* in domestic/social bustle; once/scene blend into service and go ‘unnoticed’ for one exchange.”

11.17.0.0.5 Half-Lethai-thora / Half-Vilikari *Two-Ledger Talk (Aelinnel)* broadens: “State both public stance and likely hidden price to cancel the first social SB in a negotiation scene.”

11.17.0.0.6 Half-Ykrul / Half-Linns *Storm-Seamanship (Ykrul Coasts)* applies on land: “+1 die to forecast weather/navigate adverse conditions on steppe or water; on a correct call, gain **Position +1** for a travel/survival action.”

Racial Skill Increase (Mixed Heritage)

Choose one:

1. **Adaptive Skills.** +1 die to *two* different skills that reflect your blended upbringing (e.g., **Sway + Survival**, or **Craft + Notice**).
2. **Cultural Synthesis.** Take the Racial Skill Increase from your chosen Core Package, and justify how it expresses both sides of your background in play.

Thematic Attribute (Mixed Heritage)

Choose the Thematic Attribute from your Core Package (e.g., **Wits** for Lethai-thora, **Body** for Ykrul) and anchor it in your mixed story (“sharp Wits from city schooling, tempered by border pragmatism”).

Talent (Mixed Heritage)

Select a Talent from your Core Package *or* one of the flexible options below, and re flavor its fiction to fit your synthesis.

Border Walker’s Instinct (4 XP — Minor)

Req: Presence 2+, Survival 1+

+1 die to navigate customs, rites, and cross-cultural norms. Sense a border mood with **Wits+Notice** (DV 3). **Once/scene**, gain **Position +1** when mediating between groups or leveraging one culture’s etiquette within another’s court.

Tongue of Many Waters (3 XP — Minor)

Req: Wits 2+, Sway 1+

+1 die to **Sway** and **Insight** with unfamiliar dialects/backgrounds. **Once/session**, establish a basic

pidgin/gesture channel with those who share no tongue (enough for trade or parley). **Once/scene**, gain +1 on one social roll when you correctly cite a custom from a culture *not* dominant in the interaction.

Cultural Mechanics (Mixed Heritage)

- **Hybrid Customs.** You may observe simplified forms of two cultures' mechanics (e.g., Guest-Right tokens *and* Two-Ledger receipts) with narrower scope unless adopted by a host community.
- **Bridging Role.** Treat mixed heritage as a standing fiction tag; some scenes start **Position +1** for mediation, others **Position 1** where purity is prized. Let the table lean into both.
- **Reflected Mechanic.** You can mirror the *effect* of a cultural currency (e.g., Reputation/Banked Fear) via deeds across both sides, even if the name differs.

Suggested Bonds & Complications

11.17.0.0.7 Bonds

- **Family Ties Across Borders.** Kin in two cultures offer haven, rumors, or leverage.
- **Cultural Mentor.** A teacher who drilled you in a rite, register, or craft from one side.
- **Found Family.** A circle of other mixed or liminal folk who vouch when lineage won't.
- **The Mediator.** Known for seating quarrels between your parent communities.

11.17.0.0.8 Complications

- **Identity Fray.** Moments of hesitation or self-editing under scrutiny; first social Miss in a formal venue starts *Doubt [2]*.
- **Dual Expectations.** Two elders pull you in opposite directions; clocks compete (*Obligation A* vs *Obligation B*).
- **Stereotype or Suspicion.** Purists tick *Exposure* on contact; proof is demanded twice.
- **Lost Inheritance.** A rite or ledger you never received; unlock by quest or sponsorship.
- **Translator's Burden.** Always asked to explain; *once/scene* you may turn that burden into leverage (Position +1) if you take on a new minor obligation.

Chapter 12

Character Backgrounds

From the journal of a Thepyrgosi Witch Hunter

They call it mercy when the Tower does it and cruelty when I do. The difference is a seal of wax and a hymn at the gate.

I was a bright spark once—could taste iron on my tongue when the air went thin before a working. The masters in Thepyrgos tested me, weighed me, and found me *nearly* enough. “Nearly” is a door that never opens again.

So I learned the other doors.

I keep a ledger: names, places, the hour the lamps guttered in a tenement, the way the brick sweats when a child hums without meaning to. I carry writs that make people look away. I carry cord and a promise I do not speak aloud. The University pays for talent delivered in time; the city pays for fires that never start. Between those accounts, I balance what I can.

You will say I go too far. Sometimes I do. Sometimes the street is a tinderbox and a wrong whisper is a spark. Sometimes a family would rather believe in saints than in ash. I give them a story they can live with and take away the one that might kill them.

When the bells of Thepyrgos answer the river wind, I walk the colonnade to the bursar’s door and do not look at the windows. The work is ugly. The work is necessary. The night does not care which of those is true—only that the lamps keep burning.

Before your character took their first deliberate risk, they belonged somewhere. Backgrounds are the trail-dust on your boots, the school-ink on your fingers, the bell-pattern you still tap when frightened. They explain how you know what you know—and who still knows *you*.

12.1 Understanding Backgrounds

Backgrounds serve several important functions:

- Provide narrative context for abilities and choices
- Explain how you gained skills, languages (§??), and connections
- Create ties to regions and factions (§11)
- Offer roleplaying hooks, obligations, and privileges
- Seed reliable *contacts*, *customs*, and *places* that matter on-screen

12.1.0.0.1 Mechanical Hooks. Choose **one background** at character creation. It grants:

- **Access Tags** (narrative permissions; see below)
- **A Signature Contact** (named NPC; usually a Cap 1 follower you *do not* pay XP for; they cannot take independent actions, but can grant +1d *once per scene* when their help is plausible)
- **A Background Boon** (once per session, gain a +1d or reduce DV by 1 for a task strongly tied to the background's sphere)
- **An Obligation Clock** (4 segments; when filled, it creates a *call-in* from that world—debt, favor, duty; see §12.9)

12.1.0.0.2 Access Tags. Tags describe *where* and *with whom* you have standing. Examples: *Guild-Ledgered*, *Court-Announced*, *Veteran-of-the-Marches*, *Bell-Kin of the Causeways*, *Wind-Rider's Tokens*, *Charter-Stamped*. When a scene engages a tag, the GM may:

- Waive a trivial gate (no roll) or
- Lower Position risk by one step for first contact or
- Offer a *Devil's Bargain* tied to that society's expectations

12.2 Common Background Categories

Social Class Backgrounds

12.2.0.0.1 Aristocratic House Scion

- **Access Tags:** *Court-Announced*, *Heraldic Right*
- **Skills:** Sway, Command, Lore (customs)
- **Signature Contact:** Family steward (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in a formal setting, treat Social Position as one step better for an exchange.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Marriage alliances, estate audits, house feuds
- **Challenges:** Intrigue clocks, reputation stakes

12.2.0.0.2 Merchant Factor

- **Access Tags:** *Guild-Ledgered*, *Caravan Rights*
- **Skills:** Sway (negotiation), Investigation (accounts), Lore (markets)
- **Signature Contact:** Bookkeeper or quartermaster (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session when buying/selling or logistics, reduce DV by 1 or gain +1d.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Notes due, partner demands, embargoes

12.2.0.0.3 Common Folk

- **Access Tags:** *Neighborhood Trust*, *Guild-Friend*
- **Skills:** Craft (one), Endurance, Streetwise or Nature
- **Signature Contact:** Elder, foreman, or midwife (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session among familiar folk, convert a failure on routine labor to a success-with-cost.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Communal favors, festival work, mutual aid

Professional Backgrounds

12.2.0.0.4 Marcher Veteran

- **Access Tags:** *Veteran-of-the-Marches, Muster Papers*
- **Skills:** Melee or Ranged, Tactics, Endurance
- **Signature Contact:** Old sergeant (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in organized violence, ignore the first point of situational Disadvantage from confusion or fear.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Recall to colors, feud legacies, back-pay claims

12.2.0.0.5 Academic of the Dialogues

- **Access Tags:** *School-Sealed, Reading Privileges*
- **Skills:** Lore, Investigation, Sway (debate)
- **Signature Contact:** Lecturer or archivist (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in research or disputation, ask one clarifying question the GM must answer plainly or point to the shelf that does.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Citations owed, controversial thesis, patron politics

12.2.0.0.6 Underworld Hand

- **Access Tags:** *Harbor Handsigns, Black Banner Cant*
- **Skills:** Stealth, Deception, Streetwise
- **Signature Contact:** Fence or fixer (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session when using a *cant* (§??), gain +1d to set up or slip out.
- **Obligation Seeds:** Debts, heat with a rival crew, burned safehouse

Regional Backgrounds

12.2.0.0.7 Urban Child of Silkstrand

- **Access Tags:** *Street-Stall Rights, Night-Patrol Familiar*
- **Skills:** Streetwise, Perception, Sway (fast talk)
- **Signature Contact:** Watch-lantern or stall-keeper (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in a dense city, you know a *shortcut or rumor* that reduces time/cost by one step.

12.2.0.0.8 Rural Valewood Forager

- **Access Tags:** *Green Courts Token, River-Ferry Nod*
- **Skills:** Nature, Survival, Lore (spirits)
- **Signature Contact:** Leaf-warden (Cap 1)
- **Background Boon:** Once/session in the wild, downgrade a Travel complication by one step.

12.2.0.0.9 Frontier Marcher Homesteader

- **Access Tags:** *Land-Grant Papers, Border Moot Voice*
- **Skills:** Craft (build), Endurance, Tactics or Diplomacy
- **Signature Contact:** Neighboring elder (Cap 1)

- **Background Boon:** Once/session at a contested site, shift Position up by one step when defending what's yours.

12.3 World-Linked Backgrounds

12.3.0.0.1 Aeler Charter Apprentice

- **Access Tags:** *Charter-Stamped, Stone-Speech Initiate*
- **Skills:** Craft, Lore (engineering), Investigation (plans)
- **Signature Contact:** Oathscribe (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session around structures, ignore the first *environmental* complication from collapse or strain.

12.3.0.0.2 Mistlands Bell-Keeper

- **Access Tags:** *Bell-Law, Causeway Rights*
- **Skills:** Perception, Lore (omens), Survival (fens)
- **Signature Contact:** Dusk-warden (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session, ring a lawful pattern to reframe a fog scene's Position from *Controlled* to *Dominant* for one exchange.

12.3.0.0.3 Ykrul Wind-Runner

- **Access Tags:** *Wind-Knot Tokens, Banner Hospitality*
- **Skills:** Survival (steppe), Ranged or Riding, Sway (customs)
- **Signature Contact:** Banner-aunt (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session in open country, coordinate allies at distance; they gain a one-time *Boon* if they can hear your call.

12.3.0.0.4 Kahfagian Dock-Priest Acolyte

- **Access Tags:** *Harbor Blessings, Beacon Rights*
- **Skills:** Lore (sea rites), Sway (crews), Investigation (cargo)
- **Signature Contact:** Beacon-keeper (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session at sea or harbor, treat one navigation check as if aided by favorable weather (DV−1).

12.4 Background Benefits and Limits

Typical Benefits

- **Skill Access:** Strong narrative justification for certain tests
- **Resource Access:** Borrowed tools, rooms, shrines, or records (scene-time instead of XP; see Assets, §8)
- **Social Access:** Entry to circles your tag recognizes
- **Knowledge:** Clues, maps, or customs that lower DV by 1
- **Reputation:** Advantage on *first impressions* in-tag

Common Limitations

- **Obligations:** Duties to house, guild, banner, or court
- **Restrictions:** Codes, taboos, or public expectations
- **Enemies:** Rival houses, crews, or schools
- **Secrets:** Leverage others can pull
- **Dependencies:** Loss of standing if you neglect ties

12.5 Custom Backgrounds

Build Procedure (Player & GM)

Pick 1 **Access Tag**, 1 **Signature Contact**, 1 **Boon**, and 1 **Obligation Seed**. Name places and people.

- **Origin:** Where were you taught/raised/forged?
- **Training:** Which *two* skills does this background naturally support?
- **Experiences:** One memory that still changes how you act
- **Relationships:** One ally, one rival; both want something
- **Values:** What won't you let slide?

Mechanical Considerations

- **Boon Scope:** DV−1 or +1d once/session when strongly on-theme
- **Contact Use:** +1d as assist; cannot take independent actions unless purchased as a *Follower* (Cap² XP; §8)
- **Assets:** Borrowing an institutional asset costs *scene time* (counts as upkeep for that asset this downtime) but 0 XP
- **Languages:** Choose one tongue linked to the background (see §??); at least *Conversational*

12.6 Integration with Development

Early Career

- Apprentice, recruit, junior clerk, initiate bell-keeper
- Boon is modest; obligation triggers are frequent but small

Mid-Career

- Foreman, sergeant, factor, lecturer
- Add a **second Access Tag** or elevate contact to Cap 2 by *paying XP* for a follower

Late Career

- Master, banner-aunt, beacon-warden, arbiter
- Background Boon may become a *scene-long permission* at GM approval tied to a vow or festival

12.7 Background Combinations

12.7.0.0.1 Sequential

- **Veteran** → **City Watch:** Access shifts from *Muster Papers* to *Badge Rights*

- **Scholar** → **Diplomat**: Keep libraries, gain court

12.7.0.0.2 Parallel

- **Noble Merchant**: Both *Court-Announced* and *Guild-Ledgered*; obligations multiply

12.7.0.0.3 Contrasting

- **Criminal Penitent**: Underworld ties vs. temple vows; great hooks, sharp bargains

12.8 Using Backgrounds in Play

Player Applications

- Name your places: the specific stall, shrine, or yard you know
- Cash your Boon when you leverage that familiarity
- Call on your contact to assist or to introduce a new lead

GM Applications

- Offer choices where background allegiance matters
- Turn Access Tags into *gates* and *keys*
- Spend Story Beats (§9) to *complicate the old ties*

12.9 Obligations & Evolution

Obligation Clock (4)

When filled by misses, bargains, or story, something is *due*.

- 1–2 Minor favor, time, or tithe
- 3 Significant service, costly honesty, dangerous escort
- 4 Defining ordeal: duel, audit, rite, or trial

Clear segments by honoring duties on-screen, sacrificing resources, or changing affiliation (which creates new clocks).

Enhancement & Transformation

- **Enhance**: Add a tag or upgrade the contact via XP (Follower rules)
- **Transform**: Rewrite the background after a major arc; keep one tag, swap the rest, reset the clock
- **Resolution**: Retire a background after paying its *price*; gain a *Legacy Note*—a small permanent permission

12.10 Tables & Tools

Quick Background Seeds

d10	Seed
-----	------

1	Failed heir with an honest steward and a dishonest cousin
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- 2 Caravan accountant who knows three border tariffs by heart
 - 3 Bell-tender whose dusk pattern saved a village once
 - 4 Charter apprentice who broke a measure and hid it
 - 5 Ykrul courier who owes horses to two banners
 - 6 Dock acolyte who lit the beacon in a storm against orders
-

GM SB Menu: Background Complications

- **1 SB:** A rival claims your tag is invalid here; prove it or pay time
- **2 SB:** Your contact is *busy* or *watched*; help will cost you exposure
- **3 SB:** Obligation advances; an audit, rite, or muster arrives early
- **4 SB:** An enemy weaponizes your background—publicly

Background Quick Reference

At Creation

- Choose: 1 *Access Tag*, 1 *Signature Contact* (Cap 1 assist), 1 *Boon* (once/session), 1 *Obligation Seed*.
- Pick 1 language tied to the background at *Conversational* or better (§??).

In Play

- Invoke tags to open doors or shift Position.
- Call your contact for +1d assist (no independent actions).
- Track the *Obligation Clock* (4). Pay it on-screen.

Advancing

- Upgrade contact to a *Follower* by paying XP (Cap²).
- Add a second tag after a major arc or training.

12.11 Worked Examples

House Shield (Aristocratic-Military Hybrid)

- **Tags:** *Court-Announced*, *Veteran-of-the-Marches*
- **Skills:** Command, Melee, Lore (protocol)
- **Contact:** House steward (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session while guarding a principal, treat one consequence as one step less severe.
- **Hook:** Duel clock from an old slight; an audit of campaign spoils

Ledger Lantern (Merchant-Temple Bridge)

- **Tags:** *Guild-Ledgered*, *Beacon Rights*
- **Skills:** Sway, Investigation (accounts), Lore (sea rites)
- **Contact:** Beacon-keeper (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session, secure safe harbor or fair rate; DV–1.
- **Hook:** Rivals whisper of skimming tithe; prove the books

Fog Warden (Mistlands Civic)

- **Tags:** *Bell-Law*, *Causeway Rights*
- **Skills:** Perception, Survival, Sway (local law)

- **Contact:** Dusk-warden (Cap 1)
- **Boon:** Once/session in mist, choose *route-or-safety*: negate a travel delay or downgrade a hazard.
- **Hook:** Someone silences the bells; obligation advances

Let your background do work for you. Speak its language, call its favors, and pay its debts in play. The world will answer.

12.12 Player Bonds: Ties That Bind

Your background shapes your past, but the bonds you forge with other player characters shape your future. Bonds are the shared history, debts, rivalries, or affections that connect you to one another. They are not merely narrative flavor—they are mechanical resources that allow you to shift Boons, aid each other in desperate moments, and unlock powerful teamwork options late in the campaign.

12.12.1 What Bonds Represent

A bond is a ****player-to-player agreement**** about how your characters relate. It must be:

- **Mutual:** Both players agree on its nature.
- **Specific:** It names a concrete event or recurring dynamic.
- **Consequential:** It should create roleplaying opportunities and occasional friction.

12.12.1.0.1 Examples of Bonds

1. **Oath of Shared Vengeance:** “We both lost someone to the same enemy. We swore to see them fall together.”
2. **Debt of Blood:** “You saved my life when I was helpless. I owe you a debt I cannot erase.”
3. **Secret Shared:** “We know a truth that could destroy a powerful person. Neither of us can ever speak it alone.”
4. **Rivalry of Equals:** “We constantly compete, but when outsiders threaten, we fight back-to-back without hesitation.”
5. **Foster–Kin:** “Our families bound us by rite. We are not siblings by blood, but by custom.”
6. **Old Campaigners:** “We marched together in the same condotta. We’ve seen each other bleed and lie.”

12.12.2 Mechanics of Bonds

Gaining Boons Through Bonds

Once per bond ****per session****, when you take a significant action to aid the other character and explicitly reference your bond in an ****intricate description**** (see Description Ladder, §2), you both gain **1 Boon** after the action resolves.

You cannot gain this Boon for basic assistance rolls or minor favors. The aid must involve meaningful risk or sacrifice.

Re-allocating Boons (Late Game)

At ****Tier III or higher**** (90+ XP), bonds become a channel for resource sharing. Once per scene, you may transfer ****up to 2 Boons**** from your pool to a bonded ally as a free action. The transfer must be narrated (“I toss them my last flare,” “I steady their aim with a whispered cue”). This

does not count as your action for the turn.

This represents deep trust and practiced coordination—the kind only earned through shared ordeals.

Bonded Assistance

When you assist a bonded ally on a roll, the first Boon you spend to assist (see Assistance, §2) is ****refunded**** if the roll succeeds. (You still mark any Fatigue or other costs normally.)

12.12.3 Creating Bonds at Character Creation

At campaign start, each player should establish ****two bonds**** with other player characters. Use the tables below for inspiration, or invent your own.

12.12.3.0.1 Bond Triggers (roll d8 or choose)

1. **Last Stand:** “We held a breach together when no one else would.”
2. **Betrayal Forgiven:** “You could have left me, but you didn’t.”
3. **Stolen Future:** “We both lost everything in the same fire.”
4. **Geas Shared:** “A power bound us to the same task. We cannot complete it alone.”
5. **Inherited Feud:** “Our families hate each other, but we refuse to carry that hate.”
6. **Whisper Witness:** “We overheard a secret that would end us if it got out.”
7. **Trial by Ordeal:** “We survived a rite that killed the others.”
8. **Empty Promise:** “We made a vow we half-meant, but now it has teeth.”

12.12.3.0.2 Bond Flavors (roll d8 or choose)

1. **Protective:** “I will not let them fall while I draw breath.”
2. **Resentful but Reliable:** “I don’t like them, but I owe them.”
3. **Playful Rivalry:** “They beat me at cards every night. I’ll get them back when it counts.”
4. **Devotion:** “They are the reason I still believe in anything.”
5. **Curiosity:** “I don’t understand them, but I need to.”
6. **Dependence:** “Without them, I would have drowned in my own mistakes.”
7. **Inspiration:** “They make me want to be better.”
8. **Doom-Bound:** “The omens say one of us will betray the other. I will prove them wrong.”

12.12.4 Evolving Bonds

Bonds are not static. At the end of a major story arc (GM discretion), you may:

- **Deepen a bond:** Add a second specific trigger. That bond now grants +1 Boon instead of 1 when invoked (still once per session).
- **Sever a bond:** Replace it with a new bond with the same player, or with a different player if the narrative supports it. Severing a bond before its natural conclusion generates **2 SB** for the GM (the rupture has consequences).
- **Transform a bond:** Change its flavor (e.g., from “Resentful” to “Respectful”) and reset its mechanical benefits as if new.

12.12.5 Bonds and the Late Game

As characters gain influence (Tier IV–V), bonds become the primary currency of high-stakes teamwork. Boon transfers allow one character to fuel another’s desperate rite or finishing blow.

GMs are encouraged to present challenges where no single character can succeed alone—where only bonded pairs or trios can split responsibilities, cover weaknesses, and share the load.

12.12.5.0.1 Example: The party’s Cantor has 4 Boons but is cornered and low on Fatigue. The Fighter (bonded to the Cantor) transfers 2 Boons as a free action, then uses their own action to defend. The Cantor spends those Boons to reroll a failed casting, saving the party from a collapsing ceiling.

12.12.6 Bond Hooks for the Tables Below

When you choose a background from the previous sections, consider how your bond with another PC might connect to your signature contact, obligation seed, or access tag.

- **Aristocratic House Scion + Marcher Veteran:** “Your family hired my company. I still blame you for the lost patrol.”
- **Underworld Hand + Urban Child:** “We grew up in the same tenement. You kept my secrets; I kept yours.”
- **Aeler Charter Apprentice + Mistlands Bell-Keeper:** “We met in the high passes. Your bell saved me from a fog wraith; my stone-lore saved you from a collapsed gallery.”

12.13 Bonds Quick Reference

Bonds Summary

At Creation:

- Establish 2 bonds with other PCs.
- Define trigger / flavor / mutual benefit.

Per Session:

- Once per bond per session, invoke with intricate description → both gain 1 Boon.

Tier III+ (90+ XP):

- Transfer up to 2 Boons to bonded ally as free action (once per scene).

Bonded Assistance:

- First Boon spent to assist a bonded ally is refunded on a successful roll.

Evolving:

- Deepen, sever, or transform after major arcs.

Chapter 13

The Legacy Engine

Succession & Faction Building

“Your legacy is not what you build — it is who you build.”

The Legacy Engine is a narrative framework that helps your campaign grow across generations without losing emotional continuity. It treats succession as a story event — earned through action, consequence, and choice — rather than a mechanical transaction.

This chapter is for tables where characters retire, die, or pass on their cause to a follower. It is not required for every campaign, but when the moment comes, these tools help the transition feel earned and the new character feel connected.

13.1 Core Philosophy

The Legacy Engine follows three principles:

1. **Narrative Primacy** — Succession happens because the story demands it, not because a clock fills.
2. **People Before Power** — A follower becomes a PC because of who they are, not what they can do.
3. **Consequences Persist** — Every legacy creates debts, rivals, and unfinished work that the successor must carry.

Legacy is not inherited cleanly. It comes wrapped in obligation.

13.2 When Does Succession Happen?

Succession is not automatic. It emerges from play. Common triggers include:

- A PC retires after completing a major arc.
- A PC dies or is permanently removed from play.
- A player wants to explore a new character but keep the same faction or cause alive.
- The campaign shifts to a new generation (years or decades later).

In all cases, the transition should be discussed openly at the table. The GM and player collaborate to find the right moment.

13.3 Choosing a Successor

A successor should already exist in the fiction. Typically, this is a **Follower** (see §8) with whom the PC has a meaningful relationship. It could also be a family member, a student, a loyal lieutenant, or even a rival who earns respect.

13.3.0.0.1 What Makes a Good Successor?

- They have a name, a face, and a voice.
- They have acted independently (off-screen or on-screen) at least once.
- They want something that the PC's faction or cause can provide.
- They have a flaw or burden that will complicate their rise.

If no suitable follower exists, the GM and player can create one retroactively — but that character arrives with less established history. The player may need to spend a session or two building them up before succession feels earned.

13.4 The Succession Arc

A smooth transition usually follows three beats. They can span one session or several, depending on the table's pace.

13.4.1 1. The Call

The follower faces a moment where they must act beyond their role. Examples:

- The PC is incapacitated, absent, or compromised.
- A decision must be made that no one else can make.
- A crisis demands leadership rather than obedience.

This scene answers: *Why this person, now?*

13.4.2 2. The Trial

The follower is tested. The trial can be:

- A single high-stakes scene (e.g., a duel, a negotiation, a desperate escape).
- A short sequence of escalating challenges (2–3 scenes).
- A moral or political decision with lasting impact.

Success is not guaranteed. Failure does not end the story — it changes it. A follower who fails may still become a PC, but they carry a scar, a doubt, or a broken promise into their new role.

13.4.3 3. The Ascension

At a dramatically appropriate moment — often during downtime or immediately after a crisis — the follower formally takes up the mantle. This might involve:

- A public ceremony (crowning, oath-swearing, banner-raising).
- A private passing of a symbol (sword, key, ledger).
- A quiet acknowledgment (“You’re in charge now.”).

The departing PC may be present, or they may be gone. Either way, the scene marks the end of one

chapter and the beginning of another.

13.5 What the Successor Inherits

When a follower becomes a PC, they do not simply copy the old character sheet. Instead, they inherit three things:

13.5.1 1. Faction Standing

The successor begins with the same reputation, allies, and enemies that the previous PC cultivated. The GM may adjust specific relationships based on how the succession occurred (e.g., a contested succession might lose one ally but gain a bitter rival).

13.5.2 2. One Unresolved Burden

The player and GM choose one burden that the successor must carry forward. Examples:

- **Oath of Succession:** “You must protect the valley as I did.”
- **Unfinished Task:** “Find my daughter. Tell her I’m sorry.”
- **Rival Claim:** Another faction – or a jealous lieutenant – disputes your right to lead.

This burden is a narrative hook, not a mechanical penalty. It gives the new character immediate purpose.

13.5.3 3. A Legacy Bond

The successor has a bond to their predecessor. Once per session, the player may invoke this bond to:

- Recall a memory that provides insight.
- Receive instinctive guidance in a familiar situation.
- Gain a free **Boon** when acting to uphold the predecessor’s values.

This bond fades over time as the successor finds their own identity – but it never vanishes entirely.

13.6 Building a Faction Through Succession

Each time a character passes the torch, the faction (or cause) grows. It accumulates history, traditions, and institutional memory.

13.6.1 Growth Through People

Rather than tracking territory or wealth, track the faction’s **reach** through the people who are now part of its story. Each successor adds:

- A new contact or ally they brought with them.
- A new problem they inherited.
- A new custom or saying that arose from their trials.

The GM keeps a simple list: “*The Banner of the Broken Wheel*,” “*the annual vigil at Sootfall Abbey*,” “*the debt to the Mistland ferryman*.” These are the faction’s real assets.

13.6.2 Faction Clocks (Optional)

For tables that want mechanical weight, the faction can track two simple clocks:

- **Growth (6–8):** When filled, the faction gains a new narrative permission (e.g., a safehouse in a new city, a reliable spy, a permanent shrine).
- **Health (6):** When filled, a crisis erupts – a rival attacks, a leader dies, a secret is exposed. The current PC must deal with it or watch the faction fracture.

These clocks advance only when the fiction demands – not automatically.

13.7 Example: The Fallen Captain

Miranda has played Kael, captain of the Iron Tide mercenary company, for two years. Kael dies defending a village from a wyrm. The player wants to continue the story.

13.7.0.0.1 The Successor Kael’s second-in-command, a grizzled scout named Vesper, has been a follower (Cap 3) for many sessions. Vesper once disobeyed an order to save wounded civilians – a defining moment.

13.7.0.0.2 The Call At Kael’s funeral pyre, the company looks to Vesper. No one else steps forward.

13.7.0.0.3 The Trial Vesper must negotiate a new contract with a wary noble who doubts the company’s future without Kael. The player rolls, succeeds with cost – the noble agrees, but demands a hostage.

13.7.0.0.4 The Ascension Vesper takes up Kael’s banner. The player erases Kael’s character sheet and creates Vesper as a new PC (starting XP based on campaign tier). Vesper inherits:

- The Iron Tide as a **Mercenary Contract (Standard Asset)**.
- The burden: *“Find the noble’s missing son – or lose the contract.”*
- A legacy bond to Kael: once per session, recall Kael’s advice to gain a Boon when leading the company.

The campaign continues without missing a beat.

13.8 Campaign End: The Final Legacy

When the campaign ends, the player may describe one lasting mark the faction leaves on the world. Examples:

- A new law named after the first PC.
- A shrine where the PC fell, still tended by followers.
- A phrase that enters common speech (“Stand like Kael”).

The story ends – but the legacy remains.

A character dies. A faction endures. A story echoes forward.

Chapter 14

Enhanced Player Play

14.1 Enhanced Coordination

In Fate's Edge, teamwork isn't just about helping—it's about creating decisive moments through coordinated action. These rules help you and your allies combine efforts for greater impact.

14.1.1 Core Coordination Principles

- **Fiction First:** Describe how you help before rolling dice
- **Clear Stakes:** State what help changes and what risk the helper accepts
- **One Spotlight:** Resolve one acting character's roll; fold assistance into that action
- **Visible Costs:** Story Beats, Fatigue, and consequences are tracked openly

14.1.2 Basic Assistance

- **Declare Help:** An ally states a concrete contribution (tools, opening, cover)
- **Benefit:** Acting character gains +1d (up to table's assist cap)
- **Limits:** One assistant per PC per exchange by default
- **Cost:** Assistant accepts any risk named by the GM (SB, Fatigue, collateral)

14.1.3 Cooperative Talents

Certain talents enhance group coordination:

Inspire (3 XP) Once per scene, spend 1 Boon to choose one:

- **Bonded Ally:** That ally gains +1 Boon and +1d on their next roll
- **Self:** Gain +1d on your next roll this scene
- **Rally:** Each other PC in Near gains +1d on their next roll
- **Tactical Coordination:** All allies currently acting gain +1 Position

Spotter's Mark (3 XP) Aim a target (1 action). Until end of scene, allies in Near may claim +1d or +1 Effect once vs. that target.

Battle Cant (2 XP) Once per scene, establish silent signals. On next coordinated action where at least two PCs act, those PCs gain +1 Position.

Shield Wall (4 XP) If you and at least one ally each wield a shield and are adjacent: as a Defend action, grant +1d Defend to all in the Wall and convert first incoming Harm to Fatigue.

14.1.4 Stacking Limits

To prevent overwhelming combinations, a PC may benefit from at most two cooperative effects on the same action. Choose which apply when multiple sources could stack.

14.1.5 Timing and Sequencing

- **Declare Order:** Players state intent in any order; resolve acting roll first
- **Ready/Overwatch:** Hold an action with clear trigger; resolve before next exchange
- **Refresh Windows:** "Once/scene" effects reset at scene end

14.1.6 Working With Followers

Followers can assist for up to +3d (or +4d with Exceptional Coordination talent). They can't receive PC-only benefits unless a talent states otherwise.

14.1.7 Magic Coordination

- **Ritual Support:** Allies can assist Weave or Cast phases if fiction allows
- **Rite Preparation:** Helpers can provide components or maintain focus
- **Imbuement Synergy:** Multiple characters can prepare for shared magical effort

14.1.8 Best Practices for Players

1. **Be Specific:** "I'll flank left to give you advantage" is better than "I help"
2. **Accept Risk:** Good assistance often means putting yourself in harm's way
3. **Think Creatively:** Tools, positioning, and timing matter more than raw dice
4. **Support Bonds:** Use coordination to strengthen character relationships
5. **Keep Momentum:** Quick, clear assistance keeps scenes moving

Remember: The best coordination enhances the story and makes everyone's moments shine brighter together.

14.2 Optional Player-Character Death

By default, Fate's Edge treats death as rare and dramatic. Use any of the following modules (singly or in combination) to tune how lethal your table feels. All options respect **Story Beats (SB)** and **Obligation** as core currencies.

Baseline (Default)

PCs do not die on ordinary failures. Instead, they suffer **Harm**, Conditions, lost opportunities, or narrative costs. Death only occurs when a rule below is in play or the table agrees a scene warrants it.

Option A — Severe Harm Death

Trigger. When a PC would take a **third** instance of Severe Harm (or escalate past the top of your harm track), they instead face death.

Stave It Off. The player may avoid death by choosing one: (1) mark **2 SB** *and* take a MAIMED permanent Condition, (2) accept a **Patron's Claim** (see Option D), or (3) convert the blow into a **Last Stand** (Option C).

Option B — Death Clock

Trigger. Catastrophic consequences (falls, crushes, mortal wounds) fill a named **Death Clock** (4 or 6 ticks).

While Ticking. Actions that stabilize reduce the clock; taking further punishment advances it.

When Full. The character dies unless one of the following occurs immediately: spend **2 SB** to hold at full (buy a single action), accept a **Patron's Claim**, or another PC succeeds at *Pull From the Brink* (risky, effect = clock -2 on success).

Option C — Last Stand

Trigger. On lethal harm or a full Death Clock, the player may declare a **Last Stand**.

Effect. For the remainder of the scene, the PC acts with **+1 effect** and ignores new Harm. Each action automatically creates **1 SB**. When the scene ends, the character **dies** unless a **miracle** is secured (Patron rite, relic, or equivalent).

Option D — Patron's Claim

Trigger. On death, the PC's Patron (or a circling power) intervenes.

Bargain. The GM offers 1–3 -negotiable terms (e.g., *Obligation +2, forfeit a Gift, become a vessel for a season*). If accepted, the PC lives; mark the costs immediately and record the **Claim** as an ongoing front. Refusal means the death proceeds.

Note. Claims should change the campaign; use sparingly.

Option E — Dramatic Exit Inheritance

Dramatic Exit. The player may choose a meaningful death that resolves a question or saves others.

Inheritance. The next PC created by that player inherits one of: (a) a **Relationship** (bond, contact, or rival), (b) a **Tool** (asset degraded one step), or (c) a **Lesson** (start with +1 XP toward a Talent used in the exit). Record how the world remembers them.

Option F — Return From Beyond

Trigger. A body, a name, and a path (rite, gate, bargain).

Cost. Treat as a High Rite with Obligation appropriate to the transgression. Set DV using the Rites system. On success, the PC returns **changed**: apply a SCAR (permanent Condition) and **1 SB** to the rescuer. On failure, choose: lose the body, or return with a Patron's Claim.

Quick Picks

Low lethality: Baseline + Death Clock only. **Heroic tragedy:** Severe Harm Death + Last Stand + Inheritance. **Dark bargains:** Any combo with Patron's Claim.

The world of **Fate's Edge** sings when players help steer the tune. This chapter gathers *player-facing dials*—lightweight, opt-in mechanics that turn your table's choices into momentum in the fiction of Viterra, Acasia, Ecktoria, Ubral, and the long coasts besides. Treat these as a menu: use a few, or layer many as your group grows comfortable.

14.3 Player Resources

Two shared languages of play appear throughout this chapter:

Boons Core system edge; spend to power talents or convert to XP (per core rules).

SB The GM's Story Beats; several options here invite players to accept SB in exchange for narrative benefits.

14.4 Engagement Rewards

14.4.1 Session Investment Tracker

At session close, each player privately rates their *investment* (1–3). The tracker rewards steady participation without penalizing quiet nights.

- 1 — **Low** You followed others' lead. Gain **+1d** once next session on any *support* action.
- 2 — **Medium** You took initiative in some scenes. Gain **+1d** once next session on a *relationship* roll and bank 1 **Momentum** (see §14.7.1).
- 3 — **High** You anchored or elevated multiple scenes. Gain **+1d** twice next session (different scenes) and bank 1 **Momentum**.

14.4.1.0.1 Table Boon. If *all* players report 2+ in a session, the GM may award the table 1 **free Boon** to assign at the start of the next session.

14.4.2 Cultural Immersion Bonus

Reward lived-in play with light, predictable benefits.

- **Earn 1 Culture Point** when you enrich a scene with apt language, rites, or customs (Sea-Patter hail; bell-speech courtesy; Aeler craft-honorifics). Max **3/session**.
- **Spend 3 Culture** for **+1d** on a culturally keyed roll.
- **Spend 5 Culture** (across sessions) to declare a *trusted door*: one institution in that culture treats you as Friendly for the next approach.

14.5 Collaborative Play

14.5.1 Information Trading

When the table hunts answers, convert curiosity into structure.

14.5.1.0.1 Request & Price. State the question and choose a price the table accepts:

Devil's Bargain Offer the GM a future complication to "pay" for deeper intel.

Accept SB The GM gains **+1 SB** now; you gain a strategic clue or reduced DV.

Spend Boon Spend 1 **Boon** to lower DV by 1 on the research/social approach.

14.5.1.0.2 Creative Methods. Swap coin for color: poetry duels, shrine petitions, map-reading at a parish stone. If your method sings with setting, take **+1 effect** on the check.

14.5.2 Clock Manipulation

Players can nudge tension without rewriting stakes.

- **Slow** a visible Clock by **1 segment** by either **spending 1 Boon** *or accepting +1 SB* into the scene (fiction must justify delay).
- **Hasten** a visible Clock by **1 segment** by **spending 1 Momentum** (§14.7.1) *or taking a Devil's Bargain*.
- **Limit:** Once per player per scene. If three or more players affect the same Clock in a scene, the GM gains **+1 SB**.

14.5.3 Complication Bargaining

Invite the kind of trouble you want to play.

- Name a *type*: social, physical, mystery, or moral (e.g., Valora court etiquette; Ubral scree; Isoka whispers; oath vs. mercy).
- The GM frames the complication accordingly and grants you **+1d** on your next roll *within* that trouble, or reduces DV by 1 if your approach leans into the specified texture.

14.6 Faction Awareness

14.6.1 Loyalty Recognition

Track a simple ladder ($-3 \dots +3$): *Enemy, Hostile, Unfriendly, Neutral, Friendly, Supportive, Ally*. When you act *with* an institution's aims, mark a **tick** toward the next step (GM pacing). When you betray a stated value, drop one step immediately and the GM banks **+1 SB** for future headaches.

14.6.2 Cross-Cultural Synergies

Spotting a neat cultural combo (Zakov pilots + Kahfagia signals; Aeler engineering + Ecktoria charters) grants **+1d** once per scene the synergy is actively used.

14.7 Advanced Techniques

14.7.1 Momentum Banking

When your team resolves a Clock *early* (segments unspent), bank **1 Momentum** per unused segment (max **2/session**). Spend 1 Momentum to:

- Gain **+1d** on a future approach tied to that victory (*lessons learned*); or
- *Telescope* a travel beat (skip a routine obstacle the same route would present); or
- Trigger a *Prepared Move*: declare a sensible minor setup you plausibly arranged off-screen.

14.7.2 Escalation Management

Trade heat for shape.

- **De-escalate (spend 1 Boon):** Downgrade a Major consequence to Minor with a plausible concession (quiet tolls paid, harsh words eaten).
- **Redirect (accept +1 SB):** Shift pressure to a new venue or actor you name; the GM places that SB there as attention.
- **Truce (spend 1 Momentum):** Freeze a faction's hostility for one scene if you can cite a shared value (oath, rite, charter clause).

14.8 Character Creation Enhancements

Players may take up to **2 Bonds** (+2 XP total) and up to **2 Starting Complications** (+4 XP total) for a cap of **34 XP**. Each unresolved starting Complication adds **+1 banked SB** to early scenes until cleared. Favor *storyful* picks (clan honor, guild debt, patron notice) over pure math.

14.9 Downtime

Between sessions, tend your garden—quietly moving the world.

14.9.1 Bookkeeping

- Allocate XP (respecting days required).
- Update Assets/Followers (status: Maintained, Neglected, Compromised).
- Track Boons (conversion cap remains 2 XP/session).
- Note SB Debt from unresolved Complications.

14.9.2 Activities

- **Recovery:** Clear Harm/Exposure with scenes that show the work.
- **Training:** Buy advances; narrate mentors, gyms, scriptoria.
- **Research:** Lower DVs with good sources; log new leads.
- **Social:** Strengthen Bonds; tune faction attitudes.
- **Preparation:** Cache gear, sow rumors, line up ferries.

14.9.3 Strategic Considerations

Clear SB-debt complications first; synchronize travel plans; decide which Asset gets love this interval, and which follower needs face-time to avoid Neglect.

14.10 Implementation Timeline

Sessions 1–3

Investment Tracker, Information Trading (via Boons/Bargains), light Complication Bargaining.

Sessions 4–6

Clock Manipulation (Boon/Momentum/SB), Cultural Immersion, Faction Awareness, Momentum Banking.

Sessions 7+

Cross-Cultural Synergies, Escalation Management, advanced pacing choreography.

At-Table Prompts

Seed the Scene. "Ask for the kind of complication you want."

Name the Stakes. "Is this clock worth slowing? Who pays—Boon, SB, or Momentum?"

Pay with Color. "What custom or rite do you invoke to make this work?"

Close the Loop. "Mark your Investment; one sentence of what you learned."

14.10.1 War Mount (Asset)

Type: Standard Asset

XP Cost: 8 XP

Scale: Personal

Maintenance: Regular care, feed, rest

A trained combat mount—warhorse, dune-strider, battle elk, ash lizard, or equivalent—conditioned for violence, chaos, and discipline.

14.10.1.0.1 Passive Benefits While mounted:

- Increase overland travel speed and endurance.
- Ignore the first movement-based complication per session (mud, crowd, loose terrain).
- Mounted positioning may override terrain restrictions at GM discretion.

14.10.1.0.2 Mounted Combat If the rider has the **Cavalier** talent:

- Melee attacks made while moving **Far** → **Near**: +2d
- Ranged attacks made while moving **Near** → **Far**: +2d

14.10.1.0.3 Boon Activation Spend 1 **Boon** to invoke the mount dramatically:

- Break through a hostile line or crowd
- Escape pursuit across hostile terrain
- Gain **Controlled Position** for a mounted action
- Advance or suppress a movement-related Clock

14.10.1.0.4 Risk and Wear On a *Partial* or *Miss* involving mounted actions, the GM may:

- Mark **Mount Fatigue**
- Damage tack, barding, or terrain access
- Threaten or compromise the Asset

14.10.1.0.5 Mount Fatigue If Mount Fatigue reaches 3:

- The mount cannot be used in combat until rested
- Further strain risks permanent injury or loss

14.10.1.0.6 Promoting a War Mount A War Mount may be promoted to a **Follower** if:

- It is named and narratively significant
- The rider takes a dedicated Bond or Talent

As a Follower, the mount:

- Can take actions independently (trample, defend, flee)
- Can suffer Harm
- May generate Boons through sacrifice or risk

Pike Discipline (Major Talent, 4 XP) [FORMATION] [CONTROL]

Requirements: Melee 2+, Discipline or Command 1+

You are trained to break mounted assaults through spacing, timing, and fearlessness.

14.10.1.0.7 Effect When you **Brace** against a mounted opponent:

- Cancel all **Cavalier** movement bonuses
- Mounted attackers suffer **-1d** on the attack

14.10.1.0.8 On Success

- Reduce incoming Harm by 1
- You may force the rider to **Disengage** or risk mount injury

14.10.1.0.9 On Partial

- Reduce Harm by 1
- Mark 1 Fatigue or lose formation

14.10.1.0.10 Limits

- Requires braced footing or prepared terrain
- Ineffective if flanked, surprised, or outnumbered

14.11 Between Sessions Activities Log

Use or print the following trackers.

14.11.1 Character Advancement

XP Allocation

- Total XP Available: _____
- Attributes Spent: _____ (=____ days)
- Skills Spent: _____ (=____ days)
- Remaining XP: _____

Attribute Improvements

Attribute	Old	New	Cost	Days
Body				
Spirit				
Presence				
Wits				

Skill Improvements

Skill	Old	New	Cost	Days
Arcana				
Combat				
Investigate				
Lore				
Move				
Notice				
Physique				
Resolve				
Stealth				
Sway				
Survival				

14.11.2 Asset & Follower Management

Assets

Name	Tier	Status	Notes

Followers

Name	Role	Harm	Exposure	Status

14.11.3 Bonds & Complications

Bonds Updated

- With: _____ — Change: _____

Complications

Complication	Resolution or Status

14.11.4 Boons & Momentum Summary

- Boons Held: ____/5 Converted to XP: ____ (max 2 XP/session)
- Momentum Banked: ____ (max 2/session)

14.11.5 Campaign Clocks

- Mandate: ____ / 6 Crisis: ____ / 6
- Notables: _____

14.12 Tactical Play for Players

Combat and high-stakes scenes in Fate's Edge reward clever thinking as much as raw dice. This section offers practical, player-facing advice for common situations. Use these tactics to turn the fiction in your favor.

14.12.1 Closing on Ranged and Magic Users

A Bowman on a balcony or a mage behind a ward can shred your party from a distance. Close the gap without getting shredded.

- **Use Cover and Movement.** The game's Position system (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) rewards tactical positioning. Move from cover to cover. Spend a **Move action** to dash between obstacles. If you end your movement behind solid cover, the GM may set your next defense roll as **Controlled** instead of Desperate.
- **Create Distractions.** Spend 1 **Boon** to describe a diversion — kick over a brazier, shove a table, yell a false order. On a successful **Deception** or **Command** roll, the ranged attacker may lose their or shift their attention for one exchange, dropping your Position penalty by one step.
- **Teamwork: The Running Shield.** Have a heavily armored ally take the **Defend** action while moving forward. They can intercept incoming shots (converting Harm to Fatigue) while you sprint behind them. The GM may rule that the defender's body blocks line of sight, granting you **Dominant** position for your next approach.
- **Suppress Them.** If you have a ranged weapon, use the **Suppress** option (see Core Mechanics). You don't need to hit — just force the enemy to keep their head down. The GM may impose a -1 die penalty on their next attack or worsen their Position.
- **Spend Boons to Close.** When you're stuck in the open, spend 1 **Boon** to improve your Position by one step before rolling your movement or defense. That can mean the difference between a bolt in the chest and a glancing hit.

14.12.1.0.1 Example. Lyra (rogue) wants to cross a courtyard to reach a mage on a balcony. She spends 1 Boon to improve her Position from Desperate to Controlled, then declares she's staying close to a crumbling wall. The GM rules that the mage's magic missile is at -1 die because of partial cover. Lyra makes it across with a Partial success, taking Fatigue instead of Harm.

14.12.2 When You're Outmatched

Sometimes the enemy is bigger, faster, or more numerous. You can still win — or survive.

- **Don't Trade Blows.** Instead of attacking, use your action to **Setup** for an ally (grant them +1 Position or step up Effect). Spend 1 Boon to assist them directly (+1 die). One well-supported PC can turn a fight faster than two desperate ones.
- **Accept Story Beats (SB) to Buy Time.** When you roll a Partial or Miss, the GM gets SB. You can proactively offer to accept +1 SB (banked, not spent now) in exchange for a short narrative delay: "I fall back behind a pillar – they lose sight of me for a moment." This doesn't change the roll's outcome, but it gives you a breath to reposition.
- **Spend Boons on Defense, Not Offense.** When you're outnumbered, a missed attack hurts less than a received hit. Save Boons to re-roll failed defense rolls or to improve your Position before an enemy's big swing. A **Boon spent to re-roll a 1 on a defense roll** can prevent Harm 2 or 3.
- **Escape and Reset.** There's no shame in running. Use the **Withdraw** action (see Core Mechanics). Spend 1 Boon to make it a **Controlled** withdrawal instead of Desperate. You live to fight another scene.
- **Use the Environment as a Weapon.** Ask the GM: "Is there a chandelier I can drop? A sand pile? A steep stair?" If the answer is yes, describe how you trigger it. The GM may set a low DV (2-3) and on success, the obstacle deals Harm, imposes a Condition, or improves the party's Position for a round.

14.12.2.0.1 Example. Kael (fighter) is alone against three bandits. Instead of attacking, he spends 1 Boon to assist the group's archer, then uses his action to kick over a brazier. The GM calls for a Body + Athletics roll (DV 2). Kael succeeds — the fire creates a smoky screen, worsening the bandits' Position to Desperate for one exchange. The archer picks one off.

14.12.3 When to Push It — and When Not To

The **Push It** mechanic (usually on Rites or Cantor Songs) lets you escalate an effect immediately at a cost: extra Obligation, Fatigue, Corruption, or a GM Story Beat. Use it wisely.

Good Times to Push

- **Preventing a Party Wipe.** If a teammate is about to take lethal Harm, Push to get that heal or ward off now.
- **Ending a Scene.** The clock is about to fill, or the enemy leader is fleeing. Push to finish it.
- **When the Cost Is Acceptable.** If you have spare Fatigue, or you're already at max Obligation and about to trigger a Patron demand anyway, the extra cost doesn't hurt as much.

Avoid Pushing When

- **You're Already in Trouble.** Pushing adds Fatigue or SB. If you're already at Fatigue 2 or have a full Death Clock, the extra cost could break you.
- **A Partial Success Is Enough.** Many Rites and Songs still work on a Partial — just weaker or shorter. Sometimes that's all you need. Don't pay extra for power you don't require.

- **The GM Is Low on SB.** If the GM has 0–1 SB banked, they can’t immediately punish a miss. But if they have 3+, a failed Push could trigger a major twist. Check the table’s SB tracker before deciding.

How to Avoid Needing to Push

- **Use Boons Early.** Spend 1 Boon to improve your Position before the roll. A Controlled roll is less likely to fail than a Desperate one.
- **Get Help.** Have an ally assist you (spend 1 Boon for +1 die). That +1 die might turn a Partial into a Clean Success.
- **Lower the DV with Fiction.** Describe how you create ideal conditions. “I wait for the guards to change shift” might lower DV by 1. “I use my Scholar’s Cell free use to research the ward’s pattern” could drop DV from 4 to 3.
- **Accept Failure and Bank Boons.** A Miss gives you 2 Boons. Sometimes it’s better to fail now, take the 2 Boons, and try again next round with a bigger pool or better Position.

14.12.3.0.1 Example. Sariel (Cantor) needs to charm a guard quickly. She could Push to resolve the Song instantly, but she’s already at Fatigue 2. Instead, she spends 1 Boon to improve her Position from Controlled to Dominant, then has an ally whisper a distraction (assist, another Boon). She rolls 4 dice (Lore + Performance) against DV 3. She gets 3 successes – a Clean Success. No Push needed, and she saved her Fatigue.

14.12.4 General Player Tips for Enhanced Experience

- **Track Your Boons, Fatigue, and Obligation.** These are your resources. Know them as well as your hit points in other games. A character with 4 Boons and 0 Fatigue is much stronger than one with 0 Boons and Fatigue 2.
- **Use Bonds to Shift Boons.** At Tier III, you can transfer up to 2 Boons to a bonded ally as a free action. This lets you fuel the party’s best character for a crucial roll. Don’t hoard.
- **Communicate Your Intent.** Tell the GM what you want to achieve, not just what skill you’re rolling. “I want to scare him into dropping the keys” is better than “I roll Intimidation.” The GM can set a fairer DV and offer better consequences.
- **Ask About the Environment.** “Is there loose gravel? A tapestried wall? A rain barrel?” These become levers. The GM wants you to use them.
- **Know When to Fold.** Not every fight is winnable. Spending 2 Boons to escape with everyone alive is a victory. The game rewards survival and smart choices, not just corpse counts.
- **Use Downtime.** Between sessions, update your logs, tend your Assets, and clear Complications. A well-maintained Asset (Neglected → Maintained) can save your life next session. A cleared Complication removes a GM “free SB” button.
- **Talk to Your GM.** If a rule feels off or a scene drags, speak up. Fate’s Edge is collaborative. The GM can adjust DV, offer alternative stakes, or introduce a Devil’s Bargain to keep things moving.

Appendix X: Player Tools and Quick Reference

This appendix provides lightweight, table-friendly tools for tracking character progress, campaign state, and moment-to-moment rules. Print, photocopy, or copy to index cards for use at the table.

Physical Tracker Recommendations

Many groups find that physical, tactile trackers speed up play and reduce mental load. Consider:

- **Poker chips or glass beads** for Boons and Story Beats (SB). *Keep a small bowl of chips in the center of the table – spend and earn visibly.*
- **Dry-erase boards or laminated sheets** for clocks (4/6/8 segment circles). *Use a wet-erase marker; draw a new clock each scene.*
- **Index cards (3×5)** for Assets and Followers. *Write the Asset’s name, free use, and surge on one side; flip when used.*
- **Colored paperclips or binder clips** on character sheets for Fatigue and Harm tracks. *Slide the clip up or down – no erasing.*
- **Printed “clock wheels”** (a circle divided into 4/6/8 wedges) placed inside a page protector. *Mark wedges with a dry-erase marker, erase with tissue.*
- **D10 dice** to track temporary modifiers (Position, Effect, or Momentum). *Place the die next to the relevant tracker and tick up or down.*

Resolution Index Card

Declare Action → Build Dice Pool (Attribute + Skill) → Roll → Count Successes

0 Successes = **Miss** (GM gains SB, consequences)

1–3 Successes = **Partial** (success + complication)

4+ Successes = **Full Success** (clear win, no complication)

Position (Risk) + **Effect** (Impact) may shift outcomes.

SB (Story Beats) fuel abilities, magic, momentum, and narrative pushes.

Fatigue and Harm Tracker

Fatigue: _____ (Max = Body)

Mental Fatigue: _____

Harm: [] Harm 1 (–1 die) [] Harm 2 (–2 dice) [] Harm 3 (Incapacitated)

When tracks fill:

- Fatigue overflow → increase Harm by 1, clear Fatigue.
- Mental Fatigue → causes instability or disadvantage.
- Harm 3 → Last Stand or Patron’s Claim (see §14.2).

SB and Momentum Tracking

Current SB (GM pool): _____

Momentum (party pool): _____ (max 2)

Used this session: _____

Talent Progression

XP Cost	Talent Type / Impact
2 XP	Minor Talent / Perk upgrade / situational bonus
4 XP	Major Talent / specialization / strong permanent effect
6 XP	Access talent (Spellcraft, Familiar, Codex, Patron's Symbol)
8 XP	Prestige Talent / campaign-defining ability

Character Goals Card

Name: _____

Core Drive: _____

Short-Term Goal (1–2 sessions): _____

Long-Term Goal (arc): _____

Background Complication: _____

Relationship That Matters: _____

Physical tip: Print this card on cardstock, fold in half, and stand it in front of you as a reminder.

Faction Attitude Card

Faction Name: _____

Attitude: -3 -2 -1 0 +1 +2 +3

Notes: _____

Player Orientation Card (Quick Principles)

1. **Declare Bold Action** — Drive fiction forward.
2. **Accept Consequences** — Complications create story.
3. **Spend Story Beats** — Make moments matter.
4. **Use Boons** — Re-roll, improve Position, activate Assets.
5. **Share the Spotlight** — Assist, bond, set up allies.

Class / Archetype Resource Quick Reference

Archetype	Core Resource
Fighter / Warrior	Maneuvers, Fatigue, Weapon Mastery
Rogue / Scout	Positioning, Stealth, Backstab
Caster (Freeform)	Spellcraft, Elemental Tags, Backlash
Runekeeper	Rites, Obligation, Codex
Invoker	Rituals, Patron's Symbol, Crack the Seal
Cantor	Songs, Corruption Clock, Repertoire
Summoner	Leash Clock, Spirit Bond, Pact

How to Engage with the GM (Player Prompts)

- **Ask:** “What do I need to roll?” – get the DV and Position.
- **Propose:** “Can I spend SB to achieve X?” – negotiate narrative pushes.
- **Declare:** “Here’s my intent and method.” – always state what you want to happen.

- **Offer:** “I’ll take a complication if Y happens.” – invite Devil’s Bargains.
- **Clarify:** “What’s at risk if I fail?” – know the stakes before rolling.

Downtime Project Tracker

Name: _____ **Segments:** [] [] [] [] [] []
Goal: _____
Obstacles / Resources Needed: _____

Physical tip: Use a 6-segment whiteboard clock. Each downtime, erase one segment and roll for progress.

What Consequence Do You Accept? (Menu for GM)

When a player fails or partially succeeds, the GM may offer a choice from this list (or invent a custom one):

- Harm (level 1 or 2)
- Fatigue (1 or 2)
- Lost Advantage (Position worsens, a clock advances)
- Time Delays (a clock ticks, a deadline tightens)
- Exposure / Heat (attention from enemies, bounty)
- Resource Depletion (supply clock tick, gear compromised)
- Relationship Strain (a bond or faction attitude worsens)

Ways to Shine in Fate’s Edge

- Tie actions to your drives and backstory – invoke your Background Boon.
- Offer complications and accept them – earn Boons.
- Spend SB to escalate or transform the scene – make failure memorable.
- Use your class resource early and often – don’t hoard.
- Connect scenes to campaign themes – name the faction or place.
- Make other characters look cool – assist, set up, pass the spotlight.

Blank Player Index Cards (for quick notes)

Name / Boons / Fatigue / Harm

Clocks / Obligation / Scene Notes

Final Reminder

Your character sheet is not your character. It is a tool to help you express who they have been, who they are becoming, and how their choices change the world.

Use these tools to make that expression vivid, consequential, and memorable.

Appendix Y: Magic Systems Reference

Magic in Fate's Edge is plural. Different traditions channel power through different metaphysical structures, but all obey the same truth:

Power has a cost, and magic shapes the one who wields it.

This appendix provides quick-reference tools for players using magic-affiliated systems, talismans, rites, and occult practices.

Core Magical Principles

- Magic expresses **identity and belief**.
- Casting always creates **consequences somewhere**.
- Magic rewrites reality through **intention, structure, or sacrifice**.
- Excessive power erodes **choice** (see Iconic Ascension sidebar).

Universal Casting Reference

Cast Declaration Template:

1. **Intent** — What change do you seek?
2. **Shape** — How does your tradition express it?
3. **Cost** — What do you risk or expend?
4. **Resolution** — Test; apply Position/Effect rules.
5. **Backwash** — Mark Fatigue, SB pressure, taboo, instability, or bargain.

Magic Tradition Quick Reference

Freeform Arcana (Wizardry) *Creative, rational, deliberate shaping.* Tools: Glyphs, structures, metaphors. Costs: Fatigue, reality recoil, SB instability. **Play Cue:** Diagram your spell or state its symbolism. Big spells distort fate – accept SB spikes.

Innate Arcana (Sorcery) *Emotional, instinctive, bloodline-linked.* Tools: Breath, impulse, resonance. Costs: Fatigue, unpredictable backlash. **Play Cue:** Treat magic like a reflex. Push your limits – expect consequences.

Invocation (Priest / Paladin / Medium) *Petition, prayer, pact, rite.* Tools: Symbols, vows, places of power. Costs: Taboo pressures, obligation clocks. **Play Cue:** Your magic is not your own – frame it as a request. Violating your ethos draws consequences.

Runic Consecration (Runekeeping) *Methods, seals, contracts.* Tools: Ritual steps, codices, binding clauses. Costs: Hunger clocks, escalation loops. **Play Cue:** Magic is *procedure*. Expect the system to push back.

Shaping / Druidic Power *Resonance with place, element, cycle.* Tools: Marks, offerings, seasonal rites. Costs: Environmental echo, territorial consequence. **Play Cue:** Declare what the land wants – then bargain.

Pact Binding (Warlock / Avatar) *Exchange, hunger, transformation.* Tools: Tokens, signatures, reflection marks. Costs: Autonomy loss, ascension risk. **Play Cue:** Ask: “What does my patron get?” Debt becomes plot.

Summoning (Medium / Necromancer / Shaman) *Invocation of entities, binding, vassal action.* Tools: Circles, bargains, lanterns, ancestral calls. Costs: Attention clocks, breach risk.

Play Cue: Give the summoned a personality – their aid comes with demands.

Mutual Rules of Magical Cost

No magic is free.

Cost Type	Examples in Play
Fatigue SB Pressure	Exhaustion surge, shaking focus, body strain GM spikes complications or clocks (elemental backlash, Patron omens)
Taboo / Obligation	Commandments, rites, punishment for misuse, Patron demands
Attention / Backwash Anomaly / Distortion	Spirits notice; cosmic ledger ticks; faction awareness Places react, reality warps, rituals echo – scene tags change
Identity Erosion	Compelled acts, alignment tilt, Iconic Ascension risk

Cross-System Synergies

All magic systems can blend. A Runekeeper may emulate a Cleric or Druid; an Invoker may operate as a Paladin or Prophet; a Sorcerer may look like a Witch, Elementalist, or Psion.

When combining systems:

1. Choose your **primary expression** (belief, intellect, instinct, ritual).
2. Describe spells through that lens.
3. Let costs reflect your system.
4. Track consequences separately – mixing systems increases risk.

GM Reminders for Magic

- Magic creates story – reward its use with consequences and momentum.
- Players should narrate method, not just effect.
- Big moments should change scenes, not just numbers.
- Magic should tempt the caster – echo their drives and flaws.

Player Reminders for Magic

- Lean into cost – magic feels significant when it hurts.
- Make magic personal – describe what it looks and feels like.
- Tie powers to identity, belief, trauma, duty, or legacy.
- Let magic change your character over time.

Appendix Z: Pre-made Spells with TAGS and DV Math

The following examples illustrate how TAGS, DV scaling, and spell intent interact within the casting system. Use them as inspiration or as templates for your own spells.

How to Read a Spell Entry

Each entry includes:

- **Name** and **Tradition** (optional).
- **TAGS** – the components that define the effect.
- **Effect** – plain-language outcome.
- **DV** – base calculation (1 + number of TAGS; dangerous tags add +2).
- **Notes** – typical range, duration, or special considerations.

Tier I: Minor Utility (DV 2–3)

.0.4.0.1 Simple Light (Air + Light)

TAGS: [ILLUMINATE]

Effect: Create a small sustained light (torch-brightness) for the scene.

DV: 1 + 1 = 2.

Notes: No backlash risk; lasts until dismissed.

.0.4.0.2 Mend Minor Wounds (Life + Mend)

TAGS: [MEND]

Effect: Close a small cut or bruise; reduce 1 Harm (Minor).

DV: 1 + 1 = 2.

Notes: Requires touch.

.0.4.0.3 Message on Wind (Air + Veil)

TAGS: [WHISPER]

Effect: Carry a short whispered message 100 feet on wind currents.

DV: 1 + 1 = 2.

Notes: One-way communication; 30 seconds duration.

Tier II: Combat Utility (DV 3–4)

.0.4.0.4 Blade Flame (Fire + Strike)

TAGS: [BURNING][STRIKE]

Effect: Coat a weapon in fire, adding +1 Harm and [BURN] to the next melee attack.

DV: 1 + 1 + 1 = 3.

Notes: Lasts one exchange.

.0.4.0.5 Shield of Air (Air + Wall)

TAGS: [WARD][DEFEND]

Effect: Create a compressed air barrier; gain Position +1 on next defense.

DV: 1 + 1 + 1 = 3.

Notes: One use only.

.0.4.0.6 Fleet Step (Air + Leap)**TAGS:** [HASTE][MOVE]**Effect:** Double movement speed for one exchange.**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**.**Notes:** Requires open area.**Tier III: Area Control (DV 4–5)****.0.4.0.7 Wall of Stone** (Earth + Wall)**TAGS:** [BARRIER][FORTIFY]**Effect:** Summon a 10-foot stone wall (Near; scene duration).**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**. *Dangerous DV: 4* (combat blocking).**Notes:** Provides cover; obstructs movement.**.0.4.0.8 Sleep's Gentle Touch** (Water + Mind)**TAGS:** [DREAM][COMMAND]**Effect:** One target falls asleep (scene duration; Resist: Spirit + Resolve DV 2).**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**. *Dangerous DV: 4* (combat use).**Notes:** Harm wakes target.**.0.4.0.9 Flame Cloak** (Fire + Area)**TAGS:** [BURNING][AREA]**Effect:** 6-foot radius of intense heat; enemies suffer –1 die to approach.**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**. *Dangerous DV: 4* (if allies are near).**Notes:** Creates difficult terrain.**Tier IV: Battlefield Shaping (DV 5–6)****.0.4.0.10 Earth's Tremor** (Earth + Force)**TAGS:** [QUAKE][AREA]**Effect:** 20-foot tremor; enemies test Body + Athletics (DV 3) or fall prone.**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**. *Dangerous DV: 5*.**Notes:** Destabilizes structures; affects all in area.**.0.4.0.11 Storm's Fury** (Air + Storm)**TAGS:** [STORM][AREA][FORCE]**Effect:** 30-foot storm cloud; lightning strikes random targets (Harm 2).**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = **4**. *Dangerous DV: 6*.**Notes:** Lasts scene; reduces visibility.**.0.4.0.12 Healing Circle** (Life + Area)**TAGS:** [MEND][AREA][CLEANSE]**Effect:** Allies in 15-foot radius heal 1 Harm and clear 1 Fatigue.**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = **4**.**Notes:** Major positive effect warrants high DV.

Tier V: Domain-Level Effects (DV 6–7)

.0.4.0.13 Gate of Passage (Air + Fold)

TAGS: [GATE][TRANSPORT][AREA]

Effect: Open a two-way portal 20 feet wide linking two locations.

DV: $1 + 2 + 1 + 1 = 5$. *Dangerous DV: 7.*

Notes: Requires concentration; may destabilize.

.0.4.0.14 Army of Stone (Earth + Summon)

TAGS: [CONJURE][AREA][GUARD]

Effect: Summon 4 stone guardians (Cap 2) to follow simple commands.

DV: $1 + 2 + 1 + 1 = 5$. *Dangerous DV: 6.*

Notes: Scene duration; concentration.

.0.4.0.15 Mind's Dominion (Fate + Mind)

TAGS: [COMMAND][AREA][CURSE]

Effect: All enemies in 25-foot radius test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or obey a single command.

DV: $1 + 1 + 1 + 2 = 5$. *Dangerous DV: 7.*

Notes: Significant ethical risk; backlash likely.

Signature / Personal Spells (Custom)

.0.4.0.16 The Warden's Bond (Life + Bind) – Healing Cantor

TAGS: [MEND][BIND][GUARD]

Effect: Heal 2 Harm and link caster to target – the next Harm they take, caster suffers 1 instead.

DV: $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$.

Notes: Sacrificial protection.

.0.4.0.17 Shadow's Step (Air + Veil) – Trickster's Path

TAGS: [VEIL][MOVE][LEAP]

Effect: Become invisible and teleport 30 feet; gain +2 dice to next Stealth action.

DV: $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$.

Notes: Requires shadow or dim light.

.0.4.0.18 Forge's Truth (Fire + Reveal) – Artificer's Craft

TAGS: [REVEAL][MEND][FORTIFY]

Effect: See flaws in an object and repair as if 2 Skill levels higher (scene).

DV: $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$.

Notes: Works on magical items (with risk).

Backlash and Push Guidelines

Backlash Examples by Tier

- **Tier I–II:** Minor fatigue, brief elemental effect (smoke, chill, static).
- **Tier III–IV:** Harm 1, temporary Condition, environmental hazard.
- **Tier V:** Harm 2, major Condition, significant environmental change.

Push Options (Accelerate or Amplify)

- **+1 Effect:** Increase radius, duration, or potency one step.

- **+1 die:** Improve casting roll (cost: +1 Fatigue).
- **Instant:** Resolve immediately (cost: +1 Harm).
- **Sustain:** Maintain effect with concentration (+1 Fatigue/round).

This framework provides concrete spell examples and demonstrates how TAGS, DV scaling, and ambition interact within the magic system.

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